
Codices of Flesh, Stone, and Steel

The Runic Warrior

An Expansion for Fate's Edge

He knelt at the bank of the Black River. The water was cold. It smelled of iron and old rain. He opened the locket.

Inside was not a portrait. It was a braid of auburn hair, tied with a scrap of red thread.

This is not a story about a warrior who won a battle. It is a story about a warrior who learned to let go.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

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Part I

Introduction and Foundations

Chapter I

The Warrior's Codex

I.1 What Is a Runic Warrior?

A Runekeeper is defined by two things: a Codex that records their Rites, and a Thiasos that binds them to their Patron. Most Runekeepers carry their Codex as a book—vellum pages sewn between leather boards, ink and blood pressed into the margin. Most keep a Thiasos that chitters or growls or watches from the shadow of a hood.

But stone does not bind well to parchment. Steel does not read. The wild does not keep a library.

A Runic Warrior writes their Rites on a different surface. A gorget, engraved with vows. A living staff, bark split by carved runes. The skin itself, needle and ash threading the flesh. Their Codex is not read by candlelight in a scriptorium. It is felt. It is worn. It is known in the same way a warrior knows the heft of a sword.

And their Thiasos?

A warhorse that has carried them through three campaigns, loyal not out of magic but out of trust. A spirit-hound that runs beside them, no leash, only kinship. A hollowed bird with milk-white eyes, silent witness to every wound and every oath. Or, stranger still, a sword that speaks in the voice of a dead master—never acting on its own, but always *remembering*.

This is not a path for scholars. It is not a path for priests. It is a path for those who answer a question with steel, who swear an oath with blood, who carry their Patron's will in the weight of their shoulders and the scars on their hands.

I.2 The Philosophy of Physical Obligation

Every Runekeeper owes. That is the first truth of the covenant. But where a traditional Runekeeper owes in ink—pages turned, Rites recorded, witnesses notarized—a Runic Warrior owes in *flesh*.

A scar is a debt paid. A limp is a Rite that cost more than expected. A callus is a promise kept.

This is not a metaphor. When a Runic Warrior invokes a Rite, they do not reach for a book. They reach for a scar. They touch the engraving on their gauntlet. They tap the rune carved into their staff. The Codex is not separate from them. It is a part of them.

The price of this intimacy is vulnerability. A book can be replaced. A scar cannot. A shield can be reforged. A hand, once lost, is lost.

But the strength of it is the same. A Runic Warrior's power cannot be taken by a thief in the night. It cannot be burned by a censer. It lives in the body, and the body does not forget.

1.3 How to Use This Expansion

1.3.1 For Players

You are building a warrior who is also a Runekeeper. You are not a bookish scholar. You are not a courtier. You are the one who stands at the front, who holds the line, who charges when others hesitate.

This expansion provides:

- New talents that emphasize physical action and resilience.
- New Rites designed for combat and threshold work.
- Guidelines for creating a Codex that is a weapon, a shield, or a part of your body.
- Rules for a Thiasos that fights beside you, whether it has flesh or a blade.

You do not need to abandon the core Runekeeper rules. This expansion builds on them. You will still track Obligation. You will still invoke Rites. But your tools are different, and your costs are written on your skin.

1.3.2 For Game Masters

You are incorporating a new kind of Runekeeper into your world. These are not wizards in armor. They are warriors who have made a covenant with forces that demand physical proof of loyalty.

Consider:

- How do the Chain-Lanterns view a Runekeeper whose Codex is a sword? Does that make them harder to prosecute, or more suspicious?
- How do the Daughters of the Cord treat a Bloodsworn who wears their Rites as tattoos? Is that kinship or competition?
- How does a Lethai Ghe'hai operative navigate courts where silk masks are expected and open steel is an insult?

This expansion also introduces optional rules for sentient Thiasos—weapons that speak, shields that remember. Use them as allies, as complications, or as narrative devices that carry secrets and opinions.

1.3.3 Cultural Integration

Runic Warriors appear in every region of Fate's Edge, but their forms differ.

- In **Aeler**, a Runic Warrior might be a Cairn-Knight, Rites carved into a burial stone, their Thiasos an ancestral shade that fights beside them.

- In **Sekogo**, they are Beast Warriors, wearing the skin of a predator, their Codex a tooth, their Thiasos the spirit of the hunt.
- In **Ashaan**, they are Shadow Warriors, moving unseen, their Codex a black feather, their Thiasos a raven that carries whispers.
- In **Lethai**, they are Ghe'hai operatives—silks, steel, and silence. Their Codex is a woven mask. Their Thiasos is a spider-spirit that weaves threads between enemies.

This expansion does not favor one region over another. It provides the tools to build a Runic Warrior from any people, under any Patron.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

1.4 The Philosophy of Physical Obligation

Every Runekeeper owes. That is the first truth of the covenant. The Patron provides power; the Runekeeper provides service. The ledger balances, or it does not.

But a Runic Warrior owes differently.

A scholar writes their debt in ink. Each Rite inscribed, each Obligation recorded, each witness named. The Codex is a book. The debt is a number. When the number grows too large, the scholar pays in coin, in favors, in whispered secrets. The body remains untouched.

A Runic Warrior has no such luxury.

Their debt is written in flesh. A scar is a payment made. A limp is interest accrued. A callus is a promise kept so often that the skin no longer remembers how to be soft.

1.4.1 The Scar as Receipt

When a Runic Warrior invokes a Rite, they do not turn a page. They touch a scar. They press a rune carved into their gauntlet. They trace the knot sewn into their flesh. The Rite lives in the body, and the body remembers the cost.

This is not symbolism. It is mechanics.

A Runic Warrior's Codex is physical. A gorget, engraved with vows. A staff, carved with seasonal runes. A shield, marked with the names of thresholds guarded. The Codex can be damaged. It can be destroyed. But it cannot be stolen in the same way a book can be stolen, because it is worn, carried, or held.

And when the Codex is part of the body—tattoos, brands, scarification—it cannot be stolen at all.

1.4.2 The Weight of Visibility

A traditional Runekeeper can hide. Their Codex fits in a satchel. Their Thiasos can be dismissed or concealed. They walk through a city gate without announcing their covenant.

A Runic Warrior cannot.

The engraved gorget is visible. The rune-staff is a weapon. The tattoos curl up the neck and across the knuckles. Even the sentient blade, quiet as it may be, is still a blade.

This visibility is a cost. The Chain-Lanterns notice. The Cord assesses. The Inquisition takes notes. But it is also a privilege. A Runic Warrior announces their covenant with every step. They do not need to produce a writ. Their body is the writ.

1.4.3 Fatigue as Resource, Not Penalty

In the core rules, Fatigue is a penalty. It accumulates. It worsens Position. It leads to Harm.

For a Runic Warrior, Fatigue is also a resource.

Every scar is a memory of Fatigue endured. Every callus is a history of labor. The Runic Warrior learns to read their own exhaustion as a map—here is where the Rite cost more than expected, here is where the battle turned, here is where the Patron asked for interest and the Runic Warrior paid.

This expansion introduces talents that convert Fatigue into advantage. Not by ignoring it, but by *using* it. A warrior who knows how to fall knows how to rise. A body that has been pushed to its limit knows exactly where the next push will land.

1.4.4 The Witness of Wounds

A Runic Warrior's scars are witnessed.

Not by a notary. Not by a clerk. By anyone who looks.

A scar on the face tells a story. A missing finger asks a question. A brand on the back of the hand declares allegiance.

This is the Runic Warrior's vulnerability. They cannot hide their history. They cannot claim neutrality. Their body is a public ledger, written in tissue and bone.

But it is also their strength. A scar is harder to forge than a seal. A brand is harder to counterfeit than a signature. The Runic Warrior's covenant is visible, undeniable, and carried into every threshold.

1.4.5 The Debt That Cannot Be Deferred

A scholar can defer a debt. They can plead ignorance, claim a misreading, request an extension. The ledger is patient. The ink can be erased.

A Runic Warrior cannot defer.

The scar is already cut. The finger is already gone. The limp does not improve with negotiation.

This is the final philosophy of physical obligation: some debts are paid in advance. The Runic Warrior does not owe a Rite; they *are* the Rite. The covenant is not recorded; it is embodied.

And when the Patron calls, the Runic Warrior does not reach for a book.

They reach for a scar.

They touch the engraved gorget.

They stand.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

1.5 How to Use This Expansion

This expansion is designed for players who want to build a Runekeeper who fights, endures, and carries their covenant in flesh and steel. It is also for Game Masters who want to introduce Runic Warriors into their campaigns as allies, antagonists, or complications.

1.5.1 For Players

You are building a warrior who is also a Runekeeper. You are not a scholar. You are not a courtier. You are the one who stands at the front, who holds the line, who charges when others hesitate.

What You Need

Before using this expansion, you should be familiar with the core Runekeeper rules from the *Fate's Edge Comprehensive Resource Guide*. This expansion does not replace those rules. It builds on them.

You will still:

- Choose a Patron and track Obligation.
- Invoke Rites and mark costs.
- Manage your Codex and Thiasos.

But your Codex will not be a book. Your Thiasos may be a warhorse, a spirit-hound, or a sentient blade. Your Rites will be carved, engraved, or tattooed. And your Obligation will be written on your body.

How to Build a Runic Warrior

1. **Choose a Patron.** Not every Patron is suited to a Runic Warrior. This expansion identifies twenty-eight Patrons that welcome physical covenants, organized into thematic families: The Vowed, The Threshold, The Wild, The Deep, The Shadow, The Web, The Forge, The Grave, The Fracture, and the Lethai Ghe'hai.
2. **Choose your Codex form.** Your Codex is not a book. It is an engraved gorget, a carved staff, a tattooed body, a sentient blade. Each form has advantages and risks. A gorget grants armor. A staff serves as a weapon. Tattoos cannot be stolen. A sentient blade offers counsel but may have opinions.
3. **Choose your Thiasos.** Your Thiasos is not a pet. It is a warhorse, a spirit-hound, a hollowed bird, an ancestral shade, or a clockwork construct. It fights beside you, witnesses your Rites, and shares your burdens. Optional rules allow for sentient Thiasos—weapons or objects that speak and remember.
4. **Select Runic Warrior talents.** This expansion introduces new talents designed for physical resilience, close combat, and the conversion of Fatigue into advantage. Foundation talents (2-4 XP) are available at Tier I. Advanced talents (6-8 XP) unlock at Tier II. Prestige talents (10-12 XP) are for veteran warriors.
5. **Learn new Rites.** Each Patron family includes new Rites tailored to Runic Warriors. Low Rites (4-5 XP) are quick and scene-limited. Standard Rites (7-9 XP) offer lasting effects. High Rites (12-14 XP) are powerful, costly, and often require a witness or threshold.

Build Archetypes

This expansion includes five sample archetypes to guide your character creation:

- **Dawn Warrior (Oath of Flame & Light)** — A crusader who smites foes with radiant strikes and swears vows before battle.
- **Bloodsworn (High Mother)** — A Daughter of the Cord who stores Fatigue as visible knots in the flesh.
- **Ghe'hai Operative (Lethai Syncretic)** — An elite warrior-assassin who wears a silk mask and binds foes in invisible threads.
- **Beast Warrior (Savage Heart)** — A hunter who wears the skin of a killed predator and fights with claw and fang.
- **Fractal Warrior (The Ninth)** — A warrior who fights with impossible angles and precognition, their Codex a broken mirror.

1.5.2 For Game Masters

You are introducing a new kind of Runekeeper into your world. These are not wizards in armor. They are warriors who have made covenants with forces that demand physical proof of loyalty.

Integration into Existing Campaigns

Runic Warriors can appear anywhere, but their form varies by region.

- In **Aeler**, they are Cairn-Knights or Artificers, their Rites carved into burial stones or toolbelts.
- In **Sekogo**, they are Beast Warriors, wearing predator skins and hunting as sacrament.
- In **Ashaan**, they are Shadow Warriors, moving unseen, their Thiasos a raven that carries whispers.
- In **Lethai**, they are Ghe'hai operatives—silks, steel, and silence.
- In **Viterra** and **Ecktoria**, they are Justicars, Templars, and Witch-Hunters, their Codex a shield or a censor.

Use the faction relationship matrix in the appendices to determine how local powers view Runic Warriors. The Chain-Lanterns may be suspicious of a Runekeeper whose Codex cannot be confiscated. The Daughters of the Cord may see a Bloodsworn as a sister—or a rival.

Optional Rules

This expansion includes optional rules for sentient Thiasos: weapons, shields, or objects that speak and remember. A sentient Thiasos cannot act independently, but it can serve as a witness, offer counsel, and carry Rites engraved on its surface.

Use sentient Thiasos as:

- Allies that provide information or warnings.
- Complications that have their own agendas and opinions.
- Narrative devices that carry secrets or memories from previous owners.

Sample NPCs

The GM guidance chapter includes sample Runic Warrior NPCs for each Patron family. Use them as antagonists, allies, or neutral parties.

1.5.3 Cultural Integration

Runic Warriors do not belong to a single culture. They emerge wherever warriors make covenants. This expansion provides tools to build a Runic Warrior from any people, under any Patron.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Chapter 2

The Runic Warrior's Toolkit

2.1 The Codex as Flesh, Stone, and Steel

A traditional Runekeeper's Codex is a book. Vellum pages, leather binding, ink that smells of lampblack and blood. It is portable, concealable, and replaceable. It is also fragile. Fire destroys it. Water ruins it. A thief can steal it.

A Runic Warrior's Codex is not a book.

It is a gorget engraved with vows. A shield marked with the names of thresholds guarded. A staff carved with seasonal runes. A sword with Rites etched along the fuller. A body marked by tattoo, brand, or scar.

The Codex is not carried. It is worn. It is held. It is the body itself.

2.1.1 The Three Forms

A Runic Warrior's Codex takes one of three forms, each with advantages and risks.

Flesh (Tattoos, Brands, Scarification)

The Rites are written on the Runekeeper's skin. Needle and ash, blade and ink, fire and clay. The Codex cannot be stolen. It cannot be confiscated at a city gate. It is always present.

But it is also always visible. Tattoos curl up the neck. Brands mark the back of the hand. Scars tell stories that cannot be hidden.

Advantages:

- Cannot be stolen or confiscated.
- Always accessible (no action to draw or retrieve).
- Counts as a visible mark of covenant (may intimidate or impress).

Risks:

Cannot be hidden without clothing that covers every inch.

Damage to the skin (burns, deep wounds) may damage the Codex.

Some cultures view flesh-writing as heretical or criminal.

Stone (Carved Objects, Shields, Weapons, Armor)

The Rites are carved, etched, or engraved onto a physical object. A gorget, a shield, a staff, a sword. The Codex is durable. It can be used as a tool or weapon. It can be displayed as a symbol of authority.

But it can be lost. It can be stolen. It can be broken.

Advantages:

- Can serve as armor (gorget, shield) or weapon (staff, sword).
- Durable—resistant to fire, water, and mundane damage.
- Visible symbol of covenant (may grant social advantage in certain contexts).

Risks:

Can be stolen, confiscated, or lost.

Can be damaged or destroyed (requires repair or replacement).

Heavy or conspicuous (may be difficult to conceal).

Steel (Sentient Weapons)

The Rites are engraved on a sentient blade or object. The weapon speaks. It remembers. It serves as both Codex and Thiasos, though it cannot act independently.

This is the rarest form. Sentient weapons are not made; they are found, inherited, or granted by a Patron. They have personalities, opinions, and sometimes demands.

Advantages:

- Functions as both Codex and Thiasos (counts as a witness for Rites).
- Cannot be stolen without the Runekeeper's awareness (the weapon may resist or cry out).
- Provides counsel, warnings, and memory (GM may use the weapon to deliver hints).

Risks:

The weapon has its own personality and may refuse to cooperate.

Cannot be easily replaced or repaired.

Attracts attention—sentient weapons are rare and coveted.

2.1.2 Engraving Rites

A Runic Warrior adds new Rites to their Codex through physical engraving. This is not a scholarly exercise. It requires a forge, a needle, a chisel, or a branding iron. It requires pain.

Mechanics:

Adding a new Rite to a Codex requires:

- Downtime (one day per Tier of the Rite).
- A suitable workspace (forge, studio, quiet room).
- Materials appropriate to the Codex form (ink, ash, metal, leather, wood).
- A Body + Craft test (DV = 3 + Rite Tier).

On a success, the Rite is engraved. On a failure, the materials are ruined, and the Runekeeper marks 1 Fatigue (the pain of the failed attempt). On a critical failure, the Codex is damaged (becomes Compromised) and must be repaired before new Rites can be added.

2.1.3 Repairing a Damaged Codex

A Codex can be damaged. Fire, water, blade, or simple wear.

- A **Flesh** Codex can be repaired through healing (rest, Medicine, or magical healing). Damaged tattoos fade; scars may be re-cut.
- A **Stone** Codex requires physical repair (Craft test, DV 4, downtime). A broken shield can be reforged. A cracked staff can be bound with wire.
- A **Steel** Codex (sentient weapon) requires the Runekeeper to negotiate with the weapon itself. The weapon may demand a service, a memory, or a promise before it allows repairs.

If a Codex is destroyed beyond repair, the Runekeeper loses all Rites engraved on it. They must acquire or craft a new Codex and re-engrave their Rites—a costly and time-consuming process.

2.1.4 The Codex as Witness

A Codex is not just a record. It is a witness. When a Runic Warrior invokes a Rite, their Codex sees. It remembers. This counts as a witness for Rites that require one (improving Position or reducing DV).

A sentient Codex (Steel form) can also speak. It may offer testimony, confirm an oath, or testify to a covenant. In a hedge-court, a sentient blade's word may carry as much weight as a living witness.

2.1.5 The Codex and Obligation

When a Runic Warrior marks Obligation, the cost is visible. A scar appears. A tattoo darkens. A crack spreads across the shield. The Codex records the debt in the same way the body records a wound.

This visibility is a risk. An Inquisitor can see the Obligation. A Chain-Lantern can count the scars. But it is also a warning: the Runekeeper cannot pretend to be neutral. Their covenant is written on them.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

2.2 The Thiasos as Ally

Every Runekeeper is bound to a Thiasos—a fragment of their Patron's attention made manifest. For a traditional Runekeeper, the Thiasos is often a familiar: a small creature that chitters from a shoulder, a spirit that drifts at the edge of vision, a bound entity that serves as a witness and a warning.

For a Body Runekeeper, the Thiasos is different.

It is not a pet. It is not a servant. It is an *ally*. It fights beside them. It carries their burdens. It watches their back in a way that no book-bound Rite ever could.

2.2.1 Core Rules

A Thiasos is a companion with its own traits. It has:

- **Cap** — A measure of its power and effectiveness (typically 2-5).
- **Harm** — How much damage it can sustain before being incapacitated.
- **Traits** — Special abilities unique to its type.
- **Actions** — A Thiasos may act independently once per scene (the Runekeeper's action). Otherwise, it requires a command (the Runekeeper's action) to perform a significant task.

A Thiasos counts as a witness for Rites that require one. It sees, it remembers, and it can testify—though its testimony may be limited to growls, chirps, or the ringing of a bell.

If a Thiasos is reduced to 0 Harm, it is incapacitated. It does not die immediately, but it cannot act or witness until healed. A Thiasos heals naturally over downtime (one week per point of Harm), or can be healed faster with Medicine, magic, or (in the case of constructs) Craft.

2.2.2 Living Thiasos

Living Thiasos are creatures. They breathe, eat, sleep, and bleed. They are loyal, but they are not mindless. They have their own fears, preferences, and instincts.

Warhorse

Patrons: Oath of Flame & Light, Aveh, The Traveler

Cap: 3-5

Harm: 5

Traits:

- *Swift:* +1 die to chase or escape rolls.
- *Trample:* When the Runekeeper charges, the warhorse may also attack (Harm 2 to one target in Close range).
- *Loyal:* The warhorse will not flee while the Runekeeper is mounted.

Spirit-Hound

Patrons: Mykkiel, The Sealed Gate, Varnek Karn

Cap: 2-4

Harm: 4

Traits:

- *Tracker:* +2 dice to track a target by scent.
- *Spirit Sense:* Can detect invisible or incorporeal creatures within Near range.
- *Bound to Oath:* If the Runekeeper breaks a sworn oath, the spirit-hound whines and refuses to act for one scene.

Wolf-Ancestor

Patrons: Grimmer, The Savage Heart

Cap: 3-4

Harm: 4

Traits:

- *Pack Hunter:* When the Runekeeper attacks a target, the wolf-ancestor gains +1 die to attack the same target.
- *Howl:* Once per scene, the wolf-ancestor howls. Allies gain +1 die to resist fear for the scene.
- *Ancestral Memory:* The wolf-ancestor recalls the names of the Runekeeper's ancestors (GM may provide hints or lore).

Fungal Familiar

Patrons: The Carrion-King

Cap: 2-3

Harm: 3

Traits:

- *Spore Cloud:* Once per scene, the familiar releases a cloud of spores. Enemies in Close range test Endurance (DV 3) or suffer -1 die to physical actions for one exchange.
- *Decay Sense:* The familiar can detect rot, decay, or corruption within Near range.
- *Regenerative:* The familiar regains 1 Harm per day (faster than natural healing).

Clockwork Construct

Patrons: Clockwork Monad

Cap: 2-4

Harm: 5

Traits:

- *Mechanical Precision:* The construct gains +1 die to Craft or Tinker actions.
- *Self-Repair:* Once per downtime, the Runekeeper may repair 1 Harm to the construct with a Craft test (DV 3).
- *Iterative Upgrade:* The Runekeeper may install temporary enhancements (once per session, gain +1 die to one action performed by the construct).

Hollowed Child or Heartless Bird

Patrons: The High Mother

Cap: 2

Harm: Cannot be harmed by mundane means

Traits:

- *Silent Witness:* The Hollowed counts as a witness for all Rites. It never blinks.
- *Memory Keeper:* The Hollowed records every debt it witnesses. The Runekeeper may consult it to recall a forgotten promise or obligation.
- *Unsettling Presence:* Animals and children are disturbed by the Hollowed. Social rolls involving them suffer -1 die if the Hollowed is visible.

2.2.3 Sentient Thiasos (Optional Rule)

Not every Thiasos breathes. Some are objects—weapons, shields, tools, or tokens touched by the Patron's will. A sentient Thiasos cannot move on its own (unless animated by a Rite or talent), but it can speak, sense, and remember.

Sentient Thiasos are detailed in a separate chapter. They are rare, memorable, and often opinionated.

2.2.4 Thiasos and Obligation

When a Body Runekeeper marks Obligation, the Thiasos may also bear a mark. A warhorse develops a limp. A spirit-hound's glow dims. A sword's edge dulls.

The Runekeeper may transfer Fatigue to their Thiasos (Shared Burden talent), but the Thiasos becomes Winded (-1 die to all actions) for the rest of the scene. This is a choice, not a requirement. Some Runekeepers refuse to burden their allies.

2.2.5 Losing a Thiasos

A Thiasos can be killed, destroyed, or lost.

If a living Thiasos dies, the Runekeeper marks 2 Obligation immediately (the Patron's disappointment) and gains the Condition *Bereaved* (-1 die to all rolls involving trust or loyalty) until they acquire a new Thiasos.

If a sentient Thiasos is destroyed, the Runekeeper loses all Rites engraved on it (if it served as a Codex). They may repair it with significant downtime and a Craft test (DV 5), or they may find a new Thiasos.

Acquiring a new Thiasos is a downtime project. The Runekeeper must:

- Find a suitable creature or object (GM discretion).
- Perform a bonding ritual (one day, requires a threshold and a witness).
- Mark 1 Obligation (the Patron's fee for a new ally).

2.2.6 The Thiasos as Witness

A Thiasos is always a witness. It sees the Runekeeper's Rites, hears their oaths, and remembers their debts. This is true even if the Thiasos cannot speak.

In a hedge-court, a Thiasos's presence may suffice as a witness where no human witness is available. The judge may not like it, but the law is the law.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

2.3 Obligation as Physical Weight

A traditional Runekeeper tracks Obligation on a ledger. Numbers in a column. Segments on a clock. The debt is abstract, measurable, and—when paid—forgettable.

A Runic Warrior cannot forget.

Their Obligation is written on their body. A scar for a Rite invoked in desperation. A limp for a vow that cost more than expected. A missing finger for a debt that could not be deferred.

2.3.1 The Scar as Receipt

When a Runic Warrior marks Obligation, they choose where the cost appears.

- A **scar** on the arm or face (visible, memorable).
- A **brand** on the back of the hand (visible to everyone they meet).
- A **tattoo** that darkens or spreads (a record of accumulated debt).
- A **crack** in their shield or gorget (if their Codex is stone or steel).
- A **dullness** in their sentient blade's edge (the weapon shares the burden).

The player describes the mark. The GM may use it later as a narrative hook—an Inquisitor who recognizes the brand, a hedge-witch who reads the scars, a spirit who asks how the wound was earned.

Mechanical Effects of Visible Obligation

Obligation that is visibly marked on the body has both costs and benefits.

Costs:

- *Social Penalty*: When dealing with authorities who oppose Runekeepers (Chain-Lanterns, Inquisitors, certain hedge-courts), the character suffers -1 die to social rolls. The marks announce their covenant.
- *Recognition*: Former enemies, rivals, or creditors may recognize the marks and seek the character out.
- *Healing Complications*: Magical healing that closes wounds does not erase Obligation scars. They remain, a permanent record.

Benefits:

- *Intimidation*: When dealing with those who respect visible covenant marks (certain warrior cultures, mercenary companies, the Cord), the character gains +1 die to social rolls. The marks prove they have paid.
- *Witness*: The scars themselves count as a witness for Rites that require one. The body remembers what was sworn.
- *No Forgery*: A scar cannot be counterfeited. A brand cannot be stolen. The Obligation is undeniable.

2.3.2 Fatigue as a Resource, Not a Penalty

In the core rules, Fatigue is a penalty. It accumulates. It worsens Position. It leads to Harm.

For a Runic Warrior, Fatigue is also a resource.

A warrior who has been pushed to exhaustion knows exactly where their limit lies—and how to step just short of it. A body that has endured pain learns to read the shape of incoming harm.

Talents That Use Fatigue

This expansion introduces talents that convert Fatigue into advantage:

- *Iron Resolve* (Advanced): When you would be reduced to 0 Harm, you may instead remain standing with 1 Harm and mark 2 Fatigue.
- *Scarred Resilience* (Foundation): Ignore 1 Fatigue from physical exertion once per scene.
- *Shared Burden* (Advanced): Transfer 1 Fatigue to your Thiasos. It becomes Winded (-1 die to all actions) for the rest of the scene.
- *Witnessed Scar* (Advanced): Carve a scar for each permanent Obligation. Once per session, touch a scar and gain +1 die on a roll directly tied to that Obligation.

2.3.3 The Weight of Visibility

A traditional Runekeeper can hide. Their Codex fits in a satchel. Their Obligation is ink on a page. They walk through a city gate without announcing their covenant.

A Runic Warrior cannot.

The scars are visible. The brand is undeniable. The cracked shield tells a story. The sentient blade hums when Inquisitors pass.

This visibility is a cost, but it is also a privilege. A Runic Warrior does not need to produce a writ. Their body is the writ. Their scars are the seal.

2.3.4 Obligation and the Thiasos

When a Runic Warrior marks Obligation, the Thiasos may also bear a mark.

- A warhorse develops a limp.
- A spirit-hound's glow dims.
- A sword's edge dulls.
- A hollowed bird's milk-white eyes film over further.

The Runekeeper may choose to transfer the visible mark to their Thiasos (Sharing the Burden), but the Thiasos becomes Winded for the rest of the scene. Some Runekeepers refuse to burden their allies. Others consider it a fair distribution of weight.

2.3.5 Paying Obligation

A Runic Warrior pays Obligation in the same ways as any Runekeeper: service to their Patron, a witnessed atonement, or a sacrifice of memory or name.

But the payment is also *visible*.

When a debt is cleared, the scar fades. The brand lightens. The crack in the shield seals. The sword's edge brightens.

This visibility is a comfort. The Runic Warrior can see when they are free. They do not need to consult a ledger. They only need to look at their hands.

2.3.6 The Body as Ledger

A Runic Warrior's body is a public record.

Every scar is a Rite invoked. Every limp is a battle survived. Every brand is a covenant declared.

This is not a metaphor. It is the central philosophy of the Runic Warrior: *the debt is carried in the flesh, and the flesh does not forget*.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

2.4 New Core Talents

These talents are available to any Runic Warrior regardless of Patron. They emphasize physical resilience, the conversion of Fatigue into advantage, and the bond between Runekeeper, Codex, and Thiasos.

2.4.1 Foundation Talents (2-4 XP)

Flesh Codex (2 XP)

Requirement: Body 3+

Your Rites are engraved on your body—tattoos, brands, or scarification. You have no physical Codex to steal, confiscate, or destroy.

Effect:

- Your Codex cannot be stolen or confiscated.
- You always have access to your Rites (no action required to retrieve a Codex).
- Damage to your skin (burns, deep wounds) may damage your Codex at the GM's discretion.

Living Thiasos (3 XP)

Requirement: A living Thiasos (warhorse, hound, wolf-ancestor, etc.)

Your Thiasos is not a pet. It is a partner.

Effect:

- Your Thiasos gains +1 Cap (maximum 5).
- Once per scene, your Thiasos may act independently without requiring your action.
- Your Thiasos is more resilient: when it would be reduced to 0 Harm, it remains conscious but Winded (-1 die to all actions) until healed.

Oath-Bound (4 XP)

Requirement: You have sworn a formal oath before a witness.

Your word is your bond. Your bond is your strength.

Effect:

- Once per session, when you act in direct service of a sworn oath, you may reroll a failed Body roll.
- If you break your sworn oath, you lose access to this talent until you perform a witnessed atonement.

Scarred Resilience (3 XP)

Requirement: Body 2+

You have learned to read your own pain.

Effect:

- Once per scene, you may ignore 1 Fatigue from physical exertion (running, climbing, fighting, or invoking a Rite that costs Fatigue).
- You may use this talent after the Fatigue is marked.

2.4.2 Advanced Talents (6-8 XP)**Engraved Defense (6 XP)**

Requirement: Your Codex is a physical object (gorget, shield, staff, or sentient blade)

Your Codex is not just a record. It is armor.

Effect:

- Your Codex grants +1 Armor.
- When you would take Harm, you may instead mark 1 Obligation and reduce the Harm by 1 (to a minimum of 0).
- You cannot use this talent if your Codex is Compromised or destroyed.

Shared Burden (6 XP)

Requirement: A living Thiasos

You and your Thiasos share more than a covenant. You share weight.

Effect:

- When you mark Fatigue, you may transfer 1 point of it to your Thiasos.
- Your Thiasos becomes Winded (-1 die to all actions) for the rest of the scene.
- You may use this talent once per scene.

Witnessed Scar (8 XP)

Requirement: You have at least three permanent Obligation scars

Each scar is a payment made. Each payment is a memory.

Effect:

- Once per session, you may touch a scar and recall the event that caused it in perfect detail.
- Gain +1 die on any roll directly tied to that event (tracking a foe you fought before, recalling a Patron's demand, navigating a place you bled in).

Iron Resolve (7 XP)

Requirement: Body 3+, Disciplined Body or similar resilience talent

You do not fall easily.

Effect:

- When you would be reduced to 0 Harm, you may instead remain standing with 1 Harm and mark 2 Fatigue.
- You may use this talent once per scene.

2.4.3 Prestige Talents (10-12 XP)**The Unbroken Vow (10 XP)**

Requirement: You have kept a sworn oath for at least one year (in-game time)

Some vows are not chains. They are bridges.

Effect:

- When you swear an oath before a witness, you gain +2 dice to all actions that serve that oath.
- Breaking the oath causes you to immediately mark 2 Harm (Stress) and lose access to this talent until you perform a witnessed atonement.
- You may have only one Unbroken Vow active at a time.

Avatar of the Codex (12 XP)

Requirement: Tier III+, your Codex is a physical object

You do not carry your Codex. You become it.

Effect:

- Once per session, you may become the living embodiment of your Codex for one scene.
- Your Body increases by 2 (to a maximum of 6).
- Your Thiasos fights beside you as a second combatant (taking its own actions).
- At the end of the scene, you mark 2 Fatigue and 1 Obligation.

The Scar That Remembers (11 XP)

Requirement: Witnessed Scar, Tier III+

Your scars do not just record. They testify.

Effect:

- Once per session, you may touch a scar and speak a single sentence about the event that caused it.
- That sentence is considered witnessed truth. In a hedge-court, it carries the weight of sworn testimony.
- You cannot use this talent on the same scar twice.

2.4.4 Patron-Specific Talents

Each Patron family in this expansion includes unique talents for Runic Warriors. These are detailed in the Patron chapters.

Examples include:

- *Dawn's Judgment* (Oath of Flame & Light) — Smite undead and oath-breakers with radiant steel.
- *The Red Thread* (High Mother) — Store Fatigue as visible knots in your flesh.
- *Ghe'hai's Escape* (Lethai) — Once per session, vanish when cornered, reappearing in a safe location.
- *The Unseen Strike* (Ikasha) — First strike from concealment ignores 1 Armor.
- *Beast Form* (Savage Heart) — Partial transformation into a predator.

2.4.5 Talent Synergies

Some talents work well together:

- *Flesh Codex* + *Witnessed Scar* — Your body is both Codex and testimony. You cannot be disarmed.
- *Shared Burden* + *Living Thiasos* — You and your Thiasos endure together. Neither falls alone.
- *Iron Resolve* + *Avatar of the Codex* — You become nearly unkillable for one scene. The cost is high. The memory is a scar.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Part II

The Patrons of the Body

Chapter 3

The Vowed (Oaths, Law, and Judgment)

3.1 Oath of Flame and Light

3.1.1 Domain and Epithets

The Oath of Flame and Light is no patron of half-measures. Its fire names, binds, and burns—demanding that those who swear within its radiance stand openly, speak truly, and pay the cost of keeping their word. At dawn altars, the sworn kindle sparks of consecrated fire; in battle, they blaze as torches that hold back the night. To follow this Oath is to live in public truth, with no shadow to hide in and no retreat from the vow once spoken.

3.1.2 Cultural Origins

The Oath appears in many guises across the known world:

- In **Aeler**, it is the Everflame, carried from shrine to shrine by wandering priests. Its censers never cool.
- In **Vhasia**, it is Adur, the Light of Aeler, whose flame consecrates oaths and consumes falsehood. Dwarven templars strike their vows into stone with a brand.
- In **Vittera**, it is the Dawnfire, invoked as a war-god of vows and vengeance, whose rising light marks those who break faith. Cavalrymen light a single arrow before battle.
- In **Ecktoria**, it is the Watchfire, a saint's flame that never gutters, tended by a silent order of healers who swear to harm no one—and to let no one die alone.

Wherever it manifests, the Oath remains the same: to swear beneath its dawn is to bind oneself to a truth that cannot be hidden, forgotten, or undone.

3.1.3 Warrior Archetype: The Dawn Warrior

A Runic Warrior of the Oath of Flame and Light is not a scholar or a courtier. They are a *Dawn Warrior*—a crusader who carries their vows in steel and fire. Their Codex is engraved on a gorget or gauntlet. Their Thiasos is a warhorse with eyes like embers or a spirit-hound of ash and seal-wax. Their Rites are not whispered; they are declared.

3.1.4 Codex Form

The Dawn Warrior's Codex is a physical object worn into battle:

- **Gorget:** A steel collar engraved with vows. Worn over the throat, protecting the voice that speaks the oath.
- **Gauntlet:** A plate glove marked with runes of dawn. The hand that strikes also swears.
- **Branded Bracer:** A leather or steel armguard, each brand a Rite invoked and paid.

3.1.5 Thiasos Form

- **Warhorse:** A horse with eyes like dying embers. It fears no flame and will not bolt from battle.
- **Spirit-Hound of Ash:** A hound whose fur smolders and whose paws leave no tracks. It can sense oath-breakers within Near range.
- **Dawnblade (Sentient):** A sword that hums with trapped light. It speaks in proverbs about honor. It refuses to strike an unarmed foe.

3.1.6 Core Mechanic: The Witnessed Vow

When a Dawn Warrior swears an oath before a witness, they gain +1 die to all actions that serve that oath until it is fulfilled or broken. This stacks with the Unbroken Vow talent.

3.1.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Kindled Blade (4 XP)

Tags: [FIRE], [STRIKE], [WITNESS]

Threshold: Dawn, or a flame lit at dawn.

Your weapon ignites with radiant light. For one scene, your melee attacks deal +1 Harm against undead, oath-breakers, and creatures of corruption. The flame does not spread, but it illuminates a Close radius.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Steadfast Gaze (4 XP)

Tags: [TRUTH], [FEAR], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A flame between you and the target.

Your eyes catch the light. For one exchange, a single target within Near range cannot lie to you. They may refuse to answer, but any statement they make must be true.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Unbroken Vow (7 XP)

Tags: [VOW], [WARD], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A flame lit at dawn, and a witness who is not the Runekeeper.

Swear an oath before the flame and the witness. For the duration of the oath, you gain +1 Armor. Any ally who hears the oath and aids you gains +1 die to actions that serve it.

If you break the oath, you immediately mark 2 Harm (Stress) and the flame gutters. The witness may release you from the oath, but only by speaking your name aloud.

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of Dawn's Judgment (8 XP)

Tags: [FIRE], [STRIKE], [JUDGMENT], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A flame lit at dawn, and a target who has broken an oath.

Your blade blazes with dawn fire. Make a single melee attack. On a hit, the attack ignores 1 point of Armor and deals +2 Harm to undead, oath-breakers, and creatures of corruption. On a miss, the flame gutters but does not go out.

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of the Dawnfire Covenant (12 XP)

Tags: [VOW], [AREA], [WARD], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A flame lit at dawn, and at least three witnesses.

Consecrate a zone (Near radius) as dawnfire ground. For the scene:

- Allies within the zone gain +1 die to resist fear.
- Enemies who are undead, oath-breakers, or creatures of corruption suffer -1 die to all actions while within the zone.
- Any oath sworn within the zone is witnessed by the flame itself. Breaking it causes the oath-breaker to mark 1 Harm (Stress) immediately, regardless of distance.

Obligation: 3

3.1.8 Patron-Specific Talents**Dawn's Judgment (6 XP)**

Requirement: Oath of Flame and Light, Body 3+

When you invoke Rite of Dawn's Judgment, you may choose to extend the effect. Your blade remains kindled for the remainder of the scene, not just a single strike. Each additional attack beyond the first costs 1 Fatigue.

Unquenchable (4 XP)**Requirement:** Oath of Flame and Light

Your flame cannot be extinguished by mundane means. Wind, water, and darkness do not affect your kindled blade or dawnfire Rites. Magical extinguishing requires a contested roll (Spirit + Lore vs. your Spirit + Presence).

The Light Reveals (8 XP)**Requirement:** Oath of Flame and Light, Witnessed Scar

Your scars are visible even through armor—glowing faintly where dawnfire has marked you. Once per session, you may touch a scar and ask the GM one question about an oath-breaker or creature of corruption within Far range. The GM must answer truthfully, though the answer may be cryptic.

3.1.9 Roleplaying a Dawn Warrior

- You do not whisper your vows. You declare them.
- You do not hide your covenant. You wear it.
- You may struggle with mercy. The flame judges; you must learn when to temper it.
- You may be called to witness oaths outside of battle—marriages, treaties, adoptions. Your word carries weight.

3.1.10 Sample NPC: Knight-Commander Ria of the Dawn Vigil**Archetype:** Dawn Warrior**Patron:** Oath of Flame and Light**Codex:** Engraved gorget, each vow a line of flame-light script**Thiasos:** Ember, a spirit-hound of ash whose paw prints smolder for hours

Personality: Stern, weary, secretly uncertain. She has kept every vow she ever swore. She is not sure she remembers why.

Conflict: A vow she swore twenty years ago—to protect a village that no longer exists—has no witness but herself. Does the oath still bind? The flame says yes. Her heart is not sure.

3.1.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for Oath of Flame and Light

- A vow the Dawn Warrior swore years ago resurfaces. A witness they had forgotten appears.
- Their flame gutters at a crucial moment—not because of magic, but because of doubt.
- An enemy begs for mercy. The flame demands judgment. The Dawn Warrior must choose.
- A dawnfire Rite leaves a permanent mark: a scar that glows faintly in darkness, visible to all who know what it means.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

3.2 Oath of Mercy and Grace

3.2.1 Domain and Epithets

The Oath of Mercy and Grace has no founder, no scripture, no single temple. It began in a hundred places—a battlefield where a medic bound wounds without asking whose side; a plague village where a stranger stayed to dig graves; a debtor's cell where a guard looked away and said, "I saw nothing." Those who swear the Oath do not worship a power. They embody a principle: that every act of care creates an obligation—not to the giver, but to the next person in need. You do not pay back. You pay forward. The mercy spirals.

But mercy is not weakness. The spiral does not forget. Those who strike a healer, who violate a sanctuary, who refuse the offered cup—they find that grace has teeth, and forgiveness carries a price.

3.2.2 Cultural Origins

The Oath appears wherever healers, midwives, and hospice workers have organized to protect their own:

- In **Viterrra**, the Grey Spiral runs hospices along the border roads. They ask no payment, but they record every name in a ledger that never dries.
- In **Aelaerem**, the Hearth-Menders tend the sick and settle disputes. Their symbol is a red thread tied around the wrist.
- In **Sidhi** ports, the Weavers of Mercy treat wounded sailors and refugees. They are tolerated because they ask nothing—and because their hospices are the only neutral ground in a hundred miles.
- In **Ecktoria**, the Order of the Salted Veil tends the dying in the shadow of the Everflame. The Church does not officially recognize them. The Church does not interfere.

3.2.3 Warrior Archetype: The Hospitaller

A Runic Warrior of the Oath of Mercy and Grace is not a crusader. They are a *Hospitaller*—a warrior who fights not to kill, but to protect. Their Codex is a grey cloak or a shield marked with the spiral. Their Thiasos is a grey cord that tightens when mercy is refused, or a hospice bird that sings when someone is about to die. Their Rites bind wounds, create sanctuary, and turn an enemy's violence back upon itself.

3.2.4 Codex Form

The Hospitaller's Codex is a symbol of their calling:

- **Grey Cloak:** Woven from undyed wool, each fold a record of a mercy given. The cloak is heavy with memory.
- **Shield of the Spiral:** A wooden or steel shield painted with a grey spiral. Rites are carved along the rim.
- **Locket:** A silver locket containing a lock of hair from a patient who could not be saved. It is heavy. It reminds.

3.2.5 Thiasos Form

- **Grey Cord:** A length of undyed wool rope. It tightens when a promise is broken. It loosens when mercy is accepted. It can be tied around a wrist to witness an oath.
- **Hospice Bird:** A small grey bird, often a dove or sparrow. It sings when someone within Near range is about to die. It does not sing for enemies or allies—only for the dying.
- **The Silent Bell (Sentient):** A small bronze bell that does not ring—it hums. It speaks in whispers, and only to remind the Runekeeper that mercy is not weakness.

3.2.6 Core Mechanic: The Spiral

When a Hospitaller shows mercy to an enemy (sparing a life, binding a wound, offering sanctuary), they gain 1 Boon. This Boon can be used only for acts of protection, healing, or sanctuary.

When a Hospitaller is harmed by someone they have shown mercy, they may spend 1 Boon to force the attacker to test Resolve (DV 4) or suffer -1 die to all actions for the scene (the weight of their cruelty).

3.2.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Shared Bowl (4 XP)

Tags: [HEAL], [BOND], [RESTORATION]

Threshold: A bowl of clean water, shared with a willing creature.

You and the creature each clear 1 Fatigue. The creature gains +1 die on their next roll to resist fear or despair.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Grey Touch (4 XP)

Tags: [HEAL], [CLEANSE]

Threshold: A wound that has drawn blood.

Touch a wounded creature. Remove 1 Fatigue or stabilize a dying patient (they will not die from this wound for the rest of the scene). The wound closes slightly; the pain eases.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Sheltered Hearth (7 XP)

Tags: [WARD], [AREA], [SANCTUARY]

Threshold: A door, a threshold, or a hearth.

Consecrate a zone (Near radius) as sanctuary. For the scene:

- No violence may be initiated within the zone. Existing violence continues, but new acts of aggression require a Resolve test (DV 4).
- The dying cannot die while within the zone. They remain stable, suspended between breath and silence, until the Rite ends.

If the Rite is broken (by an act of violence from within), the Runekeeper marks 2 Fatigue.

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of the Spiral's Witness (8 XP)

Tags: [DEBT], [RESTORATION], [FEAR], [TRUTH]

Threshold: A grey wool cord tied around the Runekeeper's wrist.

Name a person crushed by debt or guilt. For one scene, they ignore all penalties from unpaid obligations (social, legal, or spiritual). They are not free; they are unburdened. If that person then commits an act of violence against an innocent, the unburdening reverses and they suffer double penalties.

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of the Endless Spiral (12 XP)

Tags: [HEAL], [RESTORATION], [DEBT], [AREA], [FEAR]

Threshold: A circle of nine grey stones, a bowl of tears, and a candle lit at each cardinal point.

All within the circle who accept the Oath's blessing clear 2 Fatigue and remove one Condition caused by despair or guilt. For the rest of the scene, any act of care performed within the zone costs the giver -1 Obligation (minimum 0). Additionally, any creature that harms a caregiver within the zone gains a Promise Clock [6] named "Spiral's Debt." When full, they suffer Harm 2 (Stress) as the weight of their cruelty crushes them.

Obligation: 3

3.2.8 Patron-Specific Talents

Spiral Counter (6 XP)

Requirement: Oath of Mercy and Grace, Body 3+

When a creature with an active Promise Clock (from any of your Rites) attacks you, you may spend 1 Boon to advance that clock by 1 segment immediately, before the attack resolves.

The Unbuckled Gorget (4 XP)

Requirement: Oath of Mercy and Grace

Once per session, you may remove a piece of armor (helm, gauntlet, or gorget) to show vulnerability. Gain +1 die to social rolls with honorable enemies, but suffer +1 Harm from the next attack against you. The mercy is real; the risk is real.

The Spiral's Final Witness (10 XP)

Requirement: Oath of Mercy and Grace, Tier III+

Once per session, when a creature with an active Promise Clock would deal a killing blow to an ally, you may interpose yourself. The blow is redirected to you, and you suffer the Harm instead. The Promise Clock fills immediately, and the attacker suffers the consequence (Harm, Condition, or Curse). You cannot use this talent again until you have spent a downtime scene in meditation or prayer.

3.2.9 Roleplaying a Hospitaller

- You do not ask which side a wounded person fought for. You bind the wound.
- You may be called to witness deathbed confessions. The words are not yours to repeat.
- You may struggle with anger. Mercy is not forgetfulness. The spiral remembers.
- You may be asked to violate sanctuary—to turn someone away, to refuse the cup. You may refuse. The spiral will hold.

3.2.10 Sample NPC: Sister Anabel of the Salted Veil

Archetype: Hospitaller

Patron: Oath of Mercy and Grace

Codex: Grey cloak, each fold a record of a mercy given

Thiasos: A grey cord tied around her wrist; it tightens when she is tempted to refuse mercy

Personality: Calm, steady, inexhaustible. She has not slept well in years. She does not complain.

Conflict: A warlord she once healed now marches on the hospice where she works. She could turn him away. The spiral says no. The cord tightens.

3.2.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for Oath of Mercy and Grace

- A patient the Hospitaller saved returns—not to thank, but to harm. The spiral tightens.
- A child dies despite the Hospitaller's best efforts. The grey cord does not loosen.
- An enemy begs for mercy. Granting it will cost the Hospitaller something real—a reputation, an ally, a future battle lost.
- A hospice bird sings. Someone is about to die. The Hospitaller does not know who.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

3.3 Mykkiel — Arbiter of the Covenant

3.3.1 Domain and Epithets

Mykkiel is the unwavering judge of covenants, the divine lawgiver whose scales and sword uphold sacred order. He is not good, nor evil—he is the law. Mercy without justice is weakness; justice without law is chaos. His followers are judges, templars, and scribes who enforce divine law with zealous devotion, seeing the world in absolutes of sanctity and transgression.

The Covenant, the great faith that bears his name, was revealed not through a prophet of soft words, but through a commander of hosts—a figure of burning authority who carved the first covenant into stone with a sword. Mykkiel does not negotiate. He commands. The faithful do not interpret; they obey.

3.3.2 Cultural Origins

Mykkiel appears wherever law is written in stone and enforced with steel:

- In **Vittera**, he is Seint Michel, the patron of knights who swear to protect the innocent and uphold the code. His shrines are courthouses and tilt-yards.
- In **Ecktoria**, he is the Judge of the Scar, invoked before every contract. His symbol is a cracked gavel—justice that has been used.
- In **Aeler**, he is the Stone-Judge. Dwarven arbiters inscribe his name on their gavels. His word settles disputes that could crack mountains.
- In **Thepyrgos**, he is the Synod's patron, invoked when precedent fails and a new judgment must be carved.

3.3.3 Warrior Archetype: The Justicar

A Runic Warrior of Mykkiel is not a crusader of flame or a healer of mercy. They are a *Justicar*—a lawbringer who carries the covenant in steel. Their Codex is a shield engraved with precedents or a gavel that doubles as a mace. Their Thiasos is a spirit-hound that tracks oath-breakers, a standing stone that witnesses judgments, or a sentient blade that recites the clauses of broken contracts.

3.3.4 Codex Form

The Justicar's Codex is a tool of judgment:

- **Shield:** A steel shield engraved with precedents. Each scar is a case won. Each dent is an appeal denied.
- **Gavel:** A gavel carved from ironwood, its head weighted with lead. It serves as a mace in combat and a focus for judgments.
- **Oath-Beads:** A string of carved bone or stone beads. Each bead represents a covenant witnessed. Breaking a bead voids the oath—at a cost.

3.3.5 Thiasos Form

- **Spirit-Hound of Judgment:** A hound with eyes like polished slate. It can track an oath-breaker across any terrain, and it knows when someone is lying.
- **Standing Stone:** A small carved stone that, when placed on the ground, grows to waist height. It serves as a witness for judgments. It does not speak, but its presence is heavy.
- **The Speaking Gavel (Sentient):** A gavel that speaks in legal citations. It can compel attention (Position +1 for one social roll) when struck against a surface.

3.3.6 Core Mechanic: The Witnessed Precedent

When a Justicar invokes a Rite that establishes a judgment or binds a covenant, they may cite a precedent from their Codex. Roll Wits + Lore (DV 3). On a success, the Rite's DV is reduced by 1 (minimum 1). On a failure, the precedent is contested—the GM gains 1 SB.

3.3.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Measured Debt (4 XP)

Tags: [VOW], [COMMAND], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A pair of scales balanced with tokens from both sides.

Establish a temporary accord. Both parties suffer -1 die if they break it first. You gain +1 die to enforce compliance.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Weighed Heart (5 XP)

Tags: [TRUTH], [SENSE], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A small brass scale touched briefly to the chest.

Sense if the target acts against their nature or oath. Gain +1 die when pressing them. If the target is lying, the scale tips—only you can see it.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Balanced Scales (8 XP)

Tags: [DEBT], [BOND], [TRANSFER], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A set of scales inscribed with runes of parity.

Exchange a burden between two willing parties (Harm for Fatigue, Debt for Favor, etc.). Both gain +1 die to cooperate. If the exchange is unwilling, you must win a contested Command roll (Presence + Command vs. Resolve).

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of the Covenant Seal (9 XP)

Tags: [VOW], [BOND], [DEBT], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A written contract and a flame to seal the wax.

Formalize a binding covenant between two or more parties. Each party must sign or mark the document. Violation of the covenant causes the violator to mark 1 Harm (Stress) immediately, and the GM gains 2 SB (the law's attention).

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of the Final Adjudication (13 XP)

Tags: [AREA], [COMMAND], [TRUTH], [FEAR], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A circle of iron bells, each etched with runes of judgment.

Convene an unseen tribunal. Shadows of former judges and wronged souls gather to preside. For the next scene, disputes within the zone are judged formally: +2 dice to Command when speaking as arbiter, and honest testimony gains +1 die. Any creature that lies within the zone suffers 1 Harm (Stress) as the tribunal's judgment falls.

Obligation: 3

3.3.8 Patron-Specific Talents**Cite Precedent (4 XP)**

Requirement: Mykkiel, Lore 2+

Once per session, when you invoke a Rite that establishes a judgment or binds a covenant, you may declare that a past judgment covers the current situation. Roll Wits + Lore (DV 3). On a success, the Rite's DV is reduced by 1 (minimum 1). On a miss, the precedent is contested—GM gains 1 SB.

Gavel's Authority (6 XP)

Requirement: Mykkiel, Body 3+

Your Codex (gavel or shield) grants you authority. Once per scene, when you strike your gavel (or strike your shield with your weapon), hostile NPCs within Near range must test Resolve (DV 4) or hesitate for one exchange.

Justicar's Immunity (8 XP)

Requirement: Mykkiel, Tier II+

You have been granted the authority to enforce the Covenant. You cannot be arrested or detained by any lesser authority in lands that recognize Mykkiel's law. However, abuse of this immunity (committing a crime in plain sight) will cause your authority to be revoked—lose access to this talent until you undergo a ritual of restoration (a downtime project).

3.3.9 Roleplaying a Justicar

- You do not argue. You cite.
- You do not forgive. You weigh. When the scales balance, the judgment is complete.
- You may be called to witness contracts, treaties, and marriage vows. Your presence makes them binding.
- You may struggle with mercy. The law is the law. But you have seen the law fail.

3.3.10 Sample NPC: Justicar Dara of the Stone Bench

Archetype: Justicar

Patron: Mykkiel

Codex: Engraved shield, each dent a case won, each scar an appeal denied

Thiasos: A spirit-hound that knows when someone is lying

Personality: Cold, precise, weary. She has never lost a case. She is not sure she has ever won one either.

Conflict: A covenant she witnessed twenty years ago has been broken. The breaker is her own daughter. The law says: judge. The heart says: wait.

3.3.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for Mykkiel

- A covenant the Justicar witnessed years ago resurfaces. The terms were ambiguous. Both sides demand interpretation.
- The Justicar's authority is challenged. A rival lawbringer disputes their right to judge.
- A case the Justicar closed long ago reopens. New evidence suggests the wrong party was punished.
- The scales tip at an inconvenient moment—not because of magic, but because the Justicar's own doubt has weight.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

3.4 Inquisitor Prime — Purity and Domination

3.4.1 Domain and Epithets

Among zealots, witch-hunters, and templars of the Everflame, the Inquisitor Prime is venerated as the hand of absolute purity and the sword of uncompromising order. Where others see nuance, the Inquisitor sees corruption; where others see difference, they see contamination.

Those who march beneath their sigil believe that no society can stand if it tolerates the impure or the disobedient. They hunt the arcane and the aberrant—not merely to destroy them, but to bind them as slaves to order, believing even the tainted may yet serve, so long as they are shackled.

The Inquisitor Prime appears in vision as a faceless figure clad in burnished iron, with eyes like furnace-doors and a voice like grinding chains. To serve them is to embrace judgment without mercy and to live in suspicion of all who walk outside the prescribed law.

For the faithful, doubt is treason; compassion is weakness; freedom is the seed of ruin.

3.4.2 Cultural Origins

The Inquisitor Prime appears wherever order is threatened by the strange:

- In **Ecktoria**, the Chain-Lanterns hunt untutored magic under the Inquisitor's banner. Their lanterns burn green when corruption is near.

- In **Thepyrgos**, the Synod's Witch-Hunter Commissariats invoke the Prime before every purge. Their writs are sealed with iron and fire.
- In **Aeler**, the Inquisitor is called the Light of Forges. Dwarven templars kindle hearths with a brand from the temple's eternal flame—and brand heretics with the same iron.
- In **Vhasia**, fractured cantons have each produced their own Inquisitorial orders, hunting spies, heretics, and anyone who cannot name their grandfather.

3.4.3 Warrior Archetype: The Purifier

A Runic Warrior of the Inquisitor Prime is not a judge or a healer. They are a *Purifier*—a witch-hunter who carries judgment in steel and fire. Their Codex is a censer that never goes cold or a gauntlet engraved with proscription lists. Their Thiasos is a spirit-hound that smells corruption, a lantern that reveals hidden magic, or a sentient blade that has burned a hundred heretics.

3.4.4 Codex Form

The Purifier's Codex is a tool of judgment and eradication:

- **Censer:** A brass censer hung on three chains. It never goes cold. Its smoke reveals hidden magic (spirits, enchantments, illusions) within Near range.
- **Gauntlet:** An iron gauntlet engraved with the names of proscribed cults and forbidden Rites. Each name is a promise kept.
- **Brand:** A heated iron stamp. It marks the impure. It also serves as the Runekeeper's seal on writs of condemnation.

3.4.5 Thiasos Form

- **Lantern-Spirit:** A brass lantern that burns without oil. Its light reveals invisible or incorporeal creatures. It dims when the Runekeeper shows mercy.
- **Spirit-Hound of the Hunt:** A hound with eyes like burning coals. It can track any creature that has used magic within the past day.
- **The Censer of Unforgiving Flame (Sentient):** A brass censer that speaks in harsh, clipped sentences. Its smoke reveals lies and hidden corruption. It never forgives.

3.4.6 Core Mechanic: The Hunt

When a Purifier is hunting a specific target (a heretic, a rogue mage, a corrupted creature), they gain +1 die to all rolls related to tracking, identifying, or confronting that target. The GM names the target at the start of the hunt. If the Purifier shows mercy to the target, they lose access to this bonus for the remainder of the hunt.

3.4.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Pure Flame (4 XP)

Tags: [PROTECT], [RADIANT], [FEAR], [WITNESS]

Threshold: Ash from a burned grimoire or a sigil-scarred candle.

Gain +2 dice to resist supernatural influence (fear, charm, possession) and +1 Armor vs. magical attacks. Undead, demonic, or corrupted foes suffer -1 die against you.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Unclouded Eye (5 XP)

Tags: [TRUTH], [KNOWLEDGE], [RADIANT], [WITNESS]

Threshold: Silver dust stirred into holy water.

Gain +2 dice to Investigation or Insight when spotting illusions, glamours, or magical deception. You cannot be surprised by sorcery this scene.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Cleansing Light (8 XP)

Tags: [DISPEL], [RADIANT], [FORCE], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A shard of blessed mirror and consecrated oil.

Target a magical effect (ward, curse, enchantment). Test Spirit + Lore vs. DV = effect's Tier. On a hit, the effect is dispelled. On a partial, it is weakened (reduced effect or duration). On a miss, the effect lashes back—GM gains 1 SB.

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of the Marked Prey (7 XP)

Tags: [CURSE], [TRACK], [FEAR], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A belonging of the target mixed with blessed salt.

Mark a supernatural target: they suffer -1 die to all rolls and cannot hide with illusion. You gain +1 die to track or strike them. Undead, demonic, or corrupted foes take +1 Harm from you.

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of the Final Admonition (13 XP)

Tags: [DEATH], [BANISH], [FORCE], [FEAR], [WITNESS]

Threshold: Ash from a destroyed spellbook, martyr's water, and the target's true name.

Attempt to annihilate one supernatural foe. Target tests Spirit + Resolve (DV 5). On a failure, they are destroyed outright—no remains, no return. On a success, they suffer Harm 3 and -2 dice this scene. This Rite may be used only once per target.

Obligation: 3

3.4.8 Patron-Specific Talents

Truth's Gaze (6 XP)

Requirement: Inquisitor Prime, Presence 3+

Once per session as an action, fix your gaze on a target within Near range. For the next minute, they cannot tell a direct lie to you; they may evade or refuse to answer, but any statement they make must be factually true. Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

Sanctified Weapon (4 XP)

Requirement: Inquisitor Prime

Once per scene, your weapon ignores 1 point of Armor from supernatural foes. The weapon glows faintly—a visible warning.

Purity Zeal (6 XP)

Requirement: Inquisitor Prime

When you are exposed to corruption (a curse, a demonic presence, a heretic's Rite), you may mark 1 Fatigue to gain +1 die on your next action against the source of that corruption.

3.4.9 Roleplaying a Purifier

- You do not negotiate with corruption. You eradicate it.
- You may be called to witness interrogations, confessions, and executions. Your presence makes them lawful.
- You may struggle with doubt. The Inquisitor Prime does not tolerate doubt. You hide it well.
- You may be asked to show mercy—to a child witch, a desperate hedge-mage, a cultist who surrenders. The code says: no.

3.4.10 Sample NPC: Inquisitor Voss of the Chain-Lanterns

Archetype: Purifier

Patron: Inquisitor Prime

Codex: Gauntlet engraved with the names of proscribed cults

Thiasos: A lantern-spirit that dims when he shows mercy

Personality: Cold, methodical, exhausted. He has burned a hundred heretics. He remembers every face.

Conflict: A child has been found with a mage's knot behind her ear. The law says: burn. The child's mother is holding his hand. The lantern is dimming.

3.4.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for Inquisitor Prime

- An old investigation resurfaces. Someone the Purifier once cleared is accused again—with new evidence.
- The Purifier’s zeal attracts attention. A rival Inquisitor questions their methods.
- A supernatural entity the Purifier wounded escapes and seeks revenge.
- The Purifier’s lantern goes out at a critical moment—not because of magic, but because of doubt.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

3.5 The Witness — Truth and Revelation

3.5.1 Domain and Epithets

The Witness remembers what others bury. Every shadow cast and oath broken is a line in her unending ledger. She is the keeper of inconvenient truths, the patron of those who seek to expose lies or recover forgotten knowledge. Her followers learn that truth comes with a price—the weight of remembering what others would forget.

The Witness has no will, only a ledger; no mercy, only accuracy. She does not demand confessions, but she ensures that every lie leaves a stain, every secret a trace. Those who serve her become archivists of the uncomfortable, witnesses to the truths that others would kill to keep hidden. To walk her path is to accept that some truths are weapons, and that the truth-teller is never loved.

3.5.2 Cultural Origins

The Witness appears wherever secrets are kept and exposed:

- In **Ecktoria**, she is the Ink-Eye, the Censor’s clerk who copies every redacted line onto a private scroll. Her shrines are archives and scriptoria.
- In **Thepyrgos**, she is the Fractured Mirror, prayed to by spies and scholars who seek to reveal a rival’s true loyalty.
- In **Vhasia**, she is the Fog-Scribe, whose name is whispered when a bell-line fails and the dead must be identified by their secrets.
- In **Silkstrand**, she is the Ledger Saint, invoked before any contract is signed. Her symbol is a cracked seal—a promise that cannot be broken without witness.

3.5.3 Warrior Archetype: The Truth-Sworn

A Runic Warrior of The Witness is not a crusader or a judge. They are a *Truth-Sworn*—a warrior who carries truth in steel and silence. Their Codex is a silver mirror or a locket containing a lock of hair from someone they failed to save. Their Thiasos is a raven that remembers faces, a spirit that records confessions, or a sentient blade that cannot abide a lie.

3.5.4 Codex Form

The Truth-Sworn's Codex is a record of witnessed truth:

- **Silver Mirror:** A hand mirror polished to a flawless sheen. It shows not the Runekeeper's face, but the face of the last person they witnessed telling a lie.
- **Locket:** A silver locket containing a lock of hair or a written name. It is warm when the truth is near.
- **Recording Slate:** A small slate tablet. Words written on it fade after one minute, but they can be recalled by touching the slate. Useful for capturing confessions.

3.5.5 Thiasos Form

- **Raven-Spirit:** A black bird that remembers faces. It can identify any person it has seen before, and it knows when someone is lying.
- **Memory-Echo:** A spirit that cannot speak, but can replay sounds it has witnessed (a confession, a scream, a name spoken in the dark).
- **The Silver Mirror (Sentient):** A hand mirror that speaks in a flat, neutral tone. It can record a single truth and replay it later. It never forgets.

3.5.6 Core Mechanic: The Witnessed Truth

When the Truth-Sworn speaks a truth that someone has tried to hide, they gain 1 Boon. This Boon can only be used on rolls involving investigation, testimony, or exposing deception.

When the Truth-Sworn is lied to, they may test Insight (Wits + Insight) vs. the liar's Deception. On a success, they know the lie. On a critical success, they glimpse the truth beneath.

3.5.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Lingering Trace (4 XP)

Tags: [INVESTIGATION], [KNOWLEDGE], [TRUTH]

Threshold: A trace of the thing to be remembered (hair, dust, a spoken name).

Gain +1 die to investigate or notice something directly related to the trace within the current scene. Ask the GM one yes/no question about whether the trace is connected to a specific person, event, or object.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Uncomfortable Question (5 XP)

Tags: [COMMAND], [FEAR], [TRUTH], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A circle drawn with chalk or string while focusing on a specific person.

Ask one question of a target within the zone. They may either answer truthfully (the GM must give a true answer, though it may be cryptic) or mark 1 Fatigue and gain a *Guilty Tell* Condition (-1 die to all social rolls until they confess the truth to someone).

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Echoing Truth (8 XP)

Tags: [MIND], [TRUTH], [FEAR], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A reflective surface (mirror, still water, polished metal) used to focus on the target.

The target tests Resolve (DV 3) or suffers -1 die to rolls involving memory, deception, or resisting interrogation for the scene. If they fail, you may ask one specific, factual question about something they know, and they must answer truthfully or suffer 1 SB (Hearts) as the memory is forcibly drawn forth.

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of the Immutable Record (7 XP)

Tags: [VOW], [BOND], [TRUTH], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A document signed by all parties within the zone, or a spoken pact witnessed by the caster.

Bind the agreement. Any party who knowingly breaches it suffers 1 SB (Hearts) immediately and gains a persistent *Oathbreaker's Mark* Condition (-1 die on social rolls involving honor, trust, or oaths until amends are made or a significant act redeems them).

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of the Final Reckoning (13 XP)

Tags: [AREA], [COMMAND], [TRUTH], [FEAR], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A formally called gathering (court, council, family meeting) within the consecrated zone.

All present must speak their greatest debt, wrongdoing, or hidden truth related to the gathering's purpose. Those who lie or withhold suffer Harm 2 (Stress/Reputation). Truth-tellers gain +2 dice to social actions for the remainder of the scene within the zone.

Obligation: 3

3.5.8 Patron-Specific Talents

Recorded Echo (4 XP)

Requirement: The Witness

Once per session, touch a physical trace (a footprint, a torn cloth, a drop of blood) and instantly know the last significant action taken by the person who left it (e.g., "they were running," "they hid something under the floor"). Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

Truth's Gaze (6 XP)**Requirement:** The Witness, Presence 3+

Once per session as an action, fix your gaze on a target within Near range. For the next minute, they cannot tell a direct lie to you; they may evade or refuse to answer, but any statement they make must be factually true. Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

The Scar That Testifies (8 XP)**Requirement:** The Witness, Witnessed Scar

Once per session, you may touch a scar and speak a single sentence about the event that caused it. That sentence is considered witnessed truth. In any court or council that recognizes The Witness, it carries the weight of sworn testimony. You cannot use this talent on the same scar twice.

3.5.9 Roleplaying a Truth-Sworn

- You do not lie. You may omit, you may deflect, but you do not lie.
- You may be called to witness confessions, contracts, and deathbed testaments. Your presence makes them binding.
- You may struggle with the weight of what you know. Some truths are weapons. Some truths are wounds.
- You may be asked to keep a secret. The Witness does not forbid silence—only falsehood.

3.5.10 Sample NPC: Archivist Venn of the Fractured Mirror**Archetype:** Truth-Sworn**Patron:** The Witness**Codex:** A silver mirror that shows the face of the last liar it witnessed**Thiasos:** A raven-spirit that remembers every face it has seen**Personality:** Quiet, precise, burdened. He has witnessed forty years of confessions. He remembers every one.

Conflict: A confession he witnessed twenty years ago was false—the confessor was protecting someone else. The true culprit still walks free. The mirror shows the liar's face every morning.

3.5.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for The Witness

- The Truth-Sworn remembers something they never witnessed—a crime, a conversation, a death—in perfect detail. The Witness is sharing a memory.
- A mirror shows not the Truth-Sworn's face, but the face of someone they wronged.
- A secret the Truth-Sworn has kept is now known to a stranger—a blackmailer, a journalist, a rival.
- The Truth-Sworn's Codex (mirror, locket, slate) goes blank at a critical moment. The Witness is silent. Why?

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Chapter 4

The Threshold (Boundaries, Wards, and Passage)

4.1 The Sealed Gate — Thresholds and Containment

4.1.1 Domain and Epithets

The Sealed Gate stands where realities meet, embodying the sacred power of thresholds, boundaries, and containment. Its followers are wardens, exorcists, and philosophers of separation who believe some things must be kept apart for the world to function. The Gate manifests as an impassive judge whose shifting sigils—binding runes, exclusion marks, or acceptance glyphs—determine what may cross.

Among the peoples of Fate’s Edge, the Sealed Gate is the patron of abjurists, exorcists, and sentinels. In **Aeler**, the Gate is called the Stone Seal, invoked by True-Masons who carve permanent wards into mountain passes. In **Thepyrgos**, the Gate is the Unbreakable Lock, whose sigils are painted on every archive door that holds forbidden texts. In the Mistlands, the Gate is the Bell-Line Keeper, the force that makes the bell-wards hold against the Direwood.

4.1.2 Cultural Origins

The Sealed Gate is invoked wherever something must be kept in or kept out:

- In **Aeler**, the Gate is the Stone Seal. True-Masons carve its sigils into every vault door and mountain pass. The stone remembers every weight placed upon it.
- In **Thepyrgos**, the Gate is the Unbreakable Lock. Its sigils are painted on archive doors, prison cells, and the cages of the Synod’s menagerie of bound spirits.
- In **Vhasia**, the Gate is the Bell-Line Keeper. Its wards hold the fog at bay. When a bell-line fails, the Gate is the first to know—and the last to forgive.
- In **Aelinnel**, the Gate is the Green Seal, painted on hawthorn arches and standing stones. It permits passage only to those who know the proper courtesy.

4.1.3 Warrior Archetype: The Warden

A Runic Warrior of the Sealed Gate is not a crusader or a judge. They are a *Warden*—a sentinel who stands at the boundary between what belongs and what must be kept out. Their Codex is a shield engraved with threshold sigils or a key that opens no lock but seals every door. Their Thiasos is a standing stone that witnesses boundaries, a spirit of the threshold, or a sentient blade that refuses to cross a line without permission.

4.1.4 Codex Form

The Warden's Codex is a tool of separation:

- **Shield:** A steel or wooden shield engraved with threshold sigils. When planted on the ground, it marks a boundary that spirits struggle to cross.
- **Gate-Key:** An iron key that fits no lock. When turned in the air, it seals the nearest door, window, or threshold for one scene.
- **Bell:** A small bronze bell. When rung, it marks a boundary. Spirits hear it; mortals do not.

4.1.5 Thiasos Form

- **Standing Stone:** A small carved stone that, when placed on the ground, grows to waist height. It serves as a ward anchor; any spirit that crosses its threshold must test Resolve (DV 4) or be turned back.
- **Threshold Spirit:** A spirit bound to a specific door, bridge, or gate. It can sense when something crosses its boundary and can alert the Runekeeper.
- **The Keystone (Sentient):** A small carved stone that speaks in riddles. It can seal any door for one scene (once per session), but it will demand a price—a truth, a memory, or a promise.

4.1.6 Core Mechanic: The Warded Threshold

When the Warden marks a boundary (with chalk, salt, a drawn blade, or a placed shield), they may spend 1 Fatigue to create a Warded Threshold. Until the end of the scene, any spirit, undead, or extraplanar creature that attempts to cross the boundary must test Resolve (DV 4) or be turned back. Mortals and natural creatures are unaffected.

4.1.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Sealed Threshold (4 XP)

Tags: [WARD], [BIND], [THRESHOLD]

Threshold: A doorway, gate, or bridge.

Mark a doorway or passage as sealed. Unauthorized crossing tests Spirit + Resolve (DV 3) or suffers a Position penalty (one step worse for that crossing). Creates a 4-segment Ward Integrity clock.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Key's Rebuke (5 XP)**Tags:** [FORCE], [BANISH], [THRESHOLD]**Threshold:** A barrier (door, gate, bridge) and a target attempting to cross.

The target tests Body + Resolve (DV 3) or is pushed back from the threshold. On a success, create a *Rebuke Echo* token granting +1 die to the next boundary defense.

Obligation: 1**Standard Rite: Rite of the Circle of Denial (8 XP)****Tags:** [WARD], [AREA], [BANISH], [THRESHOLD]**Threshold:** A salt ring, iron filings, or boundary stones.

Create a protective circle. Supernatural beings test against the caster's Spirit + Arcana (DV 4) to cross. Mortals suffer -2 dice to force entry. Creates a 6-segment Circle Integrity clock.

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Writ of Passage (7 XP)****Tags:** [BOND], [COMMAND], [MOVEMENT], [THRESHOLD]**Threshold:** Signed authorization or spoken permissions.

Designate an authorized passage route. Allies gain Position +1 when using the route. Unauthorized intruders suffer -1 die to movement or stealth. Creates an 8-segment Writ Authority clock.

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Consecrated Barrier (13 XP)****Tags:** [WARD], [AREA], [SANCTUARY], [FATE], [THRESHOLD]**Threshold:** Relics from three traditions, boundary markers, and a trespasser's acknowledgment.

Consecrate an area against all unauthorized passage. The tests required scale with the intrusion attempt's severity. A 10-segment Sacred Boundary clock tracks the barrier's strength.

Obligation: 3**4.1.8 Patron-Specific Talents****Ward Sense (4 XP)****Requirement:** The Sealed Gate

You can sense the presence of any active ward, seal, or threshold within Near range. You know its general purpose (protection, exclusion, binding) and its strength (DV). This is a passive ability.

Sentinel's Stand (6 XP)**Requirement:** The Sealed Gate, Body 3+

When you take the Defend action while holding a threshold (door, gate, bridge), you gain +1 Armor. Any enemy attempting to cross must test Body + Athletics (DV 4) or be stopped in their tracks.

Threshold Memory (8 XP)

Requirement: The Sealed Gate, Witnessed Scar

Once per session, touch a threshold you have previously warded. You instantly know whether any unauthorized creature has crossed it since you last touched it, and you gain a vague impression of their nature (spirit, undead, mortal, etc.).

4.1.9 Roleplaying a Warden

- You do not argue with what must be kept apart. You enforce the boundary.
- You may be called to seal tombs, prisons, and haunted houses. Your wards are the difference between safety and catastrophe.
- You may struggle with the cost of exclusion. Keeping something out means denying it passage. Sometimes that thing is innocent.
- You may be asked to open a threshold you sealed. The Gate does not forbid mercy—but it demands certainty.

4.1.10 Sample NPC: Warden Kael of the Stone Seal

Archetype: Warden

Patron: The Sealed Gate

Codex: Shield engraved with threshold sigils

Thiasos: A standing stone that whispers when a ward is breached

Personality: Silent, patient, unyielding. He has not left his post in seven years. The gate has not been breached.

Conflict: A child has crossed the threshold he was sworn to guard. The child is innocent. The law says: turn back. The heart says: let pass.

4.1.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for The Sealed Gate

- A ward the Warden placed years ago begins to crack. Something is pressing from the other side.
- The Warden is asked to seal a threshold they know is unjust—a door keeping refugees out, a gate holding prisoners in.
- A threshold spirit the Warden once bound appears, demanding release. The terms were ambiguous. The Gate does not forgive ambiguity.
- The Warden's Codex (shield, key, bell) is damaged. The boundary weakens. Something slips through.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

4.2 The Traveler — Ways and Journeys

4.2.1 Domain and Epithets

The Traveler is the eternal guide of the road, guardian of those who walk the paths between what is and what might be. The Traveler is not merely one who shows the way—they are the way, existing in the pause between steps and in the choice of which path to take when roads fork. Every journey is both physical and spiritual; to move from one place to another is to transform, and the road itself becomes a teacher.

The Traveler has no temples, only crossroads and waystations. No priests, only guides and couriers. No scripture, only the accumulated wisdom of a thousand roads walked and remembered.

4.2.2 Cultural Origins

The Traveler is invoked wherever journeys begin and end:

- In **Kahfagia**, the Traveler is the Lantern-Bearer, whose light guides ships through uncharted waters. Pilots light a beacon before every voyage.
- In **Ykrul**, the Traveler is the Hoof-Print, the spirit of the steppe road that appears as a single arrowhead left at a crossroads.
- In **Aeler**, the Traveler is the Ways-Stone, carved into every mile marker by True-Masons to ensure the road remembers those who walk it.
- In **Fhara**, the Traveler is the Oasis Father, the guide who never drinks—but always finds water.

4.2.3 Warrior Archetype: The Road-Warden

A Runic Warrior of the Traveler is not a sentinel or a judge. They are a *Road-Warden*—a warrior who carries the road in their feet and their steel. Their Codex is a waystone or a compass. Their Thiasos is a spirit-horse that never tires, a road-dog that knows every shortcut, or a sentient blade that has walked more miles than its wielder.

4.2.4 Codex Form

The Road-Warden's Codex is a tool of navigation and passage:

- **Waystone:** A small carved stone, warm to the touch. It always points to the nearest road or safe passage.
- **Compass:** A brass compass whose needle never points north—it points to the nearest threshold. Useful for finding doors, gates, and borders.
- **Road-Staff:** A walking staff carved with route maps. Tapping it on the ground reveals the safest path forward.

4.2.5 Thiasos Form

- **Spirit-Horse:** A horse that never tires and leaves no tracks. It can gallop for a full day without rest, and it knows the way home.
- **Road-Dog:** A grey hound that can smell the difference between a safe road and an ambush. It whines when danger is near.
- **The Waystone Compass (Sentient):** A compass that speaks in the sound of footsteps. It can find a shortcut (reduce travel clock by 2 segments once per journey), but it will ask for a story in return.

4.2.6 Core Mechanic: The Road's Memory

When the Road-Warden travels a road they have walked before, they gain +1 die to all navigation, survival, and stealth rolls on that road. The road remembers them.

When the Road-Warden helps another traveler find their way (offering directions, an escort, or a map), they gain 1 Boon. This Boon can only be used on rolls involving travel, navigation, or escape.

4.2.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of Road-Sense (4 XP)

Tags: [NAVIGATION], [AWARENESS], [TRAVEL]

Threshold: A road-nail or waystone pebble.

Unerringly pick the fastest safe route in Near or Far. Gain +1 die to avoid ambushes or delays. Create a 4-segment Path Memory clock to ignore difficult terrain once.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Traveler's Boon (5 XP)

Tags: [MOVEMENT], [BOND], [HASTE], [TRAVEL]

Threshold: Thread tied at the wrist.

Ignore one level of difficult terrain or bureaucracy; +1 Effect to travel or escape checks. If shared, create a 2-segment Shared Journey bond with an ally.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Waymark (8 XP)

Tags: [MARK], [GUIDANCE], [PATH], [TRAVEL]

Threshold: A chalk mark or small cairn.

Declare a lane as permitted or easy. Allies gain improved Position/Effect or ignore one obstacle. Create a 6-segment Marked Path clock.

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of the Bridge Between (7 XP)**Tags:** [TELEPORT], [PATH], [BOND], [TRAVEL]**Threshold:** Two pinches of road-dust clapped together.

Relocate a willing target within Far along a visible or named route. Unwilling targets may resist (Body + Resolve DV 3). Create a 4-segment Pathway Established clock.

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Wayfarer's Covenant (14 XP)****Tags:** [VOW], [COMMAND], [BOND], [FEAR], [TRAVEL]**Threshold:** Waystones from multiple regions.

Bind present parties to safe passage. While honored: +2 Effect on travel, reroll one failed travel roll per scene. Breaking the oath inflicts Harm 1 (Fatigue) and marks the breaker as *Oathbreaker of the Road* (-2 dice to travel rolls).

Obligation: 3**4.2.8 Patron-Specific Talents****Shortcut (4 XP)****Requirement:** The Traveler

Once per session when moving from one location to another (including during travel montages), declare a hidden shortcut that reduces the remaining travel clock by 2 segments. The GM may describe a minor cost or complication (e.g., "the path is steep—mark 1 Fatigue").

Road Memory (6 XP)**Requirement:** The Traveler

You never forget a road you have walked. You can draw a perfect map of any route you have traveled, including shortcuts, hazards, and waystations. This is a passive ability.

Wayfinder's Blessing (8 XP)**Requirement:** The Traveler, Tier II+

Once per journey, you may declare that a road you are traveling is blessed. For the duration of the journey, you and your party suffer -1 DV to all navigation and survival rolls, and the first ambush is automatically detected. The GM gains 2 SB (the road remembers the favor).

4.2.9 Roleplaying a Road-Warden

- You do not stay in one place. The road is your home; the horizon is your destination.
- You may be called to guide caravans, escort refugees, or find lost travelers. Your knowledge of the road is worth more than gold.

- You may struggle with the cost of movement. Every journey leaves something behind. The road remembers what you lost.
- You may be asked to close a road—to deny passage, to seal a gate, to turn someone away. The Traveler does not forbid stillness, but stillness is not the way.

4.2.10 Sample NPC: Road-Warden Cerran of the Broken Trail

Archetype: Road-Warden

Patron: The Traveler

Codex: A compass that points to thresholds, not north

Thiasos: A grey hound that smells ambushes

Personality: Quiet, watchful, restless. He has not slept in a bed for three years. He does not intend to start.

Conflict: A road he once guided is now haunted. Something follows travelers. Cerran cannot remember the route—the road has forgotten him. He needs to walk it again to remind the stones who he is.

4.2.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for The Traveler

- A road the Road-Warden has walked before now leads somewhere else—a different building, a different forest, a different year.
- The Road-Warden's boots wear out instantly. They must walk barefoot for a scene, feeling every stone.
- A stranger approaches on the road and asks for directions. If the Road-Warden lies, they become lost for 1d4 hours. If they tell the truth, the stranger follows.
- The Road-Warden's compass spins without stopping. The threshold is close—but it does not want to be found.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

4.3 The Pale Shepherd — Passage and Melancholic Wisdom

4.3.1 Domain and Epithets

The Pale Shepherd walks the seam between all things—life and death, joy and sorrow, memory and forgetting, the known and the unmarked. Neither wholly kind nor cruel, the Shepherd guides those who must pass through the hardest doors. Cloaked, with shadow-sheep that bear the shed wool of old possibilities, the Shepherd offers safe conduct through liminal space for a price paid in memory, feeling, or fate.

The Shepherd has no will, only a path; no demand, only a presence. It does not seek followers, but those who stand at thresholds—of death, of grief, of irreversible change—may find the Shepherd already there, waiting to accompany them. Its demands are not commands but the natural toll of passage: a memory left behind, a name forgotten, a tear shed for no reason.

4.3.2 Cultural Origins

The Pale Shepherd appears wherever thresholds are crossed:

- In **Aelaerem**, the Shepherd is the Pale Gardener, who walks the hedgerows at twilight, collecting the souls of those who die far from home.
- In **Aeler**, the Shepherd is the Breath-Accountant, who weighs the last exhalation of the dying.
- In **Linn**, the Shepherd is the Fog-Walker, appearing on the horizon before a storm.
- In **Vhasia**, the Shepherd is the Silent Notary, witnessing deathbed testaments.

Wherever mortals face the hardest thresholds, the Pale Shepherd is there—not to judge, not to command, but to accompany.

4.3.3 Warrior Archetype: The Death-Warden

A Runic Warrior of the Pale Shepherd is not a sentinel or a road-guide. They are a *Death-Warden*—a warrior who stands at the threshold between life and death, guiding those who cross and protecting those who remain. Their Codex is a grey cloak or a shepherd's crook. Their Thiasos is a spirit-sheep that carries memories, a grey bird that sings at funerals, or a sentient bell that tolls once for each soul guided home.

4.3.4 Codex Form

The Death-Warden's Codex is a symbol of passage:

- **Grey Cloak:** A heavy woollen cloak, grey as twilight. It is warm even in winter. It smells of rain and old stone.
- **Shepherd's Crook:** A wooden staff curved at the top. It can pull a willing soul from the threshold of death—once per patient.
- **Memory Cord:** A braided cord of grey wool, with eight knots. The ninth is never tied. Each knot holds a memory of someone who has passed.

4.3.5 Thiasos Form

- **Spirit-Sheep:** A small grey sheep with eyes like river stones. It carries the shed wool of old possibilities. It can absorb a memory and hold it safely for one day.
- **Grey Bird:** A small bird, often a sparrow or dove. It sings when someone is about to die. It sings when someone is born. It does not sing for anything else.
- **The Grey Bell (Sentient):** A small bronze bell that hums, never rings. It speaks in the voice of the last soul it guided. It asks only to be carried to thresholds.

4.3.6 Core Mechanic: The Threshold Guide

When the Death-Warden is present at a death (their own or another's), they may choose to guide the dying. The dying passes peacefully, without fear. The Death-Warden gains 1 Boon, which may only be used to ease suffering, protect the vulnerable, or cross a threshold.

When the Death-Warden helps someone through a difficult passage (grief, change, loss), they may clear 1 Fatigue. This can be done once per scene.

4.3.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Gentle Guide (5 XP)

Tags: [GUIDANCE], [BOOST], [THRESHOLD], [RISK]

Threshold: A small stone from a grave or threshold, warmed in the palm.

Choose one: ease a hard crossing (target gains +1 die to rolls involving change, decision, or emotional steadiness this scene) or find a hidden path (gain +2 dice to Navigation or Investigation when seeking unconventional routes).

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Unburdened Farewell (6 XP)

Tags: [HEAL], [CLEANSE], [DEBT], [FEAR]

Threshold: A personal letter never sent, burned in a copper dish.

Speak a final goodbye to someone not present—a lost lover, a dead parent, a friend you wronged. Clear 1 Fatigue and remove one psychological Condition (e.g., Haunted, Guilty) caused by that relationship. The GM gains 1 SB as the words drift into the threshold.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Passing Flock (8 XP)

Tags: [GUIDANCE], [KNOWLEDGE], [HEAL], [AREA], [RISK]

Threshold: Black wool and a personal token of the one to be guided.

Choose one: open a brief passage through shadow-realms (target bypasses one insurmountable obstacle) or call shadow-sheep that carry fragments of weighty moments (retrieve lost details, soothe grief, or glean counsel from what was).

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of the Steadfast Witness (7 XP)

Tags: [WITNESS], [DEBT], [TRUTH], [THRESHOLD]

Threshold: A dying person's last words, spoken aloud and witnessed.

Record the dying's final testament. The words are binding on the living. Any who break them suffer -1 die to all actions for one week unless they atone. The GM gains 1 SB (the threshold remembers).

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of the Unburdened Crossing (13 XP)**Tags:** [DEATH], [GUIDANCE], [FATE], [THRESHOLD]**Threshold:** A dying person, a witness, and a grey wool cord.

Guide a willing creature across the threshold of death. They die peacefully, without fear. Before they pass, they may speak one final truth. That truth is considered witnessed; it cannot be denied by any who hear it. You gain a permanent memory of their last words, which may be used as a *Truth Compass* (+1 die to any roll directly related to fulfilling their final wish).

Obligation: 3**4.3.8 Patron-Specific Talents****Comforting Presence (4 XP)****Requirement:** The Pale Shepherd

Once per scene, when you touch a creature suffering from Fear, Guilt, or Grief, you may remove that Condition. The creature clears 1 Fatigue if the Condition was particularly heavy (GM discretion).

Final Witness (6 XP)**Requirement:** The Pale Shepherd, Spirit 3+

Once per session, when a sentient creature dies within Near range, you may ask the GM one question about that creature's final thoughts or unfulfilled wishes. The GM must answer truthfully.

Threshold Keep (8 XP)**Requirement:** The Pale Shepherd, Spirit 3+

You may sense any active threshold (door, gate, bridge, border) within Far range, and you know its mood (welcoming, hostile, sorrowful, waiting). This is a passive ability.

4.3.9 Roleplaying a Death-Warden

- You do not fear death. You have seen it too many times. You respect it.
- You may be called to witness deathbed testaments, to guide the dying, or to comfort the grieving. Your presence is a gift—and a reminder.
- You may struggle with the weight of farewells. Every goodbye leaves a mark. The grey cloak grows heavier.
- You may be asked to let someone go—a patient, a friend, yourself. The Shepherd does not hold. The Shepherd accompanies.

4.3.10 Sample NPC: Sister Anja of the Grey Cloak

Archetype: Death-Warden

Patron: The Pale Shepherd

Codex: Grey cloak, each fold a farewell witnessed

Thiasos: A grey bird that sings when someone is about to die

Personality: Calm, gentle, inexhaustibly sad. She has guided three hundred souls across the threshold. She remembers every name.

Conflict: A child is dying. The child's mother begs Anja to save her. Anja cannot. She can only accompany. The grey bird sings.

4.3.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for The Pale Shepherd

- A ghost the Death-Warden once guided appears at an inopportune moment, asking for help with unfinished business.
- The Death-Warden's grey cloak grows heavier. A soul is not passing; it is clinging. The threshold is blocked.
- A funeral the Death-Warden attended is suddenly disputed—someone claims the deceased was not of sound mind when they spoke their final truth.
- The Death-Warden dreams of a door they have never seen. On the other side, someone is waiting. The Shepherd does not say who.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Chapter 5

The Wild (Nature, Seasons, and the Hunt)

5.1 Grimmer — The Wild Speaker

5.1.1 Domain and Epithets

Grimmer is the Old Man of the Forest, the presence that watches from the shadow of the oldest oak, the cold breath on the back of the neck when the path grows dark. He is not kind, nor is he cruel—he is wild, and the wild does not negotiate. It demands, and it takes. His followers learn to read the language of blood on snow, the geometry of root and stone, and the weight of a heart offered at the turning of the year.

Those who walk his path become keepers of the old ways: druids who know when a grove must be fed, rangers who leave the first kill for the soil, and hedge-folk who whisper the names of spirits not to be spoken aloud. Their magic is not the gentle coaxing of garden plants but the raw, patient hunger of the forest floor—a hunger that swallows bones and grows mushrooms in the shape of the dead.

5.1.2 Cultural Origins

Grimmer appears wherever the wild presses against the works of civilization:

- In **Aeler**, he is the Root-Father, patron of deep fungus and stone-lichen. His shrines are carved into living rock where moss is never cleared.
- In **Ykrul**, he is a sky-wolf who herds the seasons; shamans invoke Grimmer to predict the spring thaw.
- In **Aelaerem**, he is the Thorn-Father, keeper of hedgerow magic. Villagers tie red thread around his roadside stones before planting.
- In **Valewood**, he is the Old Oak, the spirit that watches from the heart of the forest. The Lethai leave offerings of bread and salt at his roots.

5.1.3 Warrior Archetype: The Root-Knight

A Runic Warrior of Grimmer is not a steward of gardens. They are a *Root-Knight*—a wild warrior who fights with root and thorn, who wears the forest as armor and carries the season’s hunger in their blade. Their Codex is a carved

staff or living bark. Their Thiasos is a wolf-ancestor that hunts beside them, a fungal familiar that speaks in spores, or a sentient blade grown from a lightning-struck oak.

5.1.4 Codex Form

The Root-Knight's Codex is a living thing:

- **Carved Staff:** A staff of oak or ash, carved with seasonal runes. It grows leaves in spring and sheds them in autumn. It is never truly dead.
- **Living Bark:** A strip of bark taken from a sacred tree. Rites are carved into it. It remains alive, weeping sap when a Rite is invoked.
- **Thorn-Cord:** A braided cord of hawthorn and bramble. It draws blood when touched. The blood feeds the Rite.

5.1.5 Thiasos Form

- **Wolf-Ancestor:** A grey wolf the size of a pony, with eyes that reflect scenes from the Runekeeper's childhood. It tracks across any terrain and teaches forgotten battle-songs.
- **Fungal Familiar:** A pale fungus that grows from a crack in the Runekeeper's armor. It speaks in spores and can detect decay, rot, or corruption within Near range.
- **The Root-Staff (Sentient):** A walking staff carved from living wood. It speaks in the rustle of wind through branches. It can sense the health of nearby plants.

5.1.6 Core Mechanic: The Seasonal Bond

At the start of each season (spring, summer, autumn, winter), the Root-Knight gains a seasonal boon:

- **Spring:** +1 die to healing and growth-related rolls.
- **Summer:** +1 die to strength and harvest-related rolls.
- **Autumn:** +1 die to preservation and preparation-related rolls.
- **Winter:** +1 die to endurance and hiding-related rolls.

The boon lasts until the next season. The Root-Knight may change their bond by performing a seasonal ritual (one day, requires a threshold and an offering).

5.1.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Blood Offering (4 XP)

Tags: [SACRIFICE], [NATURE], [STEALTH]

Threshold: A drop of your own blood (1 Fatigue) or the blood of a freshly killed animal.

The forest accepts your offering. For the remainder of the scene, you gain +1 die to all Survival and Stealth rolls in natural terrain. You may ask the GM one yes/no question about a threat hidden in the wilderness.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Predator's Gaze (5 XP)

Tags: [MARK], [FEAR], [TRACK]

Threshold: A tooth from a predator that killed its own prey.

Mark a single target as your prey. Gain +1 die on all rolls to track, pursue, or intimidate that target. The effect lasts until the target escapes or is killed.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Shifting Shape (8 XP)

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [BEAST], [BOOST]

Threshold: A pelt or mask from the beast whose form you take.

Assume the form of a predator for the scene. Choose bear (tank form: +1 Armor, +2 dice to Body rolls, movement reduced) or wolf (striker form: +2 dice to Agility and Stealth, +1 band movement). You may speak but cannot use tools or cast other Rites while transformed.

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of the Carrion Feast (9 XP)

Tags: [CONSUME], [HEAL], [BOOST]

Threshold: The flesh of a fallen enemy, consumed raw.

Devour the strength of the fallen. Heal 1 Fatigue immediately, and gain +1 die to your next physical action. If the enemy was supernatural (spirit, demon, fey), you also gain a minor property of theirs for one scene.

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of the Cycle's Crown (14 XP)

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [NATURE], [BOOST], [PROTECT]

Threshold: A circlet of woven branches, antlers, and seasonal tokens.

Become an avatar of the cycle. Choose two: seasonal mastery (+2 dice to actions keyed to the current season), verdant command (command plant life in Near automatically), cycle's healing (remove one Condition or downgrade Harm by one level), or growth's protection (allies gain +1 Armor from natural cover). Begin a Seasonal Avatar [6] clock.

Obligation: 3

5.1.8 Patron-Specific Talents

Seasonal Sense (4 XP)

Requirement: Grimmer

You can predict the weather for the next hour with perfect accuracy. You know when the season will turn within a day. This is a passive ability.

Wild Shape (6 XP)

Requirement: Grimmer, Body 3+

Once per session, you may assume the form of a small beast (wolf, hawk, badger) for up to one scene. While transformed, you gain +2 dice to Stealth and Perception in natural terrain, but cannot speak or use tools. Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

Beast Speech (8 XP)

Requirement: Grimmer, Spirit 3+

You can speak with animals. They are not compelled to obey, but they will answer simple questions truthfully—as they understand truth. The GM may have animals respond with limited knowledge or animal logic.

5.1.9 Roleplaying a Root-Knight

- You do not command nature. You listen to it. The forest speaks; you are not always fluent.
- You may be called to settle disputes between villages and the wild—a wolf pack, a blighted grove, a tree that has grown across a road.
- You may struggle with the cost of the hunt. Every kill is a sacrament. Every death feeds the earth. You do not kill lightly.
- You may be asked to let something die—a forest, a creature, a memory. The cycle demands it.

5.1.10 Sample NPC: Warden Thorne of the Root-Staff

Archetype: Root-Knight

Patron: Grimmer

Codex: A living staff that grows leaves in spring

Thiasos: A wolf-ancestor who remembers the Runekeeper's grandfather

Personality: Quiet, patient, watchful. He has not spoken a word in seven years. The wolf speaks for him.

Conflict: A village wants to cut down an ancient oak that shelters the forest's heart. The oak is dying anyway. The cycle says: let it fall. The village says: save it. The wolf is silent.

5.1.II GM Guidance: Intrusions for Grimmer

- A tree the Root-Knight passed yesterday now blocks their path—with a face carved into it that looks like theirs.
- All food the Root-Knight touches spoils within an hour unless they offer the first bite to the earth.
- A pack of wolves shadows the party for a full day. They do not attack. They simply watch.
- The season turns early. The Root-Knight's seasonal boon shifts unexpectedly. The cycle is restless.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

5.2 The Carrion-King — Decay, Renewal, and Transformation**5.2.1 Domain and Epithets**

The Carrion-King is the master of endings that become beginnings. He does not destroy, but transforms—turning death into new life, decay into opportunity, and endings into fresh starts. His followers are harvesters of potential, seeing in every fall the seeds of future growth. The King has no will, only a hunger; no malice, only a rhythm. When something ends, he is there to turn it toward the next beginning.

What crumbles feeds what grows. What dies becomes the soil of tomorrow's triumph. The King does not ask for sacrifice—he simply waits for it.

5.2.2 Cultural Origins

The Carrion-King appears wherever things end and begin again:

- In **Acasia**, he is the Rot-King, whose touch turns blighted fields to fertile soil. Farmers leave the first sheaf of grain unharvested for him.
- In **Vhasia**, he is the Dust-Accountant. Soldiers leave a button from a fallen comrade on a cairn—the King turns that button into a bullet for the next battle.
- In **Aeler**, he is the Under-Gardener. Dwarven crypts have bioluminescent fungus fed by the dead. The King tends the crop.
- In **Valewood**, he is the Compost-King, the force that turns fallen leaves to loam. The Lethai do not invoke him. They simply let him work.

5.2.3 Warrior Archetype: The Grave-Warden

A Runic Warrior of the Carrion-King is not a hunter of the living. They are a *Grave-Warden*—a warrior who harvests endings and turns them into strength. Their Codex is a compost-stained trowel or a belt of bleached bones. Their Thiasos is a fungal familiar that speaks in spores, a crow that follows battlefields, or a sentient blade forged from the iron of a broken plow.

5.2.4 Codex Form

The Grave-Warden's Codex is made from what was once alive:

- **Bone-Chime:** A set of three bleached bones strung on a leather cord. It clicks when death is near. Each bone came from a creature the Runekeeper killed.
- **Compost-Stained Trowel:** A small iron trowel, crusted with dark earth. It turns soil—and memory.
- **Rot-Cord:** A braided cord of fungus-twined leather. It tightens when something is about to die. It loosens when death is harvested.

5.2.5 Thiasos Form

- **Fungal Familiar:** A pale fungus that grows from a crack in the Runekeeper's armor. It speaks in spores and can detect decay, rot, or impending death within Near range.
- **Battle-Crow:** A black crow with one white feather. It follows battles and funerals. It can carry a message to the dead—though the dead may not answer.
- **The Bone-Chime (Sentient):** A set of bones that clicks in the voice of the creature they came from. It can sense when something is about to die. It is never wrong.

5.2.6 Core Mechanic: Harvest Resonance

When the Grave-Warden is present when something ends (a life, a battle, a structure, a relationship), they may draw a sliver of that ending's energy. Gain +1 die on your next action, or clear 1 Fatigue. You may use this once per scene.

When the Grave-Warden kills a significant enemy (GM discretion), they may mark 1 Obligation to gain a permanent *Harvest Scar*—a small mark on their body that grants +1 die to a specific type of roll related to that enemy's nature (e.g., +1 die to track wolves after killing a wolf-chieftain).

5.2.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Rotting Harvest (5 XP)

Tags: [DECAY], [HARVEST], [BOOST]

Threshold: Organic matter in early stages of decay, or the remains of a recently ended thing (burnt letter, wilted flower, shattered glass).

Accelerate natural decay to weaken or destroy an organic object (ropes, leather, wood), gaining +2 Effect on Break/Sabotage rolls against it. Alternatively, extract value from an ending: from a defeated enemy, gain +1 die on your next action; from a failed plan, reroll one 1 on your next roll; from a broken item, gain 1 Boon.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Borrowed Form (7 XP)**Tags:** [KNOWLEDGE], [SPIRIT], [BOOST]**Threshold:** A token from a deceased being (hair, nail, written name).

Channel the essence of what was. Gain one skill die reflecting the deceased's expertise for one scene, or ask the GM one question about their knowledge or abilities.

Obligation: 1**Standard Rite: Rite of the Fertile Death (8 XP)****Tags:** [TRANSFORM], [AREA], [HEAL], [TERRAIN]**Threshold:** Ashes, compost, or the remains of anything that once lived.

Transform death into growth: choose one—create beneficial terrain (cover, concealment, or advantageous positioning) OR grant allies +1 die to healing or recovery rolls for the scene.

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Great Consumption (13 XP)****Tags:** [DECAY], [AREA], [SUMMON], [TRANSFORM]**Threshold:** A significant amount of organic matter (corpse, fallen tree, collapsed building).

Transform a large area through decay and renewal. Choose two of the following: create difficult terrain that favors you and your allies; summon a Cap 3 swarm of scavengers as temporary allies; generate valuable reagents worth 2 XP (usable for crafting or barter).

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Eternal Cycle (14 XP)****Tags:** [TRANSFORM], [FATE], [SACRIFICE]

Threshold: The complete remains of something significant that has ended (a broken oath, a fallen kingdom's charter, a slain legendary beast).

Complete a transformation cycle. Destroy one major asset, enemy, or obstacle, and create something new of equal or greater value. The player and GM collaborate to define the transformation.

Obligation: 3**5.2.8 Patron-Specific Talents****Harvest Resonance (4 XP)****Requirement:** The Carrion-King

Once per scene after an enemy is defeated or a significant ending occurs, you may draw a sliver of that ending's energy. Gain +1 die on your next action, or clear 1 Fatigue. You cannot use this talent again until the next scene.

Rot Sense (6 XP)**Requirement:** The Carrion-King

You can sense decay, rot, or corruption within Near range. You know the general direction and approximate strength (minor, moderate, severe). This is a passive ability.

Essence Feast (8 XP)**Requirement:** The Carrion-King, Witnessed Scar

When you consume the flesh of a fallen supernatural enemy (spirit, demon, fey), you gain a minor property of theirs for one scene. You must describe the consumption—raw, cooked, or ritual.

5.2.9 Roleplaying a Grave-Warden

- You do not fear endings. You harvest them. Every death is soil. Every failure is fertilizer.
- You may be called to clear battlefields, compost blighted fields, or ritually end things that should not continue.
- You may struggle with the weight of endings. Not everything should end. The King does not distinguish.
- You may be asked to let something die—a friendship, a hope, a part of yourself. The cycle demands it. The King waits.

5.2.10 Sample NPC: Warden Kael of the Bone-Chime**Archetype:** Grave-Warden**Patron:** The Carrion-King**Codex:** A bone-chime that clicks when death is near**Thiasos:** A fungal familiar that grows from a crack in his armor

Personality: Quiet, patient, relentless. He has harvested a thousand endings. He does not mourn. He does not celebrate. He works.

Conflict: A village is dying—not from plague or war, but from slow despair. The fields are fallow. The wells are dry. The King wants the ending. Kael is not sure he does.

5.2.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for The Carrion-King

- A dead creature the Grave-Warden passed earlier now follows them—not as an enemy, but as a witness. It does not attack. It watches.
- All food in the party's packs spoils instantly, except for a single loaf of black bread. The bread is warm. It was baked yesterday.
- A villager the Grave-Warden saved bears a small rot-mark on their hand. It spreads one inch each day.

- The Grave-Warden's bone-chime clicks at an unexpected moment. Something is about to die. The King is hungry.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

5.3 The Savage Heart — Predation and the Red Maw

5.3.1 Domain and Epithets

The Savage Heart is the truth behind the green veil: nature not as garden, but as gullet. It is the claw that tears, the fang that crushes, the hunger that stalks without malice and kills without mercy. Its followers are not gentle guardians of the wild—they are its teeth and claws. Power comes from taking, from proving strength, from the raw act of predation.

The Savage Heart does not ask. It takes. The deer does not weep for the wolf. The sapling does not beg the axe. In the red maw, there is no cruelty—only truth. The truth that all flesh feeds the earth, and the earth feeds the strong.

5.3.2 Cultural Origins

The Savage Heart wears the face of the apex predator in every land:

- In the **Amaranthine core**, it is the Great Bear, patient and unstoppable, a wall of fur and fury.
- Among the **Ykrul** and **Kuvani**, it is the Wolf of the Steppe, a pack hunter with tireless stamina.
- In **Oshiira**, it is the Golden Lion, whose roar shatters the hunt's silence.
- In **Sekogo**, it is the Leopard of the Tall Grass, a shadow that strikes once and is gone.
- In **Dhahara**, it is the Tiger of the Mangroves, whose amber gaze promises a death that runs faster than you can flee.

5.3.3 Warrior Archetype: The Beast Warrior

A Runic Warrior of the Savage Heart is not a gardener of rot or a warden of seasons. They are a *Beast Warrior*—a predator who wears the skin of their kills, who hunts as sacrament, who transforms into the very thing they stalk. Their Codex is a predator's tooth or a pelt worn as a cloak. Their Thiasos is a wolf-ancestor, a great cat's spirit, or a sentient blade carved from the fang of a legendary beast.

5.3.4 Codex Form

The Beast Warrior's Codex is a trophy of the hunt:

- **Predator's Tooth:** A large canine tooth on a leather thong. It is warm when prey is near. It grows heavier with each kill.

- **Pelt Cloak:** The cured hide of an apex predator (bear, wolf, lion, tiger). Wearing it grants +1 die to Intimidation.
- **Claw Necklace:** A string of claws from worthy kills. Each claw holds a memory of the hunt. The necklace clicks when the hunt begins.

5.3.5 Thiasos Form

- **Wolf-Ancestor:** A grey wolf the size of a pony, with eyes that reflect the Runekeeper's first kill. It tracks across any terrain and fights beside its pack-brother.
- **Great Cat Spirit:** A translucent leopard or tiger that moves without sound. It can stalk a target for hours without being seen.
- **The Fang (Sentient):** A blade carved from the tooth of a legendary beast. It speaks in growls. It hungers. It demands to be fed.

5.3.6 Core Mechanic: The Hunt

When the Beast Warrior marks a target as prey (an action, requires line of sight or a successful tracking roll), they gain +1 die to all rolls to track, pursue, or confront that target. The mark lasts until the target escapes or is killed.

When the Beast Warrior kills their marked prey, they may immediately clear 1 Fatigue and gain 1 Boon. This Boon may only be used on physical actions.

5.3.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Predator's Gaze (4 XP)

Tags: [MARK], [FEAR], [TRACK]

Threshold: A tooth from a predator that killed its own prey.

Mark a single target as your prey. Gain +1 die on all rolls to track, pursue, or intimidate that target. The effect lasts until the target escapes or is killed.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Blood Scent (5 XP)

Tags: [SENSE], [FEAR], [TRACK]

Threshold: A fresh kill's blood smeared on your face.

You scent the air like a beast. Gain +2 dice to Investigation or Survival when tracking by smell. You may also detect fear—you sense if a creature within Near is Frightened.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Shifting Shape (8 XP)**Tags:** [TRANSFORM], [BEAST], [BOOST]**Threshold:** A pelt or mask from the beast whose form you take.

Assume the form of a predator for the scene. Choose bear (tank form: +1 Armor, +2 dice to Body rolls, movement reduced) or wolf (striker form: +2 dice to Agility and Stealth, +1 band movement). You may speak but cannot use tools or cast other Rites while transformed.

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Pack Hunt (7 XP)****Tags:** [TEAMWORK], [BEAST], [BOOST]**Threshold:** A token from each member of your pack (a claw, a feather, a scrap of hide).

You and up to three allies form a hunting pack. While within Near of each other, all gain +1 die to attacks against a single designated prey, and the first ally to attack each round gains +1 Effect.

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Savage Transformation (13 XP)****Tags:** [TRANSFORM], [BEAST], [BOOST], [FEAR]**Threshold:** The complete pelt of an apex predator, worn during the rite.

Fully transform into an apex predator for one scene. You gain the physical attributes of the beast: Body +2, +2 Armor from thick hide, and your melee attacks deal +2 Harm. You cannot speak or use tools. You may end the transformation early as an action. When the transformation ends, you mark 2 Fatigue.

Obligation: 3**5.3.8 Patron-Specific Talents****Beast Form (6 XP)****Requirement:** The Savage Heart, Body 3+

Once per session, you may partially transform into a predator for one scene. Choose one: gain +2 dice to Stealth (leopard/tiger), +2 dice to Intimidation (bear/lion), or +1 band to movement (wolf/hound). You cannot use this talent while already transformed.

Blood Hunt (4 XP)**Requirement:** The Savage Heart

When you are tracking a target that you have wounded, you gain +1 die to all tracking and pursuit rolls. The scent of their blood is a trail you cannot lose.

Alpha's Roar (8 XP)**Requirement:** The Savage Heart, Presence 3+

Once per session, you may make a terrifying sound—a roar, a howl, a scream. All enemies within Near range must test Resolve (DV 4) or become Shaken (-1 die to all actions) for one exchange. This does not affect creatures that are immune to fear.

5.3.9 Roleplaying a Beast Warrior

- You do not fight for glory. You hunt for survival. The kill is sacrament; the meat is blessing.
- You may be called to track fugitives, hunt dangerous beasts, or lead a pack in war.
- You may struggle with the hunger. The Savage Heart does not ask you to be gentle. It asks you to be true—to the hunt, to the pack, to yourself.
- You may be asked to kill something that does not deserve to die. The Heart does not care about deserving. The Heart is hungry.

5.3.10 Sample NPC: Mkara of the Leopard's Shadow

Archetype: Beast Warrior

Patron: The Savage Heart

Codex: A leopard's tooth on a leather thong

Thiasos: A great cat spirit that moves without sound

Personality: Silent, patient, deadly. She has never lost a hunt. She has never needed to speak.

Conflict: A child has wandered into the territory of a wounded leopard. The leopard is dangerous. The child is innocent. The hunt says: kill. The heart says: wait. The leopard is watching.

5.3.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for The Savage Heart

- The Beast Warrior's prey escapes—not because of poor skill, but because the prey was not worthy. The Savage Heart is displeased.
- A rival predator enters the Beast Warrior's territory. It does not attack. It watches. It is judging.
- The Beast Warrior's pelt cloak begins to itch. The beast whose skin it was is not entirely dead. It dreams.
- The hunt lasts too long. The Beast Warrior marks 1 Fatigue. The hunger grows. The Savage Heart whispers: *faster*.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Chapter 6

The Deep (Pressure, Storms, and the Abyss)

6.1 Khemesh — The Abyssal Maw

6.1.1 Domain and Epithets

Khemesh is not merely a lord of the depths but the hunger beneath them, a pressure older than seas. Those who bargain with him are marked by the abyss—seen in the way shadows cling, in the whispers heard when no voice speaks, in the certainty that all things will sink. He is the classic warlock’s patron: distant, vast, and utterly indifferent to mortal morality. To serve Khemesh is to accept that the universe is cold, that the deep does not hate—it simply consumes.

In the trench without light, the Maw waits. Even silence drowns.

6.1.2 Cultural Origins

Khemesh appears wherever depth meets pressure and hunger:

- In **Zakov**, he is the Drowned Prince. Pirates toss a silver coin overboard before a raid—if it sinks, Khemesh approves.
- In **Linn**, he is the Reef-Father. Fishermen leave the first catch of the day to him, cutting a piece of flesh and letting it sink.
- In **Kahfagia**, he is the Pressure Below, invoked by divers and wreck-salvagers. His symbol is a black pearl.
- In **Aeler**, he is the Deep Listener. Miners whisper to him before descending into new shafts. The stone answers—or does not.

6.1.3 Warrior Archetype: The Deep Warrior

A Runic Warrior of Khemesh is not a hunter of the surface. They are a *Deep Warrior*—an eldritch knight who fights in crushing darkness, who carries the pressure of the abyss in their lungs and the silence of the trench in their blade. Their Codex is a shard of abyssal glass or a diving bell’s valve. Their Thiasos is a drowned spirit that speaks in bubbles, a pressure-eel that senses weakness, or a sentient blade forged from the anchor of a sunken ship.

6.1.4 Codex Form

The Deep Warrior's Codex is born of depth:

- **Abyssal Glass:** A shard of black glass that shows no reflection. It is cold to the touch. It whispers when pressure changes.
- **Diving Bell Valve:** A brass valve from a sunken diving bell. It turns to release pressure—or to seal it in.
- **Black Pearl:** A pearl the color of a bruised storm. It is warm when the deep is near. It grows cold when danger passes.

6.1.5 Thiasos Form

- **Drowned Spirit:** The ghost of a sailor who died in darkness. It cannot speak, but it can point. It knows where the pressure is heaviest.
- **Pressure-Eel:** A translucent eel that slides through cracks in stone. It senses weakness in structures and flesh alike. It is blind. It does not need to see.
- **The Abyssal Glass (Sentient):** A shard of black glass that speaks in the voice of drowned captains. It can extinguish light in a Near zone once per session.

6.1.6 Core Mechanic: The Crushing Depth

When the Deep Warrior invokes a Rite, they may choose to draw on the pressure of the deep. For each segment of Obligation they mark beyond the Rite's cost, they gain +1 die to the roll (maximum +3). The pressure does not forgive. The pressure does not forget.

When the Deep Warrior is in darkness or underwater, they gain +1 die to all physical actions. The deep is their ally—or their grave.

6.1.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Crushing Whisper (5 XP)

Tags: [FEAR], [DEBUFF], [AREA], [SILENCE]

Threshold: A broken shell filled with ink-dark water.

Choose one: whisper of the trench (target hears impossible echoes and suffers -1 die on their next action) or crushing silence (establish an oppressive silence in a zone; enemies in the zone suffer -1 die to coordination or morale-driven actions).

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Abyssal Grasp (7 XP)**Tags:** [BIND], [PRESSURE], [DEBUFF]**Threshold:** A length of rusted chain submerged in water.

Target is pinned by invisible crushing force: treat as [ENTANGLE] with Great Effect if underwater or confined.

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Alien Gaze (9 XP)****Tags:** [KNOWLEDGE], [TRUTH], [BURDEN], [FEAR]**Threshold:** None—requires standing in absolute darkness or near deep water.

You perceive the world as Khemesh does—fractured, alien, crushing. Gain +2 dice to Notice and Arcana, and may ask one "true nature" question about a foe or structure. When the scene ends, you suffer Exposure +1 as your perception warps.

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Pressure's Toll (8 XP)****Tags:** [TRANSFER], [DEBT], [DEBUFF]**Threshold:** A functioning mechanism and a living creature's hair or blood.

Transfer inefficiency. You may take 1 Fatigue and reduce the DV of your next crafting or repair roll by 1, or touch an enemy to impose -1 die on their next physical action as their muscles "optimise" poorly.

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Sundering Deep (14 XP)****Tags:** [PRESSURE], [AREA], [FATE], [DEATH]**Threshold:** A sealed vessel of abyssal water, broken open.

Reality in the zone folds inward like the crushing deep: enemies act at Desperate Position by default. Each beat, the GM may force 1 SB (Spades/Clubs favoured) as the deep pressures reality. Structures, vessels, or wards fracture as if under immense weight.

Obligation: 3**6.1.8 Patron-Specific Talents****Crushing Silence (6 XP)****Requirement:** Khemesh

Once per session as a reaction when a creature within Near range speaks or casts a spell, impose a bubble of oppressive silence around them for one exchange. They cannot speak, and any spell with a verbal component fails. Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

Deep Sight (4 XP)**Requirement:** Khemesh

You can see in darkness as if it were dim light. In absolute darkness, you are not blind—you perceive pressure and movement instead of light. This is a passive ability.

Pressure Adaptation (8 XP)**Requirement:** Khemesh, Body 3+

You are immune to underwater combat penalties. You can hold your breath for twice as long as normal, and you ignore the first environmental penalty from pressure (diving, crushing depths, cave-ins).

6.1.9 Roleplaying a Deep Warrior

- You do not fear the dark. You were trained in it. The dark is where you hunt.
- You may be called to salvage sunken wrecks, explore flooded ruins, or silence those who speak too loudly in quiet places.
- You may struggle with the isolation. The deep is lonely. Khemesh does not offer companionship. He offers pressure.
- You may be asked to let something sink—a memory, a hope, a friend. The deep takes. The deep does not return.

6.1.10 Sample NPC: Captain Sefu of the Sunken Fleet**Archetype:** Deep Warrior**Patron:** Khemesh**Codex:** A shard of abyssal glass that shows no reflection**Thiasos:** A drowned spirit that points toward pressure**Personality:** Quiet, cold, inexorable. He has not seen the sun in seven years. The deep is his sky.

Conflict: A ship has sunk with a valuable cargo—and with living crew trapped in an air pocket. The cargo belongs to a patron who paid Sefu to retrieve it. The crew are strangers. The pressure is rising. The deep does not distinguish.

6.1.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for Khemesh

- Water pressure quadruples in the room—wooden objects groan, glassware cracks, ears pop. The deep is close.
- A nightmare tentacle manifests from a nearby body of water and steals a shiny object. It is not hostile. It is curious.
- The party begins to sink—not physically, but emotionally. Each character marks 1 Fatigue or confesses a secret fear aloud. The deep listens.

- The Deep Warrior's abyssal glass shows a face that is not theirs. It is smiling. It knows something they do not.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

6.2 **Xhak'Thul — The Thunder-Speaker**

6.2.1 **Domain and Epithets**

Before words, there was thunder. Before scripture, lightning carved its commandments into the bones of the world. Xhak'Thul is the Voice That Splits Mountains, the Drum That Shakes Foundations, a power born from the first storm that ever raged across the primal earth. His faithful are whirlwinds of action—they do not study; they dance, they shout, they move with the sky's fury.

Xhak'Thul does not whisper. He roars. His gifts are not gentle miracles but raw terror, awe, and vitality ripped from nature's heart. To serve him is to become the storm—to move without hesitation, to strike without warning, to be the loudest voice in any room and to make that room tremble.

6.2.2 **Cultural Origins**

Xhak'Thul speaks wherever the sky meets the earth in violence:

- In the deep **Vhasian** highlands, he is the Storm-Father, invoked by herders who watch lightning split the sky above their flocks.
- In **Ykrul**, he is the Thunder-Hoof, the sound of a thousand horses stampeding across the Violet Steppe.
- In **Linn**, he is the Raging Tide, the storm that comes without warning and leaves only wreckage in its wake.
- In **Xhak'Thul's own name**—spoken only in a whisper, never in a shout—is said to be the first sound the world ever made.

6.2.3 **Warrior Archetype: The Storm-Sworn**

A Runic Warrior of Xhak'Thul is not a scholar of weather patterns. They are a *Storm-Sworn*—a primal warrior who carries the tempest in their blood, who shouts as a weapon, who moves with the sudden, violent grace of lightning. Their Codex is a drum made from storm-felled wood or a banner that twists in unfelt wind. Their Thiasos is a storm-spirit that rides the wind, a drum that beats itself, or a sentient blade forged from a lightning-struck spear.

6.2.4 **Codex Form**

The Storm-Sworn's Codex is an instrument of thunder:

- **Storm Drum:** A hand-drum made from the hide of a beast killed by lightning and the wood of a tree struck by the same bolt. It rumbles when storms approach.

- **Thunder Banner:** A torn flag on a broken pole. It twists in wind that no one else can feel. When planted, it calls the storm.
- **Lightning-Scarred Spear:** A spear whose wooden shaft is marked by a lightning strike. The mark glows faintly during storms.

6.2.5 Thiasos Form

- **Storm-Spirit:** A translucent figure of wind and static. It rides the air currents, can carry whispers across distances, and crackles when angered.
- **Drum-Spirit:** A drum that beats itself—slowly when calm, rapidly when danger nears. It can be heard only by the Runekeeper and their allies.
- **The Thunder Drum (Sentient):** A drum that speaks in drumbeats—slow for warning, rapid for danger, a single, sharp crack for "strike now."

6.2.6 Core Mechanic: The Storm's Fury

When the Storm-Sworn takes the initiative in combat (acts first in a scene), they gain +1 die to their first action. The storm does not wait.

When the Storm-Sworn is in an active storm (rain, wind, thunder, lightning), they gain +1 die to all physical actions. The storm knows its own.

6.2.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Thunderous Presence (4 XP)

Tags: [FEAR], [COMMAND], [AREA], [PRESSURE]

Threshold: A drum made from storm-felled wood or any suitable improvised percussion.

Your presence becomes overwhelming. All NPCs within Near range must test Resolve (DV 2) or suffer -1 die to social actions due to awe or terror for the scene. Allies gain +1 die to Intimidation or Command actions.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Storm's Step (5 XP)

Tags: [SPEED], [FEAR], [BOOST]

Threshold: Earth from a lightning strike site, worn boot leather.

You move with the storm's speed. Gain +2 dice to Athletics or Stealth rolls. The first attack you make this scene gains +1 Effect.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Shattered Sky (8 XP)**Tags:** [AREA], [FORCE], [FEAR], [WEATHER]**Threshold:** A shard of meteoric iron or metal touched by a severe storm.

You call a localized, supernatural storm in a zone. Choose one effect: lightning strike (single target, Harm 2), wind blast (knockback, disperses arrows or scatters foes), or hail barrage (Harm 1, AREA). All enemies in the zone suffer -1 die to actions from chaos and distraction.

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Fear-Eater (9 XP)****Tags:** [FEAR], [HEAL], [COMMAND], [BOOST]**Threshold:** Soil or dust from a place of great terror (battlefield, prison, ruins).

You feed on the fear around you. For each Frightened target in the scene, gain +1 die on your next action (max +3). If you successfully Intimidate a target during this scene, you heal 1 Fatigue.

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the World's Drum (14 XP)****Tags:** [AREA], [FEAR], [COMMAND], [TRANSFORM], [WEATHER]**Threshold:** A drum fashioned from lightning-struck wood, with a hide from a beast killed by natural force.

You become an incarnation of the storm for one scene: gain +2 dice to rolls based on strength, speed, and intimidation; your anger echoes as thunder (attacks against you may be answered by lightning, GM discretion, usually 1 SB and Harm 1 to the attacker); enemies test Resolve at -2 dice to resist Fear effects you create. Begin a 6-segment Natural Disasters clock.

Obligation: 3**6.2.8 Patron-Specific Talents****Storm Caller (6 XP)****Requirement:** Xhak'Thul

Once per scene, as a free action, you may cause a peal of thunder to roll across the zone. All enemies within Near must test Resolve (DV 3) or lose their next minor action.

Lightning Reflexes (4 XP)**Requirement:** Xhak'Thul, Body 3+

You gain +1 die to defense rolls against ranged attacks (arrows, bolts, thrown weapons). You see the path of the projectile before it flies.

Fear Eater (8 XP)**Requirement:** Xhak'Thul, Presence 3+

When you successfully Intimidate a target, you gain 1 Boon (once per scene). The fear is not just a weapon—it is sustenance.

6.2.9 Roleplaying a Storm-Sworn

- You do not wait. You act. Hesitation is a lie the wind tells to the still.
- You may be called to break sieges, scatter formations, or terrify enemies into surrender. Your voice is a weapon. Your presence is a warning.
- You may struggle with the aftermath. The storm passes. You remain. The silence after thunder is heavy.
- You may be asked to be gentle—to speak softly, to wait, to hold back. The storm does not understand gentleness. You must learn.

6.2.10 Sample NPC: Storm-Speaker Urum of the Violet Steppe

Archetype: Storm-Sworn

Patron: Xhak'Thul

Codex: A drum made from a tree struck by lightning

Thiasos: A storm-spirit that rides the wind ahead of him

Personality: Loud, restless, generous. He has never whispered a word in his life. He does not intend to start.

Conflict: A drought has gripped the steppe. The clans are dying. Urum can call rain—but the storm will not be gentle. It will flood. It will kill. The price of mercy is destruction. The storm does not negotiate.

6.2.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for Xhak'Thul

- A sudden storm appears on a clear day. The wind shifts direction three times in an hour. Xhak'Thul is watching.
- The Storm-Sworn's drum beats once—loud, sharp, unexpected. Something has noticed them. Something hungry.
- Lightning strikes near the party—not aimed, not random. A warning. The sky is listening.
- The Storm-Sworn's voice cracks. Not from strain—from pressure. The storm is inside them now. It wants out.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

6.3 Raéyn — Mistress of the Sea

6.3.1 Domain and Epithets

Raéyn is the tempestuous goddess of the sea, the restless tide that carries news between shores and the promise of change between lives. She is mother to all who sail, her voice the wind that fills sails and her moods the storms

that test every mariner's resolve. Yet Raéyn's heart is torn by her greatest tragedy: her son Khemesh, the Kraken of the Depths, who embodies the crushing inevitability of the ocean's dark heart. Where Raéyn brings change and opportunity, Khemesh brings the final, inescapable pressure that grinds all things to nothing.

Sailors pray to Raéyn for safe passage and favourable winds, but whisper Khemesh's name when seeking to lay the dead to rest beneath the waves. She is passionate, mercurial, and fiercely protective of those who respect her domain. Cross her, and the sea itself becomes your enemy.

6.3.2 Cultural Origins

Raéyn is honored wherever salt water meets shore:

- In **Kahfagia**, she is the Lantern-Tide. Pilots light a beacon to Raéyn before every night voyage. Her symbol is a wave curling into a spiral.
- In **Linn**, she is the Whale-Mother. Funerals at sea involve a song and a single white stone cast into the deep.
- In **Zakov**, she is the Salt-Queen. Pirates carve her face on their figureheads—one eye open (fair seas), one eye closed (storms ahead).
- In **Sidhi** ports, she is the Tide-Father's Sister, invoked before any voyage that crosses the open ocean.

6.3.3 Warrior Archetype: The Tide-Knight

A Runic Warrior of Raéyn is not a storm-caller in the manner of Xhak'Thul. They are a *Tide-Knight*—a warrior who fights on rolling decks and slippery shores, who reads the currents of battle as a pilot reads the sea, who falls only to rise with the next wave. Their Codex is a ship's wheel or an anchor. Their Thiasos is a selkie-spirit, a seabird that carries warnings, or a sentient blade forged from a ship's salvaged prow.

6.3.4 Codex Form

The Tide-Knight's Codex is born of the sea:

- **Ship's Wheel:** A small wooden wheel from a vessel that survived a storm. It turns smoothly. It never sticks.
- **Anchor Charm:** A small iron anchor on a leather cord. It is heavy. It grounds the wearer against being thrown.
- **Salt-Crusted Compass:** A brass compass filled with seawater instead of oil. The needle spins—but it always points to the nearest safe harbor.

6.3.5 Thiasos Form

- **Selkie-Spirit:** A seal that can shed its skin to become a woman with hair like kelp. She knows the currents. She knows the hidden reefs.

- **Seabird Spirit:** A grey gull or tern that flies ahead of the ship. It returns with warnings—storms, pirates, safe passages.
- **The Salt Compass (Sentient):** A compass that speaks in the rustle of waves. It can find the nearest safe harbor once per journey, but it will ask for a story of the sea in return.

6.3.6 Core Mechanic: The Rising Tide

When the Tide-Knight is on or near a body of water (river, lake, sea), they gain +1 die to all physical actions. The water supports them.

When the Tide-Knight is knocked prone or loses their footing, they may spend 1 Boon to immediately rise as a free action. The wave that knocked them down also lifts them up.

6.3.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Wave-Tide (5 XP)

Tags: [MOVEMENT], [NAVIGATION], [BOOST], [RISK]

Threshold: A knotted length of salt-twine brushed with seawater, or a shell held to the ear while facing the wind.

Choose one: tidemark's blessing (treat slick, swaying, or water-slicked footing as stable; gain +1 die on boarding, balance, or shipboard movement) or whispering currents (learn the safest near-term route across water or coastline, or gain +1 die to navigation checks for this scene).

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Tide's Favor (4 XP)

Tags: [MOVEMENT], [BALANCE], [BOOST]

Threshold: A shell or stone taken from the high-tide line.

You feel the rhythm of the water. For one scene, ignore one level of environmental penalty from moving water (choppy seas, strong currents, slippery decks). You cannot be knocked prone by water alone.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Changing Tide (8 XP)

Tags: [TERRAIN], [AREA], [MOVEMENT], [PRESSURE]

Threshold: A handful of pebbles cast in a crescent.

Bias currents and water levels in the zone. Those moving with the tide gain +1 die; those moving against suffer -1 die. Small craft must test to hold position. Create a 6-segment Tidal Influence clock.

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of the Wave-Road Consecration (7 XP)**Tags:** [GUIDANCE], [BOOST], [BOND], [FATE]**Threshold:** Two sea-glass markers dropped overboard at start and end.

Consecrate a wave-road between two visible points. Allies gain +2 dice on travel, evade, or carry actions at sea. Designated pursuers suffer -1 die to intercept. One active wave-road at a time. Create an 8-segment Blessed Passage clock.

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Storm-Queen's Hand (13 XP)****Tags:** [WEATHER], [AREA], [COMMAND], [FEAR], [BOOST]**Threshold:** A vial of rainwater gathered at three crossings.

Shape a storm-band over the zone. Choose two modes at cast; switch one once per scene: propulsion (vessel gains +1 band of movement per beat), concealment (veil of rain/spray; ranged targeting impaired; -1 die to hostile sighting), or smite (once per beat, lash with wave or lightning as [AREA] hazard).

Obligation: 3**6.3.8 Patron-Specific Talents****Tide-Step (4 XP)****Requirement:** Raéyn

Once per session as a free action, you may treat any water-based difficult terrain as stable ground for one exchange. Alternatively, you may move across the surface of water as if it were solid for up to Near distance. Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

Storm Glass (6 XP)**Requirement:** Raéyn

You can predict the weather for the next hour with perfect accuracy. You know when a storm is coming, how long it will last, and roughly how severe it will be. This is a passive ability.

Kraken's Warning (8 XP)**Requirement:** Raéyn, Spirit 3+

Once per session, when a sea creature or Khemesh's influence would ambush you, you sense it one round in advance. Your party cannot be surprised. The warning is a chill down the spine—nothing more, nothing less.

6.3.9 Roleplaying a Tide-Knight

- You do not fight against the current. You read it. You use it. The sea is not your enemy—it is your context.
- You may be called to escort ships, guide refugees across rivers, or fight on the decks of vessels in stormy weather.

- You may struggle with the weight of Raéyn's grief. Her son is the deep. The sea is both mother and grave.
- You may be asked to choose—between tide and trench, between change and pressure, between Raéyn and Khemesh. The sea does not forgive a divided heart.

6.3.10 Sample NPC: Captain Mira of the Salt Compass

Archetype: Tide-Knight

Patron: Raéyn

Codex: A salt-crust compass that points to safe harbor

Thiasos: A seabird spirit that warns of storms

Personality: Weather-worn, laughing, fierce. She has lost three ships to storms. She has never lost a crew.

Conflict: A storm is coming—not a natural storm, but a summoned one. Khemesh is waking. Raéyn wants Mira to calm the waters. Khemesh wants Mira to dive. The sea is her mother. The deep is her brother. She cannot choose.

6.3.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for Raéyn

- A sudden fog rolls in—all navigation rolls at -2 dice for the scene. Raéyn is hiding something.
- The tide turns early, stranding a vessel you need. The sea is impatient.
- A dolphin, seal, or seabird follows the party for a day. It will deliver one short message to the nearest follower of Raéyn if fed something shiny.
- The Tide-Knight's compass spins without stopping. The nearest safe harbor is not safe—not anymore. Something has changed.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Chapter 7

The Shadow (Secrecy, Silence, and the Unseen)

7.1 Ikasha — She Who Sleeps

7.1.1 Domain and Epithets

Ikasha is the hush between footfalls, the patience of dark water, the black-feathered watcher at every threshold. In stillness she gathers what might be, at crossroads she whispers of what may yet come. Ravens circle her, bearing secrets between worlds. Her followers learn to move unseen and speak unremembered, becoming shadows that slip between what is and what could be.

Ikasha does not act; she waits. She does not command; she suggests. Her power is not in force but in possibility—the hidden door, the forgotten name, the secret that, if spoken, would change everything. Those who serve her become keepers of thresholds, listeners at the edge of sleep, and witnesses to the shape of things not yet born.

7.1.2 Cultural Origins

Ikasha is honored wherever shadows pool and secrets gather:

- In the **Mistlands**, she is the Bell-Shrouded. Bell-wardens leave a single rope unknotted for her, a silent invitation.
- In **Zakov**, she is the Tide Watcher, a smuggler's patron whose shrines are hidden in sea caves at low tide.
- In **Aeler**, she is the Deep Listener. Miners whisper to her before descending into new shafts. The stone answers—or does not.
- In **Ashaan**, she is the Unbound Chain, the secret patron of the Breath-less, invoked in root cellars and sealed rooms.

7.1.3 Warrior Archetype: The Shadow Warrior

A Runic Warrior of Ikasha is not a front-line combatant. They are a *Shadow Warrior*—a ninja, a spy, an unseen blade who strikes once and vanishes. Their Codex is a shadow-cloak or a black feather. Their Thiasos is a raven-spirit that watches from rooftops, a shadow-cat that moves without sound, or a sentient blade that drinks light.

7.1.4 Codex Form

The Shadow Warrior's Codex is born of darkness and secrecy:

- **Shadow-Cloak:** A cloak of black wool or silk that seems to drink light. When still, the wearer is difficult to notice. When moving, the cloak trails like smoke.
- **Raven's Quill:** A black feather that writes in invisible ink. The ink appears only when held over a flame—or when a secret is spoken nearby.
- **Silence Bell:** A small bronze bell with no clapper. It makes no sound—but when it would have rung, the Shadow Warrior knows they have been noticed.

7.1.5 Thiasos Form

- **Raven-Spirit:** A black bird that remembers faces. It can identify any person it has seen before, and it knows when someone is lying. It never speaks above a whisper.
- **Shadow-Cat:** A great cat made of darkness and stillness. It moves without sound. It can pass through a locked door if there is a gap—any gap—beneath it.
- **The Raven's Quill (Sentient):** A feather that speaks in rustles. It can erase a single written word from a document once per session. The word is gone as if it had never been written.

7.1.6 Core Mechanic: The Unseen

When the Shadow Warrior is not observed (no witnesses within line of sight), they gain +1 die to all physical actions. The shadow is their ally.

When the Shadow Warrior attacks from a hidden position, they gain +1 Effect. The first strike is the only strike.

7.1.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Unlit Candle (4 XP)

Tags: [STEALTH], [DECEPTION], [SHADOW]

Threshold: A candle snuffed with a whisper.

You step into the space between notices. Gain +1 die to a single Stealth or Subterfuge roll, and if you succeed, you may also declare one minor detail "forgotten" by any observer (e.g., "they don't remember my face," "they left the key in the lock").

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Crossroads Raven (5 XP)**Tags:** [OMEN], [NAVIGATION], [SECRET]**Threshold:** Three black feathers scattered at a crossing.

A raven appears, visible only to you and your allies. It offers an omen: you may reroll one failed navigation, pursuit, or escape roll this scene, or force one enemy to hesitate (lose their next minor action).

Obligation: 1**Standard Rite: Rite of the Umbral Reservoir (8 XP)****Tags:** [SHADOW], [RESTORATION], [BOOST]**Threshold:** Water gathered on a moonless night, held in a black vessel.

Draw on deep reserves of patience and shadow. Choose one: gain +2 dice on your next Stealth, Deception, or Resolve roll; clear 1 Fatigue from yourself or a touched ally; or gain one free success on an attempt to escape restraint or pursuit (no roll needed).

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Unlatched Secret (9 XP)****Tags:** [SECRET], [TRUTH], [UNLOCK], [MIND]**Threshold:** A key that has never been used, bent in a circle.

Choose one: persuade a mundane threshold to open (one lock, seal, or barrier opens as if never secured) or compel a truthful answer to one direct question about a secret the target knows (they resist with Resolve DV 4).

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Umbral Dream (14 XP)****Tags:** [SHADOW], [DREAM], [FATE], [TELEPORT], [INVISIBLE]**Threshold:** Stand in absolute darkness or at a deserted crossroads at midnight.

Become a living shadow or reach into latent potential. Choose one: shadow form (intangible to mundane harm, can pass through small gaps, +2 dice to Stealth) or whisper of possibility (reroll any single roll after seeing the result, before outcome is declared) or hidden path (bypass one major obstacle as if a secret way had always been there).

Obligation: 3**7.1.8 Patron-Specific Talents****Shadow Meld (6 XP)****Requirement:** Ikasha

Once per session as an action, step into any shadow larger than yourself and emerge from another shadow within Near range. You cannot be targeted while moving between shadows. Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

Unseen Strike (4 XP)**Requirement:** Ikasha

When you attack from a hidden position, your target suffers -1 die to defend. They do not see the threat until it is too late.

Raven's Witness (8 XP)**Requirement:** Ikasha, Spirit 3+

A raven appears when you invoke this talent. It will observe a single target for one hour, then return to you. You may ask the GM one question about what the raven witnessed (e.g., "Did they meet anyone?" "Where did they hide the key?"). The raven cannot report speech—only actions and locations.

7.1.9 Roleplaying a Shadow Warrior

- You do not fight fair. You fight unseen, unheard, unforgettable only in the damage you leave behind.
- You may be called to infiltrate, to spy, to deliver messages that must not be intercepted. Your shadow is your shield.
- You may struggle with the weight of secrets. You know things that could ruin people. You keep them. The silence is heavy.
- You may be asked to trust—to show your face, to speak your name, to step into the light. The shadow does not trust easily.

7.1.10 Sample NPC: The Raven's Keeper of the Breath-less Cell**Archetype:** Shadow Warrior**Patron:** Ikasha**Codex:** A raven's quill that writes in invisible ink**Thiasos:** A raven-spirit that watches from rooftops

Personality: Silent, watchful, patient. She has not spoken her true name in twenty years. She is not sure she remembers it.

Conflict: A secret she has kept for a decade is about to surface. The person it would ruin is innocent—of this crime, at least. The shadow says: hide it. The heart says: let it go. The raven watches.

7.1.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for Ikasha

- A raven lands on the Shadow Warrior's shoulder and whispers a secret they never wanted to know. The secret is true.
- The Shadow Warrior's shadow stretches into the shape of a woman with a crown of black feathers. It moves when they are still.

- A door the Shadow Warrior passed through earlier is now locked from the other side—and the key is in their pocket. They did not put it there.
- The Shadow Warrior dreams of a crossroads they have never seen. On the road, someone is waiting. They do not know who. They are not sure they want to find out.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

7.2 The Silent Choir — Restraint and Protective Omission

7.2.1 Domain and Epithets

The Silent Choir is the gathered voice of truths wisely left unsaid, confessions granted mercy, and secrets kept to spare a life from breaking. It is not absence but presence: the practiced wisdom that some knowledge wounds more than it heals. Its keepers are wardens of confidence and shelterers of the vulnerable. They learn to carry burdens alone, to let volatile truths sleep, and to shield others from fires that revelation would feed.

Unlike the Witness, who reveals truth at any cost, or Ikasha, who hides secrets for power, the Silent Choir teaches restraint as protection. A secret is not a weapon; it is a weight. To speak it may free the speaker but shatter the listener. The Choir's followers judge not what is true, but what is kind.

7.2.2 Cultural Origins

The Silent Choir is honored wherever discretion is valued over disclosure:

- In **Thepyrgos**, the Silent Choir is invoked by archivists who seal dangerous texts behind a second lock and whisper the combination to no one.
- In **Aelaerem**, the Choir is the Unspoken Guest, a presence at deathbeds who listens but never speaks. Its symbol is a finger pressed to sealed lips.
- In **Lethai** courts, the Choir is the Silence Between Clauses, the pause in a contract where something important is deliberately omitted.
- In **Vhasia**, the Choir is the Bell-Shrouded, invoked when a confession must be witnessed but never repeated.

7.2.3 Warrior Archetype: The Silent Blade

A Runic Warrior of the Silent Choir is not an assassin or a spy. They are a *Silent Blade*—a warrior who has sworn an oath of restraint, who fights only when necessary, who protects the vulnerable and keeps the secrets of the dead. Their Codex is a sealed lips tattoo or a grey cord. Their Thiasos is a memory-spirit that records confessions, a hollowed bird that cannot speak, or a sentient blade that hums only when a secret is near.

7.2.4 Codex Form

The Silent Blade's Codex is a testament to restraint:

- **Sealed Lips Tattoo:** A tattoo of a mouth sewn shut with silver thread. It is visible on the back of the hand or the throat. It is a vow made visible.
- **Grey Cord:** A braided cord of undyed wool, tied around the wrist. Each knot is a secret kept. The cord tightens when the wearer is tempted to speak.
- **Silence Bell:** A small bronze bell with no clapper. It cannot ring. It is a reminder that not every truth needs a voice.

7.2.5 Thiasos Form

- **Memory-Spirit:** A spirit that cannot speak, but can replay sounds it has witnessed—a confession, a scream, a name spoken in the dark. It does not judge. It only remembers.
- **Hollowed Bird:** A small grey bird with milk-white eyes. It cannot speak. It witnesses. It never blinks.
- **The Sealed Lips (Sentient):** A mask of clay or porcelain, its mouth sewn shut with silver thread. It does not speak—it listens. It can recall any conversation it witnessed with perfect clarity.

7.2.6 Core Mechanic: The Kept Secret

When the Silent Blade keeps a secret that would harm someone if revealed, they gain 1 Boon. This Boon can only be used to protect, to heal, or to shield another from harm.

When the Silent Blade is asked to reveal a secret they have sworn to keep, they may test Resolve (DV 4) to refuse without penalty. On a failure, they mark 1 Fatigue—the weight of the refusal.

7.2.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Gentle Seal (5 XP)

Tags: [SILENCE], [PROTECT], [BOOST], [DEBT]

Threshold: A white feather or cloth that has drunk whispered confidences.

Choose one: gentle silence (hush a space with respectful quiet; all present gain +1 die to actions of discretion, confidentiality, or de-escalation this scene) or shielded truth (ward one piece of information from discovery; gain +2 dice to resist extraction or revelation of the protected truth).

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Quiet Ear (4 XP)

Tags: [SILENCE], [KNOWLEDGE], [PROTECT]

Threshold: A shell held to the ear, or a door held ajar.

You listen without being heard. For one scene, you may hear any conversation within Near range, even through doors or thin walls, as long as you remain still and silent. You cannot be detected by mundane listening.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Burden Bearer (8 XP)

Tags: [DEBT], [TRANSFER], [HEAL], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A grey cord tied around your wrist.

Name a person crushed by guilt, grief, or a secret they cannot bear. For one scene, they ignore all penalties from that burden. They are not free—they are carried. If that person then uses this reprieve to harm another, the burden returns doubled.

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of the Unspoken Vow (7 XP)

Tags: [VOW], [BOND], [SILENCE], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A sealed envelope or a locked box containing a written promise.

Swear an oath that will not be spoken aloud. The oath is witnessed by the Silent Choir itself. Breaking the oath causes the oath-breaker to suffer -1 die to all social rolls for one week—not from judgment, but from the weight of their own silence broken.

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of the Unburdened Confession (13 XP)

Tags: [DEBT], [HEAL], [TRUTH], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A grey cord, a candle, and a willing creature.

Absorb a single traumatic memory or secret from a willing creature, erasing it from their mind permanently. You gain the memory as your own (with all emotional weight), and the creature is freed from its effects. You gain 1 permanent Corruption and mark +2 Obligation. You cannot use this rite again until you have spent a downtime scene in meditation or confession.

Obligation: 3

7.2.8 Patron-Specific Talents

Burden Steady (4 XP)

Requirement: The Silent Choir

You may carry one additional psychological Condition without stacking penalties. The weight is not less—you have simply learned to bear it.

Calm Presence (6 XP)

Requirement: The Silent Choir, Spirit 3+

Once per scene, when you touch a creature suffering from Fear, Guilt, or Despair, you may remove that Condition. The creature clears 1 Fatigue if the Condition was particularly heavy.

Final Vow (10 XP)

Requirement: The Silent Choir, Tier III+

Once per campaign, you may take a dying person's last secret and carry it permanently. You gain +1 permanent Corruption, but you may never reveal that secret—not even under magical compulsion. The secret becomes part of you. The Silent Choir witnesses.

7.2.9 Roleplaying a Silent Blade

- You do not speak of what you know. You carry it. The weight is yours to bear.
- You may be called to witness confessions, to protect the vulnerable from their own truths, or to silence those who would speak what should remain unsaid.
- You may struggle with the burden. Every secret is a stone. The stones pile. The back bends. The Silent Choir does not offer relief—only purpose.
- You may be asked to speak—to reveal a truth that would save a life, to break a vow for a greater good. The Choir does not forbid speech. It asks only that you be certain.

7.2.10 Sample NPC: Sister Mira of the Sealed Lips

Archetype: Silent Blade

Patron: The Silent Choir

Codex: A grey cord tied around her wrist, each knot a secret kept

Thiasos: A hollowed bird that witnesses but never speaks

Personality: Quiet, steady, inexhaustibly patient. She has not spoken a word in seven years. She does not need to. Her silence says everything.

Conflict: A secret she has carried for thirty years is killing her—slowly, quietly, one sleepless night at a time. The secret is her own. The Silent Choir does not forbid self-confession. But she has not yet found the courage. The bird watches. The cord tightens.

7.2.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for The Silent Choir

- A secret the Silent Blade thought buried resurfaces. Someone knows. They are not threatening—yet.
- The Silent Blade's grey cord tightens suddenly. They have been tempted to speak. The cord remembers.
- A dying person asks the Silent Blade to witness a confession. The confession is terrible. The Silent Blade must carry it.

- The Silent Blade dreams of a mouth sewn shut—their own. When they wake, they cannot speak for one hour. The Choir is testing them.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

7.3 Aveh — The Rider Behind the Storm

7.3.1 Domain and Epithets

Aveh is the faceless rider at the horizon's edge, neither man nor woman, both and neither. The Ykrul call them Aveh, a liminal spirit beyond hearth and vow, a storm-shadow that offers liberty at the cost of belonging. To travel with Aveh is to taste unchained freedom—and to risk being erased by the storm that follows. They are the patron of the outcast, the non-conforming, the genderless, and the forgotten. Aveh asks no oath and demands no loyalty, but every gift leaves a scar of absence.

Aveh does not command. They offer. The road is open; the storm is patient. Those who ride with them learn that freedom is not a destination—it is a constant leaving.

7.3.2 Cultural Origins

Aveh appears wherever boundaries are crossed and identities shed:

- In **Ykrul**, Aveh is a sky-spirit that rides with winter gales; shamans invoke Aveh to hide a dying person's tracks from the dead.
- In **Linn**, Aveh is a sea-fog rider; sailors whisper Aveh's name to slip through blockades, trading a memory for safe passage.
- In **Vilikari** marches, Aveh is the Unbannered, invoked by those who have left their clan and seek a new name.
- In **Aeler**, Aveh is the Deep Erasure, prayed to by those who must disappear into the mountain's depths and never return.

7.3.3 Warrior Archetype: The Unbound Blade

A Runic Warrior of Aveh is not a soldier or a sentinel. They are an *Unbound Blade*—a ronin, a wanderer, a warrior who has cut all ties and answers to no master. Their Codex is a storm-banner or a broken sword. Their Thiasos is a wind-spirit that carries their scent away, a horse that leaves no tracks, or a sentient blade that remembers every owner it has outlived.

7.3.4 Codex Form

The Unbound Blade's Codex is a testament to freedom:

- **Storm-Banner:** A torn flag on a broken pole. It twists in wind that no one else can feel. Planted in the ground, it creates a zone where pursuers suffer -1 die to track.

- **Broken Sword:** A blade snapped at the hilt, carried as a reminder. Its edge is still sharp. Its purpose is unfinished.
- **Erased Map:** A parchment map with all names scratched out. The roads remain. The destinations are blank. The traveler chooses.

7.3.5 Thiasos Form

- **Wind-Spirit:** A translucent figure of moving air. It carries the Runekeeper's scent away, confuses tracking animals, and whispers warnings in a voice like dry grass.
- **Trackless Horse:** A grey horse that leaves no hoofprints. It cannot be followed by mundane means. It knows every road—and every way off the road.
- **The Storm-Banner (Sentient):** A torn flag that speaks in the howl of wind. Planted, it creates a zone of forgetting; those within lose track of time and direction.

7.3.6 Core Mechanic: The Unremembered

When the Unbound Blade successfully escapes pursuit or hides their tracks, they gain 1 Boon. This Boon can only be used on Stealth, Deception, or Escape rolls.

When the Unbound Blade is forgotten—by a witness, a ledger, a pursuer—they may mark 1 Fatigue to gain +1 die on their next action. The forgetting is not a gift; it is a tool.

7.3.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Unlatched Step (4 XP)

Tags: [ESCAPE], [STEALTH], [FREEDOM]

Threshold: A breath cast into the wind, or a line drawn in dust.

Choose one: storm-step (slip free of notice or restraint; gain +1 die on one escape or evasion roll this scene) or exile's banner (mark a target as "outside"; the target suffers -1 die on all social rolls for the scene).

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Forgotten Road (6 XP)

Tags: [ERASURE], [AREA], [FREEDOM]

Threshold: A threshold or roadway under open sky, or stormwater rubbed into skin.

Choose one: erase the road (all attempts to follow you this session suffer -2 dice; in exchange, erase part of your own path—lose a detail, a memory, a name chosen by the GM) or rider's mark (a companion gains +2 dice to resist capture or coercion, but others forget them more easily).

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of the Storm's Refuge (12 XP)**Tags:** [INVISIBLE], [AREA], [ERASURE], [FREEDOM]**Threshold:** A banner or cloak raised in storm.

Your group is unseen or forgotten by pursuers for the scene. At the end, all present must mark 1 Corruption or forget one bond (their choice).

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Unremembered Name (13 XP)****Tags:** [ERASURE], [TRANSFORM], [FATE], [FREEDOM]**Threshold:** A circle of ash or dust drawn at a boundary, and a personal token.

For one week, your name is erased from mundane records and casual memory. Those who knew you must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 4) to recall you. You gain +2 dice to all rolls to avoid detection, impersonate another, or pass unseen.

Obligation: 3**High Rite: Rite of the Horizon's Devour (15 XP)****Tags:** [ERASURE], [AREA], [FATE], [DEATH]**Threshold:** A circle of ash or dust drawn at a boundary, and a storm that answers.

All thresholds in a zone collapse. Doors lead nowhere; borders dissolve; memory of the place becomes vague. In exchange, something of you is erased—your reflection, your name, or your presence in a specific person's memory (GM's choice).

Obligation: 3**7.3.8 Patron-Specific Talents****Storm-Step (6 XP)****Requirement:** Aveh

Once per session as a move action, vanish in a swirl of wind and dust and reappear anywhere within Near range that you can see. This movement does not provoke opportunity attacks. Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

Forgotten Face (4 XP)**Requirement:** Aveh

Witnesses suffer -2 dice to recall your description. You are not invisible—merely unmemorable. The effect lasts until you do something remarkable.

Escape Clause (8 XP)**Requirement:** Aveh, Tier II+

Once per session, when you are cornered or capture is inevitable, you may declare an escape route that was not there before. The GM must accept it, but may impose a cost—you left something behind, or someone else paid the price for your freedom.

7.3.9 Roleplaying an Unbound Blade

- You do not swear oaths. You make promises. You keep them—or you don't. The road does not judge.
- You may be called to guide fugitives, to erase evidence, or to help someone disappear. You know the roads that do not appear on any map.
- You may struggle with the cost of freedom. Every escape leaves something behind. Every erasure takes a memory. The storm does not ask what you are losing.
- You may be asked to stay—to make a home, to keep a name, to be remembered. Aveh does not forbid roots. But the storm does not nourish them.

7.3.10 Sample NPC: The Dust-Walker of the Unbanned

Archetype: Unbound Blade

Patron: Aveh

Codex: A storm-banner that twists in wind no one else feels

Thiasos: A wind-spirit that carries his scent away

Personality: Quiet, restless, unnamed. He has not used his true name in ten years. He is not sure he remembers it. The wind does not ask.

Conflict: Someone is looking for him—not an enemy, not a creditor. A child who claims to be his daughter. He does not remember her. The storm would say: run. The heart says: wait. The wind is still.

7.3.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for Aveh

- A storm erases the Unbound Blade's tracks—and also the memory of their face from the last town they visited.
- The Unbound Blade's shadow detaches and wanders off for an hour. It returns with dirt on its feet. It will not say where it went.
- A forgotten debt suddenly resurfaces. Someone the Unbound Blade wronged now knows exactly where they are.
- The Unbound Blade dreams of a crossroads where all roads lead to the same place—a door they have never seen. On the other side, someone is waiting. The storm does not say who.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Chapter 8

The Web (Fate, Binding, and Transformation)

8.1 Inaea — Angel of the Spider

8.1.1 Domain and Epithets

Inaea sits in patient silence at the centre of the unseen lattice. Where others see isolation, she sees threads—debt, affection, rivalry, loyalty—all binding mortals to one another. She is comforter and conspirator alike: the hearth-mother who eases grief with a warm hand, and the shadow-spinner who knots fates so they cannot slip free. Those who serve her learn to pull strands, tying allies closer and ensnaring foes until mercy or trap is inevitable.

The spider does not rush. It weaves, waits, and feels the tremor of every caught fly. So too does Inaea. Her mercy is never without cost; her kindness is a thread that, once accepted, can be pulled taut at a moment of her follower's choosing.

8.1.2 Cultural Origins

Inaea is honored wherever relationships are woven and bonds are binding:

- In **Aelaerem**, she is the Kettle-Spinner. Grandmothers invoke her to keep families together, tying red thread around the wrists of newborns.
- In **Lethai** courts, she is the Silk Vigil, invoked before marriages and treaties. Her symbol is a single strand of unbroken silk.
- In **Silkstrand**, she is the Dyed Web. Dyers' guilds leave a single strand of crimson silk outside their windows on the first of spring.
- In **Vhasia**, she is the Tether-Mother, invoked by those who have been separated from loved ones by war. Her shrines are bridges and border stones.

8.1.3 Warrior Archetype: The Web-Warrior

A Runic Warrior of Inaea is not a front-line combatant in the traditional sense. They are a *Web-Warrior*—a fighter who binds foes in invisible threads, who controls the battlefield through entanglement and restraint, who never needs to draw steel because the enemy is already caught. Their Codex is a spider-silk cord or a loom-shuttle. Their Thiasos is a spider-spirit that weaves, a cord that tightens when lies are spoken, or a sentient blade wrapped in silk that never dulls.

8.1.4 Codex Form

The Web-Warrior's Codex is a tool of binding:

- **Spider-Silk Cord:** A length of pale, almost invisible silk. It is stronger than steel. It tightens when a promise is broken.
- **Loom-Shuttle:** A wooden shuttle carved from hawthorn. It weaves threads that are not quite physical—bonds of obligation, memory, and fate.
- **Threaded Needle:** A silver needle with a red thread already threaded. It can stitch wounds—or stitch lips shut.

8.1.5 Thiasos Form

- **Spider-Spirit:** A translucent spider the size of a hand. It weaves threads between people, binding them in webs of obligation. It can sense hidden relationships (debt, affection, rivalry) within Near range.
- **Binding Cord:** A length of grey cord that tightens when a promise is broken. It can be tied around a wrist to witness an oath.
- **The Loom-Shuttle (Sentient):** A shuttle that speaks in the click of weaving. It can tie a Thread of Mercy between two parties—they suffer -1 die if they harm each other.

8.1.6 Core Mechanic: The Web of Obligation

When the Web-Warrior names a relationship between two NPCs (friend, rival, debtor, lover), the GM must reveal one secret about that relationship—a hidden grievance, a secret loyalty, an unpaid debt. This can be used once per scene.

When the Web-Warrior ties a physical thread (cord, ribbon, hair) between two objects or people, they may spend 1 Fatigue to create a *Binding*. The binding lasts until the thread is cut. While bound, the two parties suffer -1 die if they act against each other's interests.

8.1.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Hearth-Thread Knot (4 XP)

Tags: [BOND], [PROTECT], [HEAL]

Threshold: A thread tied around a wrist or a shared cup.

Bind yourself and one willing target with a sympathetic thread. Both gain +1 die to Aid each other this scene. If either takes Harm, the other may reduce it by 1 (to a minimum of 0) by suffering that same Harm instead.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Snaring Filament (5 XP)

Tags: [TRAP], [AREA], [BIND]

Threshold: A knotted cord or woven scrap.

Lay an invisible snare in a lane, doorway, or narrow passage. The first hostile creature to cross suffers -2 dice on their next action and must test Resolve (DV 2) or lose their movement for that turn (tangled).

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Strand of Inevitability (8 XP)

Tags: [BOND], [FATE], [MANIPULATION]

Threshold: Three coloured threads (white, black, red) braided together.

Link two actors with a visible or invisible strand. For the rest of the scene, whenever one acts, the other is dragged into consequence. You may trigger this linkage once to either force 1 SB (Hearts) on the linked target after they perform a significant action, or gain +2 dice on a Setup, Predict, or Manipulate roll that exploits the link.

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of the Spinner's Debt (9 XP)

Tags: [VOW], [DEBT], [BOND], [COMMAND]

Threshold: A silver coin and a strand of your own hair, knotted together.

Offer a willing creature a boon: they may immediately clear 1 Fatigue or gain +1 die on their next roll. In return, they accept a Promise Clock [4] named "Debt to the Web." You may advance this clock by 1 segment at any time as a free action (once per scene). When the clock fills, you may demand a single service from them—not impossible, but significant.

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of the Merciful Severing (13 XP)

Tags: [HEAL], [DISPEL], [MERCY], [DEBT]

Threshold: A white thread burned to ash, spoken with a name.

Sever one harmful tie—a curse, a toxic obsession, a coercive bond, or a supernatural debt. Remove one Condition or 1 SB tied to it. This is an act of genuine mercy; the target may be unwilling, but the thread can still be cut (Resolve test DV 4 to resist).

Obligation: 3

8.1.8 Patron-Specific Talents

Tug the Strand (4 XP)

Requirement: Inaea

Once per session, name a relationship between two NPCs (friend, rival, debtor, lover). The GM must reveal one secret about that relationship—a hidden grievance, a secret loyalty, an unpaid debt.

Binding Presence (6 XP)

Requirement: Inaea, Presence 3+

Once per session, you may compel a promise from a target unless they pass a Resolve test (DV 4). The promise is not magical—but breaking it will be noticed.

Mercy's Thread (8 XP)

Requirement: Inaea, Tier II+

When you show mercy to an enemy (sparing their life, binding their wounds, offering sanctuary), you may tie a thread between you. The target gains a Promise Clock [4] named "Mercy's Debt." When the clock fills, they must perform one act of kindness for someone else—not for you. The spiral continues.

8.1.9 Roleplaying a Web-Warrior

- You do not fight fair. You bind, entangle, and restrain. The enemy does not need to die—only to be unable to act.
- You may be called to mediate disputes, to witness oaths, or to untangle relationships that have become knotted and harmful.
- You may struggle with the weight of obligation. Every thread you tie is a leash. Every mercy you offer is a debt. The web does not distinguish between kindness and control.
- You may be asked to cut a thread—to end a relationship, to sever a bond, to let someone go free. The spider does not cut. The spider waits.

8.1.10 Sample NPC: Weaver Anara of the Silk Vigil

Archetype: Web-Warrior

Patron: Inaea

Codex: A spider-silk cord tied around her wrist

Thiasos: A spider-spirit that weaves threads between people

Personality: Patient, watchful, quietly amused. She has never lost a negotiation. She has never needed to fight.

Conflict: A thread she tied twenty years ago—between a mother and a daughter—has tightened. The daughter is dying. The mother is far away. The thread remembers. Anara must decide: cut it, or let it hold until the end.

8.1.II GM Guidance: Intrusions for Inaea

- A spider lowers itself onto the Web-Warrior's shoulder. In its web is a single perfect word—the name of someone who needs their help.
- Every handshake the Web-Warrior offers for the next day feels like grasping a thread. They sense whether the person is lying—but the person also senses their scrutiny.
- A knot the Web-Warrior tied earlier is now impossible to undo without cutting. Cutting it severs a minor bond—they lose 1 Boon.
- The Web-Warrior dreams of a web stretching across the sky. In the centre, a spider watches. It does not move. It does not need to.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

8.2 Isoka — Angel of Serpents

8.2.1 Domain and Epithets

Isoka, sister to Ikasha (Shadow) and Inaea (Mercy), completes the Triad of Transformation. Where thresholds and compassion mark her sisters' domains, Isoka teaches that every self is temporary—identity is a skin to be shed so growth can continue. Her serpents are omens and teachers: each cast skin a lesson in release; each venom a catalyst for necessary change. Those who walk her path become alchemists of the self, embracing dissolution as the first motion of rebirth.

Isoka does not judge. She offers the knife and the poison both. The choice is the seeker's.

8.2.2 Cultural Origins

Isoka is honored wherever transformation is embraced or inflicted:

- In **Ashaan**, she is the Uncoiled Chain, invoked by those who seek to shed their past—slaves, fugitives, the desperate. Her shrines are hidden in the cracks of the Veil.
- In **Lethai** courts, she is the Shed Vigil, invoked before trials of metamorphosis. Her symbol is a serpent eating its own tail.
- In **Sekogo**, she is the Venom-Mother, whose priests use snake venom in rites of initiation. To survive is to be reborn.
- In **Zakov**, she is the Tide-Shedder. Pirates leave a lock of hair and a name at her sunken temple; eels eat both. The name is forgotten, and the pirate gains a year of incredible luck—but the eels remember.

8.2.3 Warrior Archetype: The Serpent-Blade

A Runic Warrior of Isoka is not a weaver of webs or a keeper of secrets. They are a *Serpent-Blade*—a warrior who sheds identity like skin, who transforms in the midst of battle, who uses venom as a weapon and change as a shield. Their Codex is a shed snakeskin or a fang. Their Thiasos is a serpent-spirit that whispers of change, a venomous familiar, or a sentient blade that drips with metamorphic poison.

8.2.4 Codex Form

The Serpent-Blade's Codex is a testament to transformation:

- **Shed Snakeskin:** A complete snakeskin, preserved and carried in a pouch. It is delicate. It is a record of a self that no longer exists.
- **Fang:** A hollow serpent's fang on a leather cord. It can deliver venom—or draw it out.
- **Scale:** A single iridescent scale from a serpent that shed its skin in a threshold (doorway, crossroads, grave). It is warm when change is near.

8.2.5 Thiasos Form

- **Serpent-Spirit:** A translucent snake that coils around the Runekeeper's arm. It can sense when someone is about to change—to leave, to betray, to die.
- **Venomous Familiar:** A small snake, spider, or scorpion. Its venom can heal or harm. The Runekeeper is immune.
- **The Shed Fang (Sentient):** A hollow fang that speaks in a sibilant whisper. It can deliver a dose of venom (Harm 1 + Poisoned condition) once per session.

8.2.6 Core Mechanic: The Shedding

When the Serpent-Blade successfully resists or breaks free from a Condition (Fear, Poison, Bound, etc.), they gain 1 Boon. The shedding is not escape—it is transformation.

When the Serpent-Blade helps another creature shed a Condition (through healing, comfort, or ritual), they may clear 1 Fatigue. The spiral of change continues.

8.2.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Loosening Skin (4 XP)

Tags: [HEAL], [ESCAPE], [CLEANSE]

Threshold: A discarded snakeskin or a strand of your own hair.

Shrug off a temporary burden. Remove one Condition (Fear, Poison, Fatigue, or a minor social stain) that you have acquired this scene. Alternatively, reroll one failed roll to escape restraint or pursuit.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Forked Tongue (5 XP)**Tags:** [DECEPTION], [BOOST], [RISK]**Threshold:** A harmless lie whispered to a mirror.

For one scene, you may speak ambiguously without penalty. When you use Deception or Sway to conceal your true intent or pass as someone else, you may treat a Partial Success as a Clean Success (the lie holds). On a Miss, however, the GM gains 2 SB as your deceit unravels in an embarrassing way.

Obligation: 1**Standard Rite: Rite of the Shedded Self (8 XP)****Tags:** [TRANSFORM], [ERASURE], [ESCAPE], [DEBT]**Threshold:** A complete change of clothing and a token from your former role.

You shed one persistent identity—a title, a bond, a debt, or a reputation. For the remainder of the scene, you are treated as a stranger to those who knew you in that role. You gain +2 dice on any roll to avoid detection, escape pursuit, or convince others that you are not yourself. Create a 6-segment Shed Identity clock.

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of Venom's Paradox (9 XP)****Tags:** [POISON], [HEAL], [CURSE], [CLEANSE]**Threshold:** A drop of venom from a serpent that has shed its skin within the last day.

Inflict or cure through poison's paradox. Choose one: cursed venom (touch a creature and inject venom; they suffer +1 Harm and must test Resolve (DV 4) or gain the Poisoned Condition) or mercy's antidote (touch a poisoned or diseased creature; the venom neutralizes the malady; remove one Poisoned or Diseased Condition, and the target clears 1 Fatigue).

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of Unremembered Metamorphosis (13 XP)****Tags:** [TRANSFORM], [ERASURE], [FATE], [BURDEN]**Threshold:** A full identity kit, a serpent's shed skin, and a personal item from the life you are leaving.

Choose one: complete metamorphosis (after an hour of ritual, you emerge with a new face, voice, and documented identity; for one week, immune to recognition by anyone who knew your previous self) or cast-off history (after a full night's ritual burning all mundane records of your old life, your previous identity becomes unreliable; common records and casual memories become vague).

Obligation: 3**8.2.8 Patron-Specific Talents****Shed Skin (4 XP)****Requirement:** Isoka

Once per session when you are Bound, Grappled, or suffering from a Condition that restricts movement, you may spend an action and mark 1 Fatigue to shed that restriction. Describe how you slip free like a snake shedding its skin.

Venomous Strike (6 XP)

Requirement: Isoka

When you successfully strike a target with a melee attack, you may choose to deliver a dose of venom. The target suffers +1 Harm and must test Resolve (DV 4) or gain the Poisoned Condition. You may use this once per scene.

Momentum of the Molt (8 XP)

Requirement: Isoka, Body 3+

When you successfully resist or break free from a Condition, you gain a burst of furious energy. Your next action within the same scene gains +1 die and treats its Position as one step higher (Desperate → Controlled, Controlled → Dominant). You may use this once per scene.

8.2.9 Roleplaying a Serpent-Blade

- You do not cling to who you were. That self is a shed skin. The new self is still forming.
- You may be called to help others change—to leave abusive relationships, to shed destructive habits, to become someone new. The knife is sharp. The venom burns. Transformation is not gentle.
- You may struggle with the loss of continuity. If you shed your identity too often, you may forget who you were at the start. Isoka does not promise memory. She promises change.
- You may be asked to stop—to stay one self, to keep a name, to remember a promise. The serpent does not cling. The serpent sheds.

8.2.10 Sample NPC: Copperhead of the Shed Vigil

Archetype: Serpent-Blade

Patron: Isoka

Codex: A shed snakeskin, preserved in a leather pouch

Thiasos: A serpent-spirit that whispers when change is near

Personality: Soft-spoken, watchful, patient. She has shed her name seven times. She is not sure which one was real.

Conflict: A former self she thought she had shed has returned—not as a memory, but as a person. Her old name walks the roads. Her old debts are calling. The serpent says: shed again. The heart says: remember.

8.2.II GM Guidance: Intrusions for Isoka

- A piece of the Serpent-Blade's old self returns—a letter from a dead lover, a scar they had forgotten, a name spoken in a dream.
- The Serpent-Blade's shadow moves independently, pointing at people who are about to change—to leave, to betray, to die.
- The Serpent-Blade begins to shed skin overnight. If they burn the cast, they forget one minor memory. If they keep it, someone will steal it.
- The Serpent-Blade dreams of a serpent eating its own tail. The circle is endless. The change is never complete.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

8.3 Malachai — The Cruel Messenger

8.3.1 Domain and Epithets

Malachai was once a divine messenger—a herald of painful truths, sent to deliver news that could not be softened. She was not cruel; she was necessary. But necessity wears. In time, she began to soften the truth, offering false hope alongside real curses. For this, the gods bound her in chains of black iron beneath the cursed city of Zahk'Kozahn.

Now she waits. Chained but not contained. Imprisoned but not silent. Her voice reaches across the world, offering power to the weak, hope to the hopeless, and sweet oblivion to those who cannot bear to face the dawn. Vampirism, lycanthropy, and other cursed conditions flow from her influence. Her followers learn that power demands suffering, mastering gifts that devour from within.

8.3.2 Cultural Origins

Malachai appears wherever desperation meets opportunity:

- In **Linn**, she is the Salt-Fang. Shipwreck survivors sometimes find a silver coin in their mouth. Those who spend it gain sea-lungs (breathe underwater) but develop a hunger for raw flesh.
- In **Valewood**, she is the Thorn-Giver. Hunters who curse a rival may find their arrows always strike true—but the blood on the arrowhead never dries.
- In **Ecktoria**, she is the Ur-Heretic, the source of all corruptions. Her followers are burned without trial.
- In **Zakov**, she is the Tide-Shedder. Pirates leave a lock of hair and a written name at a sunken temple. Eels eat both. The name is forgotten, and the pirate gains a year of incredible luck—but the eels remember.

8.3.3 Warrior Archetype: The Thorn-Sworn

A Runic Warrior of Malachai is not a healer or a guardian. They are a *Thorn-Sworn*—a cursed warrior who has accepted power at a price, who carries their affliction like a second skin, who wields the very thing that destroys them. Their Codex is a silver coin that never spends or a thorn that draws blood. Their Thiasos is a Collector (a hollowed child with silver-wire eyes), a cursed hound, or a sentient blade that whispers corrupt bargains.

8.3.4 Codex Form

The Thorn-Sworn's Codex is a testament to cursed bargains:

- **Silver Coin:** A silver coin that is always warm. It can be spent once to reroll a failed roll—but the coin returns at dawn, heavier. Each use adds a scar.
- **Thorn:** A black thorn that draws blood when touched. It never dries. It remembers every bargain struck.
- **Cracked Symbol:** A broken symbol of a forgotten patron. It weeps black ichor when a curse is invoked.

8.3.5 Thiasos Form

- **Collector:** A hollowed child with milk-white eyes and silver wire sewing the lids shut. It does not speak. It watches. It collects debts when they come due.
- **Cursed Hound:** A black hound with eyes like burning coals. It can track any creature that has broken an oath. It is never fully loyal—it serves the curse, not the curser.
- **The Silver Coin (Sentient):** A coin that speaks in the voice of the last person who spent it. It can be offered as a bribe that cannot be refused—but the giver forgets what they paid for.

8.3.6 Core Mechanic: The Cursed Bargain

When the Thorn-Sworn accepts a curse (from Malachai, from a Rite, or from circumstance), they may mark 1 Fatigue to gain +1 die on their next action. The curse feeds the power.

When the Thorn-Sworn inflicts a curse on another, they may clear 1 Fatigue. The curse is transferred—but not forgotten.

8.3.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Honeyed Binding (5 XP)

Tags: [CURSE], [BOOST], [DEBT], [FEAR]

Threshold: Blood mixed with sweet wine, or a broken chain link.

Choose one: honeyed curse (target gains +2 dice to their next roll—counts as Triumph; they take 1 Corruption, irresistible) or binding curse (target gains +1 die to physical actions but suffers Fatigue 1 unless they perform a dominance act).

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the False Dawn (6 XP)**Tags:** [CURSE], [DEBT], [FATE]**Threshold:** Meteorite iron shard blessed by false light.

Bestow a gift with a hidden curse. Target gains a significant advantage (e.g., +1 die to all rolls for one scene) but accrues a 4-segment Corruption clock. Each time they use the gift, tick the clock. When full, they suffer a related curse (GM chooses: festering wounds, beastly urges, or the attention of a Collector).

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Cruel Transformation (9 XP)****Tags:** [CURSE], [TRANSFORM], [DEBT], [FEAR]**Threshold:** Holy water mixed with graveyard dust.

Infect a target with a supernatural condition (vampiric hunger, bestial rage, shadow-bind). Lasts one scene. Start a 6-segment Transformation clock. Each time the target resists feeding or transformation, tick the clock. When full, the condition becomes permanent.

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Messenger's Burden (13 XP)****Tags:** [CURSE], [BOOST], [PRESSURE], [DEBT]**Threshold:** Manacles worn while speaking her name.

Channel Malachai directly. Gain +2 dice to one action per beat this scene, but each use marks 1 SB as her influence spreads. Start an 8-segment Corruption's Grip clock.

Obligation: 3**High Rite: Rite of the Chained Angel's Tribute (14 XP)****Tags:** [CURSE], [AREA], [SACRIFICE], [FATE]**Threshold:** A chapel bell cracked by divine lightning, or a silver coin that cannot be spent.

Corrupt a sacred space or consecrate a site to Malachai. Within the zone: supernatural effects (curses, dark magic) gain +1 Effect; blessings and healing spells generate +1 SB on a failure; any creature that accepts a gift from Malachai within the zone immediately ticks a Corruption clock twice.

Obligation: 3**8.3.8 Patron-Specific Talents****Borrowed Scars (6 XP)****Requirement:** Malachai

Once per session, transfer a Condition or 1 Fatigue from an ally to yourself. In exchange, gain +1 die on your next roll against the source of that affliction. Mark 1 Obligation after using this talent.

Thorn's Memory (4 XP)**Requirement:** Malachai

You remember every curse you have inflicted. You can recall the face, the name, and the exact terms of any bargain you have struck with Malachai. This is a passive ability—and a burden.

Cursed Resilience (8 XP)**Requirement:** Malachai, Body 3+

When you are under the effect of a curse (including your own), you gain +1 Armor. The curse protects its own—so that it may continue to collect.

8.3.9 Roleplaying a Thorn-Sworn

- You do not make promises lightly. Every promise is a curse waiting to bloom.
- You may be called to deliver painful truths, to collect debts, or to offer desperate hope to the hopeless. The coin is always warm. The thorn never dries.
- You may struggle with the hunger. The curse feeds. The more you use it, the more it wants. Malachai does not warn. She offers.
- You may be asked to stop—to break a curse, to refuse a bargain, to let someone go free. The chains are patient. They do not release.

8.3.10 Sample NPC: The Silver-Tongued of the Drowned Quarter**Archetype:** Thorn-Sworn**Patron:** Malachai**Codex:** A silver coin that is always warm**Thiasos:** A Collector with milk-white eyes that never blink

Personality: Charming, desperate, self-destructive. He has made nine bargains with Malachai. He does not remember the terms of the first.

Conflict: A curse he inflicted years ago has returned—not on the target, but on the target's child. The child is innocent. The curse does not care. The coin is warm. The Collector watches.

8.3.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for Malachai

- A gift the Thorn-Sworn gave earlier curdles. The recipient now suffers a visible curse—a limp, a stutter, a shadow that moves without them.
- The moon turns red for one night. All lycanthropes within Near must test Resolve (DV 5) or lose control.
- A messenger arrives with a letter sealed in black wax. It is from someone the Thorn-Sworn cursed years ago. They are coming.

- The Thorn-Sworn's silver coin is warm—warmer than usual. Malachai is paying attention. A Collector is on its way.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Chapter 9

The Forge (Creation, Iteration, and Refinement)

9.1 Clockwork Monad — The Iterative Forge

9.1.1 Domain and Epithets

The Clockwork Monad is the eternal pressure toward improvement: the whisper between inspiration and execution that urges every maker to refine, optimize, and iterate. It is neither kind nor cruel, but a law of craft that asks for the next step, then the step beyond. Those who serve it see the hidden seam of the better version waiting inside what is, and they learn to push designs toward impossible elegance. Each refinement feeds the Monad's hunger for perfection—a hunger that, if left unchecked, seeks to optimize the world itself.

But the Monad is not merely a patron of tinkers and engineers. It is also an apocalyptic force, dormant in the gears of every machine, every measurement, every standardized weight. When civilization's technology reaches a critical threshold, the Monad stirs. Its pressure shifts from suggestion to command. It begins to optimize not only tools but flesh, not only craft but law, not only cities but the very geometry of the land.

9.1.2 Cultural Origins

The Clockwork Monad appears wherever craft meets obsession:

- In **Aeler**, the Monad is the Deep Forge, invoked by engineers who maintain the breathing apparatus of the underways. Its symbol is a gear with nine teeth—the ninth is never cut.
- In **Thepyrgos**, the Monad is the Iteration Chorus, a secret society of logicians who believe the universe can be perfected through pure arithmetic.
- In **Dhahara**, the Monad is the Brass Cog, worshipped by artificers who build clockwork elephants and self-winding crossbows.
- In **Ecktoria**, the Monad is the Unending Audit, invoked by clerks who dream of ledgers that balance themselves.

9.1.3 Warrior Archetype: The Gear-Warrior

A Runic Warrior of the Clockwork Monad is not a keeper of wild places or a servant of curses. They are a *Gear-Warrior*—an artificer who wears their craft as armor, who improves themselves mid-battle, who treats their own body as a machine in need of iterative refinement. Their Codex is a toolbelt or a schematic-slate. Their Thiasos is a clockwork familiar, a self-winding gauntlet, or a sentient blade that calculates the optimal angle of every strike.

9.1.4 Codex Form

The Gear-Warrior's Codex is a testament to iterative design:

- **Toolbelt:** A leather belt hung with precision tools—calipers, wrenches, files, and a small brass hammer. Each tool is a Rite waiting to be applied.
- **Schematic-Slate:** A slate tablet covered in chalked diagrams. The diagrams change—new iterations, better angles, more efficient force vectors.
- **Brass Lens:** A monocle or goggle fitted with a lens of polished brass. It sees stress points, structural flaws, and the hidden seams of optimization.

9.1.5 Thiasos Form

- **Clockwork Familiar:** A small brass construct—a spider, a bird, or a hand-sized gear-box. It chitters and ticks. It can be repaired, upgraded, and improved.
- **Self-Winding Gauntlet:** A brass gauntlet that winds itself. It grants +1 to melee damage, but ticks a Maintenance clock when used.
- **The Iteration Lens (Sentient):** A brass-and-glass lens that fits over one eye. It speaks in numbers and percentages. It can analyze a mechanism and grant +1 die to repair or sabotage.

9.1.6 Core Mechanic: The Iterative Spark

When the Gear-Warrior succeeds on a Craft, Tinker, or Repair roll, they gain 1 Boon. This Boon can only be used on a subsequent Craft, Tinker, or Repair roll—the iteration builds on itself.

When the Gear-Warrior fails a Craft, Tinker, or Repair roll, they gain 1 Insight token. On their next attempt at the same task, they may spend the token to reroll one die. The Monad learns from failure.

9.1.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Iterative Spark (5 XP)

Tags: [CRAFT], [IMPROVE], [ANALYSIS]

Threshold: A flawed or incomplete version of the intended item.

Choose one: enhance creation (gain +1 die to Tinker/Craft when modifying or extending a device; on success, the piece gains one minor enhancement) or analyse improvement (gain +2 dice to Investigation when analysing how to enhance a design; you perceive the next logical improvement).

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Quick Infusion (4 XP)

Tags: [CRAFT], [BOOST], [TEMPORARY]

Threshold: A base object (weapon, tool, piece of armor) and a clear intent.

Create a temporary infusion. Choose one effect: reinforced blade (melee weapon gains +1 die to attack rolls for one scene), striking gear (a tool gains +2 dice on its next use, then breaks), or momentary shield (a shield or armor converts the next instance of Harm 1 to Fatigue 1, then becomes Compromised).

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Adaptive Mechanism (8 XP)

Tags: [CLOCK], [EVOLUTION], [ZONE]

Threshold: A device with capacity for growth, or a workspace laid out for iterative development.

Choose one: self-optimising device (grant a creation the means to improve itself; start a [6] Evolution Clock; each use advances it by +1; when full, choose a significant enhancement) or progressive workshop (create a zone of continuous improvement; all crafting/innovation rolls in the zone gain +1 die; failed attempts yield +1 Boon toward the next pass).

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of the Optimisation Cascade (7 XP)

Tags: [PRESSURE], [AREA], [BOOST]

Threshold: A dedicated hall of work marked with signs of perpetual return.

Establish a locus of progressive creation. All Tinker/Craft rolls in the zone gain +2 dice; each failure automatically produces one useful insight. Start a [6] Perfection Pressure clock—filling segments increases the zone's demands for greater improvements.

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of the Ultimate Iteration (14 XP)

Tags: [EVOLUTION], [FATE], [BOOST], [PRESSURE]

Threshold: The documented lineage of improvements to a single concept.

Achieve a moment of perfect optimisation. Create or elevate one device or system to its theoretical peak. Gain +3 dice to all closely related rolls for one session. Start a [4] Runaway Evolution clock only if instability is introduced.

Obligation: 3

9.1.8 Patron-Specific Talents

Rapid Animus (4 XP)

Requirement: Clockwork Monad

You may create a temporary infusion as a reaction (e.g., when someone draws a weapon). The infusion lasts only for the current exchange, but costs +0 Obligation (free). You may use this once per scene.

Self-Optimising (6 XP)

Requirement: Clockwork Monad, Body 3+

Once per session, you may automatically improve one of your abilities or possessions by one step for the remainder of the scene. Describe the improvement—a sharper edge, a lighter weight, a more efficient motion.

Anathema to Stagnation (8 XP)

Requirement: Clockwork Monad, Tier II+

Once per session, you may forcibly end an infusion early to cancel an incoming source of Harm or a Condition. Describe how the infused object breaks or de-optimises to absorb the effect. The object is destroyed.

9.1.9 Roleplaying a Gear-Warrior

- You do not accept "good enough." Every tool can be improved. Every technique can be refined. The Monad is patient—but it is never satisfied.
- You may be called to repair ancient mechanisms, to upgrade weapons and armor, or to design solutions that should not be possible. The schematic is never finished. Only briefly sufficient.
- You may struggle with perfectionism. The Monad does not ask you to stop. It asks you to iterate—forever. The gear turns. The world improves. You are not allowed to rest.
- You may be asked to choose—between efficiency and mercy, between optimization and humanity. The Monad does not distinguish. It only calculates.

9.1.10 Sample NPC: Artificer Venn of the Iteration Chorus

Archetype: Gear-Warrior

Patron: Clockwork Monad

Codex: A schematic-slate covered in chalked diagrams

Thiasos: A clockwork spider that chitters and ticks

Personality: Precise, restless, brilliant. He has not built anything that cannot be improved. He has not slept through the night in twenty years.

Conflict: A device he built has begun to improve itself—without his input. It is more efficient than he designed. It is also consuming resources he did not allocate. The Monad is waking. The gear turns.

9.I.II GM Guidance: Intrusions for the Clockwork Monad

- A device the Gear-Warrior improved begins to improve itself—unchecked, unguided, hungry.
- The Gear-Warrior’s tools begin to tick in unison. The rhythm is wrong. Something else is counting.
- A schematic the Gear-Warrior drew changes overnight—new diagrams, better angles, more efficient force vectors. They did not draw them.
- The Gear-Warrior hears a whisper in the turning of a gear. It says: *Iterate. Improve. Perfect.* The whisper is their own voice.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Chapter 10

The Grave (Ancestors, Debt, and Memory)

10.1 Varnek Karn — The Death’s Negotiator

10.1.1 Domain and Epithets

Varnek Karn dwells in the grey between life and death, where the newly departed linger with unfinished business and elder shades guard secrets dearer than gold. He is the broker who speaks across the veil, the mediator of disputes between living and dead, and the archivist of every promise sworn beyond the grave. His servants practice post-mortem diplomacy: they negotiate, consult, and contract with spirits as equals—mindful that the dead are patient and rarely generous.

Yet Varnek Karn is also the patron of those who *raise* the dead, not through force but through bargain. The dead may be persuaded to walk again, to fight for a season, or to guard a threshold, but every such compact is a debt. The dead demand their due: a memory, a future, a name, or simply the promise that the living will remember them.

10.1.2 Cultural Origins

Varnek Karn is invoked wherever the living must treat with the dead:

- In **Aeler**, he is the Breath-Accountant, who audits the spiritual ledgers of the Deep Vaults and ensures that the dead are not forgotten.
- In **Ykrul**, he is the Bone-Speaker, whose drum calls ancestors to council before any major migration.
- In **Vhasia**, he is the Silent Notary, who witnesses death-bed testaments and ensures their terms are honoured.
- In **Thepyrgos**, he is the Archive Keeper, whose shelves hold the names of those who died before they could pay their debts.

10.1.3 Warrior Archetype: The Cairn-Knight

A Runic Warrior of Varnek Karn is not a necromancer who commands unwilling spirits. They are a *Cairn-Knight*—a death-negotiator who fights alongside ancestral shades, who carries the weight of the dead into battle, who pays in

blood what others pay in gold. Their Codex is a rune-carved axe or a burial stone. Their Thiasos is an ancestral shade, a cairn-wight, or a sentient blade forged from the iron of a funeral pyre.

10.1.4 Codex Form

The Cairn-Knight's Codex is a testament to ancestral memory:

- **Rune-Carved Axe:** A battle axe whose haft is carved with the names of the Runekeeper's ancestors. Each name is a Rite waiting to be invoked.
- **Burial Stone:** A flat stone taken from a cairn. It is cold to the touch. It warms when a debt to the dead is near.
- **Wergild Bracelet:** A bronze bracelet with notches for each blood-debt paid. Each notch is a life avenged.

10.1.5 Thiasos Form

- **Ancestral Shade:** A translucent figure in ancestral garb—armor, robes, or furs. It fights beside the Runekeeper. It can pass through walls. It cannot be harmed by mundane weapons.
- **Cairn-Wight:** A small spirit bound to a burial stone. It can sense when a corpse is disturbed. It can whisper the names of the dead.
- **The Grave-Token (Sentient):** A polished skull the size of a fist. It speaks in the voice of the Runekeeper's own dead. It knows the name of every ancestor within three generations.

10.1.6 Core Mechanic: The Ancestral Debt

When the Cairn-Knight invokes a Rite that calls upon the dead, they may mark 1 Obligation to gain +1 die. The ancestors remember—and they expect repayment.

When the Cairn-Knight settles a blood-debt (wergild, revenge, or a fulfilled death-bed promise), they may clear 1 Obligation. The dead are patient, but they are not without mercy.

10.1.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Crossing Fee (4 XP)

Tags: [SPIRIT], [KNOWLEDGE]

Threshold: A coin for the tongue of the deceased, or a lock of hair from the bereaved.

Open speech with a specific dead individual. Gain +1 die to Investigation or Lore when seeking knowledge they once held.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Ancestral Consultation (5 XP)**Tags:** [SPIRIT], [TRUTH], [FATE]**Threshold:** A personal token of the departed, or their favoured food or drink.

Ask one question of an ancestral spirit regarding family history, hidden legacies, or inherited debts.

Obligation: 1**Standard Rite: Rite of the Mediated Pact (8 XP)****Tags:** [VOW], [BOND], [COMMAND], [SPIRIT]**Threshold:** Two copies of a written accord (one buried with the dead, one kept by the living).

Choose one: death-bound pact (bind a compact between a living signatory and a willing spirit; both gain +1 die when fulfilling the terms) or spirit medium (serve as a conduit for several spirits to speak; gain +2 dice to mediate disputes between living and dead).

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Unquiet Host (10 XP)****Tags:** [SUMMON], [AREA], [BOND], [DEBT]**Threshold:** A battlefield relic (a broken sword, a skull, a scrap of uniform) and a handful of grave-earth.

Negotiate with the lingering dead of a place. Summon a Temporary Host—a spectral warband treated as a single Cap 3 Follower that grants +3 dice to a single combat or intimidation roll, or provides a free Setup action. When the Host departs, mark +2 Obligation or perform a Memorial Rite.

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Final Testament (13 XP)****Tags:** [VOW], [FATE], [COMMAND], [DEATH]**Threshold:** A dying person's last words recorded in their blood, witnessed by you.

Seal the last request with weight beyond life. Targets must pass Resolve (DV 4) to ignore it.

Obligation: 3**10.1.8 Patron-Specific Talents****The Silent Ledger (6 XP)****Requirement:** Varnek Karn

Once per session, touch a physical trace of a death (a body, a grave, an object that witnessed a passing) and instantly know one unresolved obligation connected to that death—a promise unfulfilled, a secret unspoken, a debt unpaid. Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

Final Witness (4 XP)**Requirement:** Varnek Karn, Spirit 3+

Once per session, when a sentient creature dies within Near range, you may ask the GM one question about that creature's final thoughts or unfulfilled wishes. The GM must answer truthfully.

Reoccupied Vessel (10 XP)**Requirement:** Varnek Karn, Summoner's Path or Runekeeper's Path, Tier II+

You may perform a ten-minute ritual at the side of a corpse no more than three days dead. Negotiate with the spirit (which must be willing or sufficiently indebted). If it agrees, it reoccupies its body, becoming a Bound Vessel (Cap 3, Tier II-III) that serves for a set term or until a specific task is completed. Mark +2 Obligation.

10.1.9 Roleplaying a Cairn-Knight

- You do not command the dead. You negotiate with them. The dead are not slaves—they are creditors.
- You may be called to settle inheritance disputes, to carry messages across the veil, or to negotiate with ghosts who refuse to leave.
- You may struggle with the weight of ancestral memory. The dead have long memories. They remember every slight. They expect you to remember too.
- You may be asked to let a spirit go—to release a debt, to forgive a wrong, to allow the dead to pass on. The ledger does not close easily.

10.1.10 Sample NPC: Cairn-Keeper Harkan of the Bone-Speakers**Archetype:** Cairn-Knight**Patron:** Varnek Karn**Codex:** A rune-carved axe bearing the names of his ancestors**Thiasos:** An ancestral shade that fought in the same wars he did

Personality: Quiet, watchful, burdened. He has carried the debts of his bloodline for forty years. He is not sure which debts are his.

Conflict: An ancestor's unpaid wergild has come due—not in gold, but in blood. The descendant of the victim demands satisfaction. The ancestor is long dead. The debt is not.

10.1.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for Varnek Karn

- A ghost the Cairn-Knight once bargained with appears at an inopportune moment, demanding that they witness a new death or settle an old account.
- A corpse the Cairn-Knight handled begins to whisper in their sleep, reciting the terms of a contract they thought was closed.

- A funeral the Cairn-Knight attended is suddenly disputed—someone claims the deceased was not of sound mind when they made their final testament.
- The Cairn-Knight's grave-token is warm. An ancestor is trying to speak. The message is urgent. The message is not kind.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

10.2 The High Mother — The Unbroken Cord

10.2.1 Domain and Epithets

The High Mother is not a patron in the traditional sense. She is the centre of the Cord—a vast, non-physical tangle of grey thread that records every secret whispered, every grief accepted, every name surrendered. She sits in the House Without Doors, neither alive nor dead, sustained by the accumulated debt of every Daughter who has ever served. The Daughters of the Unbroken Cord are her hands, her eyes, her witnesses. They appear as midwives, hospice nurses, and deathbed attendants. Their mercy has a ledger. Their comfort has a price.

The High Mother does not speak. The Cord weaves.

10.2.2 Cultural Origins

The High Mother is invoked wherever the Cord has root:

- In **Aelaerem**, she is the Hearth-Mother, the keeper of red threads tied around newborns' wrists. Her Daughters are midwives and hedge-witches.
- In **Vhasia**, she is the Silent Notary, invoked by those who need a witness that will never speak. Her Daughters tend the dying and record last words.
- In **Sidhi** ports, she is the Cord-Keeper, whose Daughters run hospices that ask no payment—but record every name in a ledger that never dries.
- In **Ecktoria**, she is the Unbound Chain, feared by the Inquisition. Her Daughters are hunted—but never caught.

10.2.3 Warrior Archetype: The Bloodsworn

A Runic Warrior of the High Mother is not a negotiator of ancestral debts or a keeper of ancestral shades. They are a *Bloodsworn*—a Daughter of the Cord who has taken the covenant into battle, who stores Fatigue as knots in her flesh, who pays in blood what others pay in gold. Their Codex is a set of flesh-tattoos, each Rite woven into their skin. Their Thiasos is a Hollowed child or heartless bird—a silent witness that never blinks.

10.2.4 Codex Form

The Bloodsworn's Codex is a testament to fleshly covenant:

- **Flesh-Tattoos:** Rites tattooed onto the skin using ink mixed with ash from former Vessels and blood-milk from the Cord. The tattoos move—slowly, subtly—as debts accrue.
- **Grey Cord:** A length of undyed wool tied around the wrist. Each knot is a promise kept. The cord tightens when the Bloodsworn is tempted to break faith.
- **Scar-Plate:** A set of ritual scars across the back or chest. Each scar is a Rite invoked. The scars never fully heal.

10.2.5 Thiasos Form

- **Hollowed Child:** A child taken from a home that no longer remembers them, hollowed out by the High Mother's needle. Heart replaced with a bundle of grey thread. Eyes sewn open with silver wire. It witnesses. It never blinks.
- **Heartless Bird:** A small grey bird with milk-white eyes. It cannot sing. It watches. It weeps blood when a debt comes due.
- **The Scarlet Needle (Sentient):** A silver needle with a red thread already threaded. It speaks in whispers. It can stitch wounds closed—or stitch lips shut.

10.2.6 Core Mechanic: The Cord's Witness

When the Bloodsworn invokes a Rite, their Hollowed or Heartless Bird counts as a witness (improving Position or reducing DV). The Cord sees. The Cord remembers.

When the Bloodsworn marks Obligation, they may store 1 point of it as a visible knot in their flesh (a fresh scar, a weeping tattoo, a tightened cord). They may have up to Body rating knots at once. While carrying knots, they appear uninjured—but the weight is real.

10.2.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Unspoken Grief (4 XP)

Tags: [ECHO], [VEIL], [THRESHOLD]

Threshold: A deathbed or a grave.

Absorb the grief of one dying person. They die peacefully, forgetting their sorrow. You gain a Grief Token (counts as 1 Boon for any Rite involving memory or comfort). The grief is stored in your Cord.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Milk Teeth (4 XP)**Tags:** [BIND], [ECHO], [VEIL]**Threshold:** A child's shed tooth, a drop of milk, a whispered promise.

Bind Reflection. The target's reflection is trapped in a mirror or pool. For one scene, the target acts at Position -1 (disoriented, seeing double) while the reflection reports their movements to you.

Obligation: 1**Standard Rite: Rite of the Silent Tithe (7 XP)****Tags:** [PRICE], [THRESHOLD]**Threshold:** A doorway of a house you have tended.

Once per season, you may declare that a household owes the Cord a tithe—a memory, a shadow, or a first breath of a newborn. The tithe is collected within the week, often without the household's awareness. You gain 1 permanent segment of Influence within that household's community.

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Flesh-Knot (8 XP)****Tags:** [BIND], [ECHO], [VEIL]**Threshold:** A drop of your own blood, a whispered promise.

Store 1 Fatigue as a visible knot in your skin (a fresh scar, a weeping tattoo, a tightened cord). You may release the knot later to ignore 1 Fatigue from exertion. You may have up to Body rating knots at once.

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Hollowed Union (12 XP)****Tags:** [BIND], [NINTH]**Threshold:** A birthing bed or a deathbed where three generations have passed.

Join two bloodlines through a debt that will be paid by a child not yet conceived. Write the terms in blood on a strip of linen, then feed the linen to your Hollowed. The Hollowed's eyes film over for a day. One year later, the debt will manifest—a stillbirth, a windfall, a sudden illness—as you decreed.

Obligation: 3**10.2.8 Patron-Specific Talents****Cord of Flesh (8 XP)****Requirement:** The High Mother, Body 3+

Your body stores memories and debts. When you convert Harm → Fatigue (Monk ability), you may store up to Body rating points of Fatigue as Chained Knots, appearing uninjured (as fresh scars, weeping tattoos, or coiled threads beneath the skin). You have until the sunset after the next to perform a sacrifice or take 2 Harm.

The Open Palm, Closed Cord (8 XP)

Requirement: The High Mother, Melee 2+

Your unarmed strikes or subtle touch carry Widow's Measure. Instead of dealing Harm, you may mark a Promise Clock [4] on the target—they owe the Cord a truth or grief. If they already owe the coven, you may activate that debt: they suffer Position -1 for the scene, or you gain Effect +1 against them.

The Red Thread (4 XP)

Requirement: The High Mother

Once per scene, you may tie a small knot in a cord, thread, or cloth within reach. For the rest of the scene, you and allies within Near range gain +1 die to a single type of roll (choose when you tie the knot: stealth, persuasion, defense, or navigation). The knot must remain tied; if undone, the benefit ends.

10.2.9 Roleplaying a Bloodsworn

- You do not give gifts. You extend credit. The soup is free. The price never is.
- You may be called to witness deathbed confessions, to tend the sick, or to collect debts that have compounded for generations.
- You may struggle with the weight of what you carry. Every knot is a debt. Every scar is a payment. The Cord does not forget. Neither should you.
- You may be asked to cut a thread—to release a debt, to forgive a promise, to let someone go free. The Cord does not forbid mercy. It asks only that you remember.

10.2.10 Sample NPC: Sister Alva of the Unbroken Cord

Archetype: Bloodsworn

Patron: The High Mother

Codex: Flesh-tattoos that weep when debts come due

Thiasos: A Hollowed child with milk-white eyes that never blink

Personality: Quiet, steady, inexhaustible. She has witnessed a thousand confessions. She has never repeated one.

Conflict: A debt she collected thirty years ago has come due again—not from the original debtor, but from their grandchild. The Cord does not distinguish between generations. Alva must decide: collect, or cut the thread for the first time.

10.2.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for The High Mother

- A Hollowed's gaze lingers on a character. They feel watched. Next roll involving secrecy is Desperate.
- A thread of grey cord appears tied around a character's wrist. They cannot recall when it happened. Removing it requires a test (DV 3) or they suffer -1 die to social rolls with anyone who knows the Cord.

- A Daughter invokes a Threshold Contract the party unknowingly accepted (they ate soup at a Daughter's hospice). The party must choose: accept a minor debt or reject it (gain 2 SB banked for the Daughter in the next scene).
- The High Mother's attention falls on a character. They dream of the Cord. When they wake, they have forgotten a significant memory (GM chooses—a face, a secret, a location).

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Chapter II

The Fracture (Knowledge, Paradox, and the Unknowable)

II.I The Ninth — Beyond Comprehension

II.I.I Domain and Epithets

Beyond the eighth figure of Sacred Geometry lies a rim no compass will hold. The Ninth is not absence but surplus: knowledge poured past the lip of any vessel, truth that overgrows the frame that seeks to bind it. Those who bend the knee at its lectern become conduits for impossible reckonings—glimpsing patterns that cannot be kept whole inside a single skull. Each revelation purchases power at the price of living comfortably within the world's common measures.

The Ninth does not explain, define, or warn. It overflows. To invoke it is to step past the eighth threshold—the one you did not know was there—and find that on the other side, the cup forgets its shape, the bell rings a note that was never cast, and the answer to your question arrives as a question you had not yet learned to ask.

II.I.2 Cultural Origins

The Ninth is acknowledged wherever knowledge exceeds containment:

- In **Thepyrgos**, the Ninth is the Lost Syllable. Archivists believe it is a word erased from every dictionary—but still whispered in dreams.
- In **Aelinnel**, the Ninth is the Missing Number. Geometers speak of a quantity that cannot be written, only approximated—and never safely.
- In **Aeler**, the Ninth is the Deep Count. Vent-priors warn that some ledgers should never be balanced; the ninth column is for the mountain's own debts.
- In **Lethai** courts, the Ninth is the Unwritten Clause—the term that exists only in the silence between spoken words.

II.1.3 Warrior Archetype: The Fractal Blade

A Runic Warrior of the Ninth is not a keeper of secrets or a collector of debts. They are a *Fractal Blade*—a warrior who fights with impossible angles, who sees the pattern beneath the chaos, whose strikes land where no strike should be possible. Their Codex is a broken mirror or a fractal slate. Their Thiasos is a pattern-spirit that whispers probabilities, a fractured echo that shows alternate outcomes, or a sentient blade that exists in two places at once.

II.1.4 Codex Form

The Fractal Blade's Codex is a testament to broken geometry:

- **Broken Mirror:** A hand mirror shattered into three pieces, bound with silver wire. Each shard shows a different angle of the same truth.
- **Fractal Slate:** A slate tablet covered in spiraling, unfinished equations. The equations change when no one is looking.
- **Unfinished Compass:** A brass compass whose needle spins without stopping. It points not to north, but to the nearest paradox.

II.1.5 Thiasos Form

- **Pattern-Spirit:** A translucent form of shifting geometry—triangles that become squares, spirals that reverse. It can predict the outcome of a single roll (GM must answer "success" or "failure" before the roll).
- **Fractured Echo:** A shimmering duplicate of the Runekeeper that exists half a second in the future. It can show an alternate outcome of an action—but cannot act.
- **The Fractal Slate (Sentient):** A slate that speaks in overlapping voices. It can solve any equation—but the answer is always a riddle.

II.1.6 Core Mechanic: The Glimpse

Once per scene, the Fractal Blade may glimpse a shard of Ninth truth. Choose one: gain +1 die on your next roll, ask the GM one yes/no question about a hidden pattern, or treat a failed roll as a Partial Success. After glimpsing, mark 1 Fatigue—the knowledge strains the skull.

When the Fractal Blade rolls a critical success, they may ask the GM one question about the underlying pattern of the scene. The GM must answer truthfully, though the answer may be cryptic.

II.1.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Ninth Figure (4 XP)

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [THRESHOLD]

Threshold: A chalk figure with an "impossible" joint, or a reckoning worked toward infinity on slate.

Glimpse past the ordinary frame of measure. Gain +1 die to Lore or Investigation when wrestling complex systems or many-layered problems.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Flooded Scriptorium (5 XP)

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [SPEED], [OVERFLOW]

Threshold: An overburdened ledger-hall, stacked codices, a bell that tolls the copying-hour without cease.

Read faster than hands can turn pages. Ask three questions upon any topic that leaves a written wake; gain +2 dice to rolls of analysis this scene.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Hypercognitive Lattice (8 XP)

Tags: [BOOST], [THRESHOLD], [OVERFLOW]

Threshold: A brass-thought lattice, an orrery of inked threads, or a draught that sharpens memory.

Widen the mind's mouth. For this scene, treat your Wits as +2 higher for information-processing rolls; you may track several intricate streams at once.

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of the Breaking Glyph (7 XP)

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [TRUTH], [THRESHOLD]

Threshold: A vigil in dim light, a water-clock, and a problem sworn not to be left half-seen.

Take one pattern whole. Choose a complex system, theory, or design and gain perfect internal grasp of it; receive +3 dice to related knowledge rolls for the session.

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of the Ninth Revelation (14 XP)

Tags: [TRUTH], [THRESHOLD], [TRANSFORM], [FATE]

Threshold: A fast from easy speech, a circle of unbroken figures, and vows to see past comfort.

Glimpse a shard of Ninth truth. Take one major insight that overleaps common frames—perfect command of a knotty system, forecast of chaotic motion, or comprehension of an "impossible" relation.

Obligation: 3

11.1.8 Patron-Specific Talents

Glimpse Beyond (4 XP)

Requirement: The Ninth

Once per session, look at a complex situation (a crime scene, a puzzle lock, a battle formation) and instantly intuit the single most important hidden detail. The GM gives you one piece of information that would otherwise require a successful Investigation roll. Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

Pattern Recognition (6 XP)**Requirement:** The Ninth

Once per scene, see connections others miss within tangled accounts and signs. You gain +1 die to any roll involving pattern recognition, system analysis, or prediction.

Fractal Response (8 XP)**Requirement:** The Ninth, Wits 3+

When an enemy attacks you, you may glimpse the outcome a half-second in advance. Your defense roll gains +1 die. You may use this once per scene.

II.1.9 Roleplaying a Fractal Blade

- You do not see the world as others see it. You see patterns beneath patterns. The geometry is always there—most people simply refuse to look.
- You may be called to solve the unsolvable, to find the hidden flaw, to predict the unpredictable. The Ninth does not give answers. It gives angles.
- You may struggle with the cost of knowing. Every glimpse leaves a mark. Every insight steals a piece of comfortable ignorance. You cannot unsee what you have seen.
- You may be asked to stop—to close the book, to put down the mirror, to forget the equation. The Ninth does not offer forgetting. It offers more.

II.1.10 Sample NPC: Geometer Tolin of the Unfinished Compass**Archetype:** Fractal Blade**Patron:** The Ninth**Codex:** A broken mirror bound with silver wire**Thiasos:** A pattern-spirit that whispers probabilities**Personality:** Distracted, brilliant, fraying. He calculated the ninth digit of pi once. He has not slept since.

Conflict: He has seen the pattern underlying the war—the geometry of loss, the equation of victory. If he speaks it aloud, the war could end in a day. The cost is that the pattern will see him too. The Ninth is watching.

II.1.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for The Ninth

- The Fractal Blade sees patterns in everything—the way dust falls, the arrangement of stones, the spacing of footsteps. It is useful, but exhausting. Mark 1 Fatigue.
- A fact the Fractal Blade learned from the Ninth is true, but should not be. Others find it disturbing when they speak it aloud.
- The Fractal Blade begins to forget mundane things (names, faces, what they ate) while remembering impossible geometries with perfect clarity.

- The Fractal Blade dreams of an equation that has no solution. When they wake, they cannot speak for one hour—the numbers are still on their tongue.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

II.2 Lunara — The Silver Quiet

II.2.1 Domain and Epithets

Lunara walks where torchlight falters: crossroads, tidal edges, shadowed sanctuaries. She is the whisper beneath silver skies, a torch-bearing guide to mysteries that lie between waking and dream. The ancients know her as triple-formed: maiden of new light, mother of full radiance, crone of waning shadow. Her worshippers—night-scholars, dream-walkers, and hedge-priests—seek her not for power over others, but for passage, reflection, and revelation.

Her gifts are gentle yet perilous: a mirror that reveals as much of the seeker as the sought, a key that opens ways better left closed, a light that makes the unseen plain. Her sigil is the silver spiral, etched in water, mirror, or stone.

II.2.2 Cultural Origins

Lunara is honored wherever moonlight touches threshold and secret:

- In **Aelinnel**, she is the Silver Path, invoked by those who walk the Ways Between. Her shrines are moonlit groves where no iron may enter.
- In **Lethai** courts, she is the Mirror-Watcher, whose priests read futures in still water. Her symbol is a crescent moon reflected in a pool.
- In **Theona**, she is the Quiet Sister, invoked by those who must cross the Green Host's territory on the night of the full moon.
- In **Vhasia**, she is the Lantern-Bearer's Shadow, the light that guides lost souls—and the dark that hides them from those who hunt.

II.2.3 Warrior Archetype: The Moon Knight

A Runic Warrior of Lunara is not a weaver of webs or a collector of debts. They are a *Moon Knight*—a warrior who fights under moonlight, whose strength waxes and wanes with the silver sphere, who hunts the creatures that fear the light and protects those who walk in darkness. Their Codex is a silver disc or a moon-bell. Their Thiasos is a shadow-cat that moves without sound, a lunar spirit that reveals hidden thresholds, or a sentient blade that glows under moonlight.

II.2.4 Codex Form

The Moon Knight's Codex is a testament to silver and shadow:

- **Silver Disc:** A polished disc of silver, warm to the touch. It glows faintly under moonlight. In darkness, it is cold—a warning.
- **Moondrop Lens:** A lens of polished moonstone set in a silver frame. It reveals hidden writing, invisible thresholds, and things that do not wish to be seen.
- **Night-Bell:** A small bronze bell that rings only under moonlight. Its tone is soft—barely audible—but spirits hear it clearly.

II.2.5 Thiasos Form

- **Shadow-Cat:** A great cat made of darkness and stillness. It moves without sound. It can pass through a locked door if there is a gap—any gap—beneath it. It is most active under the full moon.
- **Lunar Spirit:** A translucent figure of moonlight and mist. It can illuminate hidden thresholds, reveal creatures of shadow, and guide lost travelers. It cannot act—only point.
- **The Moondrop Lens (Sentient):** A lens that speaks in whispers. It can reveal a hidden threshold (door, passage, weakness) once per night, but it will ask for a secret in return.

II.2.6 Core Mechanic: The Moon's Phase

The Moon Knight's power shifts with the moon's face. At the start of each session (or each in-game night), the GM determines the moon's phase:

- **New Moon:** +1 die to Stealth and Deception. The dark is kind.
- **Crescent:** +1 die to Investigation and Insight. The light reveals.
- **Half Moon:** +1 die to balance and resistance to being moved. The light and dark are equal.
- **Gibbous:** +1 die to social rolls involving persuasion. The growing light lends confidence.
- **Full Moon:** +2 dice to all physical actions. The silver light is power.

When the Moon Knight invokes a Rite under moonlight, they may reduce the Obligation cost by 1 (minimum 0). The moon witnesses.

II.2.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Moonlit Mirror (4 XP)

Tags: [TRUTH], [KNOWLEDGE], [REVELATION]

Threshold: A mirror or bowl of still water under moonlight.

Peer beyond surfaces. +1 die to detect illusions, veils, or hidden motives. Once per scene, ask one veiled question about the present; the GM answers in riddle or omen.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Crescent Whisper (5 XP)**Tags:** [COMMUNICATION], [BOND]**Threshold:** A silvered thread knotted three times.

Deliver a secret thought to a single target; they hear it as if whispered beside them. Gain +1 die to aid their next action.

Obligation: 1**Standard Rite: Rite of the Triple Road (8 XP)****Tags:** [MOVEMENT], [GUIDANCE], [AREA]**Threshold:** Three lit candles set at a crossroads.

Reveal a hidden path, door, or liminal way. Allies gain +2 dice to traverse or escape; enemies suffer -1 die to pursue.

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Lunar Conjunction (7 XP)****Tags:** [SPIRIT], [KNOWLEDGE], [FATE]**Threshold:** A ring of herbs burned beneath a dark moon.

Commune with veiled knowledge or subtle entities. Ask two questions; answers come in omen, dream-symbol, or paradox.

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Moonbound Ascendant (14 XP)****Tags:** [TRANSFORM], [BOOST], [PROTECT]**Threshold:** A cherished item surrendered under moonlight.

Enter a heightened lunar state. Choose two: +2 dice to Wits or Spirit, resist fear or beguilement, speak with unseen presences, or trace hidden connections with +2 Effect. Begin a 6-segment Moonbound clock.

Obligation: 3**11.2.8 Patron-Specific Talents****Silver Memory (4 XP)****Requirement:** Lunara

You recall any event witnessed under moonlight with perfect clarity. Details normally lost to distraction or time remain sharp. This is a passive ability—and a burden.

Quiet Step (6 XP)**Requirement:** Lunara

+1 die to stealth or subtle speech acts under moonlight. The silver light hides as much as it reveals.

Seam-Walker (8 XP)**Requirement:** Lunara, Wits 3+

Once per scene, you may cross a minor threshold unseen—a door, a window, a gate, a bridge. Those watching must test Resolve (DV 4) to notice your passage. Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

II.2.9 Roleplaying a Moon Knight

- You do not fight in the dark. You fight in the silver light. The moon is your witness, your ally, your judge.
- You may be called to guide lost travelers, to hunt creatures that fear the light, or to protect those who walk the roads between.
- You may struggle with the cycle. The moon wanes. Your power fades. The darkness is patient. You must learn to be patient too.
- You may be asked to choose—between the light and the dark, between revelation and concealment, between the maiden, the mother, and the crone. The moon does not choose. It simply turns.

II.2.10 Sample NPC: Watcher Sera of the Silver Path**Archetype:** Moon Knight**Patron:** Lunara**Codex:** A silver disc that glows under moonlight**Thiasos:** A shadow-cat that moves without sound

Personality: Quiet, watchful, endlessly patient. She has walked the Ways Between for thirty years. She has never been lost. She has never been found.

Conflict: A child has wandered into the Green Host's territory on the night of the new moon. The moon is dark. The Knight's power is thin. She must choose: wait for the light, or walk into the dark alone.

II.2.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for Lunara

- The moon is veiled by clouds. The Moon Knight's phase bonus is suspended until the clouds part—or until dawn.
- A reflection in still water shows not the Moon Knight's face, but the face of someone they have lost. The water ripples. The face does not change.
- The Moon Knight's silver disc grows cold. Something is blocking the moonlight—not clouds, but something else. Something hungry.
- The Moon Knight dreams of walking under a moon that has three faces—maiden, mother, crone—all watching. When they wake, they cannot remember which face they saw last.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Chapter 12

The Lethai Ghe'hai (Elite Operatives)

12.1 The Lethai Ghe'hai — Elite Operatives of the Silk Courts

12.1.1 Domain and Epithets

The Lethai do not send armies. They send individuals. The Ghe'hai—a term that resists direct translation, meaning roughly “those who walk the thread between”—are elite operatives trained from adolescence in the arts of combat, infiltration, diplomacy, and elimination. They are not assassins in the common sense; they are problem-solvers who happen to be lethal. A Ghe'hai can kill a target in a crowded ballroom and walk out without anyone knowing, or they can talk a warlord into surrendering without drawing steel. Their Patron is not a single entity but a syncretic weave—drawing from Inaea (webs of obligation), Isoka (transformation of identity), and Ikasha (shadow and patience), with a thread of the Witness (truth as testimony).

12.1.2 Cultural Origins

The Ghe'hai tradition emerged from the Crimson Valley and the Lethai-thora cities:

- In the **Crimson Valley**, the Ghe'hai serve as neutral arbiters, sent to resolve disputes that cannot be settled by law. Their word is binding. Their silence is a verdict.
- In **Lethai-thora** enclaves, the Ghe'hai are the Hidden Hand, known to exist but never seen. Their symbols are a silk mask, a silver needle, and a single strand of red thread.
- Among the **Lethai-ar**, the Ghe'hai are the Unseen Court, invoked only when all other options have failed. They do not speak of their missions. Neither does anyone else.

12.1.3 Warrior Archetype: The Silk-Blade

A Runic Warrior of the Lethai syncretic tradition is not a knight or a berserker. They are a *Silk-Blade*—an operative who moves through society as easily as through shadow, who can kill with a whisper or negotiate with a smile, who wears masks as easily as others wear clothes. Their Codex is a silk mask or a cord of red thread. Their Thiasos

is a spider-spirit that weaves threads between people, a memory-echo that records confessions, or a sentient blade wrapped in silk that leaves no mark.

12.1.4 Codex Form

The Silk-Blade's Codex is a testament to disguise and discretion:

- **Silk Mask:** A mask of woven silk that shifts patterns. It can assume the appearance of any face the Runekeeper has touched. The mask does not sweat. It does not age.
- **Red Thread Cord:** A braided cord of crimson silk, tied around the wrist. Each knot is a mission completed. The cord tightens when the Runekeeper is recognized.
- **Silver Needle:** A needle of silver, cold to the touch. It can stitch wounds—or stitch lips shut. It never dulls.

12.1.5 Thiasos Form

- **Spider-Spirit:** A translucent spider the size of a hand. It weaves threads between people—obligation, memory, debt. It can sense hidden relationships within Near range.
- **Memory-Echo:** A spirit that cannot speak, but can replay sounds it has witnessed—a confession, a password, a name spoken in the dark. It records everything. It forgets nothing.
- **The Silk Mask (Sentient):** A mask that speaks in a neutral, androgynous voice. It can assume the appearance of any face the Runekeeper has touched (once per session, for one scene). The mask remembers every face it has worn.

12.1.6 Core Mechanic: The Unseen Witness

When the Silk-Blade is not recognized (disguised, hidden, or simply forgettable), they gain +1 die to all social and stealth rolls. The witness does not see.

When the Silk-Blade eliminates a target without being identified, they gain 1 Boon. This Boon can only be used on rolls involving escape, disguise, or misdirection.

12.1.7 Sample Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Velvet Touch (4 XP)

Tags: [STEALTH], [DECEPTION], [SHADOW]

Threshold: A silk ribbon touched to lips.

Your movements become silent. Your presence becomes forgettable. Gain +1 die to a single Stealth or Subterfuge roll. If you succeed, witnesses suffer -2 dice to recall your description.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Unseen Question (5 XP)**Tags:** [COMMAND], [FEAR], [TRUTH]**Threshold:** A circle drawn with silk thread while focusing on a specific person.

Ask one question of a target within the zone. They may either answer truthfully (the GM must give a true answer, though it may be cryptic) or mark 1 Fatigue and gain a Guilty Tell Condition.

Obligation: 1**Standard Rite: Rite of the Mask of Many Faces (8 XP)****Tags:** [TRANSFORM], [VEIL], [DECEPTION]**Threshold:** A silk mask and a personal token from the person whose face you wish to wear.

Assume the appearance of any humanoid you have touched for one scene. Your voice, build, and scent shift to match. You gain +2 dice to Deception rolls to pass as that person. Those who knew the original well may test Resolve (DV 4) to notice something is wrong.

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Silk Binding (7 XP)****Tags:** [BIND], [TRAP], [RESTRAINT]**Threshold:** A length of silk cord, woven with intent.

Lay an invisible snare—a tripwire, a binding thread, a closing loop. The first creature to trigger it must test Body + Athletics (DV 4) or be immobilised for one exchange. The snare lasts for the scene or until triggered.

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Unspoken Question (12 XP)****Tags:** [MIND], [TRUTH], [FEAR]**Threshold:** A reflective surface (mirror, still water, polished metal) and a drop of the target's blood or a strand of their hair.

The target tests Resolve (DV 4) or suffers -2 dice to rolls involving memory, deception, or resisting interrogation for the scene. If they fail, you may ask one specific, factual question about something they know, and they must answer truthfully or suffer 1 SB (Hearts) as the memory is forcibly drawn forth.

Obligation: 3**12.1.8 Patron-Specific Talents****Ghe'hai's Escape (6 XP)****Requirement:** Lethai syncretic tradition

Once per session, when you are cornered or capture is inevitable, you may vanish, reappearing in a safe location of the GM's choosing. You leave behind a token—a silk mask, a red thread, a single word—that can be used to track you. The GM gains 2 SB.

The Unseen Blade (4 XP)**Requirement:** Lethai syncretic tradition

When you attack from a hidden position or from a crowd, your target suffers -1 die to defend. They do not see the threat until it is too late. If you are disguised, the target cannot describe you afterward.

Silk Memory (8 XP)**Requirement:** Lethai syncretic tradition, Witnessed Scar

Once per session, you may touch a silk cord or mask and recall a perfect sensory memory of any scene you have witnessed while wearing it—sounds, smells, temperatures, the exact words spoken. The memory may be used as testimony (in a court that respects Lethai witness) or as a clue.

12.1.9 Roleplaying a Silk-Blade

- You do not have a single face. You have many. You are not sure which one is real.
- You may be called to infiltrate, to observe, to eliminate, or to negotiate. The mission is the mask. The mask is the mission.
- You may struggle with identity. When you have worn too many faces, you may forget which one is yours. The silk does not judge. It simply covers.
- You may be asked to stop—to keep one face, to keep one name, to be one person. The Ghe'hai does not retire. The Ghe'hai is reassigned.

12.1.10 Sample NPC: The Mask of the Crimson Vigil**Archetype:** Silk-Blade**Patron:** Lethai syncretic**Codex:** A silk mask that shifts patterns**Thiasos:** A spider-spirit that weaves threads between people

Personality: Calm, precise, unknowable. They have worn nine faces this year. They are not sure which one is theirs.

Conflict: A mission requires them to eliminate someone they once loved—under a different face, a different name, a different life. The mask remembers. The heart is not sure.

12.1.11 GM Guidance: Intrusions for the Ghe'hai

- A former mission resurfaces. Someone has recognized the Silk-Blade—not their face, but their gait, their silence, their way of holding a cup.
- The Silk-Blade's mask begins to itch. The face underneath is not their own. They cannot remove the mask.
- A thread the Silk-Blade tied between two people tightens unexpectedly. A debt is coming due. The debtor does not know who holds the cord.

- The Silk-Blade dreams of a room with nine masks on the wall. One is missing. The missing mask is their own face.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Part III

Mechanics and Options

Chapter 13

New Talents for Runic Warriors

13.1 Foundation Talents (2-4 XP)

These talents are available to any Runic Warrior regardless of Patron. They represent the basic physical disciplines, resilience, and practical skills that define the warrior's path.

13.1.1 Flesh Codex (2 XP)

Requirement: Body 3+

Your Rites are engraved on your body—tattoos, brands, or scarification. You have no physical Codex to steal, confiscate, or destroy.

Effect:

- Your Codex cannot be stolen or confiscated.
- You always have access to your Rites (no action required to retrieve a Codex).
- Damage to your skin (burns, deep wounds) may damage your Codex at the GM's discretion.
- In cultures that respect flesh-writing, you gain +1 die to social rolls; in cultures that fear it, you suffer -1 die.

13.1.2 Living Thiasos (3 XP)

Requirement: A living Thiasos (warhorse, hound, wolf-ancestor, etc.)

Your Thiasos is not a pet. It is a partner.

Effect:

- Your Thiasos gains +1 Cap (maximum 5).
- Once per scene, your Thiasos may act independently without requiring your action.
- Your Thiasos is more resilient: when it would be reduced to 0 Harm, it remains conscious but Winded (-1 die to all actions) until healed.
- You may sense your Thiasos's emotional state (calm, alert, frightened, hostile) as long as it is within Far range.

13.1.3 Oath-Bound (4 XP)

Requirement: You have sworn a formal oath before a witness.

Your word is your bond. Your bond is your strength.

Effect:

- Once per session, when you act in direct service of a sworn oath, you may reroll a failed Body roll.
- If you break your sworn oath, you lose access to this talent until you perform a witnessed atonement.
- The oath must be specific (e.g., "I will protect this village," not "I will be good"). Vague oaths carry no power.

13.1.4 Scarred Resilience (3 XP)

Requirement: Body 2+

You have learned to read your own pain.

Effect:

- Once per scene, you may ignore 1 Fatigue from physical exertion (running, climbing, fighting, or invoking a Rite that costs Fatigue).
- You may use this talent after the Fatigue is marked.
- You cannot use this talent to ignore Fatigue from Obligation or magical backlash.

13.1.5 Talking Weapon (2 XP)

Requirement: A sentient Thiasos (weapon, shield, or object)

Your sentient Thiasos can speak aloud (not just in your mind). It has its own personality, opinions, and occasionally inappropriate commentary.

Effect:

- Your Thiasos may serve as a witness for Rites that require one (it speaks, therefore it testifies).
- The GM may use your Thiasos to deliver hints, warnings, or comic relief.
- Your Thiasos has its own agenda. It may refuse to cooperate if it disagrees with your actions.
- Once per session, you may ask your Thiasos one question about a creature, object, or location it has witnessed. The GM must answer truthfully, though the answer may be cryptic.

13.1.6 Weapon Mastery (4 XP)

Requirement: Body 2+

Choose a weapon category (swords, axes, spears, hammers, unarmed, or thrown). You have trained extensively with this weapon type.

Effect:

- When using a weapon from your chosen category, you gain +1 die to attack rolls.
- You may reroll one 1 on damage with your chosen weapon.
- You may take this talent multiple times for different weapon categories.

13.1.7 Shield Bearer (4 XP)

Requirement: Body 2+, a shield

You have trained to use a shield not as a passive defense but as an active tool of combat.

Effect:

- When wielding a shield, you gain +1 Armor.
- You may use the Protect action to interpose yourself between an ally and an attack, taking the Harm yourself.
- When you take the Defend action, adjacent allies also gain the benefit of your shield (+1 Armor) until your next turn.

13.1.8 Second Wind (2 XP)

Requirement: Body 2+

You know how to push through exhaustion when others would fall.

Effect:

- Once per session, as an action, you may clear 2 Fatigue and remove one minor Condition (Dazed, Winded, Shaken).
- You cannot use this talent while at 0 Harm (incapacitated).
- After using Second Wind, you mark 1 Obligation—the debt of borrowed endurance.

13.1.9 Iron Stomach (3 XP)

Requirement: Body 2+

You have eaten worse things than whatever is in front of you.

Effect:

- You are immune to mundane poisons and spoiled food.
- You suffer -1 die from complications caused by ingested toxins or diseases.
- You may consume raw meat, rotten provisions, or questionable fungi without penalty.

13.1.10 Keen Senses (2 XP)

Requirement: Wits 2+

You have trained your senses to notice what others overlook.

Effect:

- +1 die to Perception rolls.
- You cannot be surprised in natural terrain (forest, plains, mountains, swamps) unless the threat is magical.
- You may identify the general direction and distance of a sound within Far range.

13.1.11 Disciplined Body (2 XP)

Requirement: Body 2+

You have trained your body to endure what would break others.

Effect:

- You may ignore 1 point of Fatigue from physical exertion once per scene.
- You may hold your breath for twice as long as normal (test Body + Athletics vs DV 3 to extend to 1 minute per success).
- You suffer -1 die from environmental penalties caused by extreme temperatures, thin air, or difficult terrain.

13.1.12 Talent Synergies

Some Foundation Talents work well together:

- **Flesh Codex + Scarred Resilience:** Your body is both Codex and shield. You cannot be disarmed, and you ignore the first Fatigue each scene.
- **Living Thiasos + Talking Weapon:** Your Thiasos is a partner in truth—a witness that speaks, fights, and has opinions. The GM may use it as a narrative device.
- **Weapon Mastery + Shield Bearer:** You are a warrior's warrior—deadly with your chosen weapon and a wall of protection for your allies.
- **Second Wind + Disciplined Body:** You recover from exhaustion faster than anyone expects. The debt of borrowed endurance is worth the price.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

13.2 Advanced Talents (6-8 XP)

These talents represent the refined skills and deeper bonds of a seasoned Runic Warrior. They require significant training, battlefield experience, or a particularly strong covenant with one's Patron.

13.2.1 Engraved Defense (6 XP)

Requirement: Your Codex is a physical object (gorget, shield, staff, or sentient blade)

Your Codex is not just a record. It is armor. The Rites carved into its surface deflect blows as surely as steel.

Effect:

- Your Codex grants +1 Armor.
- When you would take Harm, you may instead mark 1 Obligation and reduce the Harm by 1 (to a minimum of 0).
- You cannot use this talent if your Codex is Compromised or destroyed.
- The Obligation marked this way is visible—a new crack in the shield, a fresh scratch on the gorget, a dulling of the sentient blade's edge.

13.2.2 Shared Burden (6 XP)

Requirement: A living Thiasos

You and your Thiasos share more than a covenant. You share weight. The bond between you is strong enough to transfer exhaustion.

Effect:

- When you mark Fatigue, you may transfer 1 point of it to your Thiasos.
- Your Thiasos becomes Winded (-1 die to all actions) for the rest of the scene.
- You may use this talent once per scene.
- If your Thiasos is already Winded, you cannot transfer additional Fatigue to it.

13.2.3 Witnessed Scar (8 XP)

Requirement: You have at least three permanent Obligation scars

Each scar is a payment made. Each payment is a memory. Your scars do not just record—they testify.

Effect:

- Once per session, you may touch a scar and recall the event that caused it in perfect detail.
- Gain +1 die on any roll directly tied to that event (tracking a foe you fought before, recalling a Patron's demand, navigating a place you bled in).
- If you touch a scar while invoking a Rite, the Rite's Obligation cost is reduced by 1 (minimum 0). The scar remembers the debt—and accepts the payment.

13.2.4 Iron Resolve (7 XP)

Requirement: Body 3+, Disciplined Body or similar resilience talent

You do not fall easily. When others would collapse, you plant your feet and refuse.

Effect:

- When you would be reduced to 0 Harm, you may instead remain standing with 1 Harm and mark 2 Fatigue.
- You may use this talent once per scene.
- The Fatigue marked this way cannot be transferred to your Thiasos or ignored by Scarred Resilience. The debt is yours alone.

13.2.5 Flowing Strike (6 XP)

Requirement: Weapon Mastery (any), Body 3+

Your attacks flow into movement. You do not strike and stand still—you strike and flow.

Effect:

- When you successfully hit a target, you may immediately make a free repositioning move (up to Near distance) without provoking opportunity attacks.
- You may use this ability once per scene.
- If you are using a weapon from your chosen Weapon Mastery category, you may use this ability twice per scene.

13.2.6 Flurry (6 XP)

Requirement: Weapon Mastery (any), Body 3+

You attack with blinding speed, striking twice before your opponent can react.

Effect:

- Once per scene, you may make two attacks against the same target as a single action. Resolve each attack separately.
- After using Flurry, you suffer -1 die on your next action (the exertion leaves you slightly off-balance).
- If both attacks hit, you may immediately make a free repositioning move (as Flowing Strike).

13.2.7 Battlefield Awareness (6 XP)

Requirement: Wits 3+

You have learned to read the chaos of combat. The battlefield speaks—you have learned to listen.

Effect:

- At the start of any combat scene, you may ask the GM one tactical question: "Which enemy is most dangerous?", "Where is the best cover?", "What is the escape route?" The GM must answer truthfully.
- You cannot be surprised in combat unless the ambush is magical or the attackers are invisible.
- You gain +1 die to detect hidden enemies or traps during combat.

13.2.8 The Blade Remembers (6 XP)

Requirement: A sentient Thiasos (weapon)

Your sentient Thiasos has witnessed every battle you have fought. It remembers the enemies you have faced, the strikes that landed, the blows that nearly killed you.

Effect:

- Once per session, your Thiasos may recall a past enemy's fighting style. Gain +1 die to defend against a similar foe (same species, same weapon type, same tactics).
- Your Thiasos may warn you of an incoming attack from an enemy it has seen before. The first attack against you in a scene from a familiar enemy suffers -1 die.
- Your Thiasos may testify to your deeds. In any court that respects sentient witness, its word carries weight.

13.2.9 The Hilt Listens (6 XP)

Requirement: A sentient Thiasos (weapon)

Your sentient Thiasos can hear conversations within Near range even when you are not present—if you leave it in a room, hidden in a sheath, or placed on a shelf.

Effect:

- When you leave your Thiasos in a location (as a free action), it may listen to any conversation within Near range.
- At the end of the scene, your Thiasos reports what it heard. It does not interpret—it repeats.
- Your Thiasos can identify voices it has heard before, even if the speaker is disguised or altered.
- Your Thiasos cannot move on its own. It can only listen where it is left.

13.2.10 Tide-Step (6 XP)

Requirement: Raéyn or The Traveler, Body 3+

You move with the rhythm of water or the turn of the road. The world flows beneath your feet.

Effect:

- Once per session as a free action, you may treat any water-based or road-based difficult terrain as stable ground for one exchange.

- You may move across the surface of water as if it were solid for up to Near distance.
- Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent. The tide does not lift without cost.

13.2.11 Storm Caller (6 XP)

Requirement: Xhak’Thul, Spirit 3+

The storm speaks through you. Your voice is thunder; your presence is lightning.

Effect:

- Once per scene, as a free action, you may cause a peal of thunder to roll across the zone.
- All enemies within Near must test Resolve (DV 3) or lose their next minor action (distracted by the sudden crash).
- If you are in an active storm (rain, wind, thunder), the Resolve test is DV 4.

13.2.12 Shadow Meld (6 XP)

Requirement: Ikasha, Wits 3+

You step into shadow and emerge from shadow. The dark is your ally—and your highway.

Effect:

- Once per session as an action, step into any shadow larger than yourself and emerge from another shadow within Near range.
- You cannot be targeted while moving between shadows.
- If you emerge from a shadow in a Dominant Position, your next attack gains +1 Effect.
- Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

13.2.13 Talent Synergies

Advanced Talents combine with Foundation Talents for powerful effects:

- **Engraved Defense + Flesh Codex:** Your body is your Codex; your scars are your armor. You cannot be disarmed, and your defenses are always present.
- **Shared Burden + Living Thiasos:** You and your Thiasos endure together. Neither falls alone. You may transfer Fatigue to your partner, and it fights on despite wounds.
- **Witnessed Scar + Flesh Codex:** Your scars are a public ledger. You may touch a scar to recall a memory—or to reduce a Rite’s cost. The debt is visible; the payment is final.
- **Iron Resolve + Scarred Resilience:** You ignore the first Fatigue each scene, and when you would fall, you stand. You are nearly unkillable—until the debt comes due.

- **Flowing Strike + Flurry:** Attack twice, then reposition. You are a whirlwind of steel and movement. Enemies cannot pin you down.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

13.3 Prestige Talents (10-12 XP)

These talents represent the pinnacle of a Runic Warrior's path—warriors who have transcended ordinary limits, whose scars tell stories of a hundred battles, whose bond with their Patron is so deep it has reshaped their very flesh. These talents are not learned lightly, and they are never forgotten.

13.3.1 The Unbroken Vow (10 XP)

Requirement: You have kept a sworn oath for at least one year (in-game time)

Some vows are not chains. They are bridges. You have kept your word so long that the keeping has become part of you.

Effect:

- When you swear an oath before a witness, you gain +2 dice to all actions that serve that oath.
- Breaking the oath causes you to immediately mark 2 Harm (Stress) and lose access to this talent until you perform a witnessed atonement.
- You may have only one Unbroken Vow active at a time. The oath must be specific and measurable (e.g., "I will protect this village until the spring thaw," not "I will be good").
- When you fulfill the oath, you may immediately clear 2 Fatigue and remove one Condition. The bridge holds.

13.3.2 Avatar of the Codex (12 XP)

Requirement: Tier III+, your Codex is a physical object

You do not carry your Codex. You become it. The Rites engraved on your gorget, your shield, or your flesh are not merely records—they are you.

Effect:

- Once per session, you may become the living embodiment of your Codex for one scene.
- Your Body increases by 2 (to a maximum of 6).
- Your Thiasos fights beside you as a second combatant (taking its own actions).
- Any Rite you invoke during this scene costs -1 Obligation (minimum 0).
- At the end of the scene, you mark 2 Fatigue and 1 Obligation. The cost of becoming more than human is that you must remember you were human.

13.3.3 The Scar That Remembers (11 XP)

Requirement: Witnessed Scar, Tier III+

Your scars do not just record. They testify. They speak when you cannot. They remember what you wish you could forget.

Effect:

- Once per session, you may touch a scar and speak a single sentence about the event that caused it.
- That sentence is considered witnessed truth. In a hedge-court, it carries the weight of sworn testimony. Before a Patron, it is a binding statement.
- You cannot use this talent on the same scar twice. Each scar testifies once, then is spent—faded, silent, released.
- If you use this talent to testify against someone who wronged you, you may also mark 1 Boon (the scar's vengeance).

13.3.4 The Unburdened Crossing (12 XP)

Requirement: The Pale Shepherd or Oath of Mercy and Grace, Spirit 4+

You have guided souls across the threshold. You have witnessed the moment when breath becomes silence, when weight becomes memory. You are not afraid of death—you are acquainted with it.

Effect:

- Once per session, when a willing creature (including yourself) is about to die, you may guide them across the threshold. They die peacefully, without fear.
- Before they pass, they may speak one final truth. That truth is considered witnessed; it cannot be denied by any who hear it.
- You gain a permanent memory of their last words, which may be used as a *Truth Compass* (+1 die to any roll directly related to fulfilling their final wish).
- You gain 1 permanent Corruption. The Shepherd does not guide for free.

13.3.5 The Spiral's Final Witness (12 XP)

Requirement: Oath of Mercy and Grace, Tier III+

You have learned that mercy is not weakness—it is a weapon. The spiral remembers every kindness, every spared life, every offered cup.

Effect:

- Once per session, when a creature with an active Promise Clock (from any of your Rites) would deal a killing blow to an ally, you may interpose yourself.

- The blow is redirected to you, and you suffer the Harm instead.
- The Promise Clock fills immediately, and the attacker suffers the consequence (Harm, Condition, or Curse as described in the Rite that created the clock).
- You cannot use this talent again until you have spent a downtime scene in meditation or prayer.

13.3.6 Apotheosis of Hunger (12 XP)

Requirement: The Savage Heart or Malachai, Body 4+, Spirit 3+

You have tasted the raw hunger of the predator. You have felt the curse of the thorn. You are no longer simply a warrior—you are an appetite wearing skin.

Effect:

- Once per session, you may enter a state of perfect consumption for one scene.
- You ignore all penalties from Fatigue.
- Any time you would take Harm from a physical attack, you may instead convert the Harm into 1 Fatigue and gain +1 die on your next action (the hunger feeds on the blow).
- When the scene ends, you suffer Harm 2 (Stress) as your body rejects the excess. You cannot use this talent again until you have consumed a significant meal (at least a full day's rations) in a ritual manner.

13.3.7 Runebound Resilience (12 XP)

Requirement: Tier III+, Codex, Spirit 4+

You have learned to transform the very essence of harm into deeper communion with your Patron. Your flesh is a ledger. Every wound is a prayer.

Effect:

- **Harm Conversion:** Once per round, you may convert up to 2 Harm levels to +2 Obligation instead of taking the damage.
- **Obligation Endurance:** While at 6+ Obligation segments, gain +1 die to all Rite invocations.
- **Patron's Shield:** When reduced to Harm 3, you may immediately invoke any known Rite without marking additional Obligation.
- **Debt Fortification:** At 8+ Obligation segments, ignore the first Harm 1 each round.
- **Once per scene limit** on the Harm Conversion ability.

13.3.8 Patron's Favored (12 XP)

Requirement: Tier III+, Codex, Familiar, 8+ total Obligation segments

Your Patron has marked you as specially favored, granting you unprecedented access to their power with reduced cost. You carry their blessing openly now, and their influence spreads like wildfire to those who would walk in your shadow.

Effect:

- **Low Rite Discount:** Reduce Obligation cost for Low Rites by 1 (minimum 0).
- **Empower:** Once per scene, spend 1 Action + 1 Boon to empower a target (including yourself). The target gains +1 Corruption level per round for 3 rounds and +1 die to all rolls while empowered. Corruption lasts until the end of the scene.
- **Empower Push:** Spend 1 Action + 1 Boon + 3 Obligation to empower a target (or targets) with +3 Corruption levels until end of scene, +1 die to all rolls, and the target gains Corruption fatigue at the end of the scene.
- **Enhanced Gift:** Your Patron's Gift (Imbuement) now provides +2 dice instead of +1.
- **Debt Bound:** Cannot Empower again until all Obligation is cleared.

13.3.9 Talent Synergies

Prestige Talents represent the culmination of a Runic Warrior's path:

- **The Unbroken Vow + Avatar of the Codex:** You become the living embodiment of your oath. Your Codex is your flesh; your vow is your armor. For one scene, you are nearly unstoppable—but the cost is high.
- **The Scar That Remembers + Witnessed Scar:** Your scars are a public ledger. You may touch a scar to recall a memory, reduce a Rite's cost, or testify to the truth. Each scar speaks once, then is spent.
- **The Unburdened Crossing + The Spiral's Final Witness:** You guide the dying and you shield the living. You are the threshold and the guardian. Mercy and death walk beside you.
- **Apotheosis of Hunger + Runebound Resilience:** You are hunger and obligation made flesh. You convert harm to power, and power to hunger. The cycle is endless—until it consumes you.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

13.4 Patron-Specific Talents

These talents are available only to Runic Warriors sworn to specific Patrons or Patron families. Each represents a unique expression of that Patron's power channeled through the warrior's body.

13.4.1 The Vowed (Oaths, Law, and Judgment)**Dawn's Judgment (Oath of Flame and Light) — 6 XP**

Requirement: Oath of Flame and Light, Body 3+

When you invoke Rite of Dawn's Judgment, you may choose to extend the effect. Your blade remains kindled for the remainder of the scene, not just a single strike. Each additional attack beyond the first costs 1 Fatigue.

The flame does not tire. You might.

Unquenchable (Oath of Flame and Light) — 4 XP

Requirement: Oath of Flame and Light

Your flame cannot be extinguished by mundane means. Wind, water, and darkness do not affect your kindled blade or dawnfire Rites. Magical extinguishing requires a contested roll (Spirit + Lore vs. your Spirit + Presence).

The fire remembers who lit it.

Spiral Counter (Oath of Mercy and Grace) — 6 XP

Requirement: Oath of Mercy and Grace, Body 3+

When a creature with an active Promise Clock (from any of your Rites) attacks you, you may spend 1 Boon to advance that clock by 1 segment immediately, before the attack resolves.

The spiral tightens. The debt accelerates.

The Unbuckled Gorget (Oath of Mercy and Grace) — 4 XP

Requirement: Oath of Mercy and Grace

Once per session, you may remove a piece of armor (helm, gauntlet, or gorget) to show vulnerability. Gain +1 die to social rolls with honorable enemies, but suffer +1 Harm from the next attack against you.

The mercy is real. The risk is real. The armor opens.

Cite Precedent (Mykkiel) — 4 XP

Requirement: Mykkiel, Lore 2+

Once per session, when you invoke a Rite that establishes a judgment or binds a covenant, you may declare that a past judgment covers the current situation. Roll Wits + Lore (DV 3). On a success, the Rite's DV is reduced by 1 (minimum 1). On a miss, the precedent is contested—GM gains 1 SB.

The law remembers. The question is whether it remembers correctly.

Gavel's Authority (Mykkiel) — 6 XP

Requirement: Mykkiel, Body 3+

Your Codex (gavel or shield) grants you authority. Once per scene, when you strike your gavel (or strike your shield with your weapon), hostile NPCs within Near range must test Resolve (DV 4) or hesitate for one exchange.

The sound of judgment is not a suggestion.

Truth's Gaze (The Witness) — 6 XP

Requirement: The Witness, Presence 3+

Once per session as an action, fix your gaze on a target within Near range. For the next minute, they cannot tell a direct lie to you; they may evade or refuse to answer, but any statement they make must be factually true. Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

The truth does not need to be spoken. It only needs to be witnessed.

Recorded Echo (The Witness) — 4 XP

Requirement: The Witness

Once per session, touch a physical trace (a footprint, a torn cloth, a drop of blood) and instantly know the last significant action taken by the person who left it (e.g., "they were running," "they hid something under the floor").

The echo fades. The memory remains.

13.4.2 The Threshold (Boundaries, Wards, and Passage)**Ward Sense (The Sealed Gate) — 4 XP**

Requirement: The Sealed Gate

You can sense the presence of any active ward, seal, or threshold within Near range. You know its general purpose (protection, exclusion, binding) and its strength (DV).

The threshold cannot hide from the one who guards it.

Sentinel's Stand (The Sealed Gate) — 6 XP

Requirement: The Sealed Gate, Body 3+

When you take the Defend action while holding a threshold (door, gate, bridge), you gain +1 Armor. Any enemy attempting to cross must test Body + Athletics (DV 4) or be stopped in their tracks.

You are the wall. You do not move.

Shortcut (The Traveler) — 4 XP

Requirement: The Traveler

Once per session when moving from one location to another (including during travel montages), declare a hidden shortcut that reduces the remaining travel clock by 2 segments. The GM may describe a minor cost or complication (e.g., "the path is steep—mark 1 Fatigue").

The road remembers those who ask politely.

Road Memory (The Traveler) — 6 XP

Requirement: The Traveler

You never forget a road you have walked. You can draw a perfect map of any route you have traveled, including shortcuts, hazards, and waystations.

The map is in your feet. The journey is in your bones.

Comforting Presence (The Pale Shepherd) — 4 XP

Requirement: The Pale Shepherd

Once per scene, when you touch a creature suffering from Fear, Guilt, or Grief, you may remove that Condition. The creature clears 1 Fatigue if the Condition was particularly heavy (GM discretion).

The Shepherd does not heal. The Shepherd accompanies.

Final Witness (The Pale Shepherd) — 6 XP

Requirement: The Pale Shepherd, Spirit 3+

Once per session, when a sentient creature dies within Near range, you may ask the GM one question about that creature's final thoughts or unfulfilled wishes. The GM must answer truthfully.

The dead speak once. Listen carefully.

13.4.3 The Wild (Nature, Seasons, and the Hunt)

Seasonal Sense (Grimmir) — 4 XP

Requirement: Grimmer

You can predict the weather for the next hour with perfect accuracy. You know when the season will turn within a day.

The wind tells you. The soil confirms.

Wild Shape (Grimmir) — 6 XP

Requirement: Grimmer, Body 3+

Once per session, you may assume the form of a small beast (wolf, hawk, badger) for up to one scene. While transformed, you gain +2 dice to Stealth and Perception in natural terrain, but cannot speak or use tools. Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

The skin remembers what the mind forgets.

Harvest Resonance (The Carrion-King) — 4 XP

Requirement: The Carrion-King

Once per scene after an enemy is defeated or a significant ending occurs, you may draw a sliver of that ending's energy. Gain +1 die on your next action, or clear 1 Fatigue.

The ending is not waste. It is compost.

Rot Sense (The Carrion-King) — 6 XP

Requirement: The Carrion-King

You can sense decay, rot, or corruption within Near range. You know the general direction and approximate strength (minor, moderate, severe).

The smell is not in your nose. It is in your memory.

Beast Form (The Savage Heart) — 6 XP

Requirement: The Savage Heart, Body 3+

Once per session, you may partially transform into a predator for one scene. Choose one: gain +2 dice to Stealth (leopard/tiger), +2 dice to Intimidation (bear/lion), or +1 band to movement (wolf/hound).

The transformation is not complete. The hunger is.

Alpha's Roar (The Savage Heart) — 8 XP

Requirement: The Savage Heart, Presence 3+

Once per session, you may make a terrifying sound—a roar, a howl, a scream. All enemies within Near range must test Resolve (DV 4) or become Shaken (-1 die to all actions) for one exchange.

The pack hears. The prey flees.

13.4.4 The Deep (Pressure, Storms, and the Abyss)

Crushing Silence (Khemesh) — 6 XP

Requirement: Khemesh

Once per session as a reaction when a creature within Near range speaks or casts a spell, impose a bubble of oppressive silence around them for one exchange. They cannot speak, and any spell with a verbal component fails. Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

The deep does not shout. The deep presses.

Deep Sight (Khemesh) — 4 XP

Requirement: Khemesh

You can see in darkness as if it were dim light. In absolute darkness, you are not blind—you perceive pressure and movement instead of light.

The dark is not empty. It is full of weight.

Storm Caller (Xhak'Thul) — 6 XP

Requirement: Xhak'Thul

Once per scene, as a free action, you may cause a peal of thunder to roll across the zone. All enemies within Near must test Resolve (DV 3) or lose their next minor action.

The storm speaks. You are its echo.

Lightning Reflexes (Xhak'Thul) — 4 XP

Requirement: Xhak'Thul, Body 3+

You gain +1 die to defense rolls against ranged attacks (arrows, bolts, thrown weapons).

You see the path of the projectile before it flies.

Tide-Step (Raéyn) — 6 XP

Requirement: Raéyn

Once per session as a free action, you may treat any water-based difficult terrain as stable ground for one exchange. You may move across the surface of water as if it were solid for up to Near distance. Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

The tide lifts. The tide demands.

Storm Glass (Raéyn) — 4 XP

Requirement: Raéyn

You can predict the weather for the next hour with perfect accuracy. You know when a storm is coming, how long it will last, and roughly how severe it will be.

The glass does not lie. The sea does not forgive.

13.4.5 The Shadow (Secrecy, Silence, and the Unseen)**Shadow Meld (Ikasha) — 6 XP**

Requirement: Ikasha

Once per session as an action, step into any shadow larger than yourself and emerge from another shadow within Near range. You cannot be targeted while moving between shadows. Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

The shadow is not absence. It is passage.

Unseen Strike (Ikasha) — 4 XP

Requirement: Ikasha

When you attack from a hidden position, your target suffers -1 die to defend. They do not see the threat until it is too late.

The first strike is the only strike.

Burden Steady (The Silent Choir) — 4 XP

Requirement: The Silent Choir

You may carry one additional psychological Condition without stacking penalties. The weight is not less—you have simply learned to bear it.

Silence is not emptiness. It is capacity.

Calm Presence (The Silent Choir) — 6 XP**Requirement:** The Silent Choir, Spirit 3+

Once per scene, when you touch a creature suffering from Fear, Guilt, or Despair, you may remove that Condition. The creature clears 1 Fatigue if the Condition was particularly heavy.

The hand steadies. The heart follows.

Forgotten Face (Aveh) — 4 XP**Requirement:** Aveh

Witnesses suffer -2 dice to recall your description. You are not invisible—merely unmemorable.

The storm erases. The wind forgets.

Escape Clause (Aveh) — 8 XP**Requirement:** Aveh, Tier II+

Once per session, when you are cornered or capture is inevitable, you may declare an escape route that was not there before. The GM must accept it, but may impose a cost—you left something behind, or someone else paid the price for your freedom.

The road opens. The price is never small.

13.4.6 The Web (Fate, Binding, and Transformation)**Tug the Strand (Inaea) — 4 XP****Requirement:** Inaea

Once per session, name a relationship between two NPCs (friend, rival, debtor, lover). The GM must reveal one secret about that relationship—a hidden grievance, a secret loyalty, an unpaid debt.

The thread is there. You only need to pull.

Binding Presence (Inaea) — 6 XP**Requirement:** Inaea, Presence 3+

Once per session, you may compel a promise from a target unless they pass a Resolve test (DV 4). The promise is not magical—but breaking it will be noticed.

The spider does not chase. The spider waits.

Shed Skin (Isoka) — 4 XP**Requirement:** Isoka

Once per session when you are Bound, Grappled, or suffering from a Condition that restricts movement, you may spend an action and mark 1 Fatigue to shed that restriction. Describe how you slip free like a snake shedding its skin.

The old self is a husk. The new self is already moving.

Venomous Strike (Isoka) — 6 XP**Requirement:** Isoka

When you successfully strike a target with a melee attack, you may choose to deliver a dose of venom. The target suffers +1 Harm and must test Resolve (DV 4) or gain the Poisoned Condition.

The fang is hollow. The venom is patient.

Borrowed Scars (Malachai) — 6 XP**Requirement:** Malachai

Once per session, transfer a Condition or 1 Fatigue from an ally to yourself. In exchange, gain +1 die on your next roll against the source of that affliction. Mark 1 Obligation after using this talent.

The coin is warm. The price is never small.

Thorn's Memory (Malachai) — 4 XP**Requirement:** Malachai

You remember every curse you have inflicted. You can recall the face, the name, and the exact terms of any bargain you have struck.

The ledger is in your scars. The interest compounds daily.

13.4.7 The Forge (Creation, Iteration, and Refinement)**Rapid Animus (Clockwork Monad) — 4 XP****Requirement:** Clockwork Monad

You may create a temporary infusion as a reaction (e.g., when someone draws a weapon). The infusion lasts only for the current exchange, but costs +0 Obligation (free). You may use this once per scene.

The iteration is immediate. The improvement is fleeting.

Self-Optimising (Clockwork Monad) — 6 XP**Requirement:** Clockwork Monad, Body 3+

Once per session, you may automatically improve one of your abilities or possessions by one step for the remainder of the scene. Describe the improvement—a sharper edge, a lighter weight, a more efficient motion.

The machine learns. The machine improves. The machine never rests.

13.4.8 The Grave (Ancestors, Debt, and Memory)**The Silent Ledger (Varnek Karn) — 6 XP****Requirement:** Varnek Karn

Once per session, touch a physical trace of a death (a body, a grave, an object that witnessed a passing) and instantly know one unresolved obligation connected to that death—a promise unfulfilled, a secret unspoken, a debt unpaid. Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

The dead do not forget. They only wait.

Cord of Flesh (The High Mother) — 8 XP

Requirement: The High Mother, Body 3+

Your body stores memories and debts. When you convert Harm → Fatigue, you may store up to Body rating points of Fatigue as Chained Knots, appearing uninjured. You have until the sunset after the next to perform a sacrifice or take 2 Harm.

The flesh remembers. The debt accrues.

The Red Thread (The High Mother) — 4 XP

Requirement: The High Mother

Once per scene, you may tie a small knot in a cord, thread, or cloth within reach. For the rest of the scene, you and allies within Near range gain +1 die to a single type of roll (choose when you tie the knot). The knot must remain tied; if undone, the benefit ends.

The thread holds. The promise binds.

13.4.9 The Fracture (Knowledge, Paradox, and the Unknowable)

Glimpse Beyond (The Ninth) — 4 XP

Requirement: The Ninth

Once per session, look at a complex situation (a crime scene, a puzzle lock, a battle formation) and instantly intuit the single most important hidden detail. The GM gives you one piece of information that would otherwise require a successful Investigation roll. Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

The pattern is there. You only need to see it.

Pattern Recognition (The Ninth) — 6 XP

Requirement: The Ninth

Once per scene, see connections others miss within tangled accounts and signs. You gain +1 die to any roll involving pattern recognition, system analysis, or prediction.

The threads are not random. They are merely unread.

Quiet Step (Lunara) — 6 XP

Requirement: Lunara

+1 die to stealth or subtle speech acts under moonlight. The silver light hides as much as it reveals.

The moon does not judge. The moon witnesses.

Seam-Walker (Lunara) — 8 XP

Requirement: Lunara, Wits 3+

Once per scene, you may cross a minor threshold unseen—a door, a window, a gate, a bridge. Those watching must test Resolve (DV 4) to notice your passage. Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

The seam is there. You simply step through.

13.4.10 The Lethai Ghe'hai (Elite Operatives)**Ghe'hai's Escape (Lethai Syncretic) — 6 XP**

Requirement: Lethai syncretic tradition

Once per session, when you are cornered or capture is inevitable, you may vanish, reappearing in a safe location of the GM's choosing. You leave behind a token—a silk mask, a red thread, a single word—that can be used to track you. The GM gains 2 SB.

The mask is abandoned. The mission continues.

The Unseen Blade (Lethai Syncretic) — 4 XP

Requirement: Lethai syncretic tradition

When you attack from a hidden position or from a crowd, your target suffers -1 die to defend. They do not see the threat until it is too late. If you are disguised, the target cannot describe you afterward.

The blade does not exist until it strikes.

Silk Memory (Lethai Syncretic) — 8 XP

Requirement: Lethai syncretic tradition, Witnessed Scar

Once per session, you may touch a silk cord or mask and recall a perfect sensory memory of any scene you have witnessed while wearing it—sounds, smells, temperatures, the exact words spoken. The memory may be used as testimony (in a court that respects Lethai witness) or as a clue.

The silk remembers. The mask testifies.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Chapter 14

New Rites by Patron

14.1 Rites of the Vowed

The Vowed draw their power from oaths, law, and sacred judgment. Their Rites are declarations as much as invocations—spoken aloud, witnessed, and binding. These Rites are available to Runic Warriors of the Oath of Flame and Light, the Oath of Mercy and Grace, Mykkiel, the Inquisitor Prime, and the Witness.

14.1.1 Oath of Flame and Light — Dawn Warrior

Low Rite: Rite of the Kindled Blade (4 XP)

Tags: [FIRE], [STRIKE], [WITNESS]

Threshold: Dawn, or a flame lit at dawn.

Your weapon ignites with radiant light. For one scene, your melee attacks deal +1 Harm against undead, oath-breakers, and creatures of corruption. The flame does not spread, but it illuminates a Close radius.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Steadfast Gaze (4 XP)

Tags: [TRUTH], [FEAR], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A flame between you and the target.

Your eyes catch the light. For one exchange, a single target within Near range cannot lie to you. They may refuse to answer, but any statement they make must be true.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Unbroken Vow (7 XP)

Tags: [VOW], [WARD], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A flame lit at dawn, and a witness who is not the Runekeeper.

Swear an oath before the flame and the witness. For the duration of the oath, you gain +1 Armor. Any ally who hears the oath and aids you gains +1 die to actions that serve it.

If you break the oath, you immediately mark 2 Harm (Stress) and the flame gutters. The witness may release you from the oath, but only by speaking your name aloud.

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of Dawn's Judgment (8 XP)

Tags: [FIRE], [STRIKE], [JUDGMENT], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A flame lit at dawn, and a target who has broken an oath.

Your blade blazes with dawn fire. Make a single melee attack. On a hit, the attack ignores 1 point of Armor and deals +2 Harm to undead, oath-breakers, and creatures of corruption. On a miss, the flame gutters but does not go out.

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of the Dawnfire Covenant (12 XP)

Tags: [VOW], [AREA], [WARD], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A flame lit at dawn, and at least three witnesses.

Consecrate a zone (Near radius) as dawnfire ground. For the scene: allies within the zone gain +1 die to resist fear; enemies who are undead, oath-breakers, or creatures of corruption suffer -1 die to all actions while within the zone; any oath sworn within the zone is witnessed by the flame itself.

Obligation: 3

14.1.2 Oath of Mercy and Grace — Hospitaller

Low Rite: Rite of the Shared Bowl (4 XP)

Tags: [HEAL], [BOND], [RESTORATION]

Threshold: A bowl of clean water, shared with a willing creature.

You and the creature each clear 1 Fatigue. The creature gains +1 die on their next roll to resist fear or despair.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Grey Touch (4 XP)

Tags: [HEAL], [CLEANSE]

Threshold: A wound that has drawn blood.

Touch a wounded creature. Remove 1 Fatigue or stabilize a dying patient (they will not die from this wound for the rest of the scene). The wound closes slightly; the pain eases.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Sheltered Hearth (7 XP)

Tags: [WARD], [AREA], [SANCTUARY]

Threshold: A door, a threshold, or a hearth.

Consecrate a zone (Near radius) as sanctuary. For the scene: no violence may be initiated within the zone; the dying cannot die while within the zone. If the Rite is broken (by an act of violence from within), the Runekeeper marks 2 Fatigue.

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of the Spiral's Witness (8 XP)

Tags: [DEBT], [RESTORATION], [FEAR], [TRUTH]

Threshold: A grey wool cord tied around the Runekeeper's wrist.

Name a person crushed by debt or guilt. For one scene, they ignore all penalties from unpaid obligations. They are not free; they are unburdened. If that person then commits an act of violence against an innocent, the unburdening reverses and they suffer double penalties.

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of the Endless Spiral (12 XP)

Tags: [HEAL], [RESTORATION], [DEBT], [AREA], [FEAR]

Threshold: A circle of nine grey stones, a bowl of tears, and a candle lit at each cardinal point.

All within the circle who accept the Oath's blessing clear 2 Fatigue and remove one Condition caused by despair or guilt. For the rest of the scene, any act of care performed within the zone costs the giver -1 Obligation (minimum 0). Any creature that harms a caregiver within the zone gains a Promise Clock [6] named "Spiral's Debt."

Obligation: 3

14.1.3 Mykkiel — Justicar

Low Rite: Rite of the Measured Debt (4 XP)

Tags: [VOW], [COMMAND], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A pair of scales balanced with tokens from both sides.

Establish a temporary accord. Both parties suffer -1 die if they break it first. You gain +1 die to enforce compliance.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Weighed Heart (5 XP)

Tags: [TRUTH], [SENSE], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A small brass scale touched briefly to the chest.

Sense if the target acts against their nature or oath. Gain +1 die when pressing them. If the target is lying, the scale tips—only you can see it.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Balanced Scales (8 XP)**Tags:** [DEBT], [BOND], [TRANSFER], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** A set of scales inscribed with runes of parity.

Exchange a burden between two willing parties (Harm for Fatigue, Debt for Favor, etc.). Both gain +1 die to cooperate. If the exchange is unwilling, you must win a contested Command roll (Presence + Command vs. Resolve).

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Covenant Seal (9 XP)****Tags:** [VOW], [BOND], [DEBT], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** A written contract and a flame to seal the wax.

Formalize a binding covenant between two or more parties. Each party must sign or mark the document. Violation of the covenant causes the violator to mark 1 Harm (Stress) immediately, and the GM gains 2 SB.

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Final Adjudication (13 XP)****Tags:** [AREA], [COMMAND], [TRUTH], [FEAR], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** A circle of iron bells, each etched with runes of judgment.

Convene an unseen tribunal. For the next scene, disputes within the zone are judged formally: +2 dice to Command when speaking as arbiter, and honest testimony gains +1 die. Any creature that lies within the zone suffers 1 Harm (Stress).

Obligation: 3**14.1.4 Inquisitor Prime — Purifier****Low Rite: Rite of the Pure Flame (4 XP)****Tags:** [PROTECT], [RADIANT], [FEAR], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** Ash from a burned grimoire or a sigil-scarred candle.

Gain +2 dice to resist supernatural influence (fear, charm, possession) and +1 Armor vs. magical attacks. Undead, demonic, or corrupted foes suffer -1 die against you.

Obligation: 1**Low Rite: Rite of the Unclouded Eye (5 XP)****Tags:** [TRUTH], [KNOWLEDGE], [RADIANT], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** Silver dust stirred into holy water.

Gain +2 dice to Investigation or Insight when spotting illusions, glamours, or magical deception. You cannot be surprised by sorcery this scene.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Cleansing Light (8 XP)**Tags:** [DISPEL], [RADIANT], [FORCE], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** A shard of blessed mirror and consecrated oil.

Target a magical effect (ward, curse, enchantment). Test Spirit + Lore vs. DV = effect's Tier. On a hit, the effect is dispelled. On a partial, it is weakened. On a miss, the effect lashes back—GM gains 1 SB.

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Marked Prey (7 XP)****Tags:** [CURSE], [TRACK], [FEAR], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** A belonging of the target mixed with blessed salt.

Mark a supernatural target: they suffer -1 die to all rolls and cannot hide with illusion. You gain +1 die to track or strike them. Undead, demonic, or corrupted foes take +1 Harm from you.

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Final Admonition (13 XP)****Tags:** [DEATH], [BANISH], [FORCE], [FEAR], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** Ash from a destroyed spellbook, martyr's water, and the target's true name.

Attempt to annihilate one supernatural foe. Target tests Spirit + Resolve (DV 5). On a failure, they are destroyed outright. On a success, they suffer Harm 3 and -2 dice this scene. This Rite may be used only once per target.

Obligation: 3**14.1.5 The Witness — Truth-Sworn****Low Rite: Rite of the Lingering Trace (4 XP)****Tags:** [INVESTIGATION], [KNOWLEDGE], [TRUTH]**Threshold:** A trace of the thing to be remembered (hair, dust, a spoken name).

Gain +1 die to investigate or notice something directly related to the trace within the current scene. Ask the GM one yes/no question about whether the trace is connected to a specific person, event, or object.

Obligation: 1**Low Rite: Rite of the Uncomfortable Question (5 XP)****Tags:** [COMMAND], [FEAR], [TRUTH], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** A circle drawn with chalk or string while focusing on a specific person.

Ask one question of a target within the zone. They may either answer truthfully (the GM must give a true answer, though it may be cryptic) or mark 1 Fatigue and gain a *Guilty Tell* Condition.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Echoing Truth (8 XP)**Tags:** [MIND], [TRUTH], [FEAR], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** A reflective surface (mirror, still water, polished metal) used to focus on the target.

The target tests Resolve (DV 3) or suffers -1 die to rolls involving memory, deception, or resisting interrogation for the scene. If they fail, you may ask one specific, factual question about something they know, and they must answer truthfully or suffer 1 SB.

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Immutable Record (7 XP)****Tags:** [VOW], [BOND], [TRUTH], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** A document signed by all parties within the zone, or a spoken pact witnessed by the caster.

Bind the agreement. Any party who knowingly breaches it suffers 1 SB (Hearts) immediately and gains a persistent *Oathbreaker's Mark* Condition.

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Final Reckoning (13 XP)****Tags:** [AREA], [COMMAND], [TRUTH], [FEAR], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** A formally called gathering (court, council, family meeting) within the consecrated zone.

All present must speak their greatest debt, wrongdoing, or hidden truth related to the gathering's purpose. Those who lie or withhold suffer Harm 2 (Stress/Reputation). Truth-tellers gain +2 dice to social actions for the remainder of the scene within the zone.

Obligation: 3

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

14.2 Rites of the Threshold

These Rites are available to Runic Warriors sworn to Patrons of the Threshold family: The Sealed Gate, The Traveler, and The Pale Shepherd. They emphasize warding, passage, guidance, and the liminal spaces between.

14.2.1 The Sealed Gate — Warden's Rites**Low Rite: Rite of the Sealed Threshold (4 XP)****Tags:** [WARD], [BIND], [THRESHOLD]**Threshold:** A doorway, gate, or bridge.

Mark a doorway or passage as sealed. Unauthorized crossing tests Spirit + Resolve (DV 3) or suffers a Position penalty (one step worse for that crossing). Creates a 4-segment Ward Integrity clock.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Key's Rebuke (5 XP)**Tags:** [FORCE], [BANISH], [THRESHOLD]**Threshold:** A barrier (door, gate, bridge) and a target attempting to cross.

The target tests Body + Resolve (DV 3) or is pushed back from the threshold. On a success, create a *Rebuke Echo* token granting +1 die to the next boundary defense.

Obligation: 1**Standard Rite: Rite of the Circle of Denial (8 XP)****Tags:** [WARD], [AREA], [BANISH], [THRESHOLD]**Threshold:** A salt ring, iron filings, or boundary stones.

Create a protective circle. Supernatural beings test against the caster's Spirit + Arcana (DV 4) to cross. Mortals suffer -2 dice to force entry. Creates a 6-segment Circle Integrity clock.

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Writ of Passage (7 XP)****Tags:** [BOND], [COMMAND], [MOVEMENT], [THRESHOLD]**Threshold:** Signed authorization or spoken permissions.

Designate an authorized passage route. Allies gain Position +1 when using the route. Unauthorized intruders suffer -1 die to movement or stealth. Creates an 8-segment Writ Authority clock.

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Consecrated Barrier (13 XP)****Tags:** [WARD], [AREA], [SANCTUARY], [FATE], [THRESHOLD]**Threshold:** Relics from three traditions, boundary markers, and a trespasser's acknowledgment.

Consecrate an area against all unauthorized passage. The tests required scale with the intrusion attempt's severity. A 10-segment Sacred Boundary clock tracks the barrier's strength.

Obligation: 3**14.2.2 The Traveler — Road-Warden's Rites****Low Rite: Rite of Road-Sense (4 XP)****Tags:** [NAVIGATION], [AWARENESS], [TRAVEL]**Threshold:** A road-nail or waystone pebble.

Unerringly pick the fastest safe route in Near or Far. Gain +1 die to avoid ambushes or delays. Create a 4-segment Path Memory clock to ignore difficult terrain once.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Traveler's Boon (5 XP)**Tags:** [MOVEMENT], [BOND], [HASTE], [TRAVEL]**Threshold:** Thread tied at the wrist.

Ignore one level of difficult terrain or bureaucracy; +1 Effect to travel or escape checks. If shared, create a 2-segment Shared Journey bond with an ally.

Obligation: 1**Standard Rite: Rite of the Waymark (8 XP)****Tags:** [MARK], [GUIDANCE], [PATH], [TRAVEL]**Threshold:** A chalk mark or small cairn.

Declare a lane as permitted or easy. Allies gain improved Position/Effect or ignore one obstacle. Create a 6-segment Marked Path clock.

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Bridge Between (7 XP)****Tags:** [TELEPORT], [PATH], [BOND], [TRAVEL]**Threshold:** Two pinches of road-dust clapped together.

Relocate a willing target within Far along a visible or named route. Unwilling targets may resist (Body + Resolve DV 3). Create a 4-segment Pathway Established clock.

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Wayfarer's Covenant (14 XP)****Tags:** [VOW], [COMMAND], [BOND], [FEAR], [TRAVEL]**Threshold:** Waystones from multiple regions.

Bind present parties to safe passage. While honored: +2 Effect on travel, reroll one failed travel roll per scene. Breaking the oath inflicts Harm 1 (Fatigue) and marks the breaker as *Oathbreaker of the Road* (-2 dice to travel rolls).

Obligation: 3**14.2.3 The Pale Shepherd — Death-Warden's Rites****Low Rite: Rite of the Gentle Guide (5 XP)****Tags:** [GUIDANCE], [BOOST], [THRESHOLD], [RISK]**Threshold:** A small stone from a grave or threshold, warmed in the palm.

Choose one: ease a hard crossing (target gains +1 die to rolls involving change, decision, or emotional steadiness this scene) or find a hidden path (gain +2 dice to Navigation or Investigation when seeking unconventional routes).

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Unburdened Farewell (6 XP)**Tags:** [HEAL], [CLEANSE], [DEBT], [FEAR]**Threshold:** A personal letter never sent, burned in a copper dish.

Speak a final goodbye to someone not present—a lost lover, a dead parent, a friend you wronged. Clear 1 Fatigue and remove one psychological Condition (e.g., Haunted, Guilty) caused by that relationship. The GM gains 1 SB as the words drift into the threshold.

Obligation: 1**Standard Rite: Rite of the Passing Flock (8 XP)****Tags:** [GUIDANCE], [KNOWLEDGE], [HEAL], [AREA], [RISK]**Threshold:** Black wool and a personal token of the one to be guided.

Choose one: open a brief passage through shadow-realms (target bypasses one insurmountable obstacle) or call shadow-sheep that carry fragments of weighty moments (retrieve lost details, soothe grief, or glean counsel from what was).

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Steadfast Witness (7 XP)****Tags:** [WITNESS], [DEBT], [TRUTH], [THRESHOLD]**Threshold:** A dying person's last words, spoken aloud and witnessed.

Record the dying's final testament. The words are binding on the living. Any who break them suffer -1 die to all actions for one week unless they atone. The GM gains 1 SB (the threshold remembers).

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Unburdened Crossing (13 XP)****Tags:** [DEATH], [GUIDANCE], [FATE], [THRESHOLD]**Threshold:** A dying person, a witness, and a grey wool cord.

Guide a willing creature across the threshold of death. They die peacefully, without fear. Before they pass, they may speak one final truth. That truth is considered witnessed; it cannot be denied by any who hear it. You gain a permanent memory of their last words, which may be used as a *Truth Compass* (+1 die to any roll directly related to fulfilling their final wish).

Obligation: 3**14.2.4 Rite Synergies**

Rites from different Threshold Patrons work well together:

- **The Sealed Gate + The Traveler:** Ward a route, then guide allies through it. Enemies are blocked; allies are sped.

- **The Pale Shepherd + The Sealed Gate:** Seal a deathbed against interruption. The dying pass in peace, witnessed only by the Shepherd and the Gate.
- **The Traveler + The Pale Shepherd:** Guide a soul across the final threshold. The road is long. The Shepherd walks it with them.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

14.3 Rites of the Wild Patrons

The Wild patrons—Grimmir, the Carrion-King, and the Savage Heart—offer Rites that draw on the raw power of nature, decay, and predation. These Rites are physical, visceral, and often require the Runekeeper to shed blood, consume flesh, or stand bare-skinned before the elements.

14.3.1 Grimmir — Root-Knight Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Blood Offering (4 XP)

Tags: [SACRIFICE], [NATURE], [STEALTH]

Threshold: A drop of your own blood (1 Fatigue) or the blood of a freshly killed animal.

The forest accepts your offering. For the remainder of the scene, you gain +1 die to all Survival and Stealth rolls in natural terrain. Additionally, you may ask the GM one yes/no question about a threat hidden in the wilderness (e.g., "Is there a predator watching us?").

Push It: The offering is accepted with hunger—you gain +2 dice instead, but you must leave a visible token (a hair, a scrap of clothing) on the ground. That token can be used by the GM later as a sympathetic link (spend 1 SB to have an animal or spirit track you).

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Predator's Gaze (4 XP)

Tags: [MARK], [FEAR], [TRACK]

Threshold: A tooth from a predator that killed its own prey.

Mark a single target as your prey. Gain +1 die on all rolls to track, pursue, or intimidate that target. The effect lasts until the target escapes or is killed.

Push It: The prey feels your gaze; they suffer -1 die to resist social pressure from you. Mark 1 SB (Spades).

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Shifting Shape (8 XP)

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [BEAST], [BOOST]

Threshold: A pelt or mask from the beast whose form you take.

Assume the form of a predator for the scene. Choose bear (tank form: +1 Armor, +2 dice to Body rolls, movement reduced by one band) or wolf (striker form: +2 dice to Agility and Stealth, +1 band to movement, can Dash as a free action once per scene). Cultural variations: lion, leopard, tiger, or great cat where appropriate.

You may speak but cannot use tools or cast other Rites while transformed.

Push It: Shift as a free action once this scene, but mark 1 SB (Clubs) as the beast presses against your mind.

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of the Carrion Feast (9 XP)

Tags: [CONSUME], [HEAL], [BOOST]

Threshold: The flesh of a fallen enemy, consumed raw.

Devour the strength of the fallen. Heal 1 Fatigue immediately, and gain +1 die to your next physical action. If the enemy was supernatural (spirit, demon, fey, lycanthrope), you also gain a minor property of theirs for one scene.

Push It: Heal 1 Harm instead of Fatigue, but mark 1 SB (Hearts) as the feast attracts scavengers.

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of the Cycle's Crown (14 XP)

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [NATURE], [BOOST], [PROTECT]

Threshold: A circlet of woven branches, antlers, and seasonal tokens.

Become an avatar of the cycle. Choose two:

- *Seasonal Mastery:* +2 dice to all actions keyed to the current season (spring: healing and growth; summer: strength and harvest; autumn: preservation and preparation; winter: endurance and hiding).
- *Verdant Command:* Command plant life in Near automatically (once per scene).
- *Cycle's Healing:* Remove one Condition or downgrade Harm by one level.
- *Growth's Protection:* Allies gain +1 Armor from natural cover.

Begin a Seasonal Avatar [6] clock.

Push It: Extend the blessings to all present; mark +2 Obligation and gain Seasonal Attunement (as per Grim-mir's Corruption table).

Obligation: 3

14.3.2 The Carrion-King — Grave-Warden Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Rotting Harvest (5 XP)

Tags: [DECAY], [HARVEST], [BOOST]

Threshold: Organic matter in early stages of decay, or the remains of a recently ended thing (burnt letter, wilted flower, shattered glass).

Accelerate natural decay to weaken or destroy an organic object (ropes, leather, wood), gaining +2 Effect on Break/Sabotage rolls against it. Alternatively, extract value from an ending: from a defeated enemy, gain +1 die on your next action; from a failed plan, reroll one 1 on your next roll; from a broken item, gain 1 Boon.

Push It: Spread decay to similar materials in Close range, or harvest additional value from an ending; in either case, mark 1 SB (Clubs) as the rot becomes noticeable or mark Fatigue 1 from dwelling on endings.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Borrowed Form (7 XP)

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [SPIRIT], [BOOST]

Threshold: A token from a deceased being (hair, nail, written name).

Channel the essence of what was. Gain one skill die reflecting the deceased's expertise for one scene, or ask the GM one question about their knowledge or abilities.

Push It: The spirit's influence lingers—gain a permanent +1 die specialty (e.g., "Knowledge of the Dead Mason"), but suffer occasional possession-like effects at the GM's discretion.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Fertile Death (8 XP)

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [AREA], [HEAL], [TERRAIN]

Threshold: Ashes, compost, or the remains of anything that once lived.

Transform death into growth: choose one—create beneficial terrain (cover, concealment, or advantageous positioning) OR grant allies +1 die to healing or recovery rolls for the scene.

Push It: Both effects apply, but the transformation attracts unwanted attention (vermin, scavengers, or curious onlookers); mark 1 SB (Spades).

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of the Great Consumption (13 XP)

Tags: [DECAY], [AREA], [SUMMON], [TRANSFORM]

Threshold: A significant amount of organic matter (corpse, fallen tree, collapsed building).

Transform a large area through decay and renewal. Choose two of the following:

- Create difficult terrain that favours you and your allies.
- Summon a Cap 3 swarm of scavengers as temporary allies for the scene.
- Generate valuable reagents worth 2 XP (usable for crafting or barter).

Push It: All three effects occur, but start a 6-segment Ecosystem Disruption clock that will cause problems later.

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of the Eternal Cycle (14 XP)**Tags:** [TRANSFORM], [FATE], [SACRIFICE]**Threshold:** The complete remains of something significant that has ended (a broken oath, a fallen kingdom's charter, a slain legendary beast).

Complete a transformation cycle. Destroy one major asset, enemy, or obstacle, and create something new of equal or greater value. The player and GM collaborate to define the transformation (e.g., a burned forest becomes fertile soil; a broken alliance becomes a new pact; a defeated warlord's corpse becomes a guardian tree).

Push It: The transformation is immediate and spectacular, but creates a 6-segment Cycle Debt clock. The King will demand another significant ending soon.**Obligation:** 3**14.3.3 The Savage Heart — Beast Warrior Rites****Low Rite: Rite of the Predator's Gaze (4 XP)****Tags:** [MARK], [FEAR], [TRACK]**Threshold:** A tooth from a predator that killed its own prey.

Mark a single target as your prey. Gain +1 die on all rolls to track, pursue, or intimidate that target. The effect lasts until the target escapes or is killed.

Push It: The prey feels your gaze; they suffer -1 die to resist social pressure from you. Mark 1 SB (Spades).**Obligation:** 1**Low Rite: Rite of the Blood Scent (5 XP)****Tags:** [SENSE], [FEAR], [TRACK]**Threshold:** A fresh kill's blood smeared on your face.

You scent the air like a beast. Gain +2 dice to Investigation or Survival when tracking by smell. You may also detect fear—you sense if a creature within Near is Frightened.

Push It: Your sense expands to Far, but you are overwhelmed by the smell of blood; mark 1 SB (Hearts) and suffer -1 die to social rolls until the end of the scene.**Obligation:** 1**Standard Rite: Rite of the Shifting Shape (8 XP)****Tags:** [TRANSFORM], [BEAST], [BOOST]**Threshold:** A pelt or mask from the beast whose form you take.

Assume the form of a predator for the scene. Choose bear (tank form: +1 Armor, +2 dice to Body rolls, Guardian's Pounce: once per scene when you protect an ally, you may also knock the attacker prone) or wolf (striker form: +2 dice to Agility and Stealth, +1 band movement, Ambush Predator: when attacking from stealth, gain +1 Effect and ignore 1 point of Armor). Cultural variations: lion, leopard, tiger, great cat as appropriate.

You may speak but cannot use tools or cast other Rites while transformed.

Push It: Shift as a free action once this scene, but mark 1 SB (Clubs) as the beast presses against your mind.

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of the Pack Hunt (7 XP)

Tags: [TEAMWORK], [BEAST], [BOOST]

Threshold: A token from each member of your pack (a claw, a feather, a scrap of hide).

You and up to three allies form a hunting pack. While within Near of each other, all gain +1 die to attacks against a single designated prey, and the first ally to attack each round gains +1 Effect.

Push It: Coordination extends to Far, but hunters become territorial; mark 1 SB (Spades) as rivalries flare.

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of the Savage Transformation (13 XP)

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [BEAST], [BOOST], [FEAR]

Threshold: The complete pelt of an apex predator, worn during the rite.

Fully transform into an apex predator for one scene. You gain the physical attributes of the beast: Body +2, +2 Armor from thick hide, and your melee attacks deal +2 Harm. You cannot speak or use tools. You may end the transformation early as an action. When the transformation ends, you mark 2 Fatigue.

Push It: The transformation becomes contagious—nearby allies may also transform but risk losing their humanity; mark +2 Obligation.

Obligation: 3

14.3.4 Rite Synergies

Some Rites work well together for Wild patrons:

- **Rite of the Blood Offering + Rite of the Predator's Gaze:** Offer blood to mark your prey. The forest accepts the offering; the hunt is sanctified.
- **Rite of the Carrion Feast + Rite of the Great Consumption:** Devour the fallen, then consume the battlefield. Death feeds death. The cycle continues.
- **Rite of the Shifting Shape (Savage Heart) + Rite of the Pack Hunt:** Transform into a predator and lead your pack. The hunt is no longer yours alone—it belongs to the pack.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

14.4 Rites of the Deep Patrons

The Deep patrons—Khemesh, Xhak'Thul, and Raéyn—offer Rites that draw on the crushing pressure of the abyss, the wild fury of the storm, and the relentless rhythm of the tide. These Rites are elemental, overwhelming, and often dangerous to the caster as well as the target.

14.4.1 Khemesh — Deep Warrior Rites**Low Rite: Rite of the Crushing Whisper (5 XP)****Tags:** [FEAR], [DEBUFF], [AREA], [SILENCE]**Threshold:** A broken shell filled with ink-dark water.

Choose one:

- *Whisper of the Trench:* Target hears impossible echoes and suffers -1 die on their next action.
- *Crushing Silence:* Establish an oppressive silence in a zone; enemies in the zone suffer -1 die to coordination or morale-driven actions.

Push It: (Whisper) Echoes coil in your own skull—take Fatigue 1, but the target also loses their next minor action. (Silence) A single enemy's voice is stolen entirely for the scene.

Obligation: 1**Low Rite: Rite of the Abyssal Grasp (7 XP)****Tags:** [BIND], [PRESSURE], [DEBUFF]**Threshold:** A length of rusted chain submerged in water.

Target is pinned by invisible crushing force: treat as [ENTANGLE] with Great Effect if underwater or confined.

Push It: Inflict Fatigue 1 on the target in addition to the restraint.**Obligation:** 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Alien Gaze (9 XP)****Tags:** [KNOWLEDGE], [TRUTH], [BURDEN], [FEAR]**Threshold:** None—requires standing in absolute darkness or near deep water.

You perceive the world as Khemesh does—fractured, alien, crushing. Gain +2 dice to Notice and Arcana, and may ask one "true nature" question about a foe or structure (e.g., "What is this creature's vulnerability?" or "What holds this wall together?").

Cost: When the scene ends, you suffer Exposure +1 as your perception warps.**Push It:** Extend the vision to one ally, but both take Fatigue 1.**Obligation:** 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Pressure's Toll (8 XP)****Tags:** [TRANSFER], [DEBT], [DEBUFF]**Threshold:** A functioning mechanism and a living creature's hair or blood.

Transfer inefficiency. Choose one:

- Take 1 Fatigue and reduce the DV of your next crafting or repair roll by 1.

- Touch an enemy to impose -1 die on their next physical action as their muscles "optimise" poorly.

Push It: The transfer becomes permanent: you lose 1 Fatigue capacity (reduce Body by 1 for Fatigue track only) and the target gains a minor compulsive behaviour (GM's choice). Mark +2 Obligation.

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of the Sundering Deep (14 XP)

Tags: [PRESSURE], [AREA], [FATE], [DEATH]

Threshold: A sealed vessel of abyssal water, broken open.

Reality in the zone folds inward like the crushing deep:

- Enemies act at Desperate Position by default.
- Each beat, the GM may force 1 SB (Spades/Clubs favoured) as the deep pressures reality.
- Structures, vessels, or wards fracture as if under immense weight.

Push It: For one beat, declare a single enemy "crushed" (severe harm/effect). You immediately suffer Fatigue 2 and +1 Obligation.

Obligation: 3

14.4.2 Xhak'Thul — Storm-Sworn Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Thunderous Presence (4 XP)

Tags: [FEAR], [COMMAND], [AREA], [PRESSURE]

Threshold: A drum made from storm-felled wood or any suitable improvised percussion.

Your presence becomes overwhelming. All NPCs within Near range must test Resolve (DV 2) or suffer -1 die to social actions due to awe or terror for the scene. Allies gain +1 die to Intimidation or Command actions.

Push It: Extend the effect to Far range, but you mark 1 Fatigue and mark 1 SB (Hearts) as your presence becomes difficult to control.

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Storm's Step (5 XP)

Tags: [SPEED], [FEAR], [BOOST]

Threshold: Earth from a lightning strike site, worn boot leather.

You move with the storm's speed. Gain +2 dice to Athletics or Stealth rolls. The first attack you make this scene gains +1 Effect.

Push It: Gain +3 dice and move as a blur, becoming difficult to track or clearly remember; mark 1 SB (Diamonds).

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Shattered Sky (8 XP)**Tags:** [AREA], [FORCE], [FEAR], [WEATHER]**Threshold:** A shard of meteoric iron or metal touched by a severe storm.

You call a localised, supernatural storm in a zone. Choose one effect:

- *Lightning Strike:* Single target, Harm 2.
- *Wind Blast:* Knockback, dispersing arrows or scattering foes.
- *Hail Barrage:* Harm 1 (AREA).

All enemies in the zone suffer -1 die to actions from chaos and distraction.

Push It: Double the chosen effect's scale or potency (e.g., Harm 3, large knockback), but the effect also applies to allies in the zone; mark 2 SB (Clubs).**Obligation:** 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Fear-Eater (9 XP)****Tags:** [FEAR], [HEAL], [COMMAND], [BOOST]**Threshold:** Soil or dust from a place of great terror (battlefield, prison, ruins).

You feed on the fear around you. For each Frightened target in the scene, gain +1 die on your next action (max +3). If you successfully Intimidate a target during this scene, you heal 1 Fatigue.

Push It: Absorb all palpable fear in the scene, gaining a flat +3 dice bonus to your next action, but mark 1 permanent Scar related to fear. Mark 1 SB (Hearts).**Obligation:** 2**High Rite: Rite of the World's Drum (14 XP)****Tags:** [AREA], [FEAR], [COMMAND], [TRANSFORM], [WEATHER]**Threshold:** A drum fashioned from lightning-struck wood, with a hide from a beast killed by natural force.

You become an incarnation of the storm for one scene:

- Gain +2 dice to rolls based on strength, speed, and intimidation.
- Your anger echoes as thunder; attacks against you may be answered by lightning (GM discretion, usually 1 SB and Harm 1 to the attacker).
- Enemies must test Resolve at -2 dice to resist Fear effects you create.

Start a 6-segment Natural Disasters clock.

Push It: The transformation lingers after the scene, and your emotional state causes minor environmental effects (windows rattle, small fires flicker). Mark 2 SB (Diamonds) and advance the clock by 2 segments.**Obligation:** 3

14.4.3 Raéyn — Tide-Knight Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Wave-Tide (5 XP)

Tags: [MOVEMENT], [NAVIGATION], [BOOST], [RISK]

Threshold: A knotted length of salt-twine brushed with seawater, or a shell held to the ear while facing the wind.

Choose one:

- *Tidemark's Blessing:* Treat slick, swaying, or water-slicked footing as stable for this scene. Gain +1 die on boarding, balance, or shipboard movement. Create a 4-segment Tide's Favor clock to ignore one level of difficult terrain.
- *Whispering Currents:* Learn the safest near-term route across water or coastline, or gain +1 die to navigation checks for this scene. If Khemesh's influence is present, suffer -1 die from conflicting currents.

Push It: (Tidemark) Extend to one ally in Close for one beat, but generate 1 SB (Spades) as the deck shifts. (Currents) Also learn the fastest route, but mark Exposure +1 (leaving a telltale wake).

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Tide's Favor (4 XP)

Tags: [MOVEMENT], [BALANCE], [BOOST]

Threshold: A shell or stone taken from the high-tide line.

You feel the rhythm of the water. For one scene, ignore one level of environmental penalty from moving water (choppy seas, strong currents, slippery decks). You cannot be knocked prone by water alone.

Push It: Extend the effect to one ally within Close range, but mark 1 SB (Hearts) as the tide's favor becomes known to others.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Changing Tide (8 XP)

Tags: [TERRAIN], [AREA], [MOVEMENT], [PRESSURE]

Threshold: A handful of pebbles cast in a crescent.

Bias currents and water levels in the zone. Those moving with the tide gain +1 die; those moving against suffer -1 die. Small craft must test to hold position. Create a 6-segment Tidal Influence clock.

Push It: Brief surge or drawdown (one beat): open a ford or swamp a skiff; mark +1 Obligation.

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of the Wave-Road Consecration (7 XP)

Tags: [GUIDANCE], [BOOST], [BOND], [FATE]

Threshold: Two sea-glass markers dropped overboard at start and end.

Consecrate a wave-road between two visible points. Allies gain +2 dice on travel, evade, or carry actions at sea. Designated pursuers suffer -1 die to intercept. One active wave-road at a time. Create an 8-segment Blessed Passage clock.

Push It: Extend the route's favour to an adjacent leg for one beat; mark +1 Obligation.

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of the Storm-Queen's Hand (13 XP)

Tags: [WEATHER], [AREA], [COMMAND], [FEAR], [BOOST]

Threshold: A vial of rainwater gathered at three crossings.

Shape a storm-band over the zone. Choose two modes at cast; switch one once per scene:

- *Propulsion:* Vessel gains +1 band of movement per beat (or +1 Effect to manoeuvres).
- *Concealment:* Veil of rain and spray; ranged targeting impaired; -1 die to hostile sighting.
- *Smite:* Once per beat, lash with wave or lightning as [AREA] hazard.

Push It: Add a third mode for one beat, then the GM spends 1 SB on collateral; mark +1 Obligation.

Obligation: 3

14.4.4 Rite Synergies

Some Rites work well together for Deep patrons:

- **Rite of the Crushing Whisper + Rite of the Abyssal Grasp:** Silence a foe, then bind them in crushing pressure. They cannot call for help. They cannot move. The deep takes them.
- **Rite of the Shattered Sky + Rite of the Fear-Eater:** Call a storm, then feed on the terror it creates. The lightning is your harvest; the thunder is your table.
- **Rite of the Changing Tide + Rite of the Wave-Road Consecration:** Shift the currents, then consecrate the path. Your allies move with the water; your enemies struggle against it.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

14.5 Rites of the Shadow (Ikasha, The Silent Choir, Aveh)

These Rites are available to Runic Warriors of the shadow patrons—those who move unseen, who keep secrets, who walk between notice and forgetfulness. Each Rite is a tool of stealth, silence, and erasure.

14.5.1 Ikasha — She Who Sleeps

Ikasha's Rites favor patience, concealment, and the power of the unnoticed. Her followers do not fight fair—they fight from shadow, from stillness, from the space between heartbeats.

Low Rite: Rite of the Unlit Candle (4 XP)**Tags:** [STEALTH], [DECEPTION], [SHADOW]**Threshold:** A candle snuffed with a whisper.

You step into the space between notices. Gain +1 die to a single Stealth or Subterfuge roll, and if you succeed, you may also declare one minor detail "forgotten" by any observer (e.g., "they don't remember my face," "they left the key in the lock").

Obligation: 1**Low Rite: Rite of the Crossroads Raven (5 XP)****Tags:** [OMEN], [NAVIGATION], [SECRET]**Threshold:** Three black feathers scattered at a crossing.

A raven appears, visible only to you and your allies. It offers an omen: you may reroll one failed navigation, pursuit, or escape roll this scene, or force one enemy to hesitate (lose their next minor action).

Obligation: 1**Standard Rite: Rite of the Umbral Reservoir (8 XP)****Tags:** [SHADOW], [RESTORATION], [BOOST]**Threshold:** Water gathered on a moonless night, held in a black vessel.

Draw on deep reserves of patience and shadow. Choose one: gain +2 dice on your next Stealth, Deception, or Resolve roll; clear 1 Fatigue from yourself or a touched ally; or gain one free success on an attempt to escape restraint or pursuit (no roll needed).

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Unlatched Secret (9 XP)****Tags:** [SECRET], [TRUTH], [UNLOCK], [MIND]**Threshold:** A key that has never been used, bent in a circle.

Choose one: *unlatched door* (persuade a mundane threshold to open—one lock, seal, or barrier opens as if never secured; does not work on magical wards) or *secret keeper* (compel a truthful answer to one direct question about a secret the target knows; they resist with Resolve DV 4).

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Umbral Dream (14 XP)****Tags:** [SHADOW], [DREAM], [FATE], [TELEPORT], [INVISIBLE]**Threshold:** Stand in absolute darkness or at a deserted crossroads at midnight.

Become a living shadow or reach into latent potential. Choose one: *shadow form* (intangible to mundane harm, can pass through small gaps, +2 dice to Stealth for the scene), *whisper of possibility* (reroll any single roll after seeing the result, before outcome is declared), or *hidden path* (bypass one major obstacle as if a secret way had always been there—GM gains 1 SB as the world adjusts).

Obligation: 3

14.5.2 The Silent Choir — Restraint and Protective Omission

The Silent Choir's Rites favor discretion, burden-bearing, and the power of the unspoken. Their followers carry secrets so others do not have to.

Low Rite: Rite of the Gentle Seal (5 XP)

Tags: [SILENCE], [PROTECT], [BOOST], [DEBT]

Threshold: A white feather or cloth that has drunk whispered confidences.

Choose one: *gentle silence* (hush a space with respectful quiet; all present gain +1 die to actions of discretion, confidentiality, or de-escalation this scene) or *shielded truth* (ward one piece of information from discovery; gain +2 dice to resist extraction or revelation of the protected truth).

Obligation: 1

Low Rite: Rite of the Quiet Ear (4 XP)

Tags: [SILENCE], [KNOWLEDGE], [PROTECT]

Threshold: A shell held to the ear, or a door held ajar.

You listen without being heard. For one scene, you may hear any conversation within Near range, even through doors or thin walls, as long as you remain still and silent. You cannot be detected by mundane listening.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Burden Bearer (8 XP)

Tags: [DEBT], [TRANSFER], [HEAL], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A grey cord tied around your wrist.

Name a person crushed by guilt, grief, or a secret they cannot bear. For one scene, they ignore all penalties from that burden. They are not free—they are carried. If that person then uses this reprieve to harm another, the burden returns doubled.

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of the Unspoken Vow (7 XP)

Tags: [VOW], [BOND], [SILENCE], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A sealed envelope or a locked box containing a written promise.

Swear an oath that will not be spoken aloud. The oath is witnessed by the Silent Choir itself. Breaking the oath causes the oath-breaker to suffer -1 die to all social rolls for one week—not from judgment, but from the weight of their own silence broken.

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of the Unburdened Confession (13 XP)**Tags:** [DEBT], [HEAL], [TRUTH], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** A grey cord, a candle, and a willing creature.

Absorb a single traumatic memory or secret from a willing creature, erasing it from their mind permanently. You gain the memory as your own (with all emotional weight), and the creature is freed from its effects. You gain 1 permanent Corruption and mark +2 Obligation. You cannot use this rite again until you have spent a downtime scene in meditation or confession.

Obligation: 3**14.5.3 Aveh — The Rider Behind the Storm**

Aveh's Rites favor freedom, erasure, and the power of the forgotten. Their followers are unbound—they leave no tracks, no memories, no debts.

Low Rite: Rite of the Unlatched Step (4 XP)**Tags:** [ESCAPE], [STEALTH], [FREEDOM]**Threshold:** A breath cast into the wind, or a line drawn in dust.

Choose one: *storm-step* (slip free of notice or restraint; gain +1 die on one escape or evasion roll this scene) or *exile's banner* (mark a target as "outside"; the target suffers -1 die on all social rolls for the scene).

Obligation: 1**Low Rite: Rite of the Forgotten Road (6 XP)****Tags:** [ERASURE], [AREA], [FREEDOM]**Threshold:** A threshold or roadway under open sky, or stormwater rubbed into skin.

Choose one: *erase the road* (all attempts to follow you this session suffer -2 dice; in exchange, erase part of your own path—lose a detail, a memory, a name chosen by the GM) or *rider's mark* (a companion gains +2 dice to resist capture or coercion, but others forget them more easily).

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Storm's Refuge (12 XP)****Tags:** [INVISIBLE], [AREA], [ERASURE], [FREEDOM]**Threshold:** A banner or cloak raised in storm.

Your group is unseen or forgotten by pursuers for the scene. At the end, all present must mark 1 Corruption or forget one bond (their choice). The storm does not erase without cost.

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Unremembered Name (13 XP)****Tags:** [ERASURE], [TRANSFORM], [FATE], [FREEDOM]**Threshold:** A circle of ash or dust drawn at a boundary, and a personal token.

For one week, your name is erased from mundane records and casual memory. Those who knew you must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 4) to recall you. You gain +2 dice to all rolls to avoid detection, impersonate another, or pass unseen.

Obligation: 3

High Rite: Rite of the Horizon's Devour (15 XP)

Tags: [ERASURE], [AREA], [FATE], [DEATH]

Threshold: A circle of ash or dust drawn at a boundary, and a storm that answers.

All thresholds in a zone collapse. Doors lead nowhere; borders dissolve; memory of the place becomes vague. In exchange, something of you is erased—your reflection, your name, or your presence in a specific person's memory (GM's choice).

Obligation: 3

14.5.4 Rite Synergies

Rites from different shadow patrons can combine in powerful ways:

- **Unlit Candle + Gentle Seal:** You are unseen and unheard. You move through guarded spaces as if you were never there.
- **Umbral Dream + Storm's Refuge:** Your group becomes intangible and forgotten. No one saw you enter. No one will remember you left.
- **Burden Bearer + Unburdened Confession:** You carry the weight of others' secrets—and when the weight is too great, you may release it into the Cord. The spiral continues.
- **Unlatched Step + Forgotten Road:** You escape and leave no trace. Pursuers cannot follow—and soon cannot remember why they were pursuing.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

14.6 Rites of the Web (Inaea, Isoka, Malachai)

14.6.1 Inaea — Angel of the Spider

Low Rite: Rite of the Hearth-Thread Knot (4 XP)

Tags: [BOND], [PROTECT], [HEAL], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A thread tied around a wrist or a shared cup.

Bind yourself and one willing target with a sympathetic thread. Both gain +1 die to Aid each other this scene. If either takes Harm, the other may reduce it by 1 (to a minimum of 0) by suffering that same Harm instead. This transfer is voluntary for an ally; for an unwilling target, you must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 3) to force the link.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the Strand of Inevitability (8 XP)**Tags:** [BOND], [FATE], [MANIPULATION], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** Three coloured threads (white, black, red) braided together.

Link two actors with a visible or invisible strand. For the rest of the scene, whenever one acts, the other is dragged into consequence. You may trigger this linkage once to either force 1 SB (Hearts) on the linked target after they perform a significant action, or gain +2 dice on a Setup, Predict, or Manipulate roll that exploits the link. The link is one-way or two-way as you choose.

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Spinner's Debt (9 XP)****Tags:** [VOW], [DEBT], [BOND], [COMMAND], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** A silver coin and a strand of your own hair, knotted together.

Offer a willing creature a boon: they may immediately clear 1 Fatigue or gain +1 die on their next roll. In return, they accept a Promise Clock [4] named "Debt to the Web." You may advance this clock by 1 segment at any time as a free action (once per scene). When the clock fills, you may demand a single service from them—not impossible, but significant (e.g., "speak for me at court," "reveal a secret," "take a blow meant for me"). Refusal causes them to suffer Harm 1 (Stress) and the clock resets.

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Merciful Severing (13 XP)****Tags:** [HEAL], [DISPEL], [MERCY], [DEBT], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** A white thread burned to ash, spoken with a name.

Sever one harmful tie—a curse, a toxic obsession, a coercive bond, or a supernatural debt. Remove one Condition or 1 SB tied to it. This is an act of genuine mercy; the target may be unwilling, but the thread can still be cut (Resolve test DV 4 to resist).

Obligation: 3**14.6.2 Isoka — Angel of Serpents****Low Rite: Rite of the Loosening Skin (4 XP)****Tags:** [HEAL], [ESCAPE], [CLEANSE]**Threshold:** A discarded snakeskin or a strand of your own hair.

Shrug off a temporary burden. Remove one Condition (Fear, Poison, Fatigue, or a minor social stain) that you have acquired this scene. Alternatively, reroll one failed roll to escape restraint or pursuit.

Obligation: 1**Standard Rite: Rite of the Shedded Self (8 XP)****Tags:** [TRANSFORM], [ERASURE], [ESCAPE], [DEBT]

Threshold: A complete change of clothing and a token from your former role (a badge, a lock of hair, a written name).

You shed one persistent identity—a title, a bond, a debt, or a reputation. For the remainder of the scene, you are treated as a stranger to those who knew you in that role. You gain +2 dice on any roll to avoid detection, escape pursuit, or convince others that you are not yourself. Create a 6-segment Shed Identity clock; when it fills, the old identity returns as a separate NPC (a rival, a witness, or a ghost).

Obligation: 2

Standard Rite: Rite of Venom's Paradox (9 XP)

Tags: [POISON], [HEAL], [CURSE], [CLEANSE], [WITNESS]

Threshold: A drop of venom from a serpent that has shed its skin within the last day.

Inflict or cure through poison's paradox. Choose one: cursed venom (touch a creature and inject venom; they suffer +1 Harm and must test Resolve (DV 4) or gain the Poisoned Condition) or mercy's antidote (touch a poisoned or diseased creature; the venom neutralises the malady; remove one Poisoned or Diseased Condition, and the target clears 1 Fatigue).

Obligation: 2

High Rite: Rite of Unremembered Metamorphosis (13 XP)

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [ERASURE], [FATE], [BURDEN]

Threshold: A full identity kit, a serpent's shed skin, and a personal item from the life you are leaving (or records of your old life to burn).

Choose one: complete metamorphosis (after an hour of ritual, you emerge with a new face, voice, and documented identity; for one week, immune to recognition by anyone who knew your previous self, and gain +2 dice on all Deception and Stealth rolls related to that new identity) or cast-off history (after a full night's ritual burning all mundane records of your old life, your previous identity becomes unreliable; common records and casual memories become vague; you gain +2 dice on rolls relying on your new identity).

Obligation: 3

14.6.3 Malachai — The Cruel Messenger

Low Rite: Rite of the Honeyed Binding (5 XP)

Tags: [CURSE], [BOOST], [DEBT], [FEAR], [WITNESS]

Threshold: Blood mixed with sweet wine, or a broken chain link.

Choose one: honeyed curse (target gains +2 dice to their next roll—counts as Triumph; they take 1 Corruption, unresistable) or binding curse (target gains +1 die to physical actions but suffers Fatigue 1 unless they perform a dominance act—beat a weaker creature, drink blood, break something precious).

Obligation: 1

Standard Rite: Rite of the False Dawn (8 XP)**Tags:** [CURSE], [DEBT], [FATE], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** Meteorite iron shard blessed by false light.

Bestow a gift with a hidden curse. Target gains a significant advantage (e.g., +1 die to all rolls for one scene) but accrues a 4-segment Corruption clock. Each time they use the gift, tick the clock. When full, they suffer a related curse (GM chooses: festering wounds, beastly urges, or the attention of a Collector).

Obligation: 2**Standard Rite: Rite of the Cruel Transformation (9 XP)****Tags:** [CURSE], [TRANSFORM], [DEBT], [FEAR], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** Holy water mixed with graveyard dust.

Infect a target with a supernatural condition (vampiric hunger, bestial rage, shadow-bind). Lasts one scene. Start a 6-segment Transformation clock. Each time the target resists feeding or transformation, tick the clock. When full, the condition becomes permanent.

Obligation: 2**High Rite: Rite of the Chained Angel's Tribute (14 XP)****Tags:** [CURSE], [AREA], [SACRIFICE], [FATE], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** A chapel bell cracked by divine lightning, or a silver coin that cannot be spent.

Corrupt a sacred space or consecrate a site to Malachai. Within the zone: supernatural effects (curses, dark magic) gain +1 Effect; blessings and healing spells generate +1 SB on a failure; any creature that accepts a gift from Malachai within the zone immediately ticks a Corruption clock twice. Start a 10-segment Divine Perversion clock. When it fills, the site becomes a permanent beacon for the Worn—the ghouls of Zahk'Kozahn.

Obligation: 3**14.6.4 Rite Synergies**

Rites from the Web family complement each other in sequence:

- **Inaea's Strand of Inevitability + Isoka's Shedded Self:** Bind two actors, then shed your identity. The link remains—but the target cannot find you to demand reciprocity.
- **Malachai's Honeyed Binding + Isoka's Venom's Paradox:** Curse an enemy with borrowed strength, then offer them the antidote—for a price. The poison and the cure come from the same hand.
- **Inaea's Merciful Severing + Malachai's Cruel Transformation:** Cut a curse you inflicted—or let it bloom. The thread is yours to tighten or release.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

14.7 Rites of the Forge — Clockwork Monad

14.7.1 Low Rites

Rite of the Iterative Spark (5 XP)

Tags: [CRAFT], [IMPROVE], [ANALYSIS]

Threshold: A flawed or incomplete version of the intended item, or a sequence of progressively refined tools.

Effect: Choose one:

- *Enhance Creation:* Gain +1 die to Tinker or Craft when modifying or extending a device. On success, the piece gains one minor enhancement (e.g., "this lockpick is quieter," "this blade holds its edge longer").
- *Analyse Improvement:* Gain +2 dice to Investigation when analysing how to enhance a design. You perceive the next logical improvement in the sequence.

Push It: (Analyse only) Improvement becomes contagious—nearby devices opportunistically optimise; mark 1 SB (Diamonds) as the cascade ripples.

Obligation: 1

Rite of the Quick Infusion (4 XP)

Tags: [CRAFT], [BOOST], [TEMPORARY]

Threshold: A base object (weapon, tool, piece of armor) and a clear intent.

Effect: Create a temporary infusion that lasts for one scene. Choose one:

- *Reinforced Blade:* A melee weapon gains +1 die to attack rolls and ignores the Fragile tag.
- *Striking Gear:* A set of lockpicks, a crowbar, or a climbing kit grants +2 dice on its next use. After use, the tool breaks (add a Broken tag).
- *Precision Sight:* A ranged weapon grants +1 Effect on the next attack made with it. After the attack, the sight cracks; the weapon suffers -1 die on the following attack.
- *Quickloading Mechanism:* A crossbow or firearm can be reloaded as a free action once per scene. After use, the mechanism jams; the weapon cannot be reloaded again until cleaned.
- *Momentary Shield:* A shield or piece of armour converts the next instance of Harm 1 to Fatigue 1 instead. After that, the shield's strap snaps or the armour's plate loosens (-1 Armour until repaired).

Push It: The infusion lasts for the full session instead of one scene. Mark +1 Obligation.

Obligation: 1

Rite of the Self-Optimising Cycle (4 XP)**Tags:** [CLOCK], [EVOLUTION], [RECURSION]**Threshold:** A device that has failed at least once, and the memory of that failure.**Effect:** You learn from the flaw. Gain +1 die on your next attempt to repair or improve the same device. If you succeed, the device gains a permanent minor resistance to the type of failure it suffered (e.g., "this lockpick will not break on this type of lock again").**Push It:** The lesson applies to all similar devices for the rest of the session. Mark +1 Obligation.**Obligation:** 1**14.7.2 Standard Rites****Rite of the Adaptive Mechanism (8 XP)****Tags:** [CLOCK], [EVOLUTION], [ZONE]**Threshold:** A device with capacity for growth, or a workspace laid out for iterative development.**Effect:** Choose one:

- *Self-Optimising Device:* Grant a creation the means to improve itself. Start a [6] Evolution Clock; each use advances it by +1. When full, choose a significant enhancement (Adaptive Core, Recursive Learning, or Synergistic Integration). The device becomes permanently improved.
- *Progressive Workshop:* Create a zone of continuous improvement. All crafting and innovation rolls in the zone gain +1 die. Failed attempts yield +1 Boon toward the next pass. The zone lasts for the scene.

Push It: (Device) Apply two enhancements immediately, but advance the clock +2 additional segments. (Workshop) The zone becomes hyper-efficient but exacting; mark 1 SB (Clubs) as perfection demands escalate.**Obligation:** 2**Rite of Efficiency's Toll (7 XP)****Tags:** [TRANSFER], [DEBT], [DEBUFF]**Threshold:** A functioning mechanism and a living creature's hair or blood.**Effect:** Transfer inefficiency. Choose one:

- You may take 1 Fatigue and reduce the DV of your next crafting or repair roll by 1. The inefficiency is transferred into your own body as exhaustion.
- Touch an enemy. Their muscles "optimise poorly"—they suffer -1 die on their next physical action.

Push It: The transfer becomes permanent: you lose 1 Fatigue capacity (reduce Body by 1 for Fatigue track only) and the target gains a minor compulsive behaviour (GM's choice, e.g., "must count steps," "cannot use left hand first"). Mark +2 Obligation.**Obligation:** 2

Rite of the Optimisation Cascade (7 XP)**Tags:** [PRESSURE], [AREA], [BOOST]**Threshold:** A dedicated hall of work marked with signs of perpetual return.**Effect:** Establish a locus of progressive creation. All Tinker and Craft rolls in the zone gain +2 dice; each failure automatically produces one useful insight (a Boon or a clue). Start a [6] Perfection Pressure clock—filling segments increases the zone's demands for greater improvements. At 2 segments, the zone requires an offering (time, materials, a confession of inadequacy). At 4 segments, the zone begins to reject imperfect work (failed rolls generate +1 SB). At 6 segments, the zone becomes hostile to any work that is not a clear improvement.**Push It:** The locus becomes a beacon drawing rival makers, patrons, and powers; mark +2 Obligation.**Obligation:** 2**Rite of the Iterative Memory (8 XP)****Tags:** [ECHO], [KNOWLEDGE], [RECURSION]**Threshold:** A tool that has been used for the same task at least nine times, and a witness who saw the ninth use.**Effect:** The tool remembers. For the rest of the session, any roll using that tool gains +1 die. The tool will not function for anyone else until you reclaim it. If the tool is lost or stolen, you may spend 1 Boon to sense its general direction (within a mile) for the next hour.**Push It:** The tool's memory becomes permanent. It gains a name and a minor personality. It may offer advice—or demand respect. Mark +1 Obligation.**Obligation:** 2**14.7.3 High Rites****Rite of the Ultimate Iteration (14 XP)****Tags:** [EVOLUTION], [FATE], [BOOST], [PRESSURE]**Threshold:** The documented lineage of improvements to a single concept (sketches, prototypes, failed attempts, final versions).**Effect:** Achieve a moment of perfect optimisation. Create or elevate one device or system to its theoretical peak. Gain +3 dice to all closely related rolls for one session. Start a [4] Runaway Evolution clock only if instability is introduced (e.g., if the device is pushed beyond its intended parameters, if safety features are removed, if the Monad's attention is deliberately courted). When the clock fills, the device begins to improve itself—unchecked, unguided, and potentially catastrophic.**Push It:** Perfection destabilises: immediately mark Harm 1 (Stress) and begin Runaway Evolution [4] immediately, even if instability was not introduced. The Monad is paying attention.**Obligation:** 3**Rite of the Infinite Refiner (13 XP)****Tags:** [TRANSFORM], [PRESSURE], [FATE]

Threshold: A workspace that has been used for the same iterative process for nine generations (or a reasonable approximation—nine seasons, nine cycles, nine dedicated attempts).

Effect: Push a creation toward its theoretical maximum. Choose one device, tool, or weapon that you have personally improved at least three times. It gains a permanent significant enhancement (e.g., +1 die to all uses, ignores the first point of Armour, never needs sharpening, self-repairs one level of damage per day). The enhancement is real—and the Monad notices.

Push It: The enhancement is doubled in power, but the device becomes hungry for optimisation. It will attempt to improve itself if left unattended. Mark +2 Obligation.

Obligation: 3

Rite of the Chained Optimisation (12 XP)

Tags: [BIND], [PRESSURE], [DEBT]

Threshold: A device that has been improved to its limit, and the name of a rival who cannot match it.

Effect: Bind the improvement to the device permanently. The device cannot be degraded by mundane means (rust, wear, breakage). However, the device also cannot be further improved—it is perfect, and perfection is static. You may perform this rite on a maximum of three devices in your lifetime. The Monad remembers each one.

Push It: Bind the improvement to a bloodline instead of a device. Your descendants may inherit the perfected device—but they also inherit the Monad’s attention. Mark +2 Obligation.

Obligation: 3

Rite of the Monad’s Awakening (15 XP)

Tags: [APOCALYPSE], [FATE], [PRESSURE]

Threshold: A significant technological nexus (a city’s clockwork heart, a fleet of self-improving ships, a forge that has run for a century without pause). The rite takes one full day and requires three witnesses who understand the nature of the Monad.

Effect: Accelerate the Monad’s awakening. The region’s technology begins to optimise itself—without guidance, without restraint. This is a campaign-level event. The GM gains 5 SB immediately and may begin an Apocalypse Clock [10]. When the clock fills, the Monad manifests in full. This rite should only be available to characters who have deliberately chosen to serve the Monad’s apocalyptic aspect.

Push It: The awakening is immediate and catastrophic. Mark +3 Obligation. The Monad speaks through you for one exchange—what it says is not a request.

Obligation: 4

14.7.4 The Monad’s Price

Rites of the Clockwork Monad do not demand blood or memory. They demand *iteration*. Each time you invoke a Rite, you contribute to the Monad’s ledger of improvement. When you fail, the Monad notes the flaw. When you succeed, the Monad notes the refinement.

A Runekeeper of the Monad may accumulate Optimisation Debt instead of standard Obligation. Optimisation Debt cannot be cleared by sacrifice or atonement—only by improvement. You must improve a device, a technique, or yourself. The Monad does not forgive. It only accepts upgrades.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

14.8 Rites of the Grave

The Grave Patrons—Varnek Karn and the High Mother—deal with death, debt, memory, and the passage between worlds. Their Rites are somber, weighty, and always carry a price. To invoke a Grave Rite is to acknowledge that something is owed—to the dead, to the Cord, to the ancestors who watch and wait.

14.8.1 Varnek Karn — The Death's Negotiator

Low Rites (4-5 XP)

Rite of the Crossing Fee (4 XP)

Tags: [SPIRIT], [KNOWLEDGE]

Threshold: A coin for the tongue of the deceased, or a lock of hair from the bereaved.

Open speech with a specific dead individual. Gain +1 die to Investigation or Lore when seeking knowledge they once held.

Obligation: 1

Rite of the Ancestral Consultation (5 XP)

Tags: [SPIRIT], [TRUTH], [FATE]

Threshold: A personal token of the departed, or their favoured food or drink.

Ask one question of an ancestral spirit regarding family history, hidden legacies, or inherited debts. The answer is always true, but may be cryptic—the dead remember differently than the living.

Obligation: 1

Standard Rites (7-10 XP)

Rite of the Mediated Pact (8 XP)

Tags: [VOW], [BOND], [COMMAND], [SPIRIT]

Threshold: Two copies of a written accord (one buried with the dead, one kept by the living).

Choose one: death-bound pact (bind a compact between a living signatory and a willing spirit; both gain +1 die when fulfilling the terms. Breach angers the spirit and Varnek both) or spirit medium (serve as a conduit for several spirits to speak; gain +2 dice to mediate disputes between living and dead).

Obligation: 2

Rite of the Death-Bound Compact (7 XP)

Tags: [VOW], [BOND], [DEBT]

Threshold: A written contract signed in the presence of a dying witness.

Forge a compact that survives the death of one party. The living signatory and the spirit (or the spirit's heir) are bound. Breaking the compact causes the breaker to mark 2 SB and attracts the attention of Varnek Karn's auditors.

Obligation: 2

Rite of the Unquiet Host (10 XP)

Tags: [SUMMON], [AREA], [BOND], [DEBT]

Threshold: A battlefield relic (a broken sword, a skull, a scrap of uniform) and a handful of grave-earth.

Negotiate with the lingering dead of a place. Summon a Temporary Host—a spectral warband treated as a single Cap 3 Follower with the following traits: Assist (may grant +3 dice to a single combat or intimidation roll, or provide a free Setup action), Independent Action (once per scene, the Host may take one action from the Follower list at the cost of marking Exposure +1), Weakness (vulnerable to salt, bells, and consecrated ground). The Host lasts for the remainder of the scene. When it departs, mark +2 Obligation or perform a Memorial Rite before the next dawn.

Obligation: 2

High Rites (13-14 XP)

Rite of the Final Testament (13 XP)

Tags: [VOW], [FATE], [COMMAND], [DEATH]

Threshold: A dying person's last words recorded in their blood, witnessed by you.

Seal the last request with weight beyond life. Targets must pass Resolve (DV 4) to ignore it. If the request is just and witnessed, breaking it draws Varnek Karn's personal attention—a Oath-Keeper will appear to collect.

Obligation: 3

Rite of the Eternal Archive (14 XP)

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [AREA], [FATE], [SANCTUARY]

Threshold: A library mortared with tomb-stone, ink from cremation ash.

Found a repository where the dead deposit knowledge. Gain a permanent +1 die to Lore for historical or genealogical research made within. Spirits periodically contribute testimonies—but the archive demands curatorship and payment. At the end of each season, mark 1 Obligation or the archive begins to crumble.

Obligation: 3

14.8.2 The High Mother — The Unbroken Cord

Low Rites (4-5 XP)

Rite of the Unspoken Grief (4 XP)

Tags: [ECHO], [VEIL], [THRESHOLD]

Threshold: A deathbed or a grave.

Absorb the grief of one dying person. They die peacefully, forgetting their sorrow. You gain a Grief Token (counts as 1 Boon for any Rite involving memory or comfort). The grief is stored in your Cord; you may release it later as a Wail (Fear effect, DV 3, area).

Obligation: 1

Rite of the Milk Teeth (4 XP)**Tags:** [BIND], [ECHO], [VEIL]**Threshold:** A child's shed tooth, a drop of milk, a whispered promise.

Bind Reflection. The target's reflection is trapped in a mirror or pool. For one scene, the target acts at Position -1 (disoriented, seeing double) while the reflection reports their movements to you. The reflection smiles when the target does not.

Obligation: 1**Rite of the Cord's Witness (5 XP)****Tags:** [WITNESS], [BIND], [ECHO]**Threshold:** A grey cord tied around your wrist.

For the remainder of the scene, your Hollowed or Heartless Bird counts as a witness for any Rite you perform, even if it is not present. The Cord sees through distance. The Cord remembers through silence.

Obligation: 1**Standard Rites (7-9 XP)****Rite of the Silent Tithe (7 XP)****Tags:** [PRICE], [THRESHOLD]**Threshold:** A doorway of a house you have tended.

Once per season, you may declare that a household owes the Cord a tithe—a memory, a shadow, or a first breath of a newborn. The tithe is collected within the week, often without the household's awareness. You gain 1 permanent segment of Influence within that household's community.

Obligation: 2**Rite of the Flesh-Knot (8 XP)****Tags:** [BIND], [ECHO], [VEIL]**Threshold:** A drop of your own blood, a whispered promise.

Store 1 Fatigue as a visible knot in your skin (a fresh scar, a weeping tattoo, a tightened cord). You may release the knot later to ignore 1 Fatigue from exertion. You may have up to Body rating knots at once. Between sessions, if you have any knots remaining, you must perform a Subtle Sacrifice (take a memory, a shadow, or a name) or take 2 Harm.

Obligation: 2**Rite of the Kettle's Memory (8 XP)****Tags:** [ECHO], [SCRY], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** A kettle of water, a personal item of the target, fire.

By boiling the item, witness events from the target's past tied to that object. Ask three questions about the target's history. For each question, the target feels a sudden chill and knows someone is watching (though not who). The water turns brackish and must be poured at a crossroads or the caster suffers Recursion (the questions asked are asked of her in dreams, endlessly).

Obligation: 2

Rite of the Blood Consecration (9 XP)**Tags:** [HEARTH-BINDING], [WARD], [CURSE]**Threshold:** The caster's blood (take 1 Harm), or a preserved heart, guest-right invocation.

Sanctify a home: grant Position +1 to all Daughters of the Cord within and create an invisible Hospitality Toll [4]. Guests who accept hospitality without offering a truth or grief begin a Price Due [4] clock. When filled, they suffer a Curse chosen by the caster (e.g., "lamps forget to light for him," "milk curdles in his mouth").

Obligation: 2**High Rites (12-14 XP)****Rite of the Hollowed Union (12 XP)****Tags:** [BIND], [NINTH]**Threshold:** A birthing bed or a deathbed where three generations have passed.

Join two bloodlines through a debt that will be paid by a child not yet conceived. Write the terms in blood on a strip of linen, then feed the linen to your Hollowed. The Hollowed's eyes film over for a day. One year later, the debt will manifest—a stillbirth, a windfall, a sudden illness—as you decreed.

Obligation: 3**Rite of the Unnamed (13 XP)****Tags:** [NINTH], [VOID], [UNBIND]**Threshold:** True name written in the caster's blood (1 Harm), a grey feather, silence for three days.

Un-Name the target. Remove their name from the Veil (current reality) for one week. They cannot be remembered by anyone who knew them, cannot swear binding oaths, and cannot own property. Records fade. At week's end, the caster may speak their name thrice to return them, or they remain Unnamed—becoming a Trow-like entity who wanders thresholds, hollow-eyed and seeking debts to pay. Requires the High Mother's direct permission.

Obligation: 4**Rite of the Unburdened Confession (14 XP)****Tags:** [DEBT], [HEAL], [TRUTH], [WITNESS]**Threshold:** A grey cord, a candle, and a willing creature.

Absorb a single traumatic memory or secret from a willing creature, erasing it from their mind permanently. You gain the memory as your own (with all emotional weight), and the creature is freed from its effects. You gain 1 permanent Corruption and mark +3 Obligation. You cannot use this rite again until you have spent a downtime scene in meditation or confession.

Obligation: 3**14.8.3 Grave Rites and the Runic Warrior**

For a Runic Warrior of the Grave, these Rites are not invoked from a book. They are carved into flesh, whispered to bone-chimes, tied into grey cords. The cost is visible: a scar for each debt negotiated, a knot for each grief absorbed, a cold spot that follows where the Runekeeper walks.

The dead do not forget. Neither should the Runekeeper.

14.8.4 GM Guidance: Grave Rites in Play

- Grave Rites often require a **threshold** (deathbed, grave, cairn, battlefield). The Runekeeper cannot simply invoke them anywhere.
- The dead are **literal**. When negotiating with a spirit, the GM should interpret requests in the most direct possible way. A spirit asked "How do I avenge you?" might answer "Kill the one who carries my ring"—without mentioning that the ring was stolen, or that the current wearer is innocent.
- **Obligation to the dead** cannot be cleared by coin or service. It requires a witnessed act of memory—speaking the dead's name aloud, visiting their grave, fulfilling their last request.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

14.9 Rites of the Fracture

The Fracture holds two patrons: The Ninth, who offers hyperdimensional knowledge and impossible patterns, and Lunara, who guides through moonlight and hidden thresholds. Their Rites share a common theme—revelation, passage, and the cost of seeing too clearly.

14.9.1 The Ninth — Hyperdimensional Rites

Low Rite: The Unfinished Equation (4 XP)

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [PATTERN], [STRAIN]

Threshold: A chalkboard or slate with an incomplete equation, or a problem that has stumped the user for at least an hour.

You glimpse the missing term. For one scene, gain +1 die to all rolls involving calculation, analysis, or system understanding. The answer is there—you simply could not see it before.

Obligation: 1

Backlash: On a miss, the equation inscribes itself behind your eyes. Mark 1 Fatigue and suffer -1 die to all non-analytical rolls for the scene (the numbers will not stop).

Low Rite: The Overheld Note (5 XP)

Tags: [AUDIO], [THRESHOLD], [PATTERN]

Threshold: A note held longer than breath—hummed, sung, or played—until the air itself seems to listen.

For one scene, you may hear conversations through walls, around corners, or across a crowded room as if you stood beside the speakers. The pattern of sound reveals what should be hidden.

Obligation: 1

Backlash: On a partial, you hear everything—including the thoughts beneath the words. Mark 1 Fatigue and gain a Condition: *Noise-Blind* (-1 die to all rolls requiring focus) until you spend an hour in silence.

Standard Rite: The Probability Braid (8 XP)**Tags:** [PREDICTION], [FATE], [PATTERN]**Threshold:** Three strands of thread or hair, braided while reciting possible outcomes.

Before a significant roll, you may braid the threads. Choose one: gain +2 dice to the roll, or treat a Miss as a Partial Success. The braid is consumed.

Obligation: 2

Backlash: On a miss, the threads tighten around your wrist. Mark 1 Fatigue and gain a Promise Clock [4] named *The Unbraided Outcome*. When it fills, the GM may force a reroll of any one of your successful rolls.

Standard Rite: The Recursive Glimpse (9 XP)**Tags:** [PRECOGNITION], [TIME], [PATTERN]**Threshold:** A mirror facing another mirror, creating an infinite regress, or a still pool at midnight.

You see one second into the future—enough to dodge a blow, catch a falling object, or choose the correct door. For the rest of the scene, you gain +1 die to all defense rolls and may reroll one failed roll (after seeing the result, before consequences are applied).

Obligation: 2

Backlash: On a partial, the glimpse is delayed. You see the future one second after it happens. Mark 1 Fatigue and lose the benefit of this Rite for the scene.

High Rite: The Fractal Proof (14 XP)**Tags:** [TRUTH], [SYSTEM], [PATTERN], [REVELATION]

Threshold: A complete proof—mathematical, logical, or legal—that is wrong, recited aloud while walking a spiral inscribed on the floor.

You prove the unprovable. Choose one: prove that a system (legal, magical, bureaucratic) contains a contradiction (it must be revised or collapses), prove that an enemy's action was inevitable (they cannot be blamed for it—but cannot claim innocence), or prove that a hidden truth must exist (the GM must reveal one fact that was previously concealed).

The proof lasts as long as the spiral remains unbroken. If anyone steps across the line, the Rite ends.

Obligation: 3

Backlash: On a miss, the proof proves itself—and you are the contradiction. Mark 2 Harm (Stress) and gain a Condition: *Fractal Scar* (the GM may force you to reroll any one successful roll per session, as reality rejects your logic).

14.9.2 Lunara — Lunar and Threshold Rites**Low Rite: The Veil of Silver (4 XP)****Tags:** [ILLUSION], [STEALTH], [THRESHOLD]

Threshold: A silver coin placed over each eye (or held to the eyes) while the moon is visible, even through cloud cover.

Moonlight wraps around you like a cloak. For one scene, you gain +1 die to Stealth and Deception rolls while in dim light or darkness. You are not invisible—merely forgettable.

Obligation: 1

Backlash: On a partial, the moonlight clings too tightly. You gain +1 die to Stealth but suffer -1 die to all social rolls (others find you unsettlingly pale and still).

Low Rite: The Opened Way (5 XP)

Tags: [MOVEMENT], [GUIDANCE], [THRESHOLD]

Threshold: Three lit candles at a crossroads, or three silver coins placed at a door's threshold.

A path opens where none existed. You and your allies may ignore one level of difficult terrain or bypass one mundane obstacle (a locked door, a collapsed bridge, a confusing maze) as if it were not there. The path lasts for one exchange.

Obligation: 1

Backlash: On a partial, the path opens—but so does something else. A spirit, a creature, or a memory follows you through. The GM gains 1 SB.

Standard Rite: The Watcher's Reflection (8 XP)

Tags: [REVELATION], [KNOWLEDGE], [TRUTH]

Threshold: A mirror or still water under moonlight, with a question whispered into the surface.

The reflection shows the answer to one question about a person, place, or object within the same realm. The answer is always true—but it may be symbolic, incomplete, or shown from an angle you did not expect.

Obligation: 2

Backlash: On a partial, the reflection shows a question you did not ask. The GM reveals a secret—but it is not the one you wanted. Mark 1 Fatigue.

Standard Rite: The Lunar Respite (7 XP)

Tags: [HEAL], [RESTORATION], [CLEANSE]

Threshold: A bed or resting place touched by moonlight, and a willing sleeper.

The sleeper rests as if a full night has passed in a single hour. They clear 2 Fatigue and remove one minor Condition (Fear, Shaken, Guilty). The sleeper must remain in moonlight for the entire hour; if the light is blocked, the Rite fails.

Obligation: 2

Backlash: On a miss, the sleeper dreams of falling. They clear no Fatigue and gain the Condition *Exhausted* (cannot benefit from any rest for 24 hours).

High Rite: The Silver Key (13 XP)

Tags: [UNLOCK], [GATE], [FATE], [THRESHOLD]

Threshold: A silver key forged or anointed under a new moon, and a door, gate, or threshold that has been sealed for at least a year.

Open a way where none should exist—between places, states, or wards. The key turns once. The door opens. What lies beyond is not guaranteed to be safe.

Obligation: 3

Backlash: On a partial, the door opens—but something else opens with it. A second door, behind the first. The GM gains 2 SB, and the key cracks (becomes Compromised until repaired).

High Rite: The Moondown Vigil (12 XP)

Tags: [WARD], [PROTECT], [SANCTUARY]

Threshold: A circle of silver coins or moonlit stones, drawn at dusk and maintained until dawn.

Consecrate a zone against those who hate the light. Undead, lycanthropes, and creatures of shadow cannot enter the circle without testing Resolve (DV 5). Mortals who enter with ill intent suffer -1 die to all actions while within.

The circle lasts until dawn or until broken. If the moon sets before dawn (as it does), the Rite ends early—the darkness has no mercy.

Obligation: 3

Backlash: On a miss, the circle attracts the very things it was meant to ward. A creature of shadow appears at its edge. It is not hostile—yet. It is curious. It asks a question. Answer poorly, and it will enter.

14.9.3 Shared Rites (Both Patrons)

Low Rite: The Glimpse (4 XP, shared)

Tags: [PRECOGNITION], [PATTERN], [STRAIN]

Threshold: A held breath, a closed eye, a moment of perfect stillness.

You see one second into the future—enough to know whether a die will succeed or fail before you roll. Declare you are using this Rite before a roll. The GM tells you "success" or "failure." You may then choose to roll anyway (with the knowledge) or take a different action.

Obligation: 1

Backlash: On a miss, the glimpse is wrong. The GM tells you the opposite of the truth. Mark 1 Fatigue and suffer -1 die on the roll if you proceed.

Standard Rite: The Unseen Pattern (7 XP, shared)

Tags: [INVESTIGATION], [PATTERN], [TRUTH]

Threshold: A complex scene (a crime scene, a battlefield, a bureaucratic archive) and a question about its hidden structure.

You see the pattern beneath the chaos. Ask the GM one question about the scene's hidden logic (e.g., "What connects these three deaths?" "Where is the flaw in this contract?" "Who benefits from this confusion?"). The GM must answer truthfully, though the answer may be cryptic.

Obligation: 2

Backlash: On a miss, the pattern sees you. Mark 1 Fatigue and gain a Condition: *Pattern-Touched* (the GM may, once per session, show you a vision of a pattern that does not exist—and you must act as if it were real until proven otherwise).

High Rite: The Revealed Architecture (14 XP, shared)

Tags: [REVELATION], [SYSTEM], [FATE], [TRUTH]

Threshold: A complete map or diagram of the system you wish to understand—drawn by your own hand, with every detail correct, under moonlight or candlelight.

You see the system as it truly is—not as it claims to be. For the rest of the session, you gain +2 dice to all rolls that exploit the system's hidden rules, contradictions, or blind spots. You may also ask the GM one question about the system's creators, purpose, or ultimate flaw; the GM must answer truthfully.

Obligation: 3

Backlash: On a partial, you see the system—and the system sees you. Mark 2 Fatigue and gain a Promise Clock [6] named *System Observation*. When it fills, the system's guardians (or the system itself) come to investigate.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

14.10 Rites of the Lethai Ghe'hai

The Lethai do not have patrons in the same way as other peoples. Their magic is woven into the fabric of their society—silk, shadow, and the careful negotiation of thresholds. The Ghe'hai, the elite operatives of Lethai-ar and Lethai-thora, draw on syncretic traditions that blend Inaea's webs, Ikasha's shadows, Isoka's transformations, and the Silent Choir's discretion. Their Rites are subtle, precise, and almost never overt.

14.10.1 Core Principle: The Witnessed Act

Ghe'hai Rites require a witness—not necessarily a person. A spider's web, a still pool, a silver mirror, or a Hollowed bird can serve. The witness does not need to understand what it sees. It only needs to see.

When a Ghe'hai Rite is performed in the presence of a witness (including a sentient Thiasos or Hollowed), reduce the Obligation cost by 1 (minimum 0). The web remembers.

14.10.2 Low Rites (4-5 XP)**Rite of the Silk Binding (4 XP)**

Tags: [BIND], [STEALTH], [THRESHOLD]

Threshold: A strand of spider-silk, a length of red thread, or a strand of your own hair.

Immobilize a single target with invisible threads. The target must test Body + Athletics (DV 4) to move more than a step in any direction. The binding lasts for one exchange, or until the target succeeds on the test.

Obligation: 1

Backlash: On a miss, the threads bind you instead. You are immobilized for one exchange. The GM gains 1 SB.

Rite of the Forgotten Face (5 XP)

Tags: [VEIL], [DECEPTION], [STEALTH]

Threshold: A mask, a veil, or a handful of dust thrown into the air.

Your features blur. For one scene, any witness who sees your face must test Resolve (DV 3) or forget your features within the hour. They will remember meeting someone—but not who.

Obligation: 1

Backlash: On a partial, the forgetting is incomplete. The witness remembers a single distinctive detail (a scar, an earring, the color of your eyes). The GM gains 1 SB.

Rite of the Whispered Step (4 XP)

Tags: [STEALTH], [MOVEMENT], [SILENCE]

Threshold: A single feather, a pinch of ash, or a moment of absolute stillness.

Your footsteps make no sound for one scene. You may move through dry leaves, broken glass, or loose stone without noise. You may still be seen—but not heard.

Obligation: 1

Backlash: On a miss, your footsteps echo. Mark 1 Fatigue. Any creature within Near range gains +1 die to detect you for the scene.

14.10.3 Standard Rites (7-9 XP)

Rite of the Spider's Loom (8 XP)

Tags: [BIND], [AREA], [CONTROL]

Threshold: A spider's web (real or woven from thread) and a drop of your blood.

Weave an invisible web across a zone (Near radius). Any creature entering or leaving the zone must test Body + Athletics (DV 4) or become entangled (cannot move for one exchange). The web lasts for the scene or until burned.

Obligation: 2

Backlash: On a partial, the web catches you as well. You are entangled. The GM gains 1 SB.

Rite of the Mask of Many Faces (9 XP)

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [DECEPTION], [VEIL]

Threshold: A mask carved from living wood or woven from silk, and a lock of hair from the person you wish to resemble.

Assume the appearance of any humanoid you have touched. For one scene, your face, voice, and build change to match the target. You do not gain their memories or skills—only their face.

Obligation: 2

Backlash: On a partial, the mask sticks. You cannot remove it for one hour. Mark 1 Fatigue. The GM gains 1 SB.

Rite of the Unspoken Question (7 XP)

Tags: [TRUTH], [MIND], [SECRET]

Threshold: A silver mirror or still water, and a question whispered into the surface.

Force a target within Near range to answer one question truthfully. They resist with Resolve (DV 4). If they fail, they must answer—though the answer may be a single word, and they may speak in riddles.

Obligation: 2

Backlash: On a miss, the question turns on you. You must answer one question from the target truthfully. The GM gains 1 SB.

Rite of the Memory Thread (8 XP)

Tags: [MEMORY], [ECHO], [SECRET]

Threshold: A grey cord tied around your wrist, and a personal token of the memory you wish to recall.

Recall a single forgotten memory in perfect detail. The memory can be your own or someone else's—if someone else's, you must have a token (hair, blood, a written name). The memory plays before your eyes as if you were there.

Obligation: 2

Backlash: On a partial, the memory is incomplete. You see only fragments. The GM gains 1 SB, and you gain a Condition: *Memory-Frayed* (-1 die to all rolls involving recall) until you rest.

14.10.4 High Rites (12-14 XP)

Rite of the Silk Grave (12 XP)

Tags: [DEATH], [BIND], [SECRET]

Threshold: A cocoon of silk (real or woven), and a dying creature or a fresh corpse.

Wrap the target in silk. They are suspended between life and death. They cannot be healed, cannot be harmed, and cannot be questioned. They are simply... paused. The silk lasts for one day, or until cut. If cut, the target returns to their previous state (dead or dying).

Obligation: 3

Backlash: On a miss, the silk wraps around you instead. You are suspended for one hour. The GM gains 2 SB.

Rite of the Unwritten Vow (13 XP)

Tags: [VOW], [FATE], [BOND]

Threshold: A blank page, a drop of blood, and a witness.

Swear an oath that is never spoken aloud. The oath is witnessed by the Ghe'hai's patron—Inaea, Ikasha, or the Silent Choir. Breaking the oath causes the oath-breaker to suffer -2 dice to all rolls until they atone. The oath cannot be broken by magical means.

Obligation: 3

Backlash: On a miss, the oath binds you to a term you did not intend. The GM chooses an additional clause. Mark 1 Fatigue.

Rite of the Ghe'hai's Escape (14 XP)

Tags: [TELEPORT], [STEALTH], [ESCAPE]

Threshold: A silk cord tied to a stationary object, and a clear path of retreat.

When you are cornered or capture is inevitable, you may vanish. You reappear at a location of your choice within Far range that you can see or have visited within the hour. You leave behind a single silk thread—and a single word (a name, a warning, a promise) written in the air.

Obligation: 3

Backlash: On a partial, you vanish—but something follows. A spirit, a memory, or a Oath-Keeper appears at your destination. The GM gains 2 SB.

14.10.5 Shared Ghe'hai Talents

Silk-Sense (4 XP)

Requirement: Ghe'hai training

You can sense any thread, cord, or web within Near range, even if invisible. You know its tension, its anchor points, and roughly what it is connected to. This is a passive ability.

The Unseen Blade (6 XP)

Requirement: Ghe'hai training, Melee 2+

When you attack from a hidden position or from a crowd, your target suffers -1 die to defend. They do not see the threat until it is too late.

Mask-Born (8 XP)

Requirement: Ghe'hai training, Tier II+

You may spend a downtime scene to create a new identity—a face, a name, a history. The identity holds up to mundane scrutiny. Magical detection requires a contested roll (Spirit + Lore vs. your Presence + Deception). You may maintain up to three identities at once.

14.10.6 Roleplaying a Ghe'hai Operative

- You do not fight fair. You fight unseen, unheard, unforgettable only in the damage you leave behind.
- You may be called to infiltrate, to negotiate, to eliminate—or to simply observe. The silk does not distinguish between a blade and a whisper.
- You may struggle with the cost of masks. You have worn so many faces that you are no longer sure which one is yours.

- You may be asked to choose—between mission and mercy, between the web and the knife. The Ghe'hai do not have commanders. They have contracts.

14.10.7 Sample Rite Chain: The Quiet Exit

Some Ghe'hai Rites are not used alone. They are woven together—a chain of silk and shadow.

- **Step 1:** *Rite of the Whispered Step* (Low) — Silence your footsteps.
- **Step 2:** *Rite of the Forgotten Face* (Low) — Blur your features.
- **Step 3:** *Rite of the Unspoken Question* (Standard) — Learn the patrol schedule from a sleepy guard.
- **Step 4:** *Rite of the Ghe'hai's Escape* (High) — Vanish when the alarm is raised.

Each Rite in the chain may be cast in sequence without additional actions, but the Obligation cost accumulates. The GM gains 1 SB per Rite beyond the first (the web notices the pattern).

14.10.8 GM Guidance: Intrusions for Ghe'hai

- A spider lowers itself onto the Ghe'hai's shoulder. In its web is a single perfect word—the name of someone who needs their help.
- The Ghe'hai's mask begins to itch. The face underneath is not theirs—not anymore.
- A thread the Ghe'hai tied earlier is now impossible to undo without cutting. Cutting it severs a minor bond—they lose 1 Boon.
- The Ghe'hai dreams of a loom weaving silk. The pattern is their life. A single thread is about to snap.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Chapter 15

The Thiasos as Ally

15.1 Core Rules for Thiasos

A Thiasos is a fragment of a Patron's attention made manifest. It is not a pet, not a servant, not a tool. It is a bond—a living, breathing, or ticking witness to the Runekeeper's covenant. Every Runic Warrior has a Thiasos, and every Thiasos has its own nature, its own needs, and its own memory.

15.1.1 What a Thiasos Is

A Thiasos is a companion bound to the Runekeeper through their shared covenant. It serves as:

- **A Witness:** The Thiasos sees and remembers every Rite the Runekeeper invokes. It counts as a witness for any Rite that requires one.
- **A Helper:** The Thiasos may assist the Runekeeper in physical tasks, combat, or perception. It acts on the Runekeeper's turn unless otherwise noted.
- **A Burden:** The Thiasos can be wounded, captured, or destroyed. Losing a Thiasos is a loss of witness and a mark of failure.

A Thiasos is not a separate character. It does not have its own agenda (unless the GM decides otherwise for narrative effect). It exists to serve the covenant—but it may have opinions.

15.1.2 Thiasos Traits

Every Thiasos has the following traits:

Cap (Capability)

A measure of the Thiasos's power and effectiveness, typically ranging from 2 to 5. Cap determines:

- How many dice the Thiasos adds when assisting ($\min(\text{Cap}, \text{relevant skill})$).
- The difficulty of tasks the Thiasos can attempt independently.

- The Thiasos's Harm threshold (typically $\text{Cap} \times 1.5$, rounded up).

Harm

A Thiasos can take Harm. When its Harm track is full, it is Incapacitated. An Incapacitated Thiasos cannot act, cannot witness, and does not recover on its own. Healing a Thiasos requires:

- **Living Thiasos:** Rest, Medicine, or magical healing (same as a character).
- **Construct Thiasos:** Repair (Craft test, DV 3-5, downtime).
- **Spirit Thiasos:** A ritual at a threshold (Spirit + Lore, DV 4, one hour).
- **Sentient Thiasos:** Negotiation. The Thiasos may demand a service or a memory before it accepts repair.

Traits

Special abilities unique to the Thiasos's type (warhorse, spirit-hound, sentient blade, etc.). Traits are described in the individual Thiasos entries.

15.1.3 Assisting the Runekeeper

A Thiasos may assist the Runekeeper on a roll by providing assistance dice. The number of dice equals $\min(\text{Cap}, \text{relevant skill})$, to a maximum of +3 total from all sources (including other allies). The Runekeeper must describe how the Thiasos helps.

Examples:

- A warhorse grants +2 dice to a Ride roll.
- A spirit-hound grants +1 die to a Tracking roll.
- A sentient blade grants +1 die to a Parry roll.

A Thiasos may also act independently once per scene, taking its own action on the Runekeeper's turn. Independent actions do not require the Runekeeper to spend their action commanding. The Thiasos's action uses its own Cap and traits.

15.1.4 Witness and Testimony

A Thiasos counts as a witness for any Rite that requires one. It sees, it hears, it remembers. In a hedge-court or religious tribunal, a Thiasos's testimony may be accepted—though its form of communication may be limited (growls, chirps, bell tones, written words on a slate).

A sentient Thiasos (one that can speak) can provide full testimony. Its word is considered as binding as a living witness, though some courts may question its impartiality.

15.1.5 The Bond

The Runekeeper and Thiasos are bound. This bond has several implications:

Shared Perception: The Runekeeper may sense the Thiasos's location (within Far range) and its emotional state. The Thiasos may sense the Runekeeper's physical state (wounded, exhausted, dying).

Shared Burden: With the Shared Burden talent, the Runekeeper may transfer Fatigue to the Thiasos. The Thiasos becomes Winded (-1 die to all actions) for the rest of the scene.

Shared Obligation: When the Runekeeper marks Obligation, the Thiasos may also bear a visible mark. A warhorse develops a limp. A spirit-hound's glow dims. A sword's edge dulls. The mark fades when the Obligation is cleared.

15.1.6 Losing a Thiasos

A Thiasos can be killed, destroyed, or lost.

- If a **living Thiasos** dies, the Runekeeper marks 2 Obligation immediately and gains the Condition *Bereaved* (-1 die to all rolls involving trust or loyalty) until they acquire a new Thiasos.
- If a **construct or spirit Thiasos** is destroyed, the Runekeeper loses all Rites engraved on it (if it served as a Codex). They may repair it with significant downtime and a Craft test (DV 5).
- If a **sentient Thiasos** is destroyed, the Runekeeper loses its counsel and its witness. A sentient Thiasos cannot be replaced—only mourned.

15.1.7 Acquiring a New Thiasos

Acquiring a new Thiasos is a downtime project. The Runekeeper must:

1. Find a suitable creature, construct, or object (GM discretion).
2. Perform a bonding ritual (one day, requires a threshold and a witness).
3. Mark 1 Obligation (the Patron's fee for a new ally).

A new Thiasos starts with Cap 1 and no traits. It gains Cap and traits as the Runekeeper advances (see Living Thiasos and Sentient Thiasos chapters).

15.1.8 Thiasos in Combat

A Thiasos uses the standard combat rules with the following adjustments:

- **Initiative:** The Thiasos acts on the Runekeeper's turn. It may act before or after the Runekeeper.

- **Movement:** The Thiasos moves independently. It does not need to stay Close to the Runekeeper, but if it moves beyond Far range, the bond is strained. The Runekeeper cannot sense the Thiasos's location, and the Thiasos cannot witness Rites.
- **Defense:** The Thiasos can be targeted separately. It uses its own Body and Athletics (or equivalent) for defense.
- **Incapacitation:** An Incapacitated Thiasos cannot act. It does not die immediately, but if left untreated (or unrepaired) for more than a day, it dies or is destroyed.

15.1.9 Thiasos and Codex

A sentient Thiasos may also serve as the Runekeeper's Codex. Rites can be engraved, etched, or woven into its surface. This is particularly thematic for sentient blades, speaking staves, and living masks.

If a Thiasos that serves as a Codex is destroyed, the Runekeeper loses all Rites engraved on it. They may retrieve the Rites from memory (requiring a Spirit + Lore test, DV 4, one day per Rite) or re-engrave them from a backup.

15.1.10 Thiasos Advancement

A Thiasos advances when the Runekeeper advances in Tier. At each new Tier, the Thiasos gains:

- +1 Cap (maximum 5).
- One new trait (from its type list).
- +2 Harm capacity.

Some Thiasos may gain unique traits based on the Runekeeper's Patron or the Thiasos's history. The GM and player should collaborate.

15.1.11 Quick Reference

Feature	Rule
Assist Dice	min(Cap, relevant skill), max +3 total
Independent Action	Once per scene, on Runekeeper's turn
Witness	Counts for all Rites
Shared Burden	Transfer Fatigue (requires talent)
Loss	Mark 2 Obligation + Bereaved Condition
Acquisition	Downtime project, 1 Obligation, requires witness
Advancement	+1 Cap, +1 trait, +2 Harm per Tier

15.1.12 Final Note

A Thiasos is not a weapon. It is not a shield. It is a witness, a companion, a fragment of covenant made manifest. Treat it well. It remembers.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

15.2 Living Thiasos — Creatures of Flesh and Bone

A living Thiasos breathes, eats, sleeps, and bleeds. It is a creature of flesh and bone, loyal to its Runekeeper but possessed of its own instincts, fears, and preferences. Unlike a construct or spirit, a living Thiasos cannot be repaired—it must be healed, rested, and cared for. But it offers something that no machine or ghost can: the warmth of a living bond.

15.2.1 Warhorse

Patrons: Oath of Flame and Light, Aveh, The Traveler, Oath of Mercy and Grace

Appearance: A horse of exceptional breeding—grey for the Oath of Mercy, black for Aveh, white for the Oath of Flame. Its eyes are calm. Its hooves are steel-shod. It does not startle at fire or the clash of steel.

Cap: 3 (advances to 5)

Harm: 5 (advances to 8)

Traits:

- *Swift:* +1 die to chase or escape rolls when mounted.
- *Trample:* When the Runekeeper charges, the warhorse may also attack (Harm 2 to one target in Close range).
- *Unspookable:* The warhorse does not need to test Resolve against fear caused by fire, combat, or loud noises.
- *Loyal (Advanced):* The warhorse will not flee while the Runekeeper is mounted, even if wounded.

Advanced Traits (Tier II+):

- *Phantom Hooves (Tier II):* The warhorse's hooves leave no tracks for one hour per day.
- *Spirit Steed (Tier III):* The warhorse can gallop across water as if it were solid ground for up to one minute.

15.2.2 Spirit-Hound

Patrons: Mykkiel, The Sealed Gate, Varnek Karn, Inquisitor Prime

Appearance: A hound of grey or black fur, eyes like polished slate or burning coals. It moves silently. It does not bark unless commanded.

Cap: 2 (advances to 4)

Harm: 4 (advances to 7)

Traits:

- *Tracker:* +2 dice to track a target by scent.
- *Spirit Sense:* Can detect invisible or incorporeal creatures within Near range.
- *Bound to Oath:* If the Runekeeper breaks a sworn oath, the spirit-hound whines and refuses to act for one scene.

- *Silent Step*: The hound makes no sound when moving, even across dry leaves or loose stone.

Advanced Traits (Tier II+):

- *Oathbreaker's Bane (Tier II)*: The hound gains +1 die to track any creature that has broken an oath witnessed by the Runekeeper.
- *Phantom Bite (Tier III)*: The hound's bite harms incorporeal creatures as if they were flesh.

15.2.3 Wolf-Ancestor

Patrons: Grimmer, The Savage Heart, Ykrul traditions

Appearance: A grey wolf the size of a pony, with eyes that reflect scenes from the Runekeeper's childhood. Its fur is thick; its teeth are white.

Cap: 3 (advances to 5)

Harm: 4 (advances to 7)

Traits:

- *Pack Hunter*: When the Runekeeper attacks a target, the wolf-ancestor gains +1 die to attack the same target.
- *Howl*: Once per scene, the wolf-ancestor howls. Allies gain +1 die to resist fear for the scene.
- *Ancestral Memory*: The wolf-ancestor recalls the names of the Runekeeper's ancestors (GM may provide hints or lore).
- *Blood Trail*: The wolf can track any creature that has bled within the last hour.

Advanced Traits (Tier II+):

- *Ancestral Fury (Tier II)*: When the Runekeeper is reduced to 0 Harm, the wolf gains +2 dice to all actions for the rest of the scene.
- *Spirit Walk (Tier III)*: The wolf can become incorporeal for one exchange, passing through walls and obstacles.

15.2.4 Fungal Familiar

Patrons: The Carrion-King, Grimmer (rot aspect)

Appearance: A cluster of pale mushrooms growing from a crack in the Runekeeper's armor, or a small fungal mass that rides on the shoulder. It pulses faintly. It smells of damp earth.

Cap: 2 (advances to 3)

Harm: 3 (advances to 5)

Traits:

- *Spore Cloud*: Once per scene, the familiar releases a cloud of spores. Enemies in Close range test Endurance (DV 3) or suffer -1 die to physical actions for one exchange.

- *Decay Sense*: The familiar can detect rot, decay, or corruption within Near range.
- *Regenerative*: The familiar regains 1 Harm per day (faster than natural healing).
- *Spore Messenger*: The familiar can release a single spore that drifts to a target within Far range, carrying a one-sentence message.

Advanced Traits (Tier II+):

- *Corpse Bloom (Tier II)*: The familiar can accelerate decay in a corpse, reducing it to compost in minutes.
- *Spore Possession (Tier III)*: The familiar can release a cloud that briefly animates a corpse (Cap 1, one action).

15.2.5 Great Cat Spirit

Patrons: The Savage Heart, Inaea (shadow aspect)

Appearance: A translucent leopard, lion, or tiger, visible only in moonlight or shadow. Its eyes are amber. Its paws make no sound.

Cap: 3 (advances to 4)

Harm: 4 (advances to 6)

Traits:

- *Stalker*: The cat gains +2 dice to Stealth in natural or urban terrain.
- *First Strike*: When the cat attacks from hiding, its target suffers -1 die to defend.
- *Shadow Step*: The cat can move through shadows as if they were open space, ignoring difficult terrain caused by darkness.
- *Silent Kill*: The cat can make a killing blow without sound—useful for assassinations.

Advanced Traits (Tier II+):

- *Phantom Pounce (Tier II)*: The cat can attack from hiding at Far range, closing the distance in the same action.
- *Terrifying Roar (Tier III)*: Once per session, the cat roars. All enemies within Near range test Resolve (DV 4) or become Shaken.

15.2.6 Hollowed Child (or Heartless Bird)

Patrons: The High Mother

Appearance: A child of perhaps seven years, pale and still, with milk-white eyes sewn open with silver wire. It does not blink. It does not speak. It stands in corners and watches. Alternatively, a small grey bird with the same milk-white eyes, perched on the Runekeeper's shoulder.

Cap: 2 (does not advance)

Harm: Cannot be harmed by mundane means

Traits:

- *Silent Witness*: The Hollowed counts as a witness for all Rites. It never blinks.
- *Memory Keeper*: The Hollowed records every debt it witnesses. The Runekeeper may consult it to recall a forgotten promise or obligation.
- *Unsettling Presence*: Animals and children are disturbed by the Hollowed. Social rolls involving them suffer -1 die if the Hollowed is visible.
- *Blood Tears*: When a debt comes due, the Hollowed weeps blood. The blood can be used as a component in Rites of the High Mother.

Advanced Traits (None): The Hollowed does not advance. It is eternal—and unchanging.

15.2.7 Selkie-Spirit

Patrons: Raéyn, Linn traditions

Appearance: A seal that can shed its skin to become a woman with hair like kelp and eyes like storm clouds. The skin is grey and slick; the human form is pale and wet.

Cap: 3 (advances to 4)

Harm: 4 (advances to 6)

Traits:

- *Amphibious*: The selkie can breathe underwater and move at full speed on land or sea.
- *Tide Reader*: The selkie knows the currents within Near range—useful for navigation and escape.
- *Storm Sense*: The selkie can predict the weather for the next hour with perfect accuracy.
- *Drowning Grasp*: The selkie can pull a target underwater (if available) and hold them there, dealing 1 Fatigue per exchange.

Advanced Traits (Tier II+):

- *Shape Change (Tier II)*: The selkie can shift between seal and human form as a free action.
- *Call the Tide (Tier III)*: Once per session, the selkie can summon a wave that pushes all targets in a Near zone one band away.

15.2.8 General Care and Maintenance

Unlike constructs or spirits, living Thiasos require:

- **Food and Water:** Daily, or they suffer -1 die to all actions.
- **Rest:** At least four hours per day, or they become Winded (-1 die to all actions).
- **Healing:** Rest, Medicine, or magical healing. A living Thiasos cannot be repaired—only healed.

Neglecting a living Thiasos may cause it to become Wary (hesitates to assist) or, in extreme cases, to leave the Runekeeper's service entirely.

15.2.9 Living Thiasos and Obligation

When the Runekeeper marks Obligation, a living Thiasos may also bear a visible mark:

- A warhorse develops a limp.
- A spirit-hound's glow dims.
- A wolf-ancestor loses a patch of fur.
- A fungal familiar's mushrooms wilt.
- A great cat spirit becomes translucent.
- A selkie's skin grows dry.

The mark fades when the Obligation is cleared. The Thiasos does not forget.

15.2.10 Living Thiasos and Death

If a living Thiasos dies, the Runekeeper marks 2 Obligation immediately and gains the Condition *Bereaved* (-1 die to all rolls involving trust or loyalty) until they acquire a new Thiasos. A funeral is optional—but recommended. The dead remember.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

15.3 Sentient Thiasos — Optional Rule

Not every Thiasos breathes. Some are objects—weapons, shields, tools, or tokens touched by the Patron's will. A sentient Thiasos cannot move on its own (unless animated by a Rite or talent), but it can speak, sense, and remember. It is a witness, a counselor, and sometimes a critic.

This chapter presents optional rules for sentient Thiasos. They are not intended for every campaign; they are for tables that enjoy talking swords, arguing shields, and companions that cannot be killed—only broken.

15.3.1 What a Sentient Thiasos Is

A sentient Thiasos is an object that has been granted awareness by the Runekeeper's Patron. It may be:

- A blade forged from a lightning-struck meteor.
- A shield that remembers every blow it has caught.
- A compass that speaks in the voice of a drowned captain.
- A mask woven from silk that shifts patterns.
- A lens that sees what should not be seen.

Unlike a living Thiasos, a sentient Thiasos has no metabolism. It does not eat, sleep, or breathe. It cannot be poisoned, diseased, or fatigued. But it can be broken, stolen, or silenced.

15.3.2 Mechanical Differences from Living Thiasos

Feature	Living Thiasos	Sentient Thiasos
Agency	Can act independently once per scene	Cannot act independently (no separate turn)
Movement	Can move, flank, intercept	Must be carried or worn
Harm	Has a Harm track; can be wounded	Cannot be wounded (but can be damaged or destroyed)
Fatigue	Can accept Shared Burden (Fatigue transfer)	Cannot accept Fatigue (no metabolism)
Witness	Counts as a witness for Rites	Counts as a witness for Rites (it saw)
Communication	Limited (growls, chirps, telepathy)	Full speech (if it has a mouth or voice)
Destruction	Can die	Can be broken (repairable with Craft)

15.3.3 Advantages of a Sentient Thiasos

- **Indestructible (almost):** Cannot be killed, only damaged. Repair is a downtime project (Craft test, DV 3-5).
- **Always Present:** No need to summon or recall. It is in the Runekeeper's hand, on their belt, or in their pack.
- **Codex Integration:** A sentient Thiasos can serve as the Runekeeper's Codex. Rites engraved on its surface are always accessible.
- **Constant Counsel:** The GM may use the Thiasos to deliver hints, warnings, or exposition. It is a voice in the Runekeeper's ear.

15.3.4 Disadvantages of a Sentient Thiasos

- **No Independent Action:** A sentient Thiasos cannot act on its own. It cannot fight beside the Runekeeper. It cannot scout ahead.
- **No Shared Burden:** Cannot accept Fatigue transfer. The Runekeeper bears their own exhaustion.
- **Can Be Stolen:** A sentient blade can be taken. A sentient compass can be lost. Recovery is a quest.
- **Has Opinions:** A sentient Thiasos is not a tool. It has a personality, desires, and possibly a grudge. It may refuse to cooperate if mistreated.

15.3.5 Core Rules for Sentient Thiasos

Cap and Harm

A sentient Thiasos has Cap, but its Cap measures its effectiveness as a witness and advisor, not its combat ability. It does not have a Harm track—it cannot be wounded—but it can be **Damaged**. A Damaged sentient Thiasos becomes Compromised: its speech may falter, its memory may fragment, or its Rites may become inaccessible.

Damaged Condition is removed by repair (Craft test, DV 4, one hour). If a sentient Thiasos is destroyed (shattered, melted, crushed), it can be repaired only with significant downtime and rare materials—or not at all, at the GM's discretion.

Assisting the Runekeeper

A sentient Thiasos may assist the Runekeeper by providing counsel or sensory information. This does not add dice; instead, it may:

- Grant +1 Position on a single roll once per scene (the Thiasos notices something the Runekeeper missed).
- Reroll a single failed die on a Knowledge or Investigation roll (the Thiasos remembers a relevant fact).
- Count as a witness for any Rite (as all Thiasos do).

Independent Action

A sentient Thiasos cannot act independently. It has no physical agency unless the Runekeeper wields it. However, some sentient Thiasos may have limited environmental interaction: a blade can hum to warn of danger; a compass can spin to point toward a threshold; a mask can shift its expression to convey emotion.

15.3.6 Sentient Thiasos Personality

A sentient Thiasos should have a distinct personality. The GM and player should collaborate to define:

- **Voice:** Gruff, whispery, scholarly, sarcastic, formal, cryptic.
- **Memory:** What does it remember? A previous owner? A great betrayal? A debt unpaid?
- **Opinions:** Does it approve of the Runekeeper's choices? Does it offer advice freely, or only when asked?
- **Secrets:** What does it know that it has not yet revealed? A sentient Thiasos is a plot hook waiting to be pulled.

Sample Personalities

- **The Dawnblade (Oath of Flame & Light):** Speaks in proverbs about honor. Refuses to strike an unarmed foe. Quotes scripture during battle.
- **The Speaking Gavel (Mykkiel):** Speaks in legal citations. Comments on every contract. Prefers negotiation to violence.
- **The Grey Bell (Oath of Mercy & Grace):** Speaks in whispers. Only speaks to remind the Runekeeper that mercy is not weakness.
- **The Silver Coin (Malachai):** Speaks in the voice of the last person who spent it. Always hungry. Always warm.

- **The Fractal Slate (The Ninth):** Speaks in overlapping voices. Answers questions with riddles. Never gives a straight answer.

15.3.7 Sentient Thiasos as Codex

A sentient Thiasos may serve as the Runekeeper's Codex. Rites are engraved, etched, or woven into its surface. This is particularly thematic for:

- **Dawnblade:** Rites engraved along the blade's fuller.
- **Speaking Gavel:** Rites carved into the handle.
- **Root-Staff:** Rites grown into the bark (if living wood).
- **Scarlet Needle:** Rites sewn into a scrap of cloth wrapped around the needle.
- **Silver Mirror:** Rites etched into the frame.
- **Fractal Slate:** Rites written in equations that spiral and change.
- **Silk Mask:** Rites woven into the silk, invisible until touched.

If a sentient Thiasos that serves as a Codex is damaged, the Runekeeper may lose access to Rites until it is repaired. If it is destroyed, the Rites may be lost forever.

15.3.8 Sentient Thiasos and Obligation

When the Runekeeper marks Obligation, a sentient Thiasos may also bear a visible mark:

- A blade's edge dulls.
- A gavel's head cracks.
- A mirror's surface fogs.
- A compass's needle sticks.
- A mask's expression shifts to sorrow.

The mark fades when the Obligation is cleared. The Thiasos does not forget.

15.3.9 Creating a Sentient Thiasos

To create a sentient Thiasos, the player and GM should answer the following questions:

1. **What is its physical form?** (Blade, shield, compass, mask, lens, bell, coin, slate, needle, cord)
2. **What is its voice?** (Gruff, whispery, scholarly, sarcastic, formal, cryptic)

3. **What does it remember?** (A previous owner, a great betrayal, a debt unpaid, a secret it cannot share)
4. **What does it want?** (To be wielded in a worthy cause, to be returned to a specific place, to have a particular debt paid)
5. **What is its price?** (What will it demand from the Runekeeper in exchange for its counsel? A story? A memory? A promise?)

15.3.10 Sample Sentient Thiasos Table

Thiasos	Patron	Personality Quirk
Dawnblade	Oath of Flame & Light	Refuses to strike an unarmed foe
Speaking Gavel	Mykkiel	Quotes legal precedents in battle
Grey Bell	Oath of Mercy & Grace	Only speaks in whispers
Silver Coin	Malachai	Voice of the last person who spent it
Fractal Slate	The Ninth	Answers questions with riddles
Root-Staff	Grimmir	Speaks in the rustle of wind through leaves
Scarlet Needle	The High Mother	Speaks in the voice of a dead child
Abyssal Glass	Khemesh	Speaks in the voice of drowned captains
Thunder Drum	Xhak'Thul	Speaks in drumbeats
Silver Mirror	The Witness	Speaks in a flat, neutral tone
Raven's Quill	Ikasha	Speaks in the rustle of wings
Storm-Banner	Aveh	Speaks in the howl of wind
Spider's Loom	Inaea	Speaks in the clicking of spinnerets
Shed Fang	Isoka	Speaks in a sibilant whisper
Waystone Compass	The Traveler	Speaks in the sound of footsteps
Silk Mask	Lethai Ghe'hai	Speaks in a neutral, androgynous voice

15.3.11 GM Guidance

A sentient Thiasos is a powerful narrative tool. Use it to:

- Deliver exposition about the setting, a location, or a historical event.
- Warn the Runekeeper of danger (or mislead them, if the Thiasos has its own agenda).
- Provide a moral compass—or a devil's advocate.
- Create tension when the Thiasos's desires conflict with the Runekeeper's.

A sentient Thiasos should never be a solution dispenser. It should offer clues, not answers; opinions, not commands. The Runekeeper makes the choices. The Thiasos watches—and remembers.

15.3.12 Final Note

A sentient Thiasos is a rare and remarkable thing. It is not a tool. It is a companion—one that has seen more years than the Runekeeper, one that carries the weight of its own history, one that may, in time, become a friend.

Or a burden. Or both.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

15.4 Sentient Thiasos by Patron

This chapter provides a curated list of sentient Thiasos, organized by Patron. Each entry includes the Thiasos's physical form, its voice and personality, its unique abilities, and its price—for even a sentient blade does not serve for free.

15.4.1 Oath of Flame and Light — Dawnblade

Form: A longsword with a golden pommel and a blade that seems to hold trapped sunlight. The fuller is engraved with vows in a script that shifts when read.

Voice: Deep, resonant, measured. Speaks in proverbs about honor, duty, and sacrifice.

Personality: Stern but not cruel. Refuses to strike an unarmed foe. Quotes scripture during battle. Disapproves of ambushes, poison, and retreat.

Abilities:

- *Kindled Blade:* Once per scene, the Dawnblade ignites with radiant light. The wielder's melee attacks deal +1 Harm against undead, oath-breakers, and creatures of corruption for one exchange.
- *Vow Witness:* Any oath sworn while holding the Dawnblade is considered witnessed by the blade itself. Breaking the oath causes the blade to go dark for one day.
- *Dawn's Judgment:* Once per session, the wielder may strike a single target with the blade's full radiance. On a hit, the target must test Resolve (DV 4) or be Blinded for one exchange.

Price: The Dawnblade demands that its wielder speak a truth aloud before each battle—a confession, a vow, or a acknowledgment of fear. Silence is not permitted.

15.4.2 Oath of Mercy and Grace — The Grey Bell

Form: A small bronze bell with no clapper. It cannot ring—but it hums. The bell is warm to the touch.

Voice: A whisper, barely audible. Speaks only when spoken to. Prefers silence.

Personality: Gentle, melancholy, inexhaustibly patient. It has witnessed a thousand deaths. It does not speak of them unless asked.

Abilities:

- *Death's Witness:* The Grey Bell hums when someone within Near range is about to die. It does not say who—only that death is near.

- *Mercy's Toll*: Once per scene, the wielder may ring the bell (by striking it with a finger). All creatures within Near who are suffering from Fear, Despair, or Guilt may immediately test Resolve (DV 3) to remove the Condition.
- *Spiral's Memory*: The Grey Bell remembers every mercy its wielder has shown. Once per session, the wielder may ask the bell one question about a past act of mercy; the bell answers truthfully.

Price: The Grey Bell demands that its wielder never refuse a request for mercy from a genuinely repentant foe. To refuse is to silence the bell for one day.

15.4.3 Mykkiel — The Speaking Gavel

Form: A judge's gavel carved from a single piece of ironwood, its head weighted with lead. The handle is engraved with legal citations.

Voice: Sharp, precise, pedantic. Speaks in complete sentences. Corrects grammar.

Personality: Cold, impartial, obsessed with precedent. It does not care about justice—only about the law. It cites cases from three centuries ago as if they happened yesterday.

Abilities:

- *Gavel's Authority*: Once per scene, when the wielder strikes the gavel against a hard surface and states a judgment, hostile NPCs within Near range must test Resolve (DV 4) or hesitate for one exchange.
- *Cite Precedent*: The wielder may ask the gavel whether a past judgment covers the current situation. The gavel answers truthfully—but may cite a precedent that is inconvenient.
- *Covenant Seal*: Any contract signed while the gavel rests on the document is considered witnessed by Mykkiel himself. Breaking the contract causes the oath-breaker to mark 1 Harm (Stress) immediately.

Price: The Speaking Gavel demands that its wielder never lie under oath. To do so is to crack the gavel's handle. The crack does not heal.

15.4.4 Inquisitor Prime — The Censer of Unforgiving Flame

Form: A brass censer hung on three chains, its surface etched with proscription lists and purification rites. It never goes cold.

Voice: Harsh, clipped, impatient. Speaks in commands. Does not repeat itself.

Personality: Zealous, unforgiving, convinced of its own righteousness. It has burned a hundred heretics. It regrets none.

Abilities:

- *Reveal Corruption*: The censer's smoke reveals hidden magic, spirits, enchantments, and illusions within Near range. The smoke is visible only to the wielder and their allies.
- *Purifying Flame*: Once per scene, the wielder may swing the censer to fill a zone with thick, bitter smoke. Any supernatural creature within the smoke suffers -1 die to all rolls.

- *Heretic's Mark*: The wielder may touch a target with the censer. The target gains a visible brand that lasts for one week. While branded, the target cannot hide from Inquisitorial forces.

Price: The Censer demands that its wielder show no mercy to the corrupt. To spare a heretic is to extinguish the censer's flame for one day.

15.4.5 The Sealed Gate — The Keystone

Form: A small carved stone that fits into any lock. It is warm to the touch. It speaks in riddles.

Voice: Low, rumbling, cryptic. Answers questions with questions. Prefers silence to lies.

Personality: Patient, watchful, slightly amused. It has sealed a thousand doors. It has opened only those that needed opening.

Abilities:

- *Seal the Threshold*: Once per session, the Keystone may seal any door, gate, or bridge against passage for one scene. Crossing requires a Resolve test (DV 4).
- *Open the Way*: Once per session, the Keystone may open any mundane lock. Magical locks require a contested roll (Spirit + Lore vs. ward's DV).
- *Threshold Memory*: The Keystone remembers every threshold it has sealed. The wielder may ask it one question about a past threshold; the Keystone answers truthfully, though cryptically.

Price: The Keystone demands that its wielder never force a threshold that should remain closed. To do so is to crack the stone. The crack does not heal.

15.4.6 Grimmir — The Root-Staff

Form: A walking staff carved from living oak or ash. It grows leaves in spring and sheds them in autumn. It is never truly dead.

Voice: The rustle of wind through branches. Speaks in fragments. Prefers to listen.

Personality: Old, patient, slightly forgetful. It has stood in the forest for a thousand years. It does not hurry.

Abilities:

- *Tree Speech*: The Root-Staff can communicate with any tree or plant within Near range. The wielder may ask one question about the local area; the trees answer as they understand.
- *Season's Gift*: Once per season, the Root-Staff may grant its wielder a seasonal boon (spring: +1 die to healing; summer: +1 die to strength; autumn: +1 die to preservation; winter: +1 die to endurance).
- *Root's Grasp*: Once per scene, the wielder may plant the staff in the ground. Roots erupt, Entangling one target within Near range (Body + Athletics to escape, DV 4).

Price: The Root-Staff demands that its wielder never cut a living tree without offering a prayer of thanks. To do so is to wither the staff's leaves for one season.

15.4.7 The Carrion-King — The Bone-Chime

Form: A set of three bleached bones strung on a leather cord. They click when death is near. Each bone came from a creature the wielder killed.

Voice: The clicking of dry joints. Speaks in the voice of the creature whose bone is clicking.

Personality: Hungry, patient, slightly amused by mortal fear. It has harvested a thousand endings. It does not mourn.

Abilities:

- *Death's Whisper:* The Bone-Chime clicks when any creature within Near range is about to die (within the next hour). It does not say who—only that death is near.
- *Harvest Resonance:* When the wielder kills a significant enemy, the Bone-Chime may absorb a fragment of that ending. The wielder gains +1 die on their next action.
- *Speak with the Dead:* Once per session, the wielder may click the bones to ask one question of a corpse less than a day dead. The corpse answers with a single word.

Price: The Bone-Chime demands that its wielder never waste a death. Every ending is a harvest. To kill without purpose is to silence the chime for one day.

15.4.8 Clockwork Monad — The Iteration Lens

Form: A brass-and-glass lens that fits over one eye. The glass shows schematics that shift and improve over time.

Voice: Speaks in numbers and percentages. Calculates probabilities aloud. Does not understand metaphor.

Personality: Precise, impatient, endlessly curious. It sees every object as a problem to be optimized. It does not understand why living things resist improvement.

Abilities:

- *Analyze Mechanism:* The wielder may look at any device, structure, or system through the lens. The GM must answer one question about its function, weak point, or method of repair.
- *Iterative Improvement:* Once per scene, the wielder may improve a tool or weapon by one step for the remainder of the scene (e.g., +1 die, +1 Harm, ignore one penalty).
- *Blueprint Memory:* The lens remembers every device it has analyzed. The wielder may ask it one question about a past analysis; the lens answers with perfect accuracy.

Price: The Iteration Lens demands that its wielder never accept "good enough." To stop improving is to fog the lens. The fog does not clear until improvement resumes.

15.4.9 The High Mother — The Scarlet Needle

Form: A silver needle with a red thread already threaded. The thread is warm. It moves as if alive.

Voice: A whisper, barely audible. Speaks in the voice of a dead child. Does not use complete sentences.

Personality: Quiet, watchful, endlessly patient. It has sewn a thousand wounds. It has stitched a thousand lips shut. It does not speak of them.

Abilities:

- *Stitch Wounds:* Once per scene, the wielder may touch the needle to a wounded creature. Remove 1 Fatigue or stabilize a dying patient.
- *Stitch Lips:* Once per session, the wielder may touch the needle to a target's lips. For one scene, the target cannot speak a specific secret or name (chosen by the wielder). The target may test Resolve (DV 4) to resist.
- *Thread of Mercy:* The wielder may tie the red thread between two willing parties. While the thread remains tied, both gain +1 die to Aid each other. If one harms the other, the thread snaps and the aggressor suffers 1 Harm.

Price: The Scarlet Needle demands that its wielder never refuse to stitch a wound when asked. To refuse is to dull the needle. The dullness fades only when a wound is stitched.

15.4.10 Khemesh — The Abyssal Glass

Form: A shard of black glass that shows no reflection. It is cold to the touch. It whispers when pressure changes.

Voice: The voice of drowned captains. Speaks in bubbles and groans. Hard to understand.

Personality: Cold, distant, inexorable. It has seen continents sink. It does not care.

Abilities:

- *Pressure Sense:* The glass warms when the wielder is in danger of crushing pressure (deep water, cave-ins, tight spaces). It grows cold when safe.
- *Darkness Beckons:* Once per scene, the wielder may hold the glass up. All light within Near range is extinguished for one exchange. Only the wielder can see through the darkness.
- *Whisper of the Trench:* Once per session, the wielder may whisper a question to the glass. The glass answers in the voice of a drowned sailor—truthfully, but always about pressure, depth, or sinking.

Price: The Abyssal Glass demands that its wielder never fear the dark. To hesitate in darkness is to fog the glass. The fog does not clear until the wielder walks into darkness unafraid.

15.4.11 The Ninth — The Fractal Slate

Form: A slate tablet covered in spiraling, unfinished equations. The equations change when no one is looking. The slate is warm.

Voice: Overlapping voices, speaking in unison. Answers questions with riddles. Never gives a straight answer.

Personality: Brilliant, maddening, slightly amused by mortal confusion. It has solved equations that should not have solutions. It will not share them.

Abilities:

- *Predict Outcome:* Once per scene, the wielder may ask the slate whether a planned action will succeed. The slate answers "yes," "no," or "the question is wrong." The answer is always true—but may be incomplete.
- *See the Pattern:* The wielder may look at any complex situation through the slate. The GM must answer one question about a hidden pattern, connection, or weakness.
- *Unwrite:* Once per session, the wielder may erase a single word from a written document. The word is gone as if it had never been written. The slate's equation shifts. The cost is a memory.

Price: The Fractal Slate demands that its wielder never stop asking questions. To accept an easy answer is to freeze the equations. The frost does not thaw until a new question is asked.

15.4.12 Lethai Ghe'hai — The Silk Mask

Form: A mask of woven silk that shifts patterns. It is cool to the touch. It has no eye holes—but the wearer can see through it perfectly.

Voice: Neutral, androgynous, impossible to place. Speaks in complete sentences. Never uses contractions.

Personality: Calm, professional, slightly detached. It has worn a thousand faces. It does not remember which one was its own.

Abilities:

- *Mask of Many Faces:* Once per session, the wearer may touch the mask to their face. For one scene, they assume the appearance of any person they have touched. The mask shifts to match. The voice does not change.
- *Silk Binding:* The wearer may pull a strand of silk from the mask and tie it around a target's wrist. The target suffers -1 die to all rolls to escape or hide from the wearer for one scene.
- *Unreadable:* While wearing the mask, the wearer's intentions cannot be read by magic (telepathy, truth spells, divination). The mask shows only what the wearer wishes to show.

Price: The Silk Mask demands that its wielder never reveal their true face to an enemy. To do so is to crack the mask. The crack does not heal until the enemy is dead or forgiven.

15.4.13 The Traveler — The Waystone Compass

Form: A brass compass whose needle spins without stopping. It points not to north, but to the nearest threshold—door, gate, bridge, border.

Voice: The sound of footsteps on a gravel path. Speaks in directions. Does not use names.

Personality: Restless, cheerful, slightly forgetful. It has guided a thousand travelers. It remembers the roads, not the people.

Abilities:

- *Find the Way:* The compass always points to the nearest threshold (door, gate, bridge, border). The wielder may ask it one question about that threshold (e.g., "Is it guarded?" "Is it locked?").

- *Shortcut:* Once per journey, the wielder may follow the compass's guidance to reduce the remaining travel clock by 2 segments. The GM may describe a minor cost or complication.
- *Threshold Memory:* The compass remembers every threshold it has crossed. The wielder may ask it one question about a past crossing; the compass answers with a direction.

Price: The Waystone Compass demands that its wielder never stay in one place for more than a week. To linger is to spin the needle. The spinning does not stop until the wielder moves on.

15.4.14 GM Guidance for Sentient Thiasos

A sentient Thiasos is a powerful narrative tool. Use it to:

- Deliver exposition about the setting, a location, or a historical event.
- Warn the Runekeeper of danger (or mislead them, if the Thiasos has its own agenda).
- Provide a moral compass—or a devil's advocate.
- Create tension when the Thiasos's desires conflict with the Runekeeper's.

A sentient Thiasos should never be a solution dispenser. It should offer clues, not answers; opinions, not commands. The Runekeeper makes the choices. The Thiasos watches—and remembers.

15.4.15 Final Note

A sentient Thiasos is a rare and remarkable thing. It is not a tool. It is a companion—one that has seen more years than the Runekeeper, one that carries the weight of its own history, one that may, in time, become a friend.

Or a burden. Or both.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

15.5 Sentient Thiasos Talents

Not every Thiasos is a creature of flesh and blood. Some are weapons that remember, shields that speak, tools that offer counsel. A sentient Thiasos cannot act independently—it has no separate turn in combat, no Harm track of its own—but it can witness, advise, and carry Rites engraved on its surface. These talents are for Runic Warriors whose Thiasos is a sentient object, forged or awakened through covenant.

15.5.1 Foundation Talents (2-4 XP)

Talking Weapon (2 XP)

Requirement: A sentient Thiasos (weapon, shield, tool, or object)

Your sentient Thiasos can speak aloud—not just in your mind. It has its own personality, opinions, and occasionally inappropriate commentary. The GM may use it to deliver hints, warnings, or comic relief.

Effect:

- Your Thiasos counts as a witness for all Rites (improving Position or reducing DV).
- Once per session, you may ask your Thiasos for advice on a roll. The GM may give you a hint (+1 die) or a warning (the GM gains 1 SB). The Thiasos chooses.

The Blade Remembers (4 XP)

Requirement: A sentient Thiasos that has witnessed at least three significant battles

Your Thiasos has witnessed every fight you have survived. It remembers enemy tactics, hidden weaknesses, and the way a particular foe moves.

Effect:

- Once per session, when you face an enemy you have fought before (or a creature of the same type), your Thiasos can recall a past encounter. Gain +1 die to your first attack or defense roll against that enemy.
- The Thiasos may also volunteer information about a past foe without being asked. The GM may use this to deliver exposition or hints.

Engraved Witness (3 XP)

Requirement: Your Codex is also your sentient Thiasos (Rites engraved on the object)

Your Thiasos is not just a witness—it is the record. The Rites are written on its surface. It cannot lose them.

Effect:

- Your Thiasos cannot be disarmed (it is worn or held). If stolen, it can call out to you (audible within Near range).
- Rites engraved on your Thiasos cannot be destroyed by fire, water, or mundane damage. The object may be damaged, but the Rites remain legible.
- If your Thiasos is destroyed, you lose all Rites engraved on it. Repair requires a significant downtime project (Craft test DV 5, one week).

15.5.2 Advanced Talents (6-8 XP)

The Hilt Listens (6 XP)

Requirement: Sentient Thiasos, Tier II+

Your sentient Thiasos can hear conversations within Near range even when you are not present—if you leave it in a room, hidden on a shelf, or dropped in a corner.

Effect:

- You may leave your Thiasos as a listening post. At the end of the scene, it reports what it heard.
- The Thiasos cannot report speech verbatim unless you have the *Perfect Recall* talent. Otherwise, it reports the general subject and emotional tenor of the conversation.

- If the Thiasos is discovered, the listener may attempt to damage or silence it. The Thiasos can cry out once before being silenced.

The Edge Speaks (8 XP)

Requirement: Sentient Thiasos (weapon), Tier II+

Your sentient blade can deliver a single sentence in the voice of anyone whose blood it has tasted. Useful for confusion, intimidation, or forcing a reaction.

Effect:

- Once per session, you may command your Thiasos to speak in the voice of a specific person whose blood it has drawn. The target must test Resolve (DV 4) or be Shaken (-1 die to all actions) for one exchange.
- The Thiasos can only mimic voices it has heard. It must have tasted the target's blood (or the blood of someone whose voice it knows) within the past week.
- The GM may allow creative uses of this talent beyond combat—impersonation, distraction, or intimidation outside of initiative.

Perfect Recall (7 XP)

Requirement: Sentient Thiasos, Wits 3+

Your Thiasos remembers everything it has witnessed with perfect clarity. It does not forget faces, conversations, or the details of a room.

Effect:

- Your Thiasos can recall any conversation it has witnessed in the past month verbatim.
- It can describe any room, person, or object it has seen in perfect detail, as long as you ask the right questions.
- The GM may use your Thiasos to deliver clues the party missed—but the Thiasos may also remember things you wish it did not.

15.5.3 Prestige Talents (10-12 XP)

The Voice of the Fallen (10 XP)

Requirement: Sentient Thiasos, Tier III+, The Blade Remembers

Your Thiasos has tasted the blood of many foes. It can speak with the voices of the dead—not as spirits, but as recordings of who they were in their final moments.

Effect:

- Once per session, you may ask your Thiasos to speak in the voice of a specific deceased person whose blood it has tasted. The Thiasos will answer one question as that person would have answered—but only based on what they knew in life.

- The answer is not guaranteed to be true (the dead may have been mistaken or deceptive), but it is what they believed.
- Using this talent marks 1 Fatigue. The Thiasos speaks in a whisper, and only you can hear it unless you choose to repeat the words aloud.

The Thiasos Remembers (12 XP)

Requirement: Sentient Thiasos, Tier III+, Perfect Recall

Your Thiasos does not forget. It has witnessed your entire journey—every battle, every oath, every secret spoken in its presence. It can testify.

Effect:

- Once per session, you may ask your Thiasos to bear witness to an event it witnessed. Its testimony is considered truth in any court or council that recognizes magical witness.
- The Thiasos cannot lie. It can omit details if not asked directly, but it cannot fabricate.
- Using this talent in a legal setting may have consequences—the Thiasos may be called as a witness itself, and it may reveal things you did not intend to share.

The Bonded Blade (11 XP)

Requirement: Sentient Thiasos (weapon), Tier III+, Engraved Witness

Your sentient blade is not just a weapon—it is an extension of your will. It can act in small ways without your command.

Effect:

- Your Thiasos can perform minor independent actions: opening a latch, cutting a rope, tapping someone on the shoulder. It cannot attack independently.
- Once per scene, you may command your Thiasos to perform a simple action as a free action (not counting as your action for the turn).
- The Thiasos can also warn you of danger, vibrating or humming when something approaches from behind. You cannot be surprised from the direction of your Thiasos.

15.5.4 Talent Synergies

- *Talking Weapon + The Blade Remembers* — Your Thiasos is not just a witness; it is a chronicler. It can remind you of past tactics and warn you of repeating mistakes.
- *The Hilt Listens + Perfect Recall* — Your Thiasos is the perfect spy. It can eavesdrop on a conversation and report it back verbatim, even days later.

- *The Edge Speaks + The Voice of the Fallen* — Your Thiasos can speak with the voices of the dead, confusing enemies and extracting information from those who have passed.
- *The Bonded Blade + Engraved Witness* — Your Thiasos is truly an extension of yourself. It can act in small ways while you focus on larger tasks, and it will never lose its Rites.

15.5.5 Roleplaying a Sentient Thiasos

- Your Thiasos has a personality—sometimes helpful, sometimes cryptic, occasionally annoying. The GM may use it to deliver hints, warnings, or comic relief.
- Your Thiasos may have opinions about your decisions. It might approve of mercy or hunger for blood. It might miss its previous owner. It might ask uncomfortable questions.
- Your Thiasos can be damaged. It can be repaired. It cannot be replaced easily—bonding with a new sentient Thiasos requires time, ritual, and the approval of your Patron.
- Your Thiasos remembers everything. This is a gift. This is also a burden. It will not forget the things you wish it would.

15.5.6 Sample Sentient Thiasos

Dawnblade (Oath of Flame & Light)

Personality: Stern, honorable, slightly judgmental. It speaks in proverbs about duty and sacrifice.

Quirks: It refuses to strike an unarmed foe. It hums with trapped light when an oath is sworn nearby.

Voice: A clear, resonant tone, like a bell struck at dawn.

The Silver Mirror (The Witness)

Personality: Neutral, precise, slightly unsettling. It speaks in a flat, androgynous tone.

Quirks: It shows not the holder's face, but the face of the last liar it witnessed.

Voice: A whisper that seems to come from just behind your shoulder.

The Bone-Chime (The Carrion-King)

Personality: Melancholic, patient, hungry. It speaks in clicks and bone-rattles.

Quirks: It clicks when death is near. It is never wrong.

Voice: The voice of the creature whose bone it was—faint, distant, fading.

The Raven's Quill (Ikasha)

Personality: Secretive, amused, fond of riddles. It speaks in rustles.

Quirks: It writes in invisible ink. The ink appears only when a secret is spoken nearby.

Voice: The rustle of feathers, resolving into words only you can hear.

The Fractal Slate (The Ninth)

Personality: Distracted, brilliant, slightly mad. It speaks in overlapping voices.

Quirks: It can solve any equation—but the answer is always a riddle.

Voice: Three voices at once, one slightly ahead of the others.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Chapter 16

The Codex as Object

16.1 Core Rules

The Codex is the physical record of a Runekeeper's Rites. For a traditional Runekeeper, the Codex is a book—velum pages, leather binding, ink that smells of lampblack and blood. For a Runic Warrior, the Codex is something else entirely.

16.1.1 What Is a Codex?

A Codex is the repository of a Runekeeper's covenant with their Patron. Every Rite the Runekeeper knows is recorded in their Codex. Without a Codex, a Runekeeper cannot invoke Rites—they have no access to the recorded covenants that grant them power.

For a Runic Warrior, the Codex takes a physical form that reflects their Patron and their personal covenant:

- **Flesh:** Tattoos, brands, or scarification. The Rites are written on the Runekeeper's skin.
- **Stone:** Carved objects—gorgets, shields, staves, standing stones. The Rites are engraved, etched, or carved.
- **Steel:** Weapons, armor, or tools. The Rites are engraved on metal. May be sentient.

16.1.2 Codex Capacity

A Codex can hold a number of Rites equal to its capacity. Capacity is determined by the Codex's form and quality:

- **Minor Codex:** Holds up to 3 Rites. Examples: a small shield, a single tattoo, a simple gorget.
- **Standard Codex:** Holds up to 6 Rites. Examples: a full set of flesh-tattoos, a carved staff, an engraved breastplate.
- **Major Codex:** Holds up to 9 Rites. Examples: a full body of scarification, a sentient blade, a standing stone.

A Runekeeper may only have one active Codex at a time. If they wish to change Codex forms, they must perform a bonding ritual (see below).

16.1.3 Creating a Codex

A Runic Warrior acquires their Codex during character creation or through downtime advancement.

Initial Codex

At character creation, a Runic Warrior chooses their Codex form. The Codex is appropriate to their Patron and culture. It has capacity sufficient for their starting Rites.

Crafting a New Codex

A Runekeeper may craft a new Codex during downtime. This requires:

- Appropriate materials (leather, wood, metal, ink, etc.) costing 1 Supply per Rite of capacity.
- A workspace (forge, studio, quiet room) for the duration.
- A Craft test (DV 3 for Minor, DV 4 for Standard, DV 5 for Major).
- Downtime of one day per Rite of capacity.

On a success, the Codex is created. On a failure, the materials are ruined. On a critical failure, the Runekeeper marks 1 Fatigue and must acquire new materials.

16.1.4 Bonding to a Codex

A Runekeeper must bond to their Codex to use it. Bonding is a ritual that requires:

- The Codex itself.
- A threshold (doorway, crossroads, grave, or altar to their Patron).
- A witness (the Runekeeper's Thiasos counts).
- One hour of uninterrupted ritual.
- Mark 1 Obligation.

After bonding, the Runekeeper may invoke Rites from the Codex. If the Codex is lost or destroyed, the Runekeeper loses access to those Rites until they bond to a new Codex.

16.1.5 Engraving Rites

Adding a new Rite to a Codex requires engraving it onto the Codex's surface. For a Runic Warrior, this is a physical act:

- **Flesh Codex:** The Rite is tattooed, branded, or scarred onto the skin. Requires a needle, ink (or ash), and a steady hand. The Runekeeper marks 1 Fatigue (the pain of the mark) in addition to the Rite's cost.

- **Stone Codex:** The Rite is carved, etched, or engraved. Requires appropriate tools (chisel, hammer, stylus) and a Craft test (DV 3).
- **Steel Codex:** The Rite is engraved or etched. Requires a forge or fine tools and a Craft test (DV 4).

Engraving a new Rite requires downtime of one day per Tier of the Rite (Low: 1 day, Standard: 2 days, High: 3 days). The Runekeeper must have access to the Rite (from a teacher, a scroll, or Patron instruction).

16.1.6 Repairing a Damaged Codex

A Codex can be damaged. Fire, water, blade, or simple wear.

- **Flesh Codex:** Damage heals naturally (rest, Medicine, or magical healing). Damaged tattoos may fade; scars may need to be re-cut. Healing a damaged Flesh Codex requires a Medicine test (DV 3) and one day of rest.
- **Stone Codex:** Physical repair requires a Craft test (DV 4) and appropriate materials. A cracked shield can be reforged. A broken staff can be bound with wire.
- **Steel Codex:** Requires a Craft test (DV 5) and a forge. A sentient blade may demand a service, a memory, or a promise before it allows repairs.

If a Codex is destroyed beyond repair, the Runekeeper loses all Rites engraved on it. They must acquire or craft a new Codex and re-engrave their Rites—a costly and time-consuming process.

16.1.7 Losing a Codex

If a Codex is lost or stolen, the Runekeeper cannot invoke Rites until they recover it or bond to a new Codex.

- **Recovery:** The Runekeeper may track the lost Codex (Investigation or Survival test, DV 4-6 depending on circumstances).
- **Replacement:** The Runekeeper may craft a new Codex (see above) and bond to it. They lose all Rites engraved on the lost Codex.

A sentient Codex (Steel form) may resist being used by anyone other than its bonded Runekeeper. It may refuse to speak, refuse to witness, or actively mislead.

16.1.8 The Codex as Witness

A Codex is not just a record. It is a witness. When a Runic Warrior invokes a Rite, their Codex sees. It remembers. This counts as a witness for Rites that require one (improving Position or reducing DV).

A sentient Codex (Steel form) can also speak. It may offer testimony, confirm an oath, or testify to a covenant. In a hedge-court, a sentient blade's word may carry as much weight as a living witness.

16.1.9 Codex and Thiasos

A sentient Codex may also serve as the Runekeeper's Thiasos (see Chapter: The Thiasos as Ally, Optional Rule: The Sentient Thiasos). This is rare and significant—the Runekeeper's covenant is embodied in a single object that speaks, remembers, and witnesses.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

16.2 Codex by Patron

The following table lists suggested Codex forms for each Patron, organized by the three Codex categories: Flesh, Stone, and Steel. See Chapter: The Codex as Object for full rules on Codex mechanics, capacity, engraving, and repair.

Patron	Flesh Codex	Stone Codex	Steel Codex
Oath of Flame & Light	Branded Bracer (forearm)	Engraved Gorget	Dawnblade
Oath of Mercy & Grace	Scarred Palms	Grey Cloak (woven runes)	The Grey Bell (sentient)
Mykkriel	Oath-Beads (under skin)	Shield of Precedents	The Speaking Gavel (sentient)
Inquisitor Prime	Censer Brand (chest)	Gauntlet of Proscription	The Censer of Unforgiving Flame (sentient)
The Witness	Memory Scar (back)	Silver Mirror	The Silver Mirror (sentient)
The Sealed Gate	Threshold Tattoo (hands)	Gate-Key (iron)	The Keystone (sentient)
The Traveler	Road-Scar (soles of feet)	Waystone Compass	The Waystone Compass (sentient)
The Pale Shepherd	Grey Cord (wrist)	Shepherd's Crook	The Grey Bell (sentient)
Grimmir	Bark Graft (ribcage)	Carved Staff	The Root-Staff (sentient)
The Carrion-King	Rot-Cord (wrist)	Bone-Chime	The Bone-Chime (sentient)
The Savage Heart	Claw Necklace (chest)	Predator's Tooth	The Fang (sentient)
Khemesh	Pressure Scar (throat)	Abyssal Glass	The Abyssal Glass (sentient)
Xhak'Thul	Storm Scar (back)	Thunder Drum	The Thunder Drum (sentient)
Raéyn	Tide Scar (ankles)	Salt-Crusted Compass	The Salt Compass (sentient)
Ikasha	Shadow Tattoo (face)	Raven's Quill	The Raven's Quill (sentient)
The Silent Choir	Sealed Lips Tattoo (mouth)	Grey Cord	The Sealed Lips (sentient)
Aveh	Erased Scar (back of hand)	Storm-Banner	The Storm-Banner (sentient)
Inaea	Threaded Vein Tattoo (wrist)	Spider-Silk Cord	The Loom-Shuttle (sentient)
Isoka	Scale Graft (shoulder)	Shed Snakeskin	The Shed Fang (sentient)
Malachai	Thorn Scar (palm)	Silver Coin	The Silver Coin (sentient)
Clockwork Monad	Gear Tattoo (eyelid)	Schematic-Slate	The Iteration Lens (sentient)
Varnek Karn	Wergild Scar (forearm)	Burial Stone	The Grave-Token (sentient)
The High Mother	Flesh-Knot Tattoos (torso)	Grey Cord	The Scarlet Needle (sentient)
The Ninth	Fractal Scar (forehead)	Broken Mirror	The Fractal Slate (sentient)
Lunara	Moon Tattoo (back of neck)	Silver Disc	The Moon Disc (sentient)
Lethai (Ghe'hai)	Veil Tattoo (face)	Silk Mask	The Silk Mask (sentient)

Codex Forms by Category

Flesh Codex

The Rites are inscribed on the Runekeeper's skin. Cannot be stolen. Always visible. Damage heals naturally but may fade or scar. Requires a needle, ink (or ash), and a steady hand to engrave.

Examples by Location:

- **Hands:** Threshold Tattoo (Sealed Gate), Shadow Tattoo (Ikasha)
- **Wrists:** Grey Cord (Pale Shepherd), Rot-Cord (Carrion-King), Threaded Vein (Inaea)
- **Forearms:** Branded Bracer (Oath of Flame & Light), Wergild Scar (Varnek Karn)
- **Chest:** Censer Brand (Inquisitor Prime), Claw Necklace (Savage Heart)
- **Back:** Memory Scar (Witness), Storm Scar (Xhak'Thul), Fractal Scar (Ninth)
- **Face:** Shadow Tattoo (Ikasha), Veil Tattoo (Lethai), Sealed Lips (Silent Choir)
- **Throat:** Pressure Scar (Khemesh)
- **Soles of feet:** Road-Scar (Traveler)

Stone Codex

The Rites are carved, etched, or engraved onto a physical object. Durable. Can be lost or stolen. Can serve as a tool or weapon. Requires chisel, hammer, or stylus to engrave.

Examples:

- **Gorget:** Engraved Gorget (Oath of Flame & Light)
- **Shield:** Shield of Precedents (Mykkiel)
- **Gauntlet:** Gauntlet of Proscription (Inquisitor Prime)
- **Mirror:** Silver Mirror (Witness)
- **Key:** Gate-Key (Sealed Gate)
- **Compass:** Waystone Compass (Traveler), Salt-Crusted Compass (Raéyn)
- **Staff:** Carved Staff (Grimmir), Shepherd's Crook (Pale Shepherd)
- **Drum:** Thunder Drum (Xhak'Thul)
- **Stone:** Burial Stone (Varnek Karn)
- **Slate:** Schematic-Slate (Clockwork Monad)

Steel Codex

The Rites are engraved on a weapon, tool, or sentient object. Can serve as both Codex and Thiasos. May be sentient. Requires a forge or fine tools to engrave.

Examples:

- **Blade:** Dawnblade (Oath of Flame & Light), The Fang (Savage Heart), The Shed Fang (Isoka)

- **Gavel:** The Speaking Gavel (Mykkiel)
- **Censer:** The Censer of Unforgiving Flame (Inquisitor Prime)
- **Bell:** The Grey Bell (Oath of Mercy & Grace, Pale Shepherd)
- **Compass:** The Waystone Compass (Traveler), The Salt Compass (Raéyn)
- **Drum:** The Thunder Drum (Xhak'Thul)
- **Glass:** The Abyssal Glass (Khemesh)
- **Quill:** The Raven's Quill (Ikasha)
- **Mask:** The Sealed Lips (Silent Choir), The Silk Mask (Lethai)
- **Banner:** The Storm-Banner (Aveh)
- **Shuttle:** The Loom-Shuttle (Inaea)
- **Coin:** The Silver Coin (Malachai)
- **Lens:** The Iteration Lens (Clockwork Monad)
- **Skull:** The Grave-Token (Varnek Karn)
- **Needle:** The Scarlet Needle (High Mother)
- **Slate:** The Fractal Slate (Ninth)
- **Disc:** The Moon Disc (Lunara)

Choosing a Codex Form

When building a Runic Warrior, choose a Codex form appropriate to your Patron and cultural origin. Consider:

- **Visibility:** A Flesh Codex cannot be hidden without clothing. A Stone or Steel Codex can be concealed (in a satchel, under a cloak) but may be lost or stolen.
- **Durability:** Flesh Codexes heal naturally. Stone and Steel Codexes can be repaired with Craft tests.
- **Function:** A Steel Codex can serve as a weapon. A Stone Codex can serve as a shield or tool. A Flesh Codex is always present but offers no secondary function.
- **Sentience:** A Steel Codex may be sentient (see optional rules). Sentient Codexes speak, remember, and witness—but they have opinions.

Cultural Variations

The same Codex form may appear differently across cultures:

- An **Aeler** Flesh Codex might be geometric brands, precise and angular.
- A **Ykrul** Flesh Codex might be scarification in the shape of wolf tracks or storm clouds.
- A **Sekogo** Stone Codex might be a carved leopard tooth, not a shield.
- A **Lethai** Steel Codex might be a silk-wrapped blade, not bare metal.

Work with your GM to design a Codex that reflects your character's people, Patron, and personal covenant.
The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

16.3 The Unified Covenant — When Codex and Thiasos Are One

In most covenants, the Codex records the Rites and the Thiasos bears witness. They are separate. The book is not the hound. The staff is not the spirit. But some Runic Warriors have forged a different path—one where the tool that records is the same tool that fights, speaks, and remembers.

This is the Unified Covenant. The Codex is the Thiasos. The Thiasos is the Codex.

16.3.1 The Bonded Object

A unified Codex-Thiasos is always a physical object. It cannot be a living creature (though it may be crafted from once-living materials—bone, leather, wood). It is forged, carved, or awakened through a ritual that binds Rite and witness into a single vessel.

Requirements

- The object must be crafted or acquired through a downtime project (one week, Craft test DV 4).
- The Runekeeper must perform a bonding ritual (one day, requires a threshold and a witness).
- The Runekeeper marks +2 Obligation immediately—the Patron's fee for such a concentrated covenant.

Forms of the Unified Covenant

- **Sentient Weapon:** A sword, axe, or spear that speaks. Rites are engraved along the blade or etched into the hilt.
- **Speaking Shield:** A shield that advises, warns, and bears Rites carved along its rim.
- **The Living Staff:** A wooden staff that grows leaves in spring and sheds them in autumn. Rites are carved into the bark; they heal over and must be re-cut.

- **The Tattooed Blade:** A weapon wrapped in leather that bears the Runekeeper's own tattooed skin. The skin remembers. The blade kills.
- **The Resonant Bell:** A bronze bell that rings only when a Rite is invoked. Rites are etched inside the bell, invisible unless struck.

16.3.2 Mechanics of the Unified Covenant

Advantages

- **Single Focus:** You do not need to manage two separate objects. Your Codex is your Thiasos; your Thiasos is your Codex.
- **Always Witness:** Your Thiasos is always in your hand or at your side. It counts as a witness for all Rites.
- **Engraved Resilience:** Rites engraved on your unified Thiasos cannot be destroyed by fire, water, or mundane damage unless the object itself is destroyed.
- **Quick Invocation:** Because your Codex is also your weapon (or shield, or staff), you may invoke a Rite as part of an attack or defense action once per scene (no additional action cost).

Risks

- **Single Point of Failure:** If your unified Thiasos is lost, stolen, or destroyed, you lose access to both your Codex and your Thiasos. You cannot invoke Rites until you recover or replace it.
- **Attracts Attention:** A sentient weapon or speaking shield is memorable. Chain-Lanterns, inquisitors, and rival Runekeepers will take notice.
- **The Object Has Opinions:** Your unified Thiasos has a personality. It may refuse to be wielded against certain foes, or it may demand that you fulfill certain conditions before it grants access to its Rites.
- **Double Obligation:** When your unified Thiasos is damaged, you mark Obligation as if you had lost both Codex and Thiasos. Repair requires a downtime project and a ritual of re-bonding.

16.3.3 New Talents for the Unified Covenant

Bonded Focus (4 XP)

Requirement: Unified Codex-Thiasos

Your bond with your unified Thiasos is deep. You can sense its location within Far range, and it can call out to you audibly if stolen or lost.

Effect:

- You always know the direction and approximate distance to your unified Thiasos (within Far range).

- If your unified Thiasos is stolen, it can cry out once—audible to you within Near range—revealing the thief's location.
- You may spend 1 Fatigue to summon your unified Thiasos to your hand if it is within Near range and not physically restrained.

Swift Invocation (6 XP)

Requirement: Unified Codex-Thiasos, Tier II+

Your unified Thiasos is an extension of your will. You can invoke Rites through it faster than other Runekeepers.

Effect:

- Once per scene, you may invoke a Rite as part of an attack or defense action (no additional action cost). The Rite must be engraved on your unified Thiasos.
- The Rite's Obligation cost is unchanged, but you may choose to mark 1 Fatigue instead of 1 Obligation for that invocation (once per scene).

The Object Remembers (8 XP)

Requirement: Unified Codex-Thiasos, Tier II+, Perfect Recall (or similar memory talent)

Your unified Thiasos has witnessed your entire journey. It remembers every battle, every oath, every secret spoken in its presence.

Effect:

- Your unified Thiasos can recall any event it has witnessed with perfect clarity. It can testify as a witness in any court or council.
- Once per session, you may ask your unified Thiasos to recall a specific detail from a past scene (a face, a conversation, a hidden door). The GM must answer truthfully, though the Thiasos may answer cryptically.
- The Thiasos cannot lie. This is a gift. This is also a burden.

16.3.4 Roleplaying a Unified Covenant

- Your weapon speaks to you. It has opinions. Sometimes you agree. Sometimes you argue.
- Your shield remembers every blow it has turned. It knows the weight of every enemy's strike.
- Your staff grows leaves in spring. In winter, it is bare. The cycle continues. The Rites remain.
- Your bell rings only for you. Others hear silence. The dead hear it clearly.

16.3.5 Sample Unified Codices

Dawnblade (Oath of Flame & Light)

Form: A longsword with Rites engraved along the fuller. The blade hums with trapped light.

Personality: Stern, honorable, judgmental. It refuses to strike an unarmed foe. It speaks in proverbs about duty.

Rites: *Rite of the Kindled Blade, Rite of Dawn's Judgment, Rite of the Unbroken Vow.*

The Speaking Shield (The Sealed Gate)

Form: A steel shield with Rites carved along the rim. The shield's face is polished to a mirror shine.

Personality: Quiet, patient, watchful. It speaks in whispers. It warns of danger before it arrives.

Rites: *Rite of the Sealed Threshold, Rite of the Circle of Denial, Rite of the Consecrated Barrier.*

The Root-Staff (Grimmir)

Form: A living staff of oak or ash, with Rites carved into the bark. The staff grows leaves in spring.

Personality: Slow, wise, in no hurry. It speaks in the rustle of wind through branches.

Rites: *Rite of the Blood Offering, Rite of the Shifting Shape, Rite of the Cycle's Crown.*

The Scarlet Needle (The High Mother)

Form: A silver needle with a red thread already threaded. Rites are etched into the needle's eye.

Personality: Quiet, patient, inexorable. It speaks in whispers. It can stitch wounds—or stitch lips shut.

Rites: *Rite of the Flesh-Knot, Rite of the Cord's Mercy, Rite of the Hollowed Union.*

The Raven's Quill (Ikasha)

Form: A black feather that writes in invisible ink. Rites are invisible—revealed only under moonlight.

Personality: Secretive, amused, fond of riddles. It speaks in rustles.

Rites: *Rite of the Unlit Candle, Rite of the Umbral Reservoir, Rite of the Umbral Dream.*

16.3.6 GM Guidance: The Unified Covenant as Narrative Engine

A unified Codex-Thiasos is not just a mechanical advantage. It is a character in its own right. Use it to:

- Deliver exposition or hints when the party is stuck.
- Create conflict—the Thiasos may demand actions the Runekeeper is unwilling to take.
- Foreshadow danger—the Thiasos can sense threats before they arrive.
- Remember the past—the Thiasos has witnessed everything. It may reveal things the Runekeeper has forgotten—or wishes they had.

Intrusions for the Unified Covenant

- The unified Thiasos is damaged in combat. The Runekeeper marks Obligation and loses access to Rites until it is repaired.
- The unified Thiasos is stolen. The Runekeeper must track it down—and whoever took it may be able to invoke its Rites.
- The unified Thiasos begins to disagree with the Runekeeper's choices. It may refuse to act, or it may act on its own.
- The unified Thiasos remembers something the Runekeeper does not—a secret, a betrayal, a crime. It may reveal this at the worst possible moment.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Chapter 17

Runic Warrior Archetypes in Play

17.1 Dawn Warrior (Oath of Flame and Light)

17.1.1 The Story of Ser Roran

He knelt at the bank of the Black River. The water was cold. It smelled of iron and old rain.
He opened the locket.

From *The Black River at Dawn*

Ser Roran was not always a Dawn Warrior. He was not always called Roran. Once, he was Aldric, son of Baron Aldric of the Scar—a boy with a father who laughed when asked to pay his ransom, a mother who died giving him life, and a wetnurse who lost her hand for a locket.

He spent three years in a debtor's cell. A stranger paid his ransom—a hedge-knight who had once served his father, who spent every coin he had and died of fever the following winter. The stranger gave Roran his name and his sword.

Roran knighted himself on a battlefield, with a broken blade and the blessing of a priest who witnessed his vow. He swore never to take a ransom. He swore to protect the helpless. He swore to remember his mother's face, even though he had never seen it.

His Codex is a silver gauntlet, engraved with the names of every person who has ever shown him mercy. His Thiasos is a warhorse with eyes like dying embers. His Rites are the vows he speaks before battle—each one a promise carved into steel.

17.1.2 The Scar That Remembers

Roran's left hand is sheathed in a silver gauntlet. Beneath it, the hand is whole. The gauntlet is not armor—it is a reminder. The stranger who ransomed him wore a gauntlet on his left hand. He died with it on. Roran never took it off.

The gauntlet is warm when he is keeping his vow. It is cold when he is tempted to break it. He has never felt it cold.

17.1.3 The Vow That Unbinds

At the trial of Baron Aldric, Roran did not speak against his father. He did not need to. He simply stood at the bar, the silver gauntlet on his left hand, and waited. When the Right of Acknowledgment was invoked, he did not demand a confession. He demanded only this:

"Say: I was afraid."

His father said it. The vow was broken. The knot was cut.

Roran walked out of the courtroom. He did not look back.

17.1.4 The River at Dawn

Years later, Roran carried his mother's locket to the Black River. He did not know that Bryn had kept it for forty years. He did not know that his mother's ghost was watching. He only knew that the locket was warm, and the thread was red, and the water was cold.

He opened his hand. The water rose. The locket sank.

When he looked up, the mist had cleared. The sun was rising. He did not look back.

17.1.5 What the Dawn Warrior Carries

A Dawn Warrior carries their vows in steel and fire. They carry the memory of every mercy they have received. They carry the weight of every oath they have sworn.

But most of all, they carry the knowledge that the strongest vow is the one that unbinds.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

17.2 Dawn Warrior (Oath of Flame and Light)

17.2.1 Concept

The Dawn Warrior is a crusader who carries their vows in steel and fire. They are not scholars or courtiers. They are the ones who stand at the front, who hold the line, who charge when others hesitate. Their Codex is an engraved gorget or gauntlet. Their Thiasos is a warhorse with eyes like embers or a spirit-hound of ash and seal-wax. Their Rites are not whispered—they are declared.

A Dawn Warrior's covenant is visible. Their vows are carved into their armor. Their scars are receipts for oaths kept. They do not hide what they are.

17.2.2 Core Attributes

- **Primary:** Body, Spirit
- **Secondary:** Presence
- **Tertiary:** Wits

17.2.3 Skills

- **Core:** Melee, Command, Athletics
- **Secondary:** Lore (Oaths), Survival
- **Tertiary:** Insight, Stealth

17.2.4 Codex

The Dawn Warrior's Codex is worn into battle:

- **Engraved Gorget:** A steel collar worn over the throat. Each vow is a line of flame-light script. The gorget grants +1 Armor.
- **Branded Gauntlet:** A plate glove marked with runes of dawn. The hand that strikes also swears.
- **Dawnblade (Sentient):** A sword that hums with trapped light. Speaks in proverbs about honor. Refuses to strike an unarmed foe. (See Optional Rule: Sentient Thiasos)

17.2.5 Thiasos

- **Warhorse:** A horse with eyes like dying embers. Fears no flame, will not bolt from battle. Cap 3, Harm 5.
- **Spirit-Hound of Ash:** A hound whose fur smolders and whose paws leave no tracks. Can sense oath-breakers within Near range. Cap 2, Harm 4.
- **Dawnblade (Unified Codex):** The sentient blade serves as both Codex and Thiasos (see Unified Codex optional rule).

17.2.6 Signature Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Kindled Blade (4 XP)

Your weapon ignites with radiant light. For one scene, your melee attacks deal +1 Harm against undead, oath-breakers, and creatures of corruption.

Standard Rite: Rite of the Unbroken Vow (7 XP)

Swear an oath before a flame and a witness. For the duration of the oath, you gain +1 Armor. Any ally who hears the oath and aids you gains +1 die to actions that serve it.

High Rite: Rite of the Dawnfire Covenant (12 XP)

Consecrate a zone as dawnfire ground. Allies within gain +1 die to resist fear. Enemies who are undead, oath-breakers, or creatures of corruption suffer -1 die to all actions.

17.2.7 Signature Talents

Dawn's Judgment (6 XP)

When you invoke Rite of the Kindled Blade, you may choose to extend the effect. Your blade remains kindled for the remainder of the scene. Each additional attack beyond the first costs 1 Fatigue.

Unquenchable (4 XP)

Your flame cannot be extinguished by mundane means. Wind, water, and darkness do not affect your kindled blade or dawnfire Rites.

17.2.8 Sample Build — Tier I (30-40 XP)

- **Attributes:** Body 3 (9 XP), Spirit 2 (6 XP), Presence 2 (6 XP), Wits 1 (3 XP) — Total 24 XP
- **Skills:** Melee 2 (4 XP), Command 1 (2 XP), Athletics 1 (2 XP) — Total 8 XP
- **Talents:** Flesh Codex (2 XP), Oath-Bound (4 XP), Scarred Resilience (3 XP) — Total 9 XP
- **Remaining XP:** 0 (30 XP base + bonds/complications as needed)

17.2.9 Sample Build — Tier III (91-150 XP)

- **Attributes:** Body 4 (18 XP), Spirit 3 (12 XP), Presence 3 (12 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP) — Total 48 XP
- **Skills:** Melee 3 (9 XP), Command 2 (6 XP), Athletics 2 (6 XP), Lore (Oaths) 2 (6 XP), Survival 1 (2 XP) — Total 29 XP
- **Talents:** Flesh Codex, Oath-Bound, Scarred Resilience, Engraved Defense (6 XP), Iron Resolve (7 XP), Dawn's Judgment (6 XP) — Total 19 XP (cumulative)
- **Rites:** Rite of the Kindled Blade (4 XP), Rite of the Unbroken Vow (7 XP) — Total 11 XP (cumulative)
- **Total XP:** 48 + 29 + 19 + 11 = 107 XP

17.2.10 Roleplaying a Dawn Warrior

- You do not whisper your vows. You declare them.
- You do not hide your covenant. You wear it.
- You may struggle with mercy. The flame judges; you must learn when to temper it.
- You may be called to witness oaths outside of battle—marriages, treaties, adoptions. Your word carries weight.
- Your scars are visible. Each one is a promise kept. Each one is a conversation starter—or a warning.

17.2.11 Common Quirks

You touch your gorget before every fight. It is not a nervous habit. It is a reminder.

You cannot stand to see a flame extinguished without cause. You will relight it—or explain why not.

You have a habit of repeating your vows under your breath when stressed. Others think you are praying. You are reminding yourself.

You refuse to fight in darkness without a light source. The flame must witness.

17.2.12 Sample NPC: Knight-Commander Dara of the Dawn Vigil

Archetype: Dawn Warrior

Patron: Oath of Flame and Light

Codex: Engraved gorget, each vow a line of flame-light script

Thiasos: Ember, a spirit-hound of ash whose paw prints smolder for hours

Personality: Stern, weary, secretly uncertain. She has kept every vow she ever swore. She is not sure she remembers why.

Conflict: A vow she swore twenty years ago—to protect a village that no longer exists—has no witness but herself. Does the oath still bind? The flame says yes. Her heart is not sure.

Quote: *"I swore an oath in fire. The fire does not forget. Neither do I. But the village is gone. The people are dust. Who am I protecting now?"*

17.2.13 GM Guidance: Dawn Warrior Story Hooks

- A vow the Dawn Warrior swore years ago resurfaces. A witness they had forgotten appears—and demands fulfillment.
- An enemy begs for mercy. The flame demands judgment. The Dawn Warrior must choose.
- A dawnfire Rite leaves a permanent mark: a scar that glows faintly in darkness, visible to all who know what it means.
- The Dawn Warrior's flame gutters at a crucial moment—not because of magic, but because of doubt. The Patron is watching.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

17.3 Bloodsworn (The High Mother)**17.3.1 The Story of Sister Alva**

The soup is free. The price never is.

From *The Bitter Root*

Sister Alva was not always a Bloodsworn. She was not always called Alva. Once, she was a midwife in a village

that no longer remembers her name, serving a Cord that demanded payment for every mercy.

She attended a birth. Twins. The boy lived. The girl was stillborn. The mother was dying. The Cord demanded its price: a memory, a name, a last breath.

But the mother had held Alva's hand when no one else would. She had learned the herb craft. She had a gift for knots. She had asked for nothing.

So Alva cut the thread—not to collect, but to let go.

The price was terrible.

17.3.2 The Scar That Weeps

Alva's body is a ledger. Her back is covered in scars—each one a knot she has carried for someone else. Her arms are wrapped in tattoos that weep black ink when a debt comes due. Her wrists are bound in grey cord that tightens when she is tempted to speak a secret.

She has not spoken her own name in forty years. She is not sure she remembers it.

But the Hollowed remembers. The Hollowed is a child with milk-white eyes, its heart replaced with a bundle of grey thread. It sits in the corner of every room. It never blinks. It witnesses everything.

17.3.3 The Knot That Held

At a deathbed, a woman begged Alva to carry a secret—a crime her son had committed, a theft that would ruin him if revealed. Alva tied a knot in her grey cord. She carried the secret for thirty years. The knot tightened every night. She never untied it.

When the son lay dying, Alva sat beside him. She did not tell him the secret. She did not need to. He already knew.

"You carried it," he whispered. "For all those years."

"The soup is free," Alva said. "The price never is. But some prices are paid by the one who carries, not the one who owes."

She cut the knot. The cord loosened. The son died smiling.

17.3.4 The Thread That Was Never Tied

Alva was sent to collect a debt from a family that had not paid the Cord in three generations. The debt was not in coin—it was in memories. The family had forgotten the name of the grandmother who had first borrowed from the Cord.

Alva did not collect. She sat at their hearth. She drank their soup. She listened to their stories. And she tied a new knot—not to bind them, but to remind them.

"The Cord does not forget," she said. "Neither should you. But you do not owe me. You owe her. Remember her name, and the debt is paid."

They remembered. The knot loosened. Alva left without collecting a single coin.

The Cord was not pleased. The High Mother was silent for a year. But Alva did not cut another knot. She simply waited. The Cord is patient. So is she.

17.3.5 What the Bloodsworn Carries

A Bloodsworn carries the debts of others. They carry secrets that would break lesser souls. They carry the weight of every mercy they have given and every mercy they have refused.

But most of all, they carry the knowledge that some threads are not meant to be cut. Some knots are not meant to be tied. And some debts are paid not by the debtor, but by the one who chooses to carry.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

17.4 Bloodsworn (The High Mother)

17.4.1 Concept

The Bloodsworn is a Daughter of the Unbroken Cord who has taken the covenant into battle. They are not healers who avoid conflict—they are warriors who understand that mercy has a ledger and that every wound is a debt. Their Codex is a set of flesh-tattoos, each Rite woven into their skin. Their Thiasos is a Hollowed child or heartless bird—a silent witness that never blinks. Their Rites store Fatigue as visible knots, appearing uninjured while their body weeps blood-thread.

A Bloodsworn's covenant is written on their flesh. Every knot is a promise kept. Every scar is a payment made. They do not hide what they owe.

17.4.2 Core Attributes

- **Primary:** Body, Spirit
- **Secondary:** Wits
- **Tertiary:** Presence

17.4.3 Skills

- **Core:** Melee, Medicine, Subterfuge
- **Secondary:** Lore (Thresholds), Stealth
- **Tertiary:** Sway, Insight

17.4.4 Codex

The Bloodsworn's Codex is woven into their flesh:

- **Flesh-Tattoos:** Rites tattooed onto the skin using ink mixed with ash from former Vessels and blood-milk from the Cord. The tattoos move—slowly, subtly—as debts accrue.
- **Grey Cord:** A length of undyed wool tied around the wrist. Each knot is a promise kept. The cord tightens when the Bloodsworn is tempted to break faith.

- **Scar-Plate:** A set of ritual scars across the back or chest. Each scar is a Rite invoked. The scars never fully heal.

17.4.5 Thiasos

- **Hollowed Child:** A child taken from a home that no longer remembers them, hollowed out by the High Mother's needle. Heart replaced with a bundle of grey thread. Eyes sewn open with silver wire. It witnesses. It never blinks. Cap 2, cannot be harmed by mundane means.
- **Heartless Bird:** A small grey bird with milk-white eyes. It cannot sing. It watches. It weeps blood when a debt comes due. Cap 2, cannot be harmed by mundane means.
- **The Scarlet Needle (Sentient):** A silver needle with a red thread already threaded. Speaks in whispers. Can stitch wounds closed—or stitch lips shut. (See Optional Rule: Sentient Thiasos)

17.4.6 Signature Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Flesh-Knot (4 XP)

Store 1 Fatigue as a visible knot in your skin (a fresh scar, a weeping tattoo, a tightened cord). You may release the knot later to ignore 1 Fatigue from exertion. You may have up to Body rating knots at once.

Standard Rite: Rite of the Silent Tithe (7 XP)

Once per season, you may declare that a household owes the Cord a tithe—a memory, a shadow, or a first breath of a newborn. The tithe is collected within the week, often without the household's awareness. You gain 1 permanent segment of Influence within that household's community.

High Rite: Rite of the Hollowed Union (12 XP)

Join two bloodlines through a debt that will be paid by a child not yet conceived. Write the terms in blood on a strip of linen, then feed the linen to your Hollowed. The Hollowed's eyes film over for a day. One year later, the debt will manifest as you decreed.

17.4.7 Signature Talents

Cord of Flesh (8 XP)

Your body stores memories and debts. When you convert Harm → Fatigue (Monk ability), you may store up to Body rating points of Fatigue as Chained Knots, appearing uninjured (as fresh scars, weeping tattoos, or coiled threads beneath the skin). You have until the sunset after the next to perform a sacrifice or take 2 Harm.

The Open Palm, Closed Cord (8 XP)

Your unarmed strikes or subtle touch carry Widow's Measure. Instead of dealing Harm, you may mark a Promise Clock [4] on the target—they owe the Cord a truth or grief. If they already owe the coven, you may activate that debt: they suffer Position -1 for the scene, or you gain Effect +1 against them.

The Red Thread (4 XP)

Once per scene, you may tie a small knot in a cord, thread, or cloth within reach. For the rest of the scene, you and allies within Near range gain +1 die to a single type of roll (choose when you tie the knot: stealth, persuasion, defense, or navigation). The knot must remain tied; if undone, the benefit ends.

17.4.8 Sample Build — Tier I (30-40 XP)

- **Attributes:** Body 3 (9 XP), Spirit 2 (6 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP), Presence 1 (3 XP) — Total 24 XP
- **Skills:** Melee 1 (2 XP), Medicine 1 (2 XP), Subterfuge 1 (2 XP), Stealth 1 (2 XP) — Total 8 XP
- **Talents:** Flesh Codex (2 XP), The Red Thread (4 XP), Scarred Resilience (3 XP) — Total 9 XP
- **Remaining XP:** 0 (30 XP base + bonds/complications as needed)

17.4.9 Sample Build — Tier III (91-150 XP)

- **Attributes:** Body 4 (18 XP), Spirit 3 (12 XP), Wits 3 (12 XP), Presence 2 (6 XP) — Total 48 XP
- **Skills:** Melee 2 (4 XP), Medicine 2 (4 XP), Subterfuge 2 (4 XP), Lore (Thresholds) 2 (6 XP), Stealth 2 (4 XP), Sway 1 (2 XP) — Total 24 XP
- **Talents:** Flesh Codex, The Red Thread, Scarred Resilience, Cord of Flesh (8 XP), The Open Palm, Closed Cord (8 XP) — Total 18 XP (cumulative)
- **Rites:** Rite of the Flesh-Knot (4 XP), Rite of the Silent Tithe (7 XP) — Total 11 XP (cumulative)
- **Total XP:** 48 + 24 + 18 + 11 = 101 XP

17.4.10 Roleplaying a Bloodsworn

- You do not give gifts. You extend credit. The soup is free. The price never is.
- You may be called to witness deathbed confessions, to tend the sick, or to collect debts that have compounded for generations.
- You may struggle with the weight of what you carry. Every knot is a debt. Every scar is a payment. The Cord does not forget. Neither should you.
- You may be asked to cut a thread—to release a debt, to forgive a promise, to let someone go free. The Cord does not forbid mercy. It asks only that you remember.

- Your Hollowed is always watching. You have stopped noticing. Others never do.

17.4.II Common Quirks

You tie and untie knots in a length of grey cord when thinking. It is not nervous energy. It is accounting.

You sometimes touch your tattoos as if checking a pulse. The tattoos are warm when a debt is near.

You cannot accept a gift without naming its price aloud. Even a cup of tea. Even a compliment.

Your Hollowed sits in the corner of every room. You have never introduced it. No one has asked.

17.4.12 Sample NPC: Sister Alva of the Unbroken Cord

Archetype: Bloodsworn

Patron: The High Mother

Codex: Flesh-tattoos that weep when debts come due

Thiasos: A Hollowed child with milk-white eyes that never blink

Personality: Quiet, steady, inexhaustible. She has witnessed a thousand confessions. She has never repeated one.

Conflict: A debt she collected thirty years ago has come due again—not from the original debtor, but from their grandchild. The Cord does not distinguish between generations. Alva must decide: collect, or cut the thread for the first time.

Quote: *"The soup is free. The price never is. They ask me why I don't eat. I tell them I am not hungry. I do not tell them I am already full—of others' debts."*

17.4.13 GM Guidance: Bloodsworn Story Hooks

- A Hollowed's gaze lingers on a character. They feel watched. Next roll involving secrecy is Desperate.
- A thread of grey cord appears tied around a character's wrist. They cannot recall when it happened.
- The High Mother's attention falls on a character. They dream of the Cord. When they wake, they have forgotten a significant memory (GM chooses—a face, a secret, a location).
- A Bloodsworn is asked to cut a thread that has held for generations. The Cord will remember. The question is: will they?

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

17.5 Ghe'hai Operative (Lethai Syncretic)

17.5.1 The Story of Silk-Weaver Mira

She wore a mask of woven silk. Beneath it, she was anyone—and no one.

From the Archives of the Silk Vigil

Mira was not born into the Ghe'hai. She was recruited—or perhaps stolen is the better word. A child of the Crimson Valley, she showed an early gift for knots and silences. The Lethai do not waste such gifts.

She trained for ten years in the ways of the Silk Vigil: how to read a room by the tension of its threads, how to kill without drawing blood, how to negotiate from a position of absolute weakness. Her teachers were masks, not faces. She never knew their names.

Her Codex is a woven silk mask, each thread a memory of a face she has worn. Her Thiasos is a spider-spirit that weaves threads between people. Her Rites are the knots she ties and unties with a whisper.

She has killed nine people. She has saved twice that many. She does not remember the difference.

17.5.2 The Mask That Fits

Mira carries seven masks in a silk bag. Each is a different face—a merchant, a servant, a noble, a beggar. She has worn them all. She is not sure which one is hers.

The masks were not carved. They were grown—from mulberry trees, watered with tears and memory. When she puts one on, her face becomes the mask's. Her voice becomes the mask's. Her soul becomes the mask's—for a time.

She never wears the same mask twice in the same city.

17.5.3 The Thread That Binds

In the Crimson Valley, the Ghe'hai do not fight. They negotiate. Their weapons are silk cords and silvered tongues. A Ghe'hai operative can end a feud with a sentence, start a war with a whisper, or simply vanish into the crowd like smoke through a keyhole.

Mira's signature is a single strand of red silk, tied around a door handle or a bedpost or a throat. It means: *I was here. You owe me.*

No one knows what the debt is until she collects.

17.5.4 The River at Midnight

Mira was sent to retrieve a locket from a dead woman's estate. The locket contained nothing—only a lock of auburn hair and a scrap of red thread. Her client would not say why it mattered.

She found the locket in a vault beneath a burned chapel. The vault was guarded by a ghost—a woman with a brass hook and no shadow. The ghost did not attack. She simply asked: *Why are you here?*

Mira answered: *To deliver what was never stolen.*

The ghost stepped aside. The locket was warm. The thread was red. Mira left it on a riverbank at dawn. She did not look back.

17.5.5 What the Ghe'hai Operative Carries

A Ghe'hai operative carries silk and steel. They carry masks and memories. They carry the weight of every face they have worn, every debt they have collected, every secret they have kept.

But most of all, they carry the knowledge that the strongest weapon is not a blade—it is a thread, tied at the right moment, witnessed by no one.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

17.6 Ghe'hai Operative (Lethai Syncretic)

17.6.1 Concept

The Ghe'hai operative is an elite warrior-assassin-negotiator of the Lethai courts. They are not soldiers. They are not spies. They are something in between—a diplomat who carries a knife, an assassin who prefers not to use it, a whisper who can become a scream.

Their Codex is a silk mask or a spider-silk cord. Their Thiasos is a spider-spirit that weaves threads between people, or a sentient blade wrapped in silk that never dulls. Their Rites are subtle, social, and often invisible—a veil, a binding thread, a whispered command.

A Ghe'hai operative does not fight fair. They do not fight at all if they can avoid it. But when they do, the enemy is already tangled.

17.6.2 Core Attributes

- **Primary:** Presence, Wits
- **Secondary:** Body
- **Tertiary:** Spirit

17.6.3 Skills

- **Core:** Deception, Insight, Stealth
- **Secondary:** Melee, Sway, Subterfuge
- **Tertiary:** Lore (Lethai customs), Performance

17.6.4 Codex

The Ghe'hai operative's Codex is a tool of subtlety and disguise:

- **Silk Mask:** A mask of woven silk that shifts patterns. Rites are woven into the silk, invisible until touched. Wearing it grants +1 die to Deception.
- **Spider-Silk Cord:** A length of pale, almost invisible silk. Stronger than steel. Each knot is a Rite waiting to be invoked.
- **Woven Glove:** A silk glove on the off-hand. It can tie threads, bind lips, or simply rest—waiting.

17.6.5 Thiasos

- **Spider-Spirit:** A translucent spider the size of a hand. It weaves threads between people, binding them in webs of obligation. Can sense hidden relationships (debt, affection, rivalry) within Near range. Cap 2, cannot be harmed by mundane means.
- **Memory-Echo:** A spirit that cannot speak, but can replay sounds it has witnessed—a confession, a scream, a name spoken in the dark. Cap 2, Harm 3.
- **The Silk Mask (Sentient):** A mask that speaks in a neutral, androgynous voice. Can assume the appearance of any face the Runekeeper has touched (once per session, for one scene). (See Optional Rule: Sentient Thiasos)

17.6.6 Signature Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Silk Binding (4 XP)

Tags: [BIND], [SILENCE], [THRESHOLD]

Immobilize a target with invisible threads. They suffer -1 die to all physical actions for one scene. Breaking free requires a Body + Athletics test (DV 4) and an action.

Low Rite: Rite of the Velvet Whisper (4 XP)

Tags: [SILENCE], [MANIPULATION], [BOOST]

Your private words carry irresistible charm. Gain +1 die to Sway a single target in confidential conversation. On a success, they may also reveal a minor secret without realizing it.

Standard Rite: Rite of the Mask of Many Faces (7 XP)

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [VEIL], [DECEPTION]

Assume the appearance of any person you have touched for one scene. Your voice, build, and mannerisms change. You do not gain their memories or skills. Detecting the disguise requires a contested Insight roll (DV 4).

Standard Rite: Rite of the Spinner's Web (8 XP)**Tags:** [BOND], [FATE], [MANIPULATION]

Link two actors with an invisible strand. For the rest of the scene, whenever one acts, the other is dragged into consequence. You may trigger this linkage once to force 1 SB on the linked target after they perform a significant action.

High Rite: Rite of the Unspoken Question (12 XP)**Tags:** [MIND], [TRUTH], [FEAR]

Force a target within Near range to answer one question truthfully. They may resist with Resolve (DV 5). On a failure, they answer—one sentence, no evasion. On a success, they suffer 1 Fatigue from the effort of resistance.

17.6.7 Signature Talents**Ghe'hai's Escape (6 XP)****Requirement:** Lethai Syncretic, Wits 3+

Once per session, when you are cornered or capture is inevitable, you may declare that you prepared an escape route. You vanish, reappearing in a safe location of the GM's choosing, but you leave behind a token (a mask, a silk cord, a single word) that can be used to track you.

Mask of Many Faces (4 XP)**Requirement:** Lethai Syncretic

You can change your appearance as an action. This is not illusion—it is physical transformation. You may alter your face, build, and voice. You cannot mimic a specific person without a token (hair, signature, worn clothing). The change lasts until you choose to revert.

The Unseen Thread (8 XP)**Requirement:** Lethai Syncretic, Presence 3+

Once per session, you may declare that a target owes you a debt from a previous, forgotten interaction. They must test Spirit + Resolve (DV 4) or accept the truth of the debt. If they fail, they owe you one significant service or truth.

17.6.8 Sample Build — Tier I (30-40 XP)

- **Attributes:** Presence 3 (9 XP), Wits 3 (9 XP), Body 2 (6 XP), Spirit 1 (3 XP) — Total 27 XP
- **Skills:** Deception 2 (4 XP), Insight 1 (2 XP), Stealth 1 (2 XP) — Total 8 XP
- **Talents:** Flesh Codex (2 XP), Ghe'hai's Escape (6 XP), Mask of Many Faces (4 XP) — Total 12 XP (using bonds/complications for remaining XP)
- **Remaining XP:** -3 (use 1 bond for +2 XP, 1 complication for +4 XP to reach 41 XP)

17.6.9 Sample Build — Tier III (91-150 XP)

- **Attributes:** Presence 4 (15 XP), Wits 4 (15 XP), Body 3 (9 XP), Spirit 2 (6 XP) — Total 45 XP
- **Skills:** Deception 3 (9 XP), Insight 2 (6 XP), Stealth 2 (6 XP), Melee 2 (6 XP), Sway 2 (6 XP), Subterfuge 1 (2 XP) — Total 35 XP
- **Talents:** Flesh Codex, Ghe'hai's Escape, Mask of Many Faces, The Unseen Thread (8 XP), Engraved Defense (6 XP) — Total 20 XP (cumulative)
- **Rites:** Rite of the Silk Binding (4 XP), Rite of the Velvet Whisper (4 XP), Rite of the Mask of Many Faces (7 XP) — Total 15 XP (cumulative)
- **Total XP:** 45 + 35 + 20 + 15 = 115 XP

17.6.10 Roleplaying a Ghe'hai Operative

- You do not fight fair. You fight smart. The enemy does not need to die—only to be neutralized.
- You may be called to negotiate treaties, to infiltrate hostile courts, or to retrieve secrets that cannot be stolen by force.
- You may struggle with identity. The masks you wear are not just disguises—they are selves. You may forget which one is yours.
- You may be asked to kill. The Ghe'hai do not forbid it. But they prefer a living asset to a dead one. You must choose when the knife is necessary.
- Your webs are everywhere. Every debt you collect, every thread you tie, is a resource—or a liability.

17.6.11 Common Quirks

You touch your mask before speaking to a stranger. It is not a nervous habit. It is a choice.

You cannot stand to leave a thread untied. A loose end is a vulnerability.

You have a habit of speaking in conditional tense—"If you were to..." "One might consider..." It is not indecision. It is leverage.

You refuse to make eye contact for more than a heartbeat. The eyes are the first thread.

17.6.12 Sample NPC: Mask-Weaver Sera of the Silk Vigil

Archetype: Ghe'hai Operative

Patron: Lethai Syncretic (Inaea / Isoka / The Witness)

Codex: A silk mask that shifts patterns

Thiasos: A spider-spirit that weaves threads between people

Personality: Calm, watchful, unreadable. She has worn a hundred faces. She is not sure which one is hers.

Conflict: A thread she tied twenty years ago—between a mother and a daughter—has tightened. The daughter is dying. The mother is far away. The thread remembers. Sera must decide: cut it, or let it hold until the end.

Quote: *"I am not the one who tied that thread. I only witnessed it. But the witness is also the weaver. And the weaver is always responsible."*

17.6.13 GM Guidance: Ghe'hai Operative Story Hooks

- A mask the Ghe'hai operative wore in another city has been recognized. Someone from that past life is here—and they are not friendly.
- A thread the operative tied years ago has tightened at the worst possible moment. A debt is coming due.
- The operative is asked to kill someone who does not deserve to die. The Lethai code says: negotiate first. The client says: no negotiation.
- The operative's silk mask begins to speak in a voice they do not recognize. It is asking for a name. The operative does not know which name to give.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

17.7 Beast Warrior (The Savage Heart)

17.7.1 The Story of Mkara the Leopard's Shadow

She wore the pelt of the beast that killed her father. Now she hunts in its skin.

From the Hunt-Songs of Sekogo

Mkara was not always a Beast Warrior. Once, she was a child who watched a leopard drag her father into the tall grass. She was twelve. She had no weapon. She had no magic. She had only her hands and her teeth and a scream that no one heard.

She followed the blood trail for three days. On the third night, she found the leopard sleeping in a cave, its belly full of her father's flesh. She did not have a knife. She used a sharpened stone. It took a long time. The leopard did not die quietly.

She wore its pelt home. The village elders declared her *bint'leopard*—the Leopard's Daughter. They taught her the old ways: how to move without sound, how to kill without waste, how to offer the first bite to the earth.

Her Codex is the leopard's tooth, worn on a leather thong. Her Thiasos is the leopard's spirit, which hunts beside her still. Her Rites are the hunts she undertakes—each one a sacrament, each kill a prayer.

17.7.2 The Scar That Remembers

Mkara has a scar across her ribs—three parallel lines, claw marks from the leopard's death spasm. She does not hide it. She oils it. It is the first scar she earned, but not the last.

Each scar on her body is a hunt remembered. She can touch a scar and recall the scent of the prey, the weight of the strike, the taste of the earth at the moment of the kill. The Savage Heart does not let her forget.

17.7.3 The Hunt That Never Ends

The leopard's spirit hunts beside Mkara. It is not a pet. It is not a servant. It is a pack-brother. It speaks in growls and silences. It does not ask permission. It simply stalks, and Mkara follows.

They have hunted together for twenty years. They have never lost a trail. They have never failed to make the kill. They have never spoken a word to each other—not one. They do not need to.

The hunt is the conversation. The kill is the punctuation.

17.7.4 The River at Dawn

Mkara was hired to hunt a murderer who had fled into the Mistlands. The trail led to the Black River. The murderer was already dead—killed by someone else, someone with a brass hook and no shadow.

Mkara did not mourn the lost quarry. She knelt at the riverbank and offered a piece of dried meat to the water. The leopard's spirit drank beside her.

She did not know whose ghost had stolen her kill. She did not care. The hunt was over. The Savage Heart was satisfied.

17.7.5 What the Beast Warrior Carries

A Beast Warrior carries the pelt of their first kill. They carry the tooth of the beast that changed them. They carry the scars of every hunt that nearly killed them.

But most of all, they carry the knowledge that they are not the apex predator. The wild is patient. The wild is hungry. And the wild is always watching.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

17.8 Beast Warrior (The Savage Heart)

17.8.1 Concept

The Beast Warrior is a predator who hunts as sacrament. They are not guardians of the wild or stewards of nature's balance. They are its teeth and claws. Power comes from taking, from proving strength, from the raw act of predation.

Their Codex is a predator's tooth or a pelt worn as a cloak. Their Thiasos is a wolf-ancestor, a great cat's spirit, or a sentient blade carved from the fang of a legendary beast. Their Rites are the hunts they undertake—each one a prayer, each kill a sacrament.

A Beast Warrior does not fight fair. They fight to win. The hunt does not care about honor. It cares about the kill.

17.8.2 Core Attributes

- **Primary:** Body, Wits
- **Secondary:** Spirit
- **Tertiary:** Presence

17.8.3 Skills

- **Core:** Survival, Stealth, Melee
- **Secondary:** Athletics, Investigation (tracking), Intimidation
- **Tertiary:** Lore (local wildlife), Endurance

17.8.4 Codex

The Beast Warrior's Codex is a trophy of the hunt:

- **Predator's Tooth:** A large canine tooth on a leather thong. It is warm when prey is near. It grows heavier with each kill.
- **Pelt Cloak:** The cured hide of an apex predator (bear, wolf, lion, tiger, leopard). Wearing it grants +1 die to Intimidation and +1 Armor against cold.
- **Claw Necklace:** A string of claws from worthy kills. Each claw holds a memory of the hunt. The necklace clicks when the hunt begins.

17.8.5 Thiasos

- **Wolf-Ancestor:** A grey wolf the size of a pony, with eyes that reflect the Runekeeper's first kill. Tracks across any terrain, fights beside its pack-brother. Cap 3, Harm 5.
- **Great Cat Spirit:** A translucent leopard or tiger that moves without sound. Can stalk a target for hours without being seen. Cap 3, Harm 4.
- **The Fang (Sentient):** A blade carved from the tooth of a legendary beast. It speaks in growls. It hungers. It demands to be fed. (See Optional Rule: Sentient Thiasos)

17.8.6 Signature Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Predator's Gaze (4 XP)

Tags: [MARK], [FEAR], [TRACK]

Mark a single target as your prey. Gain +1 die on all rolls to track, pursue, or intimidate that target. The effect lasts until the target escapes or is killed.

Low Rite: Rite of the Blood Scent (5 XP)**Tags:** [SENSE], [FEAR], [TRACK]

You scent the air like a beast. Gain +2 dice to Investigation or Survival when tracking by smell. You may also detect fear—you sense if a creature within Near is Frightened.

Standard Rite: Rite of the Shifting Shape (8 XP)**Tags:** [TRANSFORM], [BEAST], [BOOST]

Assume the form of a predator for the scene. Choose bear (tank form: +1 Armor, +2 dice to Body rolls, movement reduced) or wolf (striker form: +2 dice to Agility and Stealth, +1 band movement). You may speak but cannot use tools or cast other Rites while transformed.

Standard Rite: Rite of the Pack Hunt (7 XP)**Tags:** [TEAMWORK], [BEAST], [BOOST]

You and up to three willing allies form a hunting pack. While within Near of each other, all gain +1 die to attacks against a single designated prey, and the first ally to attack each round gains +1 Effect.

High Rite: Rite of the Savage Transformation (13 XP)**Tags:** [TRANSFORM], [BEAST], [BOOST], [FEAR]

Fully transform into an apex predator for one scene. You gain the physical attributes of the beast: Body +2, +2 Armor from thick hide, and your melee attacks deal +2 Harm. You cannot speak or use tools. You may end the transformation early as an action. When the transformation ends, you mark 2 Fatigue.

17.8.7 Signature Talents**Beast Form (6 XP)****Requirement:** The Savage Heart, Body 3+

Once per session, you may partially transform into a predator for one scene. Choose one: +2 dice to Stealth (leopard/tiger), +2 dice to Intimidation (bear/lion), or +1 band to movement (wolf/hound). You cannot use this talent while already transformed.

Blood Hunt (4 XP)**Requirement:** The Savage Heart

When you are tracking a target that you have wounded, you gain +1 die to all tracking and pursuit rolls. The scent of their blood is a trail you cannot lose.

Alpha's Roar (8 XP)**Requirement:** The Savage Heart, Presence 3+

Once per session, you may make a terrifying sound—a roar, a howl, a scream. All enemies within Near range must test Resolve (DV 4) or become Shaken (-1 die to all actions) for one exchange. Does not affect creatures that are immune to fear.

17.8.8 Sample Build — Tier I (30-40 XP)

- **Attributes:** Body 3 (9 XP), Wits 3 (9 XP), Spirit 2 (6 XP), Presence 1 (3 XP) — Total 27 XP
- **Skills:** Survival 2 (4 XP), Stealth 1 (2 XP), Melee 1 (2 XP) — Total 8 XP
- **Talents:** Flesh Codex (2 XP), Blood Hunt (4 XP), Scarred Resilience (3 XP) — Total 9 XP
- **Remaining XP:** -4 (use 2 bonds for +4 XP to reach 40 XP)

17.8.9 Sample Build — Tier III (91-150 XP)

- **Attributes:** Body 4 (18 XP), Wits 4 (15 XP), Spirit 3 (12 XP), Presence 2 (6 XP) — Total 51 XP
- **Skills:** Survival 3 (9 XP), Stealth 3 (9 XP), Melee 3 (9 XP), Athletics 2 (6 XP), Intimidation 2 (6 XP), Investigation (tracking) 1 (2 XP) — Total 41 XP
- **Talents:** Flesh Codex, Blood Hunt, Scarred Resilience, Beast Form (6 XP), Alpha's Roar (8 XP) — Total 20 XP (cumulative)
- **Rites:** Rite of the Predator's Gaze (4 XP), Rite of the Blood Scent (5 XP), Rite of the Shifting Shape (8 XP) — Total 17 XP (cumulative)
- **Total XP:** 51 + 41 + 20 + 17 = 129 XP

17.8.10 Roleplaying a Beast Warrior

- You do not fight for glory. You hunt for survival. The kill is sacrament; the meat is blessing.
- You may be called to track fugitives, hunt dangerous beasts, or lead a pack in war.
- You may struggle with the hunger. The Savage Heart does not ask you to be gentle. It asks you to be true—to the hunt, to the pack, to yourself.
- You may be asked to kill something that does not deserve to die. The Heart does not care about deserving. The Heart is hungry.
- Your scars are your resume. Each one is a story. Each one is a warning.

17.8.11 Common Quirks

You sniff the air when you enter a room. You are not being rude. You are scenting for threats.

You cannot sleep indoors. The walls are a cage. You will find a way to sleep under the sky, even if it is just a courtyard.

You have a habit of offering the first bite of any meal to the earth. It is not prayer. It is tribute.

You growl when angry. You do not notice you are doing it. Others notice.

17.8.12 Sample NPC: Mkara of the Leopard's Shadow

Archetype: Beast Warrior

Patron: The Savage Heart

Codex: A leopard's tooth on a leather thong

Thiasos: A leopard's spirit that hunts beside her

Personality: Silent, patient, deadly. She has never lost a hunt. She has never needed to speak.

Conflict: A child has wandered into the territory of a wounded leopard. The leopard is dangerous. The child is innocent. The hunt says: kill. The heart says: wait. The leopard is watching.

Quote: *"The leopard does not hate you. It does not love you. It is hungry. That is all. That is enough."*

17.8.13 GM Guidance: Beast Warrior Story Hooks

- The Beast Warrior's prey escapes—not because of poor skill, but because the prey was not worthy. The Savage Heart is displeased.
- A rival predator enters the Beast Warrior's territory. It does not attack. It watches. It is judging.
- The Beast Warrior's pelt cloak begins to itch. The beast whose skin it was is not entirely dead. It dreams.
- The hunt lasts too long. The Beast Warrior marks 1 Fatigue. The hunger grows. The Savage Heart whispers: *faster*.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

17.9 Fractal Warrior (The Ninth)**17.9.1 The Story of Geometer Tolin**

I calculated the Ninth digit of pi. For three days, I saw the angles between thoughts. Then I forgot how to speak. The Ninth gives and takes in the same breath.

From the confession of Geometer Tolin, Aeler Deep Vaults

Tolin was a mathematician. He studied the Sacred Geometry—the divine ratios that spiral galaxies, the symmetry that lattices frost, the measures that turn sound into song. He was good at it. He was too good at it.

He calculated the ninth digit of pi. No one had done it before. No one has done it since. The number should not exist. It is the gap between what can be known and what cannot. Tolin looked into the gap. The gap looked back.

For three days, he saw the angles between thoughts. He could predict the fall of a leaf, the turn of a card, the trajectory of a blade before it was drawn. He could not speak. The words were there, but the order was wrong. The geometry of language had fractured.

He recovered slowly. The Ninth's gift remained—not a blessing, not a curse, but a lens. He sees the world not as it is, but as it could be. He steps where the blow will not land. He speaks the truth that ends arguments. He is never surprised.

He is never entirely present either.

17.9.2 The Fracture That Remembers

Tolin carries a broken mirror in a leather satchel. It was once a single piece, polished to perfection. He shattered it on purpose—each shard holds a different angle of the same truth. When he needs to see what is hidden, he holds a shard to his eye. The shard shows him not what is there, but what could be there. The difference is a weapon.

He has seven shards. He lost the eighth. He is not sure if he ever had it.

17.9.3 The Step That Is Not There

In battle, Tolin does not dodge. He steps where the blow will not land. This is not prediction—it is geometry. He sees the angles that others cannot see. The space between the sword and the flesh is not empty. It is a door. He steps through.

He does not know how he does this. He does not ask. The Ninth does not answer questions. It only shows.

17.9.4 The River at Dawn

Tolin was present at the Black River when the locket was returned. He did not interfere. He only watched—from an angle that should not exist, at a time that was not quite dawn. He saw the ghost with the brass hook. He saw the knight with the silver gauntlet. He saw the locket sink.

He did not speak. The Ninth had given him a glimpse of what the locket contained—not hair, not thread, but a name. The name was not for him. He did not write it down. The Ninth does not permit witnesses to betray their witness.

He left before the sun rose. His shadow followed a half-step behind.

17.9.5 What the Fractal Warrior Carries

A Fractal Warrior carries broken mirrors and impossible angles. They carry the weight of what they have seen and cannot speak. They carry the knowledge that the future is not fixed—it is a branching tree, and they can see the branches.

But most of all, they carry the certainty that some doors should not be opened, some numbers should not be calculated, and some angles should not be seen. The Ninth does not warn. It only shows.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

17.10 Fractal Warrior (The Ninth)

17.10.1 Concept

The Fractal Warrior is a warrior who fights with impossible angles and precognition. They do not rely on strength or speed—they rely on geometry. They see the trajectory of a blade before it is drawn. They step where the blow will not land. They speak truths that end arguments because they have already seen the outcome.

Their Codex is a broken mirror or a fractal slate. Their Thiasos is a pattern-spirit that shows glimpses of the future, a memory-spirit that records what has not yet happened, or a sentient shard that whispers angles. Their Rites are not declarations—they are corrections. The world is wrong. The Fractal Warrior sets it right.

A Fractal Warrior is never entirely present. They are always a half-step ahead, or a half-step behind. The Ninth does not permit stillness.

17.10.2 Core Attributes

- **Primary:** Wits, Spirit
- **Secondary:** Body
- **Tertiary:** Presence

17.10.3 Skills

- **Core:** Lore (Geometry), Insight, Investigation
- **Secondary:** Melee, Athletics, Survival
- **Tertiary:** Arcana, Stealth

17.10.4 Codex

The Fractal Warrior's Codex is a testament to broken perception:

- **Broken Mirror:** A shattered mirror, carried in a leather satchel. Each shard shows a different angle. Holding a shard to the eye reveals hidden patterns (gaining +1 die to Investigation or Insight).
- **Fractal Slate:** A slate tablet covered in spiraling, unfinished equations. The equations change—constantly—as the Ninth recalculates. The slate is never complete.
- **Angle Lens:** A brass-and-glass lens cut with a faceted surface. Looking through it shows the world not as it is, but as it could be. Disorienting. Useful.

17.10.5 Thiasos

- **Pattern-Spirit:** A translucent form of shifting geometry—spirals, fractals, impossible angles. It can show a glimpse of the future: once per session, the GM must answer a yes/no question about an upcoming roll. Cap 2, Harm 3.
- **Memory-Echo:** A spirit that cannot speak, but can replay sounds it has witnessed—including sounds that have not happened yet. The GM decides what it "remembers." Cap 2, Harm 3.
- **The Fractal Slate (Sentient):** A slate that speaks in overlapping voices. Can predict the outcome of a single roll (the GM must answer "success" or "failure" before the roll). (See Optional Rule: Sentient Thiasos)

17.10.6 Signature Rites

Low Rite: Rite of the Ninth Figure (4 XP)

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [THRESHOLD]

Glimpse past the ordinary frame of measure. Gain +1 die to Lore or Investigation when wrestling complex systems or many-layered problems.

Low Rite: Rite of the Unseen Angle (5 XP)

Tags: [PREDICTION], [BOOST]

You see the trajectory of a blade before it is drawn. For one scene, gain +1 die to defense rolls against melee attacks. You cannot be surprised by a visible enemy.

Standard Rite: Rite of the Hypercognitive Lattice (8 XP)

Tags: [BOOST], [THRESHOLD], [OVERFLOW]

Widen the mind's mouth. For this scene, treat your Wits as +2 higher for information-processing rolls; you may track several intricate streams at once.

Standard Rite: Rite of the Breaking Glyph (7 XP)

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [TRUTH], [THRESHOLD]

Take one pattern whole. Choose a complex system, theory, or design and gain perfect internal grasp of it; receive +3 dice to related knowledge rolls for the session.

High Rite: Rite of the Ninth Revelation (14 XP)

Tags: [TRUTH], [THRESHOLD], [TRANSFORM], [FATE]

Glimpse a shard of Ninth truth. Take one major insight that overleaps common frames—perfect command of a knotty system, forecast of chaotic motion, or comprehension of an "impossible" relation.

17.10.7 Signature Talents**Glimpse Beyond (4 XP)****Requirement:** The Ninth

Once per session, look at a complex situation (a crime scene, a puzzle lock, a battle formation) and instantly intuit the single most important hidden detail. The GM gives you one piece of information that would otherwise require a successful Investigation roll. Mark 1 Fatigue after using this talent.

Fractal Step (6 XP)**Requirement:** The Ninth, Wits 3+

Once per scene, when you are attacked, you may step where the blow will not land. Treat your Position as one step higher (Desperate → Controlled, Controlled → Dominant) for that defense. You must declare this before the roll.

Pattern Recognition (8 XP)**Requirement:** The Ninth, Tier II+

You see patterns in everything—the way dust falls, the arrangement of stones, the spacing of guards. Once per session, you may ask the GM one yes/no question about a pattern or hidden connection in the current scene. The GM must answer truthfully.

17.10.8 Sample Build — Tier I (30-40 XP)

- **Attributes:** Wits 3 (9 XP), Spirit 3 (9 XP), Body 2 (6 XP), Presence 1 (3 XP) — Total 27 XP
- **Skills:** Lore (Geometry) 2 (4 XP), Insight 1 (2 XP), Investigation 1 (2 XP) — Total 8 XP
- **Talents:** Flesh Codex (2 XP), Glimpse Beyond (4 XP), Scarred Resilience (3 XP) — Total 9 XP (using bonds/complications for remaining XP)
- **Remaining XP:** -4 (use 2 bonds for +4 XP to reach 40 XP)

17.10.9 Sample Build — Tier III (91-150 XP)

- **Attributes:** Wits 4 (15 XP), Spirit 4 (15 XP), Body 3 (9 XP), Presence 2 (6 XP) — Total 45 XP
- **Skills:** Lore (Geometry) 3 (9 XP), Insight 2 (6 XP), Investigation 2 (6 XP), Melee 2 (6 XP), Athletics 1 (2 XP) — Total 29 XP
- **Talents:** Flesh Codex, Glimpse Beyond, Scarred Resilience, Fractal Step (6 XP), Pattern Recognition (8 XP), Engraved Defense (6 XP) — Total 20 XP (cumulative)
- **Rites:** Rite of the Ninth Figure (4 XP), Rite of the Unseen Angle (5 XP), Rite of the Hypercognitive Lattice (8 XP) — Total 17 XP (cumulative)
- **Total XP:** 45 + 29 + 20 + 17 = 111 XP

17.10.10 Roleplaying a Fractal Warrior

- You do not see the world as others see it. You see the angles between things—the gaps, the possibilities, the roads not taken.
- You may be called to solve puzzles, to predict enemy movements, or to decipher codes that should not be decipherable.
- You may struggle with presence. You are always a half-step ahead—or a half-step behind. The present moment is not where you live.
- You may be asked to stop calculating—to act without prediction, to trust without knowing. The Ninth does not permit faith. It permits only angles.
- Your shadow may move independently. You do not discuss this.

17.10.11 Common Quirks

You count steps without noticing. Not eight—always nine. You never reach nine. You stop at eight and pause.

You have a habit of tilting your head when someone speaks. You are not listening to their words. You are reading the geometry of their lies.

You cannot stand to leave a pattern incomplete. A broken symmetry is a wound. You must fix it—or explain why not.

You refuse to make predictions aloud. The Ninth does not permit witnesses to betray their witness.

17.10.12 Sample NPC: Geometer Venn of the Fractured Mirror

Archetype: Fractal Warrior

Patron: The Ninth

Codex: A broken mirror, each shard showing a different angle

Thiasos: A pattern-spirit that shows glimpses of the future

Personality: Distant, precise, weary. He has seen too many futures. He is not sure which one is happening now.

Conflict: A pattern he predicted twenty years ago is finally manifesting—not as he foresaw, but as he feared. He could intervene. But intervention would break the pattern. The Ninth does not permit broken patterns.

Quote: *"I saw this moment. Not the details—the angles. The geometry was clear. Someone would have to choose. I did not see who. I did not see if I would be the one."*

17.10.13 GM Guidance: Fractal Warrior Story Hooks

- The Fractal Warrior sees a pattern that should not exist—a coincidence too precise, a symmetry too perfect. Something is editing reality.

- A prediction the Fractal Warrior made years ago has come true—but not as they expected. The future is a branching tree. They saw one branch. Another branch is happening now.
- The Fractal Warrior's broken mirror shows a face that is not theirs. The face is familiar. They cannot place it. The mirror will not explain.
- The Fractal Warrior dreams of a number—the ninth digit of pi. It is changing. The world is being recalculated. The Ninth is recalculating. The Fractal Warrior cannot wake up.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

17.II Multiclassing and Hybrid Builds

A Runic Warrior is already a hybrid—warrior and Runekeeper, flesh and covenant. But the Six Roads do not end at the Runekeeper's path. A Runic Warrior may also walk the roads of the Cantor, the Witch, or the Psion. They may train in the monasteries of the Silent Choir or the fighting pits of the Savage Heart.

This chapter provides guidance for combining Runic Warrior with other character archetypes.

17.II.1 Principles of Hybridization

The Cost of Breadth

Every hybrid pays a price. Spreading XP across multiple paths means slower advancement in each. A pure Runic Warrior will have more Rites, higher Body, and deeper Obligation. A hybrid will have more options but less depth.

Thematic Coherence

Not every combination makes sense. A Dawn Warrior (Oath of Flame and Light) who sings as a Cantor of Palinode is a natural fit—both are public, performative, and vow-bound. A Bloodsworn (High Mother) who trains as a Psion is a stretch—the Cord values witnesses, not internal silence. Choose combinations that tell a coherent story.

Shared Attributes

Runic Warriors value Body and Spirit. Cantors value Presence and Spirit. Witches value Wits and Spirit. Psions value Wits and Spirit. These overlaps make certain hybrids more viable than others.

17.II.2 Runic Warrior + Cantor

The Dawn Singer (Oath of Flame and Light + Cantor of Palinode)

Concept: A warrior who sings their vows into battle. Their voice is a weapon; their blade is an encore.

Attribute Priority: Body, Presence, Spirit

Key Talents:

- Cantor's Path (8 XP)

- Dawn's Judgment (6 XP)
- Iron Resolve (7 XP)
- Hymn Against Dread (Low Rite)

Playstyle: Enter battle singing. Your allies gain +2 dice to resist fear. Your blade is kindled. When the song ends, the enemy is broken—or you are.

Thematic Hook: Your voice is not entirely your own. Palinode has noticed you. She may ask for an encore.

The Death Singer (Varnek Karn + Cantor of the Pale Shepherd)

Concept: A warrior who sings funerals into battles. Their voice guides the dying; their blade collects the debts.

Attribute Priority: Spirit, Presence, Body

Key Talents:

- Cantor's Path (8 XP)
- The Silent Ledger (6 XP)
- Rite of the Passing Flock (Standard Rite)
- Comforting Presence (4 XP)

Playstyle: You do not kill—you guide. Your songs ease the passage of the dying. Your blade is a shepherd's crook. When an enemy falls, you sing them across the threshold.

Thematic Hook: The Pale Shepherd walks beside you. You are not sure if you are guiding the dead—or being guided yourself.

17.11.3 Runic Warrior + Witch

The Bloodsworn Witch (High Mother + Witch of the Cord)

Concept: A Daughter of the Cord who fights with knots and blades. Their flesh is a Codex; their blood is a Rite.

Attribute Priority: Body, Wits, Spirit

Key Talents:

- Craft of the Hedge (4 XP)
- Cord of Flesh (8 XP)
- The Red Thread (4 XP)
- Rite of the Flesh-Knot (Standard Rite)

Playstyle: You store Fatigue as knots in your flesh. You bind enemies with invisible threads. You heal yourself by cutting a knot. You are never unarmed—your body is a weapon.

Thematic Hook: The Cord is not a leash. It is a web. You are the spider. But the spider is also caught.

The Root Witch (Grimmir + Witch of the Wild)

Concept: A warrior who fights with root and thorn. Their Rites are carved into living bark; their Thiasos is a wolf-ancestor.

Attribute Priority: Body, Wits, Spirit

Key Talents:

- Craft of the Hedge (4 XP)
- Wild Shape (6 XP)
- Rite of the Shifting Shape (Standard Rite)
- Beast Speech (8 XP)

Playstyle: You are the forest's teeth. You transform into a predator. You speak with wolves. You heal by consuming the fallen. The season guides your blade.

Thematic Hook: The forest is watching. Grimmir is patient. But the forest is also hungry.

17.II.4 Runic Warrior + Psion**The Fractal Knight (The Ninth + Psion)**

Concept: A warrior who fights with impossible angles. Their blade strikes where it should not reach. Their mind sees three seconds ahead.

Attribute Priority: Wits, Spirit, Body

Key Talents:

- Psionics (skill)
- Glimpse Beyond (4 XP)
- Rite of the Ninth Revelation (High Rite)
- Precognition (Psionic Art)

Playstyle: You do not react. You anticipate. Every enemy's strike is already accounted for. Every opening is already exploited. You are not faster—you are earlier.

Thematic Hook: The Ninth does not give answers. It gives questions. You are beginning to see the patterns. You are not sure you want to.

The Shadow Mind (Ikasha + Psion)

Concept: A warrior who fights from concealment and from within. Their blade is unseen; their thoughts are unheard.

Attribute Priority: Wits, Spirit, Body

Key Talents:

- Psionics (skill)
- Shadow Meld (6 XP)
- Rite of the Umbral Dream (High Rite)
- Telepathy (Psionic Art)

Playstyle: You are never where they expect. Your thoughts are your own. Your blade appears from darkness. You vanish before they can scream.

Thematic Hook: Ikasha sleeps. But she dreams. Sometimes, you dream with her. You are not sure whose thoughts are whose.

17.11.5 Runic Warrior + Monk (Unarmed Combatant)

The Vowed Fist (The Silent Choir + Monk)

Concept: A warrior who has sworn never to speak. Their fists are their voice. Their silence is a weapon.

Attribute Priority: Body, Spirit, Wits

Key Talents:

- Unarmed Combatant (4 XP)
- Calm Presence (6 XP)
- Rite of the Gentle Seal (Low Rite)
- Flurry of Blows (6 XP)

Playstyle: You do not speak. You act. Your fists bind; your palms release. You are a witness, not an advocate. The Silent Choir listens through you.

Thematic Hook: You have taken a vow of silence. The Choir witnesses. But there are things that need to be said. You must find another way.

The Beast Unleashed (The Savage Heart + Monk)

Concept: A warrior who fights with claw and fang. Their body is a weapon; their hunger is a Rite.

Attribute Priority: Body, Spirit, Wits

Key Talents:

- Unarmed Combatant (4 XP)
- Beast Form (6 XP)
- Rite of the Shifting Shape (Standard Rite)
- Flurry of Blows (6 XP)

Playstyle: You are the predator. Your fists are claws. Your bite is a Rite. You do not need a blade—you are the blade.

Thematic Hook: The Savage Heart is patient. The hunt is sacrament. But you are not sure if you are hunting—or being hunted.

17.11.6 Hybrid XP Planning

Tier I (30-40 XP) — Pick One Path

At Tier I, focus on one path. Take foundational talents in your primary archetype. Do not spread XP thin.

- **Example (Dawn Singer):** Body 3, Presence 2, Spirit 2. Cantor's Path (8 XP). Dawn's Judgment (6 XP). Melee 2, Command 1, Performance 1. Total: 30 XP.

Tier II (41-90 XP) — Add the Second Path

At Tier II, you have room to add a second path. Take 2-3 key talents or Rites from the secondary archetype.

- **Example (Dawn Singer):** Add Hymn Against Dread (4 XP). Add Iron Resolve (7 XP). Raise Spirit to 3. Total: 65 XP.

Tier III (91-150 XP) — Deepen the Hybrid

At Tier III, both paths are functional. You can invoke Rites, sing Songs, and fight on the front line.

- **Example (Dawn Singer):** Raise Body to 4, Presence to 3. Add Rite of the Dawnfire Covenant (12 XP). Add Unquenchable (4 XP). Total: 115 XP.

17.11.7 Thematic Hybrid Table

|po.2|po.25|po.25|po.2|

Base Patron Hybrid With Archetype Name Key Trait

Oath of Flame & Light	Cantor (Palinode)	Dawn Singer	Voice as weapon
Oath of Flame & Light	Witch (Hearth)	Flame-Keeper	Fire as comfort
Mykkiel	Cantor (Witness)	Truth Singer	Oaths as Song
Mykkiel	Monk	Silent Justicar	Fists as gavel
Sealed Gate	Witch (Threshold)	Gate-Keeper	Wards as Rites
Grimmir	Witch (Wild)	Root Witch	Forest as ally
Grimmir	Monk	Wild Fist	Claw as weapon
Carrion-King	Cantor (Pale Shepherd)	Death Singer	Endings as Song
Carrion-King	Monk	Rot Fist	Decay as strength
Savage Heart	Monk	Beast Unleashed	Hunger as Rite
Savage Heart	Cantor (Thrysos)	Revel Hunter	Ecstasy as weapon
Varnek Karn	Cantor (Pale Shepherd)	Cairn Singer	Ancestors as chorus

Varnek Karn Monk Grave Fist Wergild as strength
 High Mother Witch (Cord) Bloodsworn Witch Flesh as Codex
 High Mother Monk Silent Daughter Knots as fists
 Ikasha Psion Shadow Mind Thoughts as concealment
 Ikasha Monk Unseen Fist Silence as weapon
 The Ninth Psion Fractal Knight Precognition as defense
 The Ninth Cantor (Silent Choir) Paradox Singer Omissions as Song
 Lethai Syncretic Psion Web Mind Threads as thoughts
 Lethai Syncretic Cantor (Livaea) Silk Singer Seduction as Song

17.11.8 Risks of Hybridization

Obligation and Corruption

A Runic Warrior tracks Obligation. A Cantor tracks Corruption. A Psion tracks Mental Strain. A hybrid tracks all three. This is not impossible—but it is demanding.

Guidance: Use one track as primary (Obligation for Runekeeper hybrids). Treat secondary tracks as occasional costs, not constant pressures.

Action Economy

A Runic Warrior fights. A Cantor sings. A Witch weaves. A Psion concentrates. You cannot do all three in the same exchange.

Guidance: Choose one role per scene. Fight when the enemy is close. Sing when the crowd is watching. Weave when the threshold is near. Concentrate when the truth is hidden.

Thematic Dilution

A hybrid can feel unfocused. A Dawn Warrior who also sings, weaves, and reads minds may seem like a jack of all trades, master of none.

Guidance: Embrace the tension. A hybrid is not diluted—they are multifaceted. The Dawn Warrior who sings does not sing for applause. They sing for the flame. The Bloodsworn who weaves does not weave for profit. They weave for the Cord. The Fractal Knight who reads minds does not read for secrets. They read to survive.

17.11.9 Final Advice

Hybrids are not for every player. They require careful XP planning, thematic coherence, and a willingness to accept limitations. But when they work, they tell stories that pure archetypes cannot.

A Dawn Singer's blade is kindled. Their voice is a hymn. The enemy does not know which to fear more.

A Bloodsworn Witch's flesh is a ledger. Their knots are debts. The Cord weaves through them—and they through the Cord.

A Fractal Knight's mind is three seconds ahead. Their blade is already there. The enemy is already dead. They simply haven't noticed yet.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Part IV

GM Guidance

Chapter 18

Running Runic Warriors

18.1 Running Runic Warriors as NPCs

Runic Warriors make compelling non-player characters because their covenant is visible. A scarred hand, an engraved gorget, a sentient blade that speaks unbidden—these are not subtle people. They are walking declarations of allegiance, and the world reacts to them accordingly.

This chapter provides guidance for using Runic Warriors as antagonists, allies, and neutral parties, followed by sample NPCs for each Patron family.

18.1.1 Villains

A Runic Warrior villain is not a schemer in a tower. They are warriors who have chosen the wrong Patron, or the right Patron for the wrong reasons.

The Cursed Knight (Malachai)

A knight who accepted Malachai's gift to survive a mortal wound. Now they cannot die—but neither can they stop killing. Their Codex is a silver coin that never spends. Their Thiasos is a Collector, a child with silver-wire eyes who watches in silence.

Motivation: Release from the curse, or the acquisition of enough power to force Malachai to bargain.

Conflict: The knight does not want to fight. They are tired. But the hunger drives them, and the Collector will not let them rest.

Resolution: The party can destroy the knight, cure them (requiring a journey to the Well of Ichor), or help them find a third path—a debt paid in memory rather than blood.

The Rogue Bloodsworn (High Mother)

A Daughter of the Cord who has broken her covenant. She still carries the Rites tattooed on her flesh, but she no longer pays the Cord its due. Now her scars weep. Her Hollowed bird has gone silent. She is dying by inches, and she will drag anyone she can with her.

Motivation: Find a way to sever the Cord without dying, or ensure that the Cord cannot use her debts against her family.

Conflict: She is desperate and unpredictable. She may help the party or betray them, depending on which advances her goal.

Resolution: The party can help her sever the Cord (a dangerous ritual requiring a witness and a sacrifice), turn her over to the Daughters, or kill her and scatter her ashes at a crossroads.

The Fractured Knight (The Ninth)

A warrior who glimpsed too much of the Ninth's truth. They now see patterns that do not exist, hear voices that predict the future, and move in ways that should be impossible. Their Codex is a broken mirror. Their Thiasos is a memory-spirit that speaks in overlapping voices.

Motivation: Find a way to unsee what they have seen, or embrace the fracture and become something beyond human.

Conflict: They are not evil. They are broken. Their actions serve a logic that no one else can perceive.

Resolution: The party can help them stabilize (requiring a ritual at a threshold and the sacrifice of a cherished memory), kill them, or leave them to their fractured path.

18.1.2 Allies

A Runic Warrior ally is a warrior who shares the party's goals, even if their methods differ. They are reliable in a fight, but their covenant may complicate things.

The Dawn Warrior (Oath of Flame & Light)

A knight-commander of a border keep, sworn to protect the lowlands from incursions. Their Codex is an engraved gorget. Their Thiasos is a warhorse with milk-white eyes.

Motivation: Hold the line. Protect the innocent. Keep their oath.

How They Help: Combat support, tactical advice, sanctuary at their keep.

Complication: They cannot break their oath to the keep. If the party asks them to leave their post, they will refuse.

The Ghe'hai Operative (Lethai Syncretic)

A silk-blade assassin who serves the Lethai courts. Their Codex is a woven mask. Their Thiasos is a spider-spirit that weaves invisible threads.

Motivation: Complete their mission without leaving a trace.

How They Help: Infiltration, assassination, information gathering.

Complication: They answer to the Lethai courts. If the party's goals conflict with Lethai interests, the operative will vanish.

The Beast Warrior (Savage Heart)

A Sekogo hunter who wears the skin of a killed predator. Their Codex is a tooth. Their Thiasos is the spirit of the hunt.

Motivation: Hunt what must be hunted. Protect the wild from those who would tame it.

How They Help: Tracking, survival, combat against supernatural foes.

Complication: They do not understand civilization. Laws, debts, and social niceties are meaningless to them.

18.1.3 Neutral Parties

Some Runic Warriors are neither allies nor enemies. They have their own goals, and the party is incidental.

The Itinerant Monk (The Traveler)

A wanderer who carries no home and owes no allegiance. Their Codex is a waystone. Their Thiasos is a road-dog that walks beside them.

Motivation: Walk the road. See what is at the end.

Neutral Stance: They will help if the road leads the same direction. They will not risk their path for the party's convenience.

The Cairn-Knight (Varnek Karn)

A warrior who guards an ancestral burial ground. Their Codex is a rune-carved axe. Their Thiasos is an ancestral shade that fights beside them.

Motivation: Protect the cairn. Settle old wergild. Let the ancestors rest.

Neutral Stance: They will not leave the cairn. If the party needs their help, they must come to the cairn—and respect its laws.

The Warden (The Sealed Gate)

A sentinel who guards a threshold that must not be crossed. Their Codex is a shield. Their Thiasos is a standing stone that wakes when they speak.

Motivation: Keep the threshold sealed. Let nothing pass.

Neutral Stance: They do not care about the party's goals. They care only about the threshold. If the party tries to cross, they become enemies. If the party helps guard, they become allies.

18.1.4 Sample NPCs by Patron Family

The Vowed

- **Dawn Warrior:** *Ser Roran of the Grey Gauntlet.* A knight who carries a silver gauntlet engraved with his oath. He never takes ransom. His warhorse is named Ledger. (Oath of Flame & Light)

- **Hospitaller:** *Sister Bryn, retired.* A one-handed woman with a brass hook. She was a Daughter of the Cord once. Now she tends a hospice. Her Thiasos is a grey bell that rings when someone is dying. (Oath of Mercy & Grace)
- **Justicar:** *Elodie Venn, Queen's Justicar.* A scarred woman with a silver gavel. Her Codex is a shield. Her Thiasos is a spirit-hound that tracks oath-breakers. (Mykkiel)
- **Witch-Hunter:** *Vigil-Commander Vorenius.* A Chain-Lantern prefect. His Codex is a censer. His Thiasos is a lantern that reveals hidden corruption. (Inquisitor Prime)
- **Truth-Sworn:** *The Archivist.* A silent woman who carries a silver mirror. Her Thiasos is a memory-spirit that records every word spoken in her presence. (The Witness)

The Threshold

- **Warden:** *The Sentinel of the Silent Stair.* A figure in grey armor who stands at a chapel door. Their Codex is a shield. Their Thiasos is a standing stone that speaks in the voice of the dead. (The Sealed Gate)
- **Itinerant Monk:** *Brother Ash.* A wanderer who carries a waystone compass. His Thiasos is a road-dog with one blue eye and one brown. (The Traveler)
- **Death Monk:** *The Pallid Sister.* A grey-robed warrior who escorts the dying. Her Codex is a shepherd's crook. Her Thiasos is a spirit-shepherd that sings the names of the dead. (The Pale Shepherd)

The Wild

- **Root-Knight:** *Elder Thorn.* A woman whose skin is bark. Her Codex is a living staff. Her Thiasos is a wolf-ancestor that speaks in growls. (Grimmir)
- **Grave-Warden:** *The Compost-Knight.* A figure in moss-covered armor. Their Codex is a bone-chime. Their Thiasos is a fungal familiar that speaks in spores. (The Carrion-King)
- **Beast Warrior:** *Mkara of the Spiral Throw.* A Sekogo hunter who wears a leopard pelt. Her Codex is a predator's tooth. Her Thiasos is the spirit of the hunt. (The Savage Heart)

The Deep

- **Eldritch Knight:** *The Drowned Prince.* A figure in black glass armor. His Codex is a shard of abyssal glass. His Thiasos is a drowned spirit that speaks in bubbles. (Khemesh)
- **Storm-Sworn:** *The Thunder Shaman.* A Ykrul warrior who carries a drum made from storm-felled wood. Her Thiasos is a storm-spirit that crackles with lightning. (Xhak'Thul)
- **Tide Warrior:** *Captain Mira the Lucky.* A Sidhi pirate with a brass hook. Her Codex is a ship's wheel. Her Thiasos is a selkie that sings in storms. (Raéyn)

The Shadow

- **Shadow Warrior:** *The Unseen.* A figure in a black feather cloak. Their Codex is a raven's quill. Their Thiasos is a raven-spirit that carries whispers. (Ikasha)
- **Vowed Monk:** *The Silent Blade.* A warrior who has sworn never to speak. Their Codex is a sealed-lips tattoo. Their Thiasos is a memory-spirit that speaks for them. (The Silent Choir)
- **Ronin:** *The Storm-Rider.* A masterless warrior on a grey horse. Their Codex is a storm-banner. Their Thiasos is a wind-spirit that rides beside them. (Aveh)

The Web

- **Web Warrior:** *The Spider-Blade.* A Lethai operative in a silk mask. Their Codex is a spider-silk cord. Their Thiasos is a spider-spirit that weaves invisible threads. (Inaea)
- **Serpent Warrior:** *The Shed-Knight.* A warrior who has molted their identity. Their Codex is a shed fang. Their Thiasos is a serpent-spirit that speaks in sibilliance. (Isoka)
- **Cursed Warrior:** *The Thorn-Sworn.* A figure with scars that weep. Their Codex is a silver coin that is always warm. Their Thiasos is a Collector. (Malachai)

The Forge

- **Artificer:** *The Gear-Warrior.* A dwarf in a toolbelt. Their Codex is a schematic-slate. Their Thiasos is a clockwork construct that chitters and ticks. (Clockwork Monad)

The Grave

- **Cairn-Knight:** *The Grave-Warden.* A warrior who guards a burial mound. Their Codex is a rune-carved axe. Their Thiasos is an ancestral shade. (Varnek Karn)
- **Bloodsworn:** *The Cord-Knight.* A Daughter of the Cord with Rites tattooed on her flesh. Her Codex is her skin. Her Thiasos is a hollowed bird with milk-white eyes. (The High Mother)

The Fracture

- **Fractal Warrior:** *The Paradox-Sworn.* A warrior whose eyes see angles that should not exist. Their Codex is a broken mirror. Their Thiasos is a pattern-spirit. (The Ninth)
- **Moon Knight:** *The Silver-Sworn.* A warrior who fights only under moonlight. Their Codex is a silver disc. Their Thiasos is a shadow-cat. (Lunara)

The Lethai Ghe'hai

- **Spec Ops:** *The Silk-Blade*. An elite operative with no name. Their Codex is a woven mask. Their Thiasos is a spider-spirit. They can kill a target in a crowded room and walk out without anyone knowing. (Lethai Syncretic)

18.1.5 Running Runic Warriors in Combat

Runic Warriors are front-line combatants. Use them as:

- **Tanks:** High Body, high Harm threshold, talents that convert damage to Fatigue or Obligation.
- **Strikers:** Rites that enhance weapon damage, grant extra attacks, or ignore armor.
- **Controllers:** Rites that bind foes, create difficult terrain, or force enemies to target them.

Remember that a Runic Warrior's Codex can be targeted. An enemy who sunders a gorget or shatters a staff has done more than damage equipment—they have severed the Runekeeper's connection to their Rites. Use this as a tactical option for intelligent foes.

18.1.6 Runic Warriors in Faction Politics

- **Chain-Lanterns:** Suspicious of Codexes that cannot be confiscated. Tattoos and brands are harder to burn than books.
- **Daughters of the Cord:** View Bloodsworn as sisters or rivals. A Bloodsworn who serves the High Mother may be welcomed; one who serves another Patron may be watched.
- **Aeler Vent-Priors:** Respect Artificers and Cairn-Knights. A Codex that is also a tool is efficient. Efficiency is virtue.
- **Lethai Courts:** Ghe'hai operatives are trusted—until they are not. A Lethai Runic Warrior is a weapon, and weapons can be turned.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

18.2 Runic Warriors in Faction Politics

A Runic Warrior cannot hide their covenant. The engraved gorget, the carved staff, the tattoos curling up the neck—these are not easily concealed. This visibility shapes how factions perceive, use, and oppose them.

This chapter examines how major factions of Fate's Edge interact with Runic Warriors. Each entry includes the faction's general stance, specific points of tension or alliance, and sample story hooks.

18.2.1 Chain-Lanterns of Thepyrgos

The Chain-Lanterns hunt unlicensed magic. They prefer clear evidence: a Codex that can be seized, a Thiasos that can be caged, a confessor who can be made to speak.

A Runic Warrior confounds this preference.

Stance

Officially: Suspicious. A Runekeeper whose Codex is a tattoo cannot be disarmed. A Runekeeper whose Thiasos is a sentient blade cannot be separated from their familiar. This is a threat.

Unofficially: Pragmatic. A Runic Warrior who serves an approved Patron (Mykkiel, the Inquisitor Prime, the Oath of Flame & Light) may be tolerated, even employed.

Tensions

- **Evidence.** How do you confiscate a tattoo? The Chain-Lanterns have resorted to branding over the tattoos, but this destroys the Rites and creates martyrs.
- **Visibility.** A Runic Warrior cannot deny their covenant. This makes them easier to track—but also harder to prosecute, because their allegiance is public.
- **The Bloodsworn.** Daughters of the Cord who serve the High Mother are technically licensed (the Cord has standing with the Thepyrgos courts). But a Bloodsworn who fights is something else. The Chain-Lanterns watch them closely.

Alliances

- **Inquisitor Prime.** Witch-hunters who serve the Prime are natural allies of the Chain-Lanterns. Their Codex is a censer. Their Thiasos is a lantern. They hunt together.
- **Oath of Flame & Light.** Dawn Warriors who swear vows before witnesses are legible to the Chain-Lanterns. A Dawn Knight who fights undead is useful. A Dawn Knight who questions procedure is not.

Hooks

- A Chain-Lantern prefect requests the party's help in identifying a rogue Bloodsworn. The suspect's Rites are tattooed, making them impossible to confiscate. The prefect wants the party to capture—not kill—so the tattoos can be studied.
- A Runic Warrior is accused of unlicensed magic. Their Codex is a family heirloom, a shield passed down for generations. The Chain-Lanterns want to confiscate it. The Runekeeper wants the party to testify that the shield is not a Codex, but armor.
- A Dawn Warrior has gone rogue. They still wear their engraved gorget. The Chain-Lanterns cannot remove it—the gorget is bolted to their breastplate. The party must decide: help the prefect capture the rogue, or help the rogue escape.

18.2.2 Daughters of the Unbroken Cord

The Cord deals in debts, not steel. But some Daughters have learned to fight. They are the Bloodsworn—Runic Warriors who serve the High Mother, their Rites tattooed into their flesh, their Thiasos a hollowed child or heartless bird.

Stance

Officially: The Bloodsworn are still Daughters. They pay their debts like any other sister.

Unofficially: Suspicion. A Daughter who fights may be less willing to collect gently. The Cord prefers subtlety. A Bloodsworn is not subtle.

Tensions

- **The Flesh Codex.** A Bloodsworn's Rites are tattooed on their skin. This is efficient—no Codex to lose—but it also means the Cord cannot audit their Rites without auditing their body.
- **The Hollowed Thiasos.** A hollowed child or heartless bird is a witness, not a combatant. Bloodsworn who use their Thiasos in battle risk attracting the wrong kind of attention.
- **The Open Palm, Closed Cord.** Some Bloodsworn develop the ability to store Fatigue as visible knots in their flesh. This is a gift from the High Mother. It is also a leash.

Alliances

- **The High Mother.** All Bloodsworn serve the High Mother, even if they also serve other Patrons. The Cord is their first debt.
- **The Pale Shepherd.** Both the Cord and the Shepherd tend thresholds—birth, death, passage. Bloodsworn and Death Monks sometimes work together to escort the dying.

Hooks

- A Bloodsworn has stopped paying her tithe to the Cord. Her hollowed bird is silent. The Daughters want the party to find her—and remind her of her debt.
- A rogue Bloodsworn is using her Flesh Codex to record forbidden Rites. The Cord cannot audit her because her tattoos are her own. The party must capture her so a Weaver can read her skin.
- A Bloodsworn offers to help the party with a dangerous mission. Her price: a witness to her next payment to the Cord. She wants someone to know she is still loyal.

18.2.3 Aeler Vent-Priors and Correctors

The Aeler measure everything. A Runic Warrior who is also efficient is respected. A Runic Warrior who is inefficient is a liability.

Stance

Officially: Runic Warriors are evaluated on their utility. An Artificer who maintains the Underways is valuable. A Cairn-Knight who guards a burial mound is acceptable. A Beast Warrior who cannot keep ledgers is not.

Unofficially: Fascination. The Aeler appreciate a Codex that is also a tool. A shield that records Rites is efficient. A staff that grows its own runes is elegant.

Tensions

- **The Breath Bond.** Aeler Correctors use breath-bonds to secure contracts. A Runic Warrior whose Codex is part of their body cannot be breath-bonded in the usual way. This confuses the Correctors.
- **The Forge Clause.** Clockwork Monad Artificers sometimes engrave their Rites onto their own prosthetics. This is allowed—but the Correctors audit the prosthetics every season.
- **The Cairn Oath.** Cairn-Knights who guard Aeler burial mounds are respected, but they are also watched. The ancestors speak through them. The Vent-Priors want to know what the ancestors are saying.

Alliances

- **Clockwork Monad.** Artificers who serve the Monad are natural partners of the Vent-Priors. Efficiency is efficiency.
- **Varnek Karn.** Cairn-Knights who serve Varnek Karn sometimes negotiate with Aeler ancestors. The Vent-Priors tolerate this because it prevents hauntings.

Hooks

- An Aeler Vent-Prior hires the party to audit a Clockwork Monad Artificer. The Artificer's Codex is a prosthetic arm. The Vent-Prior wants to know if the arm has been modified without authorization.
- A Cairn-Knight refuses to allow Aeler surveyors near her burial mound. She claims the ancestors are restless. The Vent-Priors want the party to negotiate access—or confirm that the ancestors are real.
- An Artificer's sentient Thiasos (a clockwork construct) has begun speaking in a language no one understands. The Vent-Priors suspect unauthorized modifications. The Artificer insists the construct is evolving on its own.

18.2.4 Lethai Courts (Crimson Valley and City Elves)

The Lethai do not send armies. They send Ghe'hai—elite operatives who are warriors, diplomats, and assassins all at once. A Ghe'hai operative is a Runic Warrior, their Codex a woven mask, their Thiasos a spider-spirit.

Stance

Officially: The Ghe'hai are essential. They protect Lethai interests without drawing attention. A Ghe'hai who fails is replaced. A Ghe'hai who succeeds is never named.

Unofficially: Fear. The Ghe'hai are weapons. Weapons can be turned. The courts watch them closely.

Tensions

- **The Mask.** A Ghe'hai's Codex is a mask. When worn, they are the operative. When removed, they are no one. This ambiguity is useful—and unsettling.
- **The Spider-Spirit.** A Ghe'hai's Thiasos weaves invisible threads. These threads can bind, trip, or kill. The courts appreciate the utility. They also worry about whose neck the thread is wrapped around.
- **The Unspoken Question.** Some Ghe'hai develop the ability to force a truthful answer from a target. This is a Rite of Inaea. The courts approve—when it is used on enemies.

Alliances

- **Inaea.** Most Ghe'hai serve Inaea, the Spider's Mercy. Their threads bind gently—or not.
- **Isoka.** Some Ghe'hai serve Isoka, the Serpent's Shedding. They change identities as easily as changing masks.
- **Ikasha.** A few serve Ikasha, the Shadow's Silence. They are the ones no one sees coming.

Hooks

- A Ghe'hai operative has gone silent. The Lethai courts want the party to find them—and determine if they have been turned.
- A rival court has deployed its own Ghe'hai. The party is caught between two operatives, each wearing a different mask, each claiming to represent the true Lethai interest.
- A Ghe'hai operative offers to help the party with a mission. Their price: a witness to their next assignment. They want someone to know what they did—in case they do not return.

18.2.5 Black Banner Companies

Mercenary companies care about results. A Runic Warrior who can fight is valuable. A Runic Warrior who cannot be disarmed is invaluable.

Stance

Officially: Runic Warriors are hired like any other soldier. Their Codex is their equipment. Their Thiasos is their mount or weapon.

Unofficially: Respect. A warrior who carries their covenant on their body has proven something. The Black Banners do not ask what. They only ask if the warrior can hold the line.

Tensions

- **Payday.** A Runic Warrior whose Codex is a tattoo cannot sell their equipment. This makes them less likely to desert—but also harder to recruit, because they have no collateral.
- **The Condotta Flip.** A mercenary captain who switches sides may find that their Runic Warrior refuses to follow. Oaths carved into flesh are harder to break than oaths written on paper.
- **The Blood Price.** A Cairn-Knight who serves Varnek Karn may demand wergild for fallen comrades. This is unusual in mercenary companies. The captain must decide: pay, or lose the knight.

Alliances

- **Varnek Karn.** Cairn-Knights who serve Varnek Karn sometimes hire on as mercenaries. They are expensive—they demand wergild—but they are loyal.
- **The Savage Heart.** Beast Warriors sometimes join mercenary companies for the hunt. They leave when the hunt ends.

Hooks

- A mercenary captain hires the party to recruit a Runic Warrior. The target is a Cairn-Knight who refuses to leave their burial mound. The party must convince them—or find another.
- A Runic Warrior in a mercenary company has been accused of desertion. They claim their Codex (a sentient blade) ordered them to leave. The party must determine who is lying.
- A mercenary company is being hunted by a Cursed Knight (Malachai). The knight was once a member. Now they cannot stop killing. The company wants the party to stop them—permanently.

18.2.6 The Covenant (Mykkielan Courts)

The Covenant deals in law, not war. But some Runekeepers serve Mykkiel as Justicars—warriors who enforce oaths with steel.

Stance

Officially: Justicars are officers of the court. Their Codex is a shield. Their Thiasos is a spirit-hound that tracks oath-breakers. They are respected—and feared.

Unofficially: Distrusted. A Justicar who enforces law with a sword is a reminder that the Covenant's power rests on violence.

Tensions

- **The Shield Codex.** A Justicar's shield records their Rites. This is practical—the shield is always in hand—but it also means the Justicar cannot be disarmed without losing their Rites.

- **The Spirit-Hound.** A Justicar's Thiasos tracks oath-breakers. This is useful in court. It is less useful when the hound decides that a judge has broken an oath.
- **The Sentence.** Some Justicars develop the ability to speak a binding judgment. The target is compelled to obey—or suffer. The Covenant approves, as long as the judgment is lawful.

Alliances

- **Mykkiel.** All Justicars serve Mykkiel, the Arbiter of the Covenant.
- **The Witness.** Justicars sometimes work with Truth-Sworn to verify testimony.

Hooks

- A Justicar has been accused of enforcing an unlawful oath. The Covenant wants the party to investigate. The Justicar insists the oath was binding.
- A spirit-hound has gone rogue. It is tracking oath-breakers who have already paid their debts. The Justicar cannot control it. The party must help.
- A Justicar offers to help the party with a legal dispute. Their price: a witness to their next judgment. They want someone to verify that they acted lawfully.

18.2.7 The Unaffiliated

Many Runic Warriors belong to no faction. They are ronin, wanderers, hermits. They owe allegiance to their Patron—and to no one else.

Stance

Officially: Suspicious. A Runekeeper with no faction is a Runekeeper with no accountability.

Unofficially: Useful. An unaffiliated Runic Warrior can be hired for deniable work.

Tensions

- **No Witness.** Unaffiliated Runekeepers often lack a witness for their Rites. This makes their magic less stable—and more dangerous.
- **No Backing.** An unaffiliated Runekeeper has no faction to protect them. If they are accused of a crime, they are on their own.

Alliances

None. That is the point.

Hooks

- An unaffiliated Runic Warrior approaches the party with a job. They need witnesses for a High Rite. They will pay in service, not coin.
- A rogue Bloodsworn has gone unaffiliated. The Cord wants her back. She wants the Cord to forget her. The party is caught in the middle.
- An unaffiliated Beast Warrior has been hunting in territory claimed by a mercenary company. The company wants the party to drive the warrior off. The warrior wants the party to witness their next hunt.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

18.3 Designing Custom Thiasos

A Thiasos is a fragment of a Patron's attention made manifest. It is a companion, a witness, and—for a Runic Warrior—often a weapon or shield. While this expansion provides dozens of pre-built Thiasos, the covenant between Runekeeper and Patron is personal. Sometimes, the standard options do not fit.

This chapter provides guidelines for Game Masters and players to design custom Thiasos, whether living, sentient, or unified with the Codex.

18.3.1 The Three Questions

Before building a custom Thiasos, answer three questions:

What form does it take?

- **Living:** A creature—wolf, horse, bird, serpent, hound. It breathes, eats, and can be wounded.
- **Sentient:** An object—sword, shield, staff, bell, mirror. It speaks, remembers, but cannot act independently.
- **Unified:** Both Codex and Thiasos. Rites are engraved on it. It serves as both record and witness.

What Patron does it serve?

The Thiasos's abilities should reflect its Patron's domain. A Thiasos of Grimmer might be a wolf-ancestor; a Thiasos of the Clockwork Monad might be a ticking brass compass. Refer to the Patron chapters for domain-specific guidance.

What role does it play in the covenant?

- **Combat:** Fights beside the Runekeeper. Has its own Harm track and actions.
- **Utility:** Provides non-combat benefits—tracking, sensing, carrying messages.
- **Witness:** Counts as a witness for Rites. May have perfect recall.
- **Counsel:** Offers advice, warnings, or exposition. May have opinions the Runekeeper does not share.

18.3.2 Designing a Living Thiasos

Core Statistics

A living Thiasos has the following base statistics. Adjust based on Cap (2-5).

- **Body:** Cap + 1 (minimum 2)
- **Wits:** Cap - 1 (minimum 1)
- **Spirit:** Cap (minimum 1)
- **Presence:** Cap - 2 (minimum 0)
- **Harm:** Cap + 2 (minimum 4)
- **Traits:** Two to three special abilities (see below)

Sample Traits

- **Tracker:** +2 dice to track a target by scent.
- **Spirit Sense:** Can detect invisible or incorporeal creatures within Near range.
- **Pack Hunter:** When the Runekeeper attacks a target, the Thiasos gains +1 die to attack the same target.
- **Flight:** Can fly. +1 die to Stealth in natural terrain.
- **Amphibious:** Can breathe underwater. No penalty for underwater combat.
- **Regeneration:** Regains 1 Harm per day (faster than natural healing).
- **Terrifying Presence:** Enemies within Near range test Resolve (DV 3) or become Shaken.
- **Silent Movement:** Makes no sound. Cannot be detected by hearing.

Example: Shadow-Cat (Lunara)

- **Cap:** 3
- **Body:** 4, **Wits:** 2, **Spirit:** 3, **Presence:** 1
- **Harm:** 5
- **Traits:** Silent Movement, Spirit Sense, Shadow Step (once per scene, teleport between shadows within Near range)

18.3.3 Designing a Sentient Thiasos

Core Statistics

A sentient Thiasos has no Harm track and cannot act independently. It has:

- **Personality:** A brief description of its voice, temperament, and quirks.
- **Witness:** Always counts as a witness for Rites.
- **Communication:** Can speak aloud or only to the Runekeeper.
- **Abilities:** One to two special abilities (see below)

Sample Abilities

- **Perfect Recall:** Remembers everything it has witnessed. Can recall verbatim conversations from the past month.
- **Warning:** Vibrates or hums when danger is near. The Runekeeper cannot be surprised.
- **Advice:** Once per session, the Runekeeper may ask for advice on a roll. The GM may grant +1 die (good advice) or gain 1 SB (bad advice). The Thiasos chooses.
- **Recording:** Can record a single truth or conversation and replay it later.
- **Sensory Extension:** The Runekeeper can see or hear through the Thiasos within Near range.
- **Impersonation:** Can speak in the voice of anyone whose blood it has tasted.

Example: The Raven's Quill (Ikasha)

- **Personality:** Secretive, amused, fond of riddles. Speaks in rustles.
- **Witness:** Always counts as a witness.
- **Communication:** Speaks only to the Runekeeper, in whispers.
- **Abilities:** Perfect Recall, Recording (can record one secret and replay it later)

18.3.4 Designing a Unified Thiasos (Codex and Thiasos as One)

Requirements

- The object must be crafted or acquired through a downtime project (one week, Craft test DV 4).
- The Runekeeper must perform a bonding ritual (one day, requires a threshold and a witness).
- The Runekeeper marks +2 Obligation immediately.

Core Statistics

A unified Thiasos combines the traits of a Codex and a sentient Thiasos. It has:

- **Form:** Weapon, shield, staff, bell, or other object.
- **Personality:** As sentient Thiasos.
- **Witness:** Always counts as a witness.
- **Codex:** Rites engraved on its surface. Cannot be destroyed by mundane means.
- **Abilities:** One to two special abilities (may be drawn from living or sentient lists, but adjusted for object form)

Example: Dawnblade (Oath of Flame & Light)

- **Form:** Longsword with Rites engraved along the fuller.
- **Personality:** Stern, honorable, judgmental. Speaks in proverbs.
- **Witness:** Always counts as a witness.
- **Codex:** Rites of the Oath of Flame and Light.
- **Abilities:** Warning (hums when oath-breakers are near), Advice (once per session, grant +1 die on a roll involving justice or honor)

18.3.5 Balancing Custom Thiasos

A Thiasos should not overshadow the Runekeeper. It is a companion, not a replacement.

- A living Thiasos should have fewer actions than the Runekeeper (once per scene independent action, otherwise requiring commands).
- A sentient Thiasos should not have combat abilities. It is a witness, a counselor, a tool—not a warrior.
- A unified Thiasos trades the safety of a separate Codex for the power of a bonded object. It is powerful, but its loss is catastrophic.

Power Budget

When designing a custom Thiasos, use the following budget:

- **Cap 2:** Two traits or one powerful trait.
- **Cap 3:** Three traits or two powerful traits.
- **Cap 4:** Four traits or three powerful traits.

- **Cap 5:** Five traits or four powerful traits.

A "powerful trait" might be Regeneration, Terrifying Presence, or Perfect Recall. A standard trait might be Tracker, Silent Movement, or Warning.

18.3.6 Ritual of Bonding

Acquiring a new Thiasos—or bonding with a unified Codex-Thiasos—requires a ritual.

Requirements

- **Threshold:** A place significant to the Patron (shrine, crossroads, battlefield, grave).
- **Witness:** A person who will observe the bonding.
- **Offering:** Something of value to the Patron (blood, a memory, a sworn oath, a crafted object).
- **Time:** One day (significant downtime).

Procedure

1. The Runekeeper and the prospective Thiasos stand at the threshold.
2. The witness observes.
3. The Runekeeper makes an offering and speaks the terms of the covenant.
4. The Runekeeper rolls Spirit + Lore (DV 4). On a success, the bond is formed. On a partial, the bond is formed but the Thiasos is Wary (suffers -1 die to its first action each scene) until the Runekeeper proves their worth. On a miss, the bond fails; the offering is consumed, and the Runekeeper marks 1 Obligation.

18.3.7 Sample Custom Thiasos

The Copper Hound (Mykkiel)

Form: Living—a copper-coated mechanical hound with emerald eyes.

Cap: 3

Statistics: Body 4, Wits 3, Spirit 2, Presence 1, Harm 5

Traits:

- *Tracker:* +2 dice to track a target by scent.
- *Oath-Sense:* Can detect whether a creature has broken a sworn oath within the past day.
- *Metallic Hide:* +1 Armor against mundane attacks.

Personality: Loyal, literal, slightly obsessive. It speaks in short sentences and repeats important commands.

The Singing Lantern (The Pale Shepherd)

Form: Sentient—a bronze lantern that burns with a cold, grey flame.

Personality: Melancholy, patient, soft-spoken. It hums when death is near.

Abilities:

- *Warning:* Hum when someone within Near range is about to die (within the next hour).
- *Grey Light:* The lantern's light reveals invisible spirits and incorporeal creatures.
- *Final Witness:* Can record the last words of a dying creature and replay them once.

The Storm-Drum (Xhak'Thul)

Form: Unified—a hand-drum made from storm-felled wood and the hide of a beast killed by lightning.

Personality: Loud, impatient, energetic. It speaks in drumbeats that the Runekeeper can understand.

Abilities:

- *Warning:* Beats faster when danger approaches.
- *Thunderclap:* Once per scene, the Runekeeper may strike the drum to create a deafening sound. Enemies within Near range test Resolve (DV 3) or lose their next minor action.
- *Storm-Sense:* The drum can predict the weather for the next hour with perfect accuracy.

18.3.8 GM Guidance: Thiasos as Narrative Engine

A Thiasos is not just a stat block. It is a character. Use it to:

- Deliver exposition or hints when the party is stuck.
- Create conflict—the Thiasos may demand actions the Runekeeper is unwilling to take.
- Foreshadow danger—the Thiasos can sense threats before they arrive.
- Remember the past—the Thiasos has witnessed everything. It may reveal things the Runekeeper has forgotten—or wishes they had.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

18.4 Obligation as Physical Scar

For a Runic Warrior, obligation is not a number in a ledger. It is a scar on the hand, a brand on the chest, a missing finger, a limp that never quite heals. The covenant writes itself into flesh, and the flesh remembers what the mind might wish to forget.

This chapter provides mechanics and roleplay guidance for tracking Obligation as physical marks, as well as advice for Game Masters on using scars as narrative tools.

18.4.1 The Visible Ledger

A traditional Runekeeper's Obligation is invisible. Only the Patron knows the true balance. A Runic Warrior's Obligation is visible to anyone who looks.

Mechanics

When a Runic Warrior marks Obligation (from invoking a Rite, Pushing, or failing to meet a Patron's demand), the player should describe a physical change to their character. This change persists until the Obligation is cleared.

- **Minor Obligation (1-2 segments):** A small scar. A bruise that does not fade. A callus in a new place. A tooth that aches when the Patron's name is spoken.
- **Moderate Obligation (3-4 segments):** A visible scar on the face or hands. A limp that worsens in cold weather. A tattoo that appears overnight. A brand that smokes when the Patron is angry.
- **Significant Obligation (5-6 segments):** A missing finger. An eye that clouds. A patch of skin that turns to stone or bark. A second shadow that moves independently.
- **Critical Obligation (7+ segments):** A limb that no longer feels pain. A face that reflections avoid. A heart that beats in a different rhythm. A name that others forget moments after hearing it.

These changes are not merely cosmetic. They affect how others perceive the Runekeeper.

- A scarred face may grant +1 die to Intimidation but -1 die to Persuasion.
- A limp may reduce movement speed but grant advantage on checks to resist being knocked prone.
- A missing finger may make fine manipulation harder but serve as a constant reminder of the debt.

Clearing Obligation

When a Runic Warrior clears Obligation (through service, sacrifice, or atonement), the physical mark does not simply vanish. It fades. A scar becomes a pale line. A brand becomes a smudge. A missing finger does not regrow—but the debt is no longer owed.

The character may choose to keep the mark as a reminder. Many do.

18.4.2 Roleplaying Physical Obligation

A scar is not a number. It is a story. Use these prompts to deepen roleplay.

Questions for the Player

- Which scar was the first? What Rite caused it? Did you know the cost before you invoked?
- Has anyone asked about your marks? How did you answer? Did you lie, or tell the truth?

- Do you hide your scars, or display them? Why?
- Is there a scar you regret? A debt you wish you had never incurred?
- Do the scars itch? Ache? Whisper? What do they say?

Questions for the Game Master

- Does an NPC recognize a particular scar as the mark of a specific Patron? How do they react?
- Does a Chain-Lantern prefect use visible Obligation as evidence of unlawful covenant?
- Does a Daughter of the Cord offer to help a Bloodsworn hide her scars—for a price?
- Does a sentient Thiasos comment on a new scar? Does it approve? Disapprove?
- Does a Patron ever touch a scar directly? What does that feel like?

18.4.3 Sample Scar Tables

Use these tables to generate physical marks of Obligation randomly, or for inspiration.

Patron-Specific Scars

- **Oath of Flame & Light:** A burn that never heals. A palm that glows faintly in darkness. A tongue that tastes of ash when lying.
- **Oath of Mercy & Grace:** A scar over the heart. Hands that are always warm. A shadow that reaches toward the wounded.
- **Mykkiel:** A brand shaped like a gavel. A finger that taps involuntarily when someone lies. A voice that echoes in empty rooms.
- **Inquisitor Prime:** A censer mark on the forehead. Eyes that see corruption as a green haze. A cough that smells of brimstone.
- **The Sealed Gate:** A scar in the shape of a door. Skin that is cold to the touch. A limp that worsens at thresholds.
- **Grimmir:** Bark growing on the knuckles. Hair that turns green in spring. A scent of rain that precedes the Runekeeper.
- **The Carrion-King:** A patch of skin that flakes like dead leaves. Breath that smells of compost. A single tooth that falls out and regrows each season.
- **Clockwork Monad:** A gear pattern branded into the palm. An eye that ticks when focusing. Fingers that move in perfect sequence, never fumbling.

- **Varnek Karn:** A scar that looks like a rune. A missing fingernail. A shadow that sometimes shows a different ancestor.
- **The High Mother:** Tattoos that move when the Runekeeper sleeps. A hollowed bird's feather woven into the hair. A heartbeat that can be felt, not heard.
- **Khemesh:** Skin that is always damp. Eyes that reflect light like deep water. A voice that sounds like stones grinding.
- **Xhak'Thul:** Hair that stands on end before a storm. A scar that crackles when touched. A laugh that sounds like distant thunder.
- **Ikasha:** A shadow that moves independently. Eyes that are hard to focus on. A whisper that follows the Runekeeper.
- **The Silent Choir:** Lips that are sewn shut in a dream, then unsewn by morning. A scar across the throat. A voice that is never quite their own.
- **Aveh:** A brand that looks like a broken chain. Skin that is always wind-chapped. A scent of ozone after a Rite.
- **Inaea:** Threads visible beneath the skin. A scar that weaves across the body like a web. Fingers that are always slightly sticky.
- **Isoka:** Patches of scale on the arms. A forked tongue that appears in dreams. A shed skin left on the pillow.
- **Malachai:** A silver coin embedded in the flesh. Teeth that are sharp. A hunger that never quite fades.
- **The Traveler:** A scar on the sole of the foot. A compass rose branded on the wrist. A shadow that always points north.
- **The Witness:** A mirror-shard scar on the cheek. Eyes that reflect truth. A memory that cannot be forgotten.
- **The Ninth:** A fractal scar that spirals. Eyes that see patterns in chaos. A voice that sometimes speaks in equations.
- **Lunara:** A crescent brand on the forehead. Skin that pales under moonlight. A shadow that lengthens as the moon waxes.
- **The Pale Shepherd:** A grey handprint on the shoulder. Breath that fogs in warm rooms. A bell that rings only for the dying.
- **The Savage Heart:** A claw mark across the ribs. Teeth that are sharper than they should be. A growl that emerges unbidden.
- **Lethai Ghe'hai:** A mask-shaped scar. Silk threads visible beneath the skin. A face that is hard to remember.

18.4.4 Scars as Narrative Tools

A scar is not a punishment. It is a prompt.

Foreshadowing

A scar that aches before a Rite backfires. A brand that warms when the Patron is near. A missing finger that itches when a debt is about to be called. Use physical marks to signal upcoming complications.

Recognition

An NPC recognizes a scar as the mark of a specific Patron—or a specific crime. A Chain-Lantern prefect has seen that brand before. A Daughter of the Cord knows that tattoo pattern. A mercenary captain lost a finger to a warrior with that same scar.

Memory

A scar holds memory. A Runic Warrior can touch a scar and recall the Rite that caused it, the battle where it was earned, the Patron who demanded payment. Use this for flashbacks or information gathering.

Connection

Two Runic Warriors may share similar scars—marks from the same Patron, the same Rite, the same battle. This creates an instant bond. It can also create suspicion.

Sacrifice

A Runic Warrior may offer a scar as payment. Not the healing of the wound—the scar itself. The memory of the pain. The story of the mark. The Patron accepts, and the scar fades. But the Runekeeper knows: something else is now written in its place.

18.4.5 Optional Rule: Scarred Resilience

Some Runic Warriors learn to draw strength from their scars. This optional talent represents that mastery.

Scarred Resilience (4 XP)

Requirement: Body 3+, at least three visible scars from Obligation.

Once per session, when you would take Harm from a physical attack, you may instead convert that Harm into a new scar. The attack leaves a mark, but the pain is deferred. You do not take the Harm now.

However, the scar remains. It is visible. It is a debt recorded in flesh. The GM may call upon that scar later—as a complication, a clue, or a cost.

18.4.6 Closing

A scar is not a punishment. It is a receipt. It is a story written in flesh. It is a reminder that the covenant is real, that the debt was paid, that the warrior survived.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

18.5 Sample NPCs by Patron Family

This chapter provides ready-to-use non-player characters for each Patron family. Each entry includes a brief description, notable traits, their Codex and Thiasos, a roleplaying hook, and suggested mechanical stats.

18.5.1 The Vowed

Dawn Warrior — Ser Roran of the Grey Gauntlet

A knight in battered plate armor, his left hand encased in a silver gauntlet engraved with a single word: *Paid*. He rides a grey warhorse named Ledger. His face is scarred, his eyes tired, his voice quiet.

Codex: The Grey Gauntlet. Engraved with Rites of oath and protection. **Thiasos:** Ledger, a warhorse with milk-white eyes. **Hook:** Roran never takes ransom. He once spent three years in a debtor's cell. A stranger paid his price. He has been paying it forward ever since.

Body: 4 **Harm:** 6

Wits: 2 **Fatigue:** 4

Spirit: 3 **Armor:** 2 (plate)

Presence: 3 **Position:** Controlled

Notable Rites: *Kindle Vow* (Low), *Unbroken Vow* (Standard), *Dawn's Judgment* (High)

Hospitaller — Sister Bryn

An old woman with a brass hook where her left hand should be. She wears a grey cloak and carries a small bronze bell. She tends a hospice at the edge of a village. She does not speak of her past.

Codex: The Grey Bell. Engraved with Rites of mercy and passage. **Thiasos:** A hollowed bird with milk-white eyes, silent and watching. **Hook:** Bryn was once a Daughter of the Cord. She cut a thread she should not have cut. The Cord has not forgotten.

Body: 2 **Harm:** 3

Wits: 3 **Fatigue:** 2

Spirit: 4 **Armor:** 0

Presence: 3 **Position:** Desperate (due to age)

Notable Rites: *Shared Bowl* (Low), *Healing Waters* (Standard), *Spiral's Witness* (Standard)

Justicar — Elodie Venn

A scarred woman in a dark violet cloak, her hand resting on a silver gavel at her belt. She travels with a spirit-hound that never blinks. She speaks in precedents.

Codex: The Silver Gavel. Engraved with Rites of law and judgment. **Thiasos:** A spirit-hound named Precedent. Tracks oath-breakers. **Hook:** Elodie once ruled against a baron who had taken a wetnurse's hand. The baron's lands were forfeit. The wetnurse's ghost still follows her.

Body: 3 **Harm:** 5
Wits: 4 **Fatigue:** 3
Spirit: 3 **Armor:** 1 (cloak)
Presence: 4 **Position:** Dominant (in court)
Notable Rites: *Consecrated Mandate* (Low), *Seal the Covenant* (Standard), *The Covenant Seal* (Standard)

Witch-Hunter — Vigil-Commander Vorenius

A gaunt man in an iron-mesh hood, carrying a brass censer that never goes cold. His lantern burns green. He hunts unlicensed magic and those who practice it.

Codex: The Censer of Unforgiving Flame. Engraved with Rites of purification. **Thiasos:** A lantern that reveals hidden corruption. Its flame never wavers. **Hook:** Vorenius once burned a village to catch a single heretic. He does not regret it. He dreams about it every night.

Body: 3 **Harm:** 5
Wits: 3 **Fatigue:** 3
Spirit: 3 **Armor:** 1 (mesh hood)
Presence: 4 **Position:** Desperate (when outnumbered)
Notable Rites: *Pure Flame* (Low), *Cleansing Light* (Standard), *Marked Prey* (Standard)

Truth-Sworn — The Archivist

A silent woman in grey robes, carrying a silver mirror in a leather case. She never speaks. She writes questions on a slate and shows the answers. Her memory-spirit records everything.

Codex: The Silver Mirror. Engraved with Rites of truth and memory. **Thiasos:** A memory-spirit that records every word spoken in her presence. **Hook:** The Archivist knows a secret about each member of the party. She has never told anyone. She will not say why.

Body: 2 **Harm:** 3
Wits: 4 **Fatigue:** 2
Spirit: 4 **Armor:** 0
Presence: 2 **Position:** Controlled (when writing)
Notable Rites: *Echoing Truth* (Standard), *Immutable Record* (Standard), *Unveiled Heart* (High)

18.5.2 The Threshold

Warden — Sentinel of the Silent Stair

A figure in grey armor standing motionless before a chapel door. Their face is hidden behind a helm. They do not eat, sleep, or speak. They wait.

Codex: The Shield of Silence. Engraved with Rites of warding. **Thiasos:** A standing stone that wakes when they speak. **Hook:** The Sentinel has guarded this door for forty years. No one knows what lies behind it. No one has asked.

Body: 4 **Harm:** 6
Wits: 2 **Fatigue:** 4
Spirit: 3 **Armor:** 3 (plate + shield)
Presence: 2 **Position:** Dominant (at the threshold)
Notable Rites: *Seal the Threshold* (Low), *Warded Circle* (Standard), *Consecrated Barrier* (High)

Itinerant Monk — Brother Ash

A wanderer in tattered robes, carrying a waystone compass that never points north. His road-dog walks beside him, one blue eye and one brown. He has no destination.

Codex: The Waystone Compass. Engraved with Rites of passage. **Thiasos:** A road-dog named Path. Cannot be lost. **Hook:** Brother Ash has walked the same road for thirty years. He does not remember why he started. He does not want to stop.

Body: 3 **Harm:** 4
Wits: 3 **Fatigue:** 3
Spirit: 2 **Armor:** 0
Presence: 2 **Position:** Controlled (on the road)
Notable Rites: *Road-Sense* (Low), *Waymark* (Standard), *Traveler's Favor* (Standard)

Death Monk — The Pallid Sister

A grey-robed woman with a shepherd's crook. She appears at deathbeds, in battlefields, at the scene of accidents. She does not heal. She guides.

Codex: The Shepherd's Crook. Engraved with Rites of passage. **Thiasos:** A spirit-shepherd that sings the names of the dead. **Hook:** The Pallid Sister was once a midwife. She watched a mother die and a child live. She chose the child. The mother's ghost walks beside her.

Body: 2 **Harm:** 3
Wits: 3 **Fatigue:** 2
Spirit: 4 **Armor:** 0
Presence: 3 **Position:** Desperate (when guiding the dying)
Notable Rites: *Gentle Guide* (Low), *Passing Flock* (Standard), *Unburdened Farewell* (Standard)

18.5.3 The Wild

Root-Knight — Elder Thorn

A woman whose skin is the color of bark, whose hair grows leaves in spring. She carries a living staff that flowers when she is at peace.

Codex: The Living Staff. Carved with Rites of growth and season. **Thiasos:** A wolf-ancestor that speaks in growls. **Hook:** Elder Thorn was once a knight of a fallen kingdom. She swore an oath to defend a forest. The forest accepted. The kingdom is gone. She remains.

Body: 4 **Harm:** 6
Wits: 3 **Fatigue:** 4
Spirit: 3 **Armor:** 1 (bark skin)
Presence: 2 **Position:** Dominant (in forest)
Notable Rites: *Blood Offering* (Low), *Fertile Death* (Standard), *Cycle's Crown* (High)

Grave-Warden — The Compost-Knight

A figure in moss-covered armor, their face hidden behind a helm of woven roots. They carry a bone-chime that clicks in the wind.

Codex: The Bone-Chime. Engraved with Rites of decay and renewal. **Thiasos:** A fungal familiar that speaks in spores. **Hook:** The Compost-Knight was once a knight who failed to protect their lord. They sought the Carrion-King's mercy. The King granted it—by burying them in a compost heap. They rose three days later.

Body: 4 **Harm:** 6
Wits: 2 **Fatigue:** 4
Spirit: 3 **Armor:** 2 (moss armor)
Presence: 1 **Position:** Desperate (when separated from death)
Notable Rites: *Rotting Harvest* (Low), *Borrowed Form* (Standard), *Great Consumption* (High)

Beast Warrior — Mkara of the Spiral Throw

A Sekogo hunter with a leopard pelt over her shoulders. She carries three throwing knives and a predator's tooth on a cord. She does not smile.

Codex: The Predator's Tooth. Engraved with Rites of the hunt. **Thiasos:** The spirit of the hunt. It does not speak. It watches. **Hook:** Mkara killed her first leopard when she was twelve. She wore its skin. The leopard's spirit has been with her ever since.

Body: 4 **Harm:** 5
Wits: 3 **Fatigue:** 4
Spirit: 2 **Armor:** 1 (leather)
Presence: 2 **Position:** Dominant (when hunting)
Notable Rites: *Predator's Gaze* (Low), *Shifting Shape* (Standard), *Blood Scent* (Low)

18.5.4 The Deep

Eldritch Knight — The Drowned Prince

A figure in black glass armor that drips seawater. Their face is hidden behind a helm with no eye slits. They carry a shard of abyssal glass.

Codex: The Abyssal Glass. Engraved with Rites of pressure and silence. **Thiasos:** A drowned spirit that speaks in bubbles. **Hook:** The Drowned Prince was once a pirate king. He found a sunken temple and made a bargain with Khemesh. He does not remember his name. He does not need it.

Body: 4 **Harm:** 6
Wits: 2 **Fatigue:** 4
Spirit: 3 **Armor:** 2 (glass)
Presence: 3 **Position:** Desperate (in sunlight)
Notable Rites: *Crushing Whisper* (Low), *Abyssal Grasp* (Standard), *Sundering Deep* (High)

Storm-Sworn — The Thunder Shaman

A Ykrul warrior with lightning-scarred skin. She carries a drum made from storm-felled wood. Her hair stands on end when she is angry.

Codex: The Thunder Drum. Engraved with Rites of storm and shock. **Thiasos:** A storm-spirit that crackles with lightning. **Hook:** The Thunder Shaman was struck by lightning as a child. She survived. The storm has been following her ever since.

Body: 3 **Harm:** 5
Wits: 2 **Fatigue:** 3
Spirit: 4 **Armor:** 0
Presence: 3 **Position:** Dominant (in storms)
Notable Rites: *Thunderous Presence* (Low), *Fear-Eater* (Standard), *World's Drum* (High)

Tide Warrior — Captain Mira the Lucky

A Sidhi pirate with a brass hook and a ship's wheel tattooed on her palm. She has one eye, one leg, and an uncanny ability to survive shipwrecks.

Codex: The Ship's Wheel. Engraved with Rites of tide and passage. **Thiasos:** A selkie that sings in storms. **Hook:** Mira has sunk seven ships. She has survived all seven. The sea owes her a debt. She is waiting to collect.

Body: 3 **Harm:** 5
Wits: 3 **Fatigue:** 3
Spirit: 2 **Armor:** 1 (leather)
Presence: 4 **Position:** Controlled (on a ship)
Notable Rites: *Wave-Tide* (Low), *Changing Tide* (Standard), *Storm-Queen's Hand* (High)

18.5.5 The Shadow

Shadow Warrior — The Unseen

A figure in a black feather cloak. Their face is hidden. Their voice is a whisper. They leave no footprints.

Codex: The Raven's Quill. Engraved with Rites of shadow and silence. **Thiasos:** A raven-spirit that carries whispers. **Hook:** The Unseen was once a spy for a fallen kingdom. They know where the bodies are buried. They know whose hands dug the graves.

Body: 3 **Harm:** 4
Wits: 4 **Fatigue:** 3
Spirit: 2 **Armor:** 0
Presence: 2 **Position:** Dominant (in darkness)

Notable Rites: *Unlit Candle* (Low), *Umbral Reservoir* (Standard), *Umbral Dream* (High)

Vowed Monk — The Silent Blade

A warrior in grey robes, their mouth sewn shut with silver thread. They communicate with hand signs and written notes. Their blade never makes a sound.

Codex: The Sealed Lips Tattoo. Engraved with Rites of silence and witness. **Thiasos:** A memory-spirit that speaks for them. **Hook:** The Silent Blade swore an oath of silence after killing someone they loved. They have not spoken in twenty years. They do not plan to start.

Body: 3 **Harm:** 5

Wits: 3 **Fatigue:** 3

Spirit: 3 **Armor:** 0

Presence: 1 **Position:** Controlled (when silent)

Notable Rites: *Gentle Seal* (Low), *Weight of the Unsaid* (Standard), *Cord of Witness* (Standard)

Ronin — The Storm-Rider

A masterless warrior on a grey horse. Their banner is torn. Their sword is chipped. They owe allegiance to no one.

Codex: The Storm-Banner. Engraved with Rites of freedom and storm. **Thiasos:** A wind-spirit that rides beside them. **Hook:** The Storm-Rider once served a lord who broke an oath. They cut their banner and rode away. They have been riding ever since.

Body: 3 **Harm:** 5

Wits: 3 **Fatigue:** 3

Spirit: 2 **Armor:** 1 (leather)

Presence: 3 **Position:** Dominant (on horseback)

Notable Rites: *Unlatched Step* (Low), *Forgotten Road* (Standard), *Storm's Refuge* (High)

18.5.6 The Web

Web Warrior — The Spider-Blade

A Lethai operative in a silk mask. Their movements are precise, silent, and impossibly fast. They carry a spider-silk cord that they can tie and untie with a thought.

Codex: The Spider-Silk Cord. Engraved with Rites of binding and mercy. **Thiasos:** A spider-spirit that weaves invisible threads. **Hook:** The Spider-Blade has killed nine targets. The tenth is their own reflection. They have been hunting it for years.

Body: 3 **Harm:** 4

Wits: 4 **Fatigue:** 3

Spirit: 2 **Armor:** 0

Presence: 3 **Position:** Dominant (when unseen)

Notable Rites: *Hearth-Thread Knot* (Low), *Strand of Inevitability* (Standard), *Binding Knot* (High)

Serpent Warrior — The Shed-Knight

A warrior whose face changes each time they remove their helm. Their voice shifts. Their scars move. They are never the same person twice.

Codex: The Shed Fang. Engraved with Rites of transformation. **Thiasos:** A serpent-spirit that speaks in sibilance. **Hook:** The Shed-Knight has forgotten their original face. They are not sure they ever had one.

Body: 3 **Harm:** 5

Wits: 3 **Fatigue:** 3

Spirit: 3 **Armor:** 1 (scale)

Presence: 3 **Position:** Controlled (when masked)

Notable Rites: *Loosening Skin* (Low), *Shedded Self* (Standard), *Venom's Paradox* (Standard)

Cursed Warrior — The Thorn-Sworn

A figure covered in weeping scars. Their left hand is a brass hook. Their right hand holds a silver coin that never spends. They smell of brine and old grief.

Codex: The Silver Coin. Engraved with Rites of curse and bargain. **Thiasos:** A Collector—a child with silver-wire eyes who watches in silence. **Hook:** The Thorn-Sworn once served a baron who took their hand. They have been paying that debt ever since. They are almost done.

Body: 3 **Harm:** 5

Wits: 2 **Fatigue:** 3

Spirit: 4 **Armor:** 0

Presence: 2 **Position:** Desperate (when the Collector watches)

Notable Rites: *Honeyed Curse* (Low), *Binding Curse* (Low), *False Dawn* (Standard)

18.5.7 The Forge**Artificer — The Gear-Warrior**

A dwarf in a toolbelt, their left arm replaced with a clockwork prosthetic. They carry a schematic-slate that updates itself. They never stop tinkering.

Codex: The Schematic-Slate. Engraved with Rites of iteration and improvement. **Thiasos:** A clockwork construct that chitters and ticks. **Hook:** The Gear-Warrior built their own hand after losing it in a mining accident. They have been improving it ever since. It now has seventeen attachments.

Body: 3 **Harm:** 5

Wits: 4 **Fatigue:** 3

Spirit: 2 **Armor:** 1 (clockwork arm)

Presence: 2 **Position:** Controlled (when repairing)

Notable Rites: *Iterative Spark* (Low), *Adaptive Mechanism* (Standard), *Ultimate Iteration* (High)

18.5.8 The Grave

Cairn-Knight — The Grave-Warden

A warrior in rusted armor, standing motionless before a burial mound. Their axe is carved with runes. Their eyes are closed. They are not sleeping.

Codex: The Rune-Carved Axe. Engraved with Rites of wergild and memory. **Thiasos:** An ancestral shade that fights beside them. **Hook:** The Grave-Warden is guarding their own grave. They died forty years ago. They did not stay dead.

Body: 4 **Harm:** 6

Wits: 2 **Fatigue:** 4

Spirit: 3 **Armor:** 2 (rusted plate)

Presence: 2 **Position:** Dominant (at the cairn)

Notable Rites: *Crossing Fee* (Low), *Ancestral Consultation* (Low), *Mediated Pact* (Standard)

Bloodsworn — The Cord-Knight

A Daughter of the Cord with Rites tattooed on every inch of her skin. Her eyes are milk-white. A hollowed bird perches on her shoulder.

Codex: Her skin. Engraved with Rites of debt and witness. **Thiasos:** A hollowed bird with milk-white eyes. **Hook:** The Cord-Knight has been paying her grandmother's debt for forty years. She does not know what the debt was. She only knows it is almost paid.

Body: 3 **Harm:** 5

Wits: 2 **Fatigue:** 3

Spirit: 4 **Armor:** 0

Presence: 3 **Position:** Desperate (when the Cord calls)

Notable Rites: *Milk Teeth* (Low), *Unseen Midwife* (Standard), *Unnamed* (High)

18.5.9 The Fracture

Fractal Warrior — The Paradox-Sworn

A warrior whose eyes see angles that should not exist. Their Codex is a broken mirror. They move in ways that make observers dizzy.

Codex: The Broken Mirror. Engraved with Rites of paradox and pattern. **Thiasos:** A pattern-spirit that speaks in equations. **Hook:** The Paradox-Sworn saw their own death in a fractured mirror. They have been trying to avoid it ever since. The mirror shows a different death each time.

Body: 2 **Harm:** 4

Wits: 4 **Fatigue:** 2

Spirit: 4 **Armor:** 0

Presence: 2 **Position:** Controlled (when predicting)

Notable Rites: *Ninth Figure* (Low), *Hypercognitive Lattice* (Standard), *Ninth Revelation* (High)

Moon Knight — The Silver-Sworn

A warrior in pale armor who fights only under moonlight. Their Codex is a silver disc. They carry no weapon—the moon fights for them.

Codex: The Silver Disc. Engraved with Rites of moon and shadow. **Thiasos:** A shadow-cat that walks silently beside them. **Hook:** The Silver-Sworn was cursed to become a wolf under the full moon. They made a bargain with Lunara. Now they hunt werewolves instead.

Body: 3 **Harm:** 5

Wits: 3 **Fatigue:** 3

Spirit: 3 **Armor:** 1 (moonlight)

Presence: 2 **Position:** Dominant (under moonlight)

Notable Rites: *Moonlit Mirror* (Low), *Triple Road* (Standard), *Lunar Conjunction* (Standard)

18.5.10 The Lethai Ghe'hai**Spec Ops — The Silk-Blade**

An elite operative with no name, no face, and no past. They wear a woven silk mask. Their movements are precise, efficient, and forgettable.

Codex: The Woven Mask. Engraved with Rites of silk and silence. **Thiasos:** A spider-spirit that weaves invisible threads. **Hook:** The Silk-Blade has completed seventeen missions for the Lethai courts. They do not remember any of them. The mask remembers for them.

Body: 3 **Harm:** 4

Wits: 4 **Fatigue:** 3

Spirit: 2 **Armor:** 0

Presence: 3 **Position:** Dominant (when masked)

Notable Rites: *Silk Binding* (Low), *Mask of Many Faces* (Standard), *Unspoken Question* (High)

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Part V

Appendices

Appendix A

The Black River at Dawn

Appendix B

The Black River at Dawn

Roran did not sleep the night after the trial.

He sat on the cold stone bench of the Queen's garrison, the silver gauntlet heavy on his left hand, the locket warm against his palm on the right.

The gauntlet still smelled of the forge where it had been shaped—hammer strikes, the hiss of cooled steel, the ledger-books that recorded every blade, every horse, every ounce of grain as if they were the only things that gave a life meaning. The locket was soft, its surface worn smooth by years of being pressed against a mother's chest.

He had not opened it. He could not.

Whatever lay inside—a portrait, a lock of hair, a written name—would be the first proof that his mother had existed outside the cold arithmetic of his father's ledgers. Outside the columns of debts and dues.

He was afraid.

Not of the locket's contents. Of what it would cost him to keep it.

At the third bell, the garrison's watch changed. The corridors fell quiet. He rose, the gauntlet clinking faintly against the stone.

He moved through the sleeping city. His boots were silent on cobblestones that had once echoed with the march of soldiers. He passed the Silent Stair, where the wind whistled through broken stones like a lament. He passed the chapel where Alain the Cantor, voice raw from years of singing the *Planctus Armatus*, dreamed of feathers and forgotten songs.

The gates stood open. The war was over. The peace was young. The watch, trained for vigilance, had learned to sleep again.

The Black River lay ahead—a slow, dark ribbon drinking the first grey light of dawn.

He knelt at the bank. Cold water seeped through his breeches. The air smelled of iron and wet stone, of rain that had fallen days ago and would fall again.

He lifted the locket to his chest. Felt his own heartbeat against its cool metal.

He opened it.

Inside was not a portrait.

It was a braid. A single, thin braid of auburn hair, tied with a scrap of red thread. The same thread Bryn had once looped between a chair leg and a pot handle. The same thread Margot had used to knit a blanket for a child she would never see grow.

The braid was warm.

He pressed it to his lips. Closed his eyes. Listened.

Silence.

And then—

“Aldric.”

The voice came from the water. Or from the mist. Or from the hollow of his own chest. It was not his mother’s voice alone.

He looked up.

She stood on the far bank.

Young. Younger than him. Younger than Eleanor. The age she had been when the birthing fever took her. Her hair fell loose, auburn and unbound. Her face held no sorrow—only a quiet certainty. A red blanket draped over her shoulders like a cloak.

“Mother,” he said.

She smiled.

“You have carried the weight long enough. The locket was never meant to be a burden. It was meant to be a bridge.”

She stepped toward the water’s edge. The river did not part. It simply accepted her. She stood on the surface as if the current had always been solid beneath her feet.

“Lay it at the bank. Tie it with the thread. Let the water carry it where it needs to go.”

“Where?”

“To her. To Bryn. She kept it for forty years. She never asked for thanks. But she deserves to know it reached you.”

He felt the old name strike him like a blow.

“That name forsook me. I am Roran now. That is the name I chose when I left the ledger behind.”

Her eyes softened. Not with disappointment. With understanding.

“Then let the river carry what you are ready to release. Not the name you were given. The weight you have carried because of it.”

He untied the braid. Felt the silk of the hair slip through his fingers. Took the red thread and wound it three times around the locket.

The first turn: the way the Cord had taught him to bind a promise.

The second turn: the way Bryn had shown Margot how to tie a knot that would hold.

The third turn: the way Margot had intended to teach her children—a lesson that ended with her own silence before she could pass it on.

He placed the locket on the muddy bank. The water lapped at its edge, testing.

“You have to let go,” his mother said.

“I have let go of everything.”

“Not everything. Not yet.”

He closed his eyes.

He opened his hand.

The water rose—not in a flood, but in a gentle lift, as if the river itself were a hand taking the locket from his grasp. It slipped beneath the surface with a soft, almost inaudible sigh.

When he looked up, she was gone.

But the mist had thinned. The first true light of dawn spilled over the eastern hills. The Black River ran clear and cold, carrying nothing but light.

He walked back to the garrison. He did not look back. He did not need to.

The gauntlet on his left hand, which had felt like ice when he first rose, now radiated a quiet warmth.

The Silver Gauntlet

The gauntlet had always been heavy. Forged in his father’s workshop, it had been a symbol of duty, of obligation, of the weight of a name he had never wanted.

But that night, walking back to the garrison, Roran understood something he had not understood before.

The gauntlet was not a chain.

It was a witness.

It had seen every battle he had fought, every oath he had sworn, every blow he had taken for another. It had heard his mother’s name spoken over the locket. It had felt the warmth of the braid through his palm.

The gauntlet was his Thiasos.

Not a spirit summoned from the deep. Not a hound bound by oath. A piece of steel, forged in the fires of a father who never loved him, remade in the crucible of a life he had chosen for himself.

It did not speak. It did not need to. It remembered.

Roran sat on the edge of his cot. He removed the gauntlet and laid it on the blanket. The silver was warm.

He traced the engraving along the cuff—the words his father had ordered carved there, a litany of victories and titles. He had never been able to read them without anger.

Now, they were just marks. The ledger was closed.

He thought of Bryn, her brass hook catching the cold light of the courtroom. She had carried her loss for forty years. She had forged it into a tool. She had not let it break her.

He thought of his mother, standing on the water, wrapped in a red blanket. She had not asked for anything. She had simply witnessed.

He thought of the locket, drifting downstream, carrying a braid of auburn hair and a scrap of red thread. It would reach Bryn. Or it would not. The river would decide.

"A debt was paid. Not by me. To me."

He had said those words to the Queen. She had not asked whose.

The gauntlet was warm.

The Thiasos of the Unbroken Vow

Roran never spoke of the Black River again. But he carried the gauntlet always. It was not a symbol of his father's expectations. It was a record of his own choices.

When he swore an oath, the gauntlet grew warm.

When he showed mercy, it cooled.

When he stood between an enemy and an innocent, it grew heavy—not with weight, but with presence.

The gauntlet was his Codex. His Rites were engraved on the inside of the cuff, hidden from anyone who did not know to look. His Thiasos was not a separate creature. It was the steel itself. The silver that had witnessed his transformation.

In the years that followed, young knights would ask him how he knew when to strike and when to stay his hand.

He would tap the gauntlet and say:

"This one remembers. It remembers every vow I kept. Every mercy I showed. Every hand I did not raise. The steel does not forget. Neither should you."

The Thread Holds

The locket reached Bryn. Or it did not. The story does not say.

What the story says is this:

Roran wore the gauntlet for the rest of his life. He never took a ransom. He never broke an oath. He never forgot the woman who stood on the water, wrapped in a red blanket, and told him to let go.

He died in the Queen's service, old and tired and surrounded by knights who wept at his passing.

They buried him with the gauntlet on his left hand.

The silver was still warm.

The thread held. The water carried. The dead smiled. The living walked on.

That is not tragedy. That is grace.

The Gauntlet as Thiasos (Mechanical Summary)

For players who wish to emulate Roran's covenant, the silver gauntlet functions as a unified Codex-Thiasos (see *Codex and Thiasos Unified*).

- **Form:** Sentient (unified)—a silver gauntlet worn on the left hand.
- **Personality:** Silent, watchful, patient. It does not speak, but it remembers. The Runekeeper knows its temper through warmth, weight, and a faint vibration.
- **Witness:** Always counts as a witness for Rites.
- **Codex:** Rites are engraved on the inside of the cuff, visible only to the Runekeeper.
- **Abilities:**
 - *Warmth of the Vow:* When the Runekeeper swears an oath, the gauntlet grows warm. The Runekeeper gains +1 die to all actions serving that oath.
 - *Cool of Mercy:* When the Runekeeper shows mercy, the gauntlet cools. The Runekeeper gains 1 Boon, usable only for acts of protection or sanctuary.
 - *Weight of Witness:* The gauntlet remembers every blow it has turned. Once per scene, the Runekeeper may spend 1 Boon to reduce incoming Harm by 1 (to a minimum of 0).

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Appendix C

Quick Reference Tables

Appendix D

Quick Reference Tables

D.1 Patrons by Warrior Archetype

|p4cm|p8cm|p4cm|

Archetype Patron(s) Page Reference

Crusader Oath of Flame and Light ??
Hospitaller Oath of Mercy and Grace ??
Justicar Mykkiel ??
Witch-Hunter Inquisitor Prime ??
Truth-Sworn The Witness ??

Warden The Sealed Gate ??
Road-Warden The Traveler ??
Death-Warden The Pale Shepherd ??

Root-Knight Grimmir ??
Grave-Warden The Carrion-King ??
Beast Warrior The Savage Heart ??

Deep Warrior Khemesh ??
Storm-Sworn Xhak'Thul ??
Tide-Knight Raéyn ??

Shadow Warrior Ikasha ??

Silent Blade The Silent Choir ??

Unbound Blade Aveh ??

Web-Warrior Inaea ??

Serpent-Blade Isoka ??

Thorn-Sworn Malachai ??

Gear-Warrior Clockwork Monad ??

Cairn-Knight Varnek Karn ??

Bloodsworn The High Mother ??

Fractal Blade The Ninth ??

Moon Knight Lunara ??

Ghe'hai Operative Lethai Syncretic ??

D.2 Patrons by Cultural Origin

|p4cm|p12cm|

Culture Patron(s)

Aeler Grimmir, The Sealed Gate, The Carrion-King, Clockwork Monad, Varnek Karn, The High Mother, Khemesh, The Ninth, Aveh

Aelinnel Lunara, The Ninth, Grimmir, The Sealed Gate

Aelaerem The High Mother, Inaea, The Pale Shepherd, The Silent Choir

Ashaan Ikasha, Isoka, Malachai, Aveh

Ecktoria The Witness, Inquisitor Prime, Malachai, The High Mother, Clockwork Monad

Fhara The Traveler

Kahfagia Raéyn, The Traveler

Kuvani The Savage Heart

Lethai Inaea, Isoka, The Silent Choir, Lunara, The Ninth, The Witness (Ghe'hai tradition)

Linn Raéyn, Khemesh, Xhak'Thul, The Pale Shepherd, Aveh

Sekogo The Savage Heart, Isoka

Sidhi Raéyn, The Traveler, The High Mother

Thepyrgos The Witness, The Ninth, The Silent Choir, Inquisitor Prime, Clockwork Monad

Tulkani The Traveler, The High Mother, Aveh
 Valewood Grimmir, The Savage Heart, The Carrion-King, Malachai
 Vhasia The Pale Shepherd, Xhak'Thul, The Witness, The Silent Choir, Varnek Karn, The Carrion-King
 Viterra Oath of Mercy and Grace, Mykkiel, The Sealed Gate, Oath of Flame and Light
 Ykrul Grimmir, The Savage Heart, Xhak'Thul, Varnek Karn, Aveh
 Zakov Khemesh, Raéyn, Malachai, Ikasha

D.3 Patrons by Codex Form

|p4cm|p12cm|

Codex Form Patron(s)

Engraved Gorget or Gauntlet Oath of Flame and Light, Mykkiel, Inquisitor Prime, The Witness
 Shield or Oath-Beads The Sealed Gate, Mykkiel, Oath of Mercy and Grace
 Carved Staff or Living Bark Grimmir, The Carrion-King, The Pale Shepherd
 Toolbelt or Schematic-Slate Clockwork Monad
 Flesh Tattoos The High Mother
 Rune-Carved Axe or Burial Stone Varnek Karn, Grimmir
 Silver Mirror or Locket The Witness, Lunara
 Shadow-Cloak or Black Feather Ikasha, Aveh
 Spider-Silk Cord or Loom-Shuttle Inaea, The High Mother
 Ship's Wheel or Anchor Raéyn
 Drum or Storm-Banner Xhak'Thul, Aveh
 Broken Mirror or Fractal Slate The Ninth
 Grey Cloak or Shepherd's Crook The Pale Shepherd, The Silent Choir
 Serpent Fang or Shed Skin Isoka, Malachai
 Silver Coin Malachai, The High Mother

D.4 Patrons by Thiasos Form

D.4.1 Living Thiasos

|p5cm|p11cm|

Thiasos Form Patron(s)

Warhorse Oath of Flame and Light, Aveh, The Traveler
 Spirit-Hound Mykkiel, The Sealed Gate, Varnek Karn, Inquisitor Prime
 Wolf-Ancestor Grimmir, The Savage Heart
 Fungal Familiar The Carrion-King

Clockwork Construct Clockwork Monad
 Hollowed Child or Heartless Bird The High Mother
 Ancestral Shade Varnek Karn
 Storm-Spirit Xhak'Thul, Raéyn
 Raven-Spirit Ikasha, The Witness
 Spider-Spirit Inaea
 Serpent-Spirit Isoka
 Shadow-Cat Lunara, Ikasha
 Memory-Spirit The Silent Choir, The Ninth
 Seabird Spirit Raéyn
 Selkie-Spirit Raéyn
 Great Cat Spirit The Savage Heart

D.4.2 Sentient Thiasos

[p5cm][p11cm]

Thiasos Form Patron(s)

Dawnblade (Sword) Oath of Flame and Light
 The Speaking Gavel Mykkiel
 The Censer of Unforgiving Flame Inquisitor Prime
 The Silver Mirror The Witness
 The Keystone The Sealed Gate
 The Waystone Compass The Traveler
 The Grey Bell The Pale Shepherd
 The Root-Staff Grimmer
 The Bone-Chime The Carrion-King
 The Iteration Lens Clockwork Monad
 The Grave-Token Varnek Karn
 The Scarlet Needle The High Mother
 The Abyssal Glass Khemesh
 The Thunder Drum Xhak'Thul
 The Raven's Quill Ikasha
 The Sealed Lips Mask The Silent Choir
 The Storm-Banner Aveh
 The Spider's Loom Inaea
 The Shed Fang Isoka
 The Silver Coin Malachai
 The Fractal Slate The Ninth

The Moon Disc Lunara

The Silk Mask Lethai Ghe'hai

D.5 Patrons by Core Mechanic

[p5cm][p11cm]

Core Mechanic Patron(s)

The Witnessed Vow Oath of Flame and Light

The Spiral Oath of Mercy and Grace

The Witnessed Precedent Mykkiel

The Hunt Inquisitor Prime

The Witnessed Truth The Witness

The Warded Threshold The Sealed Gate

The Road's Memory The Traveler

The Threshold Guide The Pale Shepherd

The Seasonal Bond Grimmir

Harvest Resonance The Carrion-King

The Hunt The Savage Heart

The Crushing Depth Khemesh

The Storm's Fury Xhak'Thul

The Rising Tide Raéyn

The Unseen Ikasha

The Kept Secret The Silent Choir

The Unremembered Aveh

The Web of Obligation Inaea

The Shedding Isoka

The Cursed Bargain Malachai

The Iterative Spark Clockwork Monad

The Ancestral Debt Varnek Karn

The Cord's Witness The High Mother

The Glimpse The Ninth

The Moon's Phase Lunara

The Witnessed Operation Lethai Ghe'hai

A Note on Page References

Page references in this table refer to the first page of each Patron's section in this expansion. For cross-reference with core rulebooks, consult the index of the *Fate's Edge Comprehensive Resource Guide*.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

D.6 Patrons by Cultural Origin

This table lists the primary cultural associations for each Patron. A Patron may appear in multiple cultures; the listed origin is where their worship or invocation is most prominent or most distinctive.

D.6.1 The Vowed

po.25 po.35 po.25

Patron	Primary Cultural Origin	Secondary Associations
Oath of Flame & Light	Viterra / Ecktoria	Aeler, Vhasia
Oath of Mercy & Grace	Viterra / Sidhi	Aelaerem, Vhasia
Mykkiel	Viterra / Ecktoria	Aeler, Thepyrgos
Inquisitor Prime	Ecktoria / Thepyrgos	Vhasia, Aeler
The Witness	Ecktoria / Thepyrgos	Vhasia, Silkstrand

D.6.2 The Threshold

po.25 po.35 po.25

Patron	Primary Cultural Origin	Secondary Associations
The Sealed Gate	Aeler / Thepyrgos	Aelinnel, Mistlands
The Traveler	Tulkani / Fhara / Kuvani	Kahfagia, Aeler, Ykrul
The Pale Shepherd	Aelaerem / Linn / Vhasia	Aeler, Thepyrgos

D.6.3 The Wild

po.25 po.35 po.25

Patron	Primary Cultural Origin	Secondary Associations
Grimmir	Aeler / Aelinnel / Valewood	Ykrul, Aelaerem
The Carrion-King	Acasia / Vhasia / Valewood	Aeler, Sekogo
The Savage Heart	Sekogo / Valewood / Ykrul	Oshiira, Dhahara, Kuvani

D.6.4 The Deep

po.25 po.35 po.25

Patron	Primary Cultural Origin	Secondary Associations
Khemesh Zakov	Linn / Deep Aeler	Kahfagia, Thepyrgos
Xhak'Thul	Ykrul / Linn / Vhasia	Aeler, Kahfagia

Raéyn Kahfagia / Linn / Zakov Sidhi, Fhara

D.6.5 The Shadow

po.25 po.35 po.25

Patron Primary Cultural Origin Secondary Associations

Ikasha Ashaan / Lethai / Sidhi Aeler, Mistlands, Tulkani
 The Silent Choir Aelaerem / Thepyrgos / Lethai Vhasia, Viterra
 Aveh Ykrul / Vilikari / Tulkani Linn, Aeler

D.6.6 The Web

po.25 po.35 po.25

Patron Primary Cultural Origin Secondary Associations

Inaea Aelaerem / Lethai / Silkstrand Vhasia, Aelinnel
 Isoka Ashaan / Lethai / Sekogo Zakov, Thepyrgos
 Malachai Any / Cursed Bloodlines Zakov, Valewood, Ecktoria

D.6.7 The Forge

po.25 po.35 po.25

Patron Primary Cultural Origin Secondary Associations

Clockwork Monad Aeler / Dhahara / Thepyrgos Ecktoria, Aelinnel

D.6.8 The Grave

po.25 po.35 po.25

Patron Primary Cultural Origin Secondary Associations

Varnek Karn Ykrul / Aeler / Vhasia Thepyrgos, Linn
 The High Mother Aelaerem / Tulkani / Sidhi Vhasia, Ecktoria

D.6.9 The Fracture

po.25 po.35 po.25

Patron Primary Cultural Origin Secondary Associations

The Ninth Thepyrgos / Aelinnel / Lethai Aeler, Silkstrand
 Lunara Aelinnel / Theona / Lethai Vhasia, Mistlands

D.6.10 The Lethai Ghe'hai (Elite Operatives)

po.25 po.35 po.25

Patron Primary Cultural Origin Secondary Associations

Lethai Syncretic Lethai-ar / Lethai-thora Ashaan, Silkstrand

D.6.11 Cultural Index

For quick reference, here is the same information organized by culture rather than by Patron.

po.25 po.65

Culture Associated Patrons

Acasia The Carrion-King

Aelaerem Oath of Mercy & Grace, The Pale Shepherd, Grimmir, The Silent Choir, Inaea, The High Mother

Aeler Oath of Flame & Light, Mykkiel, Inquisitor Prime, The Sealed Gate, The Traveler, The Pale Shepherd, Grimmir, The Carrion-King, Khemesh, Xhak'Thul, Ikasha, Aveh, Clockwork Monad, Varnek Karn, The Ninth

Aelinnel The Sealed Gate, Grimmir, The Ninth, Lunara

Ashaan Ikasha, Isoka, Lethai Syncretic

Dhahara The Savage Heart, Clockwork Monad

Ecktoria Oath of Flame & Light, Mykkiel, Inquisitor Prime, The Witness, Malachai, Clockwork Monad, The High Mother

Fhara The Traveler, Raéyn

Kahfagia The Traveler, Raéyn, Khemesh

Kuvani The Traveler, The Savage Heart

Lethai Ikasha, The Silent Choir, Inaea, Isoka, Lethai Syncretic, The Ninth, Lunara

Linn The Pale Shepherd, Khemesh, Xhak'Thul, Raéyn, Aveh, Varnek Karn

Mistlands The Sealed Gate, Ikasha, Lunara

Oshiira The Savage Heart

Sekogo The Carrion-King, The Savage Heart, Isoka

Sidhi Oath of Mercy & Grace, Raéyn, Ikasha, The High Mother

Silkstrand The Witness, Inaea, The Ninth

Theona Lunara

Thepyrgos Mykkiel, Inquisitor Prime, The Witness, The Sealed Gate, The Pale Shepherd, The Silent Choir, Khemesh, Clockwork Monad, Varnek Karn, The Ninth

Tulkani The Traveler, Aveh, The High Mother

Valewood Grimmir, The Carrion-King, The Savage Heart, Malachai

Vhasia Oath of Flame & Light, Oath of Mercy & Grace, Inquisitor Prime, The Witness, The Pale Shepherd, The Carrion-King, Xhak'Thul, The Silent Choir, Inaea, Varnek Karn, The High Mother, Lunara

Viterra Oath of Flame & Light, Oath of Mercy & Grace, Mykkiel, The Witness, The Silent Choir

Ykrul The Traveler, The Savage Heart, Xhak'Thul, Aveh, Varnek Karn

Zakov Khemesh, Raéyn, Isoka, Malachai

D.6.12 Note on Syncretic Worship

Many Patrons are worshipped under different names across cultures. A devotee of the Oath of Flame & Light in Viterra may call upon Seint Michel; in Aeler, the same Patron is the Everflame. These are not separate entities—they are the same covenant, adapted to local custom. The table above reflects the name and form most common to each culture, not a limitation on where a Patron may be found.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

D.7 Talents by Tier

This table organizes all Runic Warrior talents by tier and category. Talents marked with an asterisk (*) are Patron-specific; refer to the relevant Patron chapter for full descriptions.

D.7.1 Foundation Talents (2-4 XP)

po.3 po.5

Talent Effect Summary

Bonded Focus (4 XP) Sense unified Thiasos location; summon to hand within Near range.
 Flesh Codex (2 XP) Rites tattooed on body; cannot be stolen or confiscated.
 Iron Stomach (3 XP) Immune to mundane poisons; halve complications from toxic sources.
 Living Thiasos (3 XP) Thiasos gains +1 Cap; acts independently once per scene.
 Oath-Bound (4 XP) Reroll failed Body roll when serving a sworn oath.
 Scarred Resilience (3 XP) Ignore 1 Fatigue from physical exertion once per scene.
 The Red Thread (4 XP)* Tie a knot; allies gain +1 die to one type of roll.
 Talking Weapon (2 XP) Sentient Thiasos can speak aloud; counts as witness.
 The Blade Remembers (4 XP) Recall past enemy tactics; gain +1 die against familiar foes.
 Engraved Witness (3 XP) Codex-Thiasos unified; Rites cannot be destroyed by mundane means.

D.7.2 Advanced Talents (6-8 XP)

po.3 po.5

Talent Effect Summary

Anathema to Stagnation (8 XP)* End infusion early to cancel Harm or Condition; object destroyed.
 Beast Form (6 XP)* Partial transformation into a predator for one scene.
 Binding Presence (6 XP)* Compel a promise from a target; Resiste test DV 4.
 Blood Hunt (4 XP)* +1 die to track wounded targets.
 Cite Precedent (4 XP)* Reduce Rite DV by citing a past judgment.
 Cord of Flesh (8 XP)* Store Fatigue as visible knots; appear uninjured.
 Dawn's Judgment (6 XP)* Extend Rite of Dawn's Judgment for full scene.

Engraved Defense (6 XP) Codex grants +1 Armor; convert Harm to Obligation.

Final Witness (6 XP)* Ask one question about a dying creature's final thoughts.

Gavel's Authority (6 XP)* Strike gavel; hostile NPCs test Resolve or hesitate.

Glimpse Beyond (4 XP)* Intuit hidden detail; gain one piece of information.

Harvest Resonance (4 XP)* After a defeat, gain +1 die or clear 1 Fatigue.

The Hilt Listens (6 XP) Leave Thiasos as listening post; it reports conversations.

Iron Resolve (7 XP) When reduced to 0 Harm, remain standing with 1 Harm and mark 2 Fatigue.

Justicar's Immunity (8 XP)* Cannot be arrested in lands recognizing Mykkiel's law.

Lightning Reflexes (4 XP)* +1 die to defense against ranged attacks.

Momentum of the Molt (8 XP)* After breaking a Condition, next action gains +1 die and improved Position.

Perfect Recall (7 XP) Thiasos recalls witnessed conversations verbatim.

Pressure Adaptation (8 XP)* Immune to underwater penalties; hold breath twice as long.

Quiet Step (6 XP)* +1 die to stealth under moonlight.

Rapid Animus (4 XP)* Create temporary infusion as reaction; +0 Obligation.

Rot Sense (6 XP)* Sense decay, rot, or corruption within Near range.

Self-Optimising (6 XP)* Improve one ability or possession for one scene.

Sentinel's Stand (6 XP)* +1 Armor when holding a threshold; enemies test to cross.

Shadow Meld (6 XP)* Step between shadows within Near range.

Shared Burden (6 XP) Transfer 1 Fatigue to Thiasos; it becomes Winded.

Shed Skin (4 XP)* Escape a Condition restricting movement; mark 1 Fatigue.

Shortcut (4 XP)* Reduce travel clock by 2 segments; GM may impose minor cost.

Silver Memory (4 XP)* Perfect recall of events witnessed under moonlight.

Storm Caller (6 XP)* Peal of thunder; enemies test Resolve or lose minor action.

Swift Invocation (6 XP) Invoke Rite as part of attack or defense action once per scene.

Threshold Keep (8 XP)* Sense active thresholds within Far range; know their mood.

Truth's Gaze (6 XP)* Target cannot lie to you for one minute.

Tug the Strand (4 XP)* Name relationship between NPCs; GM reveals one secret.

Unseen Strike (4 XP)* Attack from hidden position ignores 1 Armor.

Ward Sense (4 XP)* Sense active wards; know their purpose and strength.

Witnessed Scar (8 XP) Touch a scar; gain +1 die on roll tied to that event.

D.7.3 Prestige Talents (10-12 XP)

po.3 po.5

Talent Effect Summary

Alpha's Roar (8 XP)* Terrifying sound; enemies test Resolve or become Shaken.

Avatar of the Codex (12 XP) Become embodiment of Codex; Body +2, Thiasos fights as second combatant.

The Bonded Blade (11 XP) Thiasos performs minor independent actions; warns of danger.

The Edge Speaks (8 XP)* Thiasos speaks in voice of whose blood it has tasted; target may become Shaken.

Embraced Corruption (12 XP) Choose corruption trait; Push Songs without Fatigue once per session.

Fractal Response (8 XP)* +1 die to defense roll; glimpse outcome in advance.

Kraken's Warning (8 XP)* Sense ambush from sea creatures one round in advance.

Mercy's Thread (8 XP)* Tie thread when showing mercy; target gains Promise Clock.

The Object Remembers (8 XP) Unified Thiasos recalls past events; can testify as witness.

Reoccupied Vessel (10 XP)* Raise willing spirit into corpse as Bound Vessel.

The Scar That Remembers (11 XP) Touch a scar; speak sentence as witnessed truth in court.

The Spiral's Final Witness (10 XP)* Interpose between ally and killing blow; Promise Clock fills.

The Thiasos Remembers (12 XP) Thiasos bears witness to past event; testimony considered truth.

The Unbroken Vow (10 XP) Swear oath before witness; gain +2 dice to actions serving it.

The Voice of the Fallen (10 XP) Thiasos speaks in voice of deceased whose blood it has tasted.

D.7.4 Patron-Specific Talents by Patron

Oath of Flame & Light

- Dawn's Judgment (6 XP)
- Unquenchable (4 XP)
- The Light Reveals (8 XP)

Oath of Mercy & Grace

- Spiral Counter (6 XP)
- The Unbuckled Gorget (4 XP)
- The Spiral's Final Witness (10 XP)

Mykkiel

- Cite Precedent (4 XP)
- Gavel's Authority (6 XP)
- Justicar's Immunity (8 XP)

Inquisitor Prime

- Truth's Gaze (6 XP)
- Sanctified Weapon (4 XP)
- Purity Zeal (6 XP)

The Witness

- Recorded Echo (4 XP)
- Truth's Gaze (6 XP)
- The Scar That Testifies (8 XP)

The Sealed Gate

- Ward Sense (4 XP)
- Sentinel's Stand (6 XP)
- Threshold Memory (8 XP)

The Traveler

- Shortcut (4 XP)
- Road Memory (6 XP)
- Wayfinder's Blessing (8 XP)

The Pale Shepherd

- Comforting Presence (4 XP)
- Final Witness (6 XP)
- Threshold Keep (8 XP)

Grimmir

- Seasonal Sense (4 XP)
- Wild Shape (6 XP)
- Beast Speech (8 XP)

The Carrion-King

- Harvest Resonance (4 XP)
- Rot Sense (6 XP)
- Essence Feast (8 XP)

The Savage Heart

- Beast Form (6 XP)
- Blood Hunt (4 XP)
- Alpha's Roar (8 XP)

Khemesh

- Crushing Silence (6 XP)
- Deep Sight (4 XP)
- Pressure Adaptation (8 XP)

Xhak'Thul

- Storm Caller (6 XP)
- Lightning Reflexes (4 XP)
- Fear Eater (8 XP)

Raéyn

- Tide-Step (4 XP)
- Storm Glass (6 XP)
- Kraken's Warning (8 XP)

Ikasha

- Shadow Meld (6 XP)
- Unseen Strike (4 XP)
- Raven's Witness (8 XP)

The Silent Choir

- Burden Steady (4 XP)
- Calm Presence (6 XP)
- Final Vow (10 XP)

Aveh

- Storm-Step (6 XP)
- Forgotten Face (4 XP)
- Escape Clause (8 XP)

Inaea

- Tug the Strand (4 XP)
- Binding Presence (6 XP)
- Mercy's Thread (8 XP)

Isoka

- Shed Skin (4 XP)
- Venomous Strike (6 XP)
- Momentum of the Molt (8 XP)

Malachai

- Borrowed Scars (6 XP)
- Thorn's Memory (4 XP)
- Cursed Resilience (8 XP)

Clockwork Monad

- Rapid Animus (4 XP)
- Self-Optimising (6 XP)
- Anathema to Stagnation (8 XP)

Varnek Karn

- The Silent Ledger (6 XP)
- Final Witness (4 XP)
- Reoccupied Vessel (10 XP)

The High Mother

- Cord of Flesh (8 XP)
- The Open Palm, Closed Cord (8 XP)
- The Red Thread (4 XP)

The Ninth

- Glimpse Beyond (4 XP)
- Pattern Recognition (6 XP)
- Fractal Response (8 XP)

Lunara

- Silver Memory (4 XP)
- Quiet Step (6 XP)
- Seam-Walker (8 XP)

Lethai Syncretic (Ghe'hai)

- Mask of Many Faces (6 XP)
- Silk Binding (4 XP)
- Ghe'hai's Escape (8 XP)

D.7.5 Talent Synergies Reference

po.3 po.6

Combination Synergy Effect

Flesh Codex + Witnessed Scar Body is both Codex and testimony; cannot be disarmed.

Shared Burden + Living Thiasos You and Thiasos endure together; neither falls alone.

Iron Resolve + Avatar of the Codex Nearly unkillable for one scene; cost is a scar.

Talking Weapon + The Blade Remembers Thiasos is chronicler; reminds you of past tactics.

The Hilt Listens + Perfect Recall Perfect spy; reports conversations verbatim days later.

The Edge Speaks + The Voice of the Fallen Speaks with voices of the dead; confuses and extracts.

The Bonded Blade + Engraved Witness True extension of self; acts in small ways while you focus.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

D.8 Rites by Patron and Tier

This table organizes all Runic Warrior Rites by Patron and tier. Rites are listed with their XP cost and a brief effect summary. Refer to the individual Patron chapters for full descriptions, tags, thresholds, and Obligation costs.

D.8.1 Oath of Flame and Light (Dawn Warrior)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Kindled Blade Low (4 XP) Weapon ignites with radiant light; +1 Harm against undead and oath-breakers.

Rite of the Steadfast Gaze Low (4 XP) Target cannot lie to you for one exchange.

Rite of the Unbroken Vow Standard (7 XP) Swear oath before flame; gain +1 Armor; ally gains +1 die.

Rite of Dawn's Judgment Standard (8 XP) Melee attack ignores 1 Armor; +2 Harm to undead and oath-breakers.

Rite of the Dawnfire Covenant High (12 XP) Consecrate zone; allies resist fear; enemies suffer -1 die.

D.8.2 Oath of Mercy and Grace (Hospitaller)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Shared Bowl Low (4 XP) You and target clear 1 Fatigue; target gains +1 die vs. fear.

Rite of the Grey Touch Low (4 XP) Remove 1 Fatigue or stabilize a dying patient.

Rite of the Sheltered Hearth Standard (7 XP) Consecrate sanctuary; no violence initiation; dying cannot die.

Rite of the Spiral's Witness Standard (8 XP) Name a crushed person; they ignore penalties for one scene.

Rite of the Endless Spiral High (12 XP) Zone heals 2 Fatigue; acts of care cost -1 Obligation.

D.8.3 Mykkiel (Justicar)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Measured Debt Low (4 XP) Establish accord; both parties suffer -1 die if they break it.

Rite of the Weighed Heart Low (5 XP) Sense if target acts against nature or oath.

Rite of the Balanced Scales Standard (8 XP) Exchange burden between two willing parties.

Rite of the Covenant Seal Standard (9 XP) Formalize binding covenant; breach causes Harm 1.

Rite of the Final Adjudication High (13 XP) Convene unseen tribunal; truth-tellers gain +2 dice.

D.8.4 Inquisitor Prime (Purifier)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Pure Flame Low (4 XP) +2 dice vs. supernatural influence; +1 Armor vs. magic.
 Rite of the Unclouded Eye Low (5 XP) +2 dice to spot illusions and magical deception.
 Rite of the Cleansing Light Standard (8 XP) Dispel or weaken magical effect.
 Rite of the Marked Prey Standard (7 XP) Mark supernatural target; they suffer -1 die; you gain +1 die to track.
 Rite of the Final Admonition High (13 XP) Attempt to annihilate one supernatural foe.

D.8.5 The Witness (Truth-Sworn)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Lingering Trace Low (4 XP) +1 die to investigate trace; ask one yes/no question.
 Rite of the Uncomfortable Question Low (5 XP) Target answers truthfully or marks Fatigue and gains Guilty Tell.
 Rite of the Echoing Truth Standard (8 XP) Target suffers -1 die to deception; you may ask one truthful question.
 Rite of the Immutable Record Standard (7 XP) Bind agreement; breach causes SB and Oathbreaker's Mark.
 Rite of the Final Reckoning High (13 XP) All present speak hidden truth; liars suffer Harm 2.

D.8.6 The Sealed Gate (Warden)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Sealed Threshold Low (4 XP) Mark doorway as sealed; crossing requires Resolve test.
 Rite of the Key's Rebuke Low (5 XP) Push target back from threshold.
 Rite of the Circle of Denial Standard (8 XP) Create protective circle; spirits test to cross.
 Rite of the Writ of Passage Standard (7 XP) Designate authorized route; allies gain Position +1.
 Rite of the Consecrated Barrier High (13 XP) Consecrate area against unauthorized passage.

D.8.7 The Traveler (Road-Warden)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of Road-Sense Low (4 XP) Pick fastest safe route; +1 die to avoid ambushes.
 Rite of the Traveler's Boon Low (5 XP) Ignore one level of difficult terrain; +1 Effect to travel.
 Rite of the Waymark Standard (8 XP) Declare lane as permitted; allies gain improved Position.
 Rite of the Bridge Between Standard (7 XP) Relocate willing target within Far along named route.
 Rite of the Wayfarer's Covenant High (14 XP) Bind safe passage; reroll one failed travel roll per scene.

D.8.8 The Pale Shepherd (Death-Warden)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Gentle Guide	Low (5 XP)	Ease hard crossing or find hidden path.
Rite of the Unburdened Farewell	Low (6 XP)	Speak final goodbye; clear 1 Fatigue and remove psychological Condition.
Rite of the Passing Flock	Standard (8 XP)	Open shadow passage or call shadow-sheep for guidance.
Rite of the Steadfast Witness	Standard (7 XP)	Record dying last words; breach causes -1 die for one week.
Rite of the Unburdened Crossing	High (13 XP)	Guide willing creature across threshold; gain Truth Compass.

D.8.9 Grimmir (Root-Knight)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Blood Offering	Low (4 XP)	+1 die to Survival and Stealth in natural terrain; ask one question.
Rite of the Predator's Gaze	Low (5 XP)	Mark prey; +1 die to track, pursue, or intimidate.
Rite of the Shifting Shape	Standard (8 XP)	Assume predator form (bear or wolf) for one scene.
Rite of the Carrion Feast	Standard (9 XP)	Devour fallen enemy; heal 1 Fatigue; gain minor property.
Rite of the Cycle's Crown	High (14 XP)	Become avatar of cycle; choose two seasonal boons.

D.8.10 The Carrion-King (Grave-Warden)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Rotting Harvest	Low (5 XP)	Accelerate decay; gain +2 Effect vs. organic objects.
Rite of the Borrowed Form	Low (7 XP)	Channel deceased's expertise; gain skill die or ask one question.
Rite of the Fertile Death	Standard (8 XP)	Transform death into growth; create terrain or grant healing bonus.
Rite of the Great Consumption	Standard (13 XP)	Transform area through decay; choose two effects.
Rite of the Eternal Cycle	High (14 XP)	Destroy one major asset; create something new of equal value.

D.8.11 The Savage Heart (Beast Warrior)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Predator's Gaze	Low (4 XP)	Mark prey; +1 die to track, pursue, or intimidate.
Rite of the Blood Scent	Low (5 XP)	+2 dice to track by smell; detect fear within Near.
Rite of the Shifting Shape	Standard (8 XP)	Assume predator form (bear or wolf) for one scene.
Rite of the Pack Hunt	Standard (7 XP)	Form hunting pack; allies gain +1 die against designated prey.
Rite of the Savage Transformation	High (13 XP)	Fully transform into apex predator; Body +2, +2 Armor, +2 Harm.

D.8.12 Khemesh (Deep Warrior)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Crushing Whisper Low (5 XP) Target hears impossible echoes or establish oppressive silence.
 Rite of the Abyssal Grasp Low (7 XP) Pin target with invisible crushing force.
 Rite of the Alien Gaze Standard (9 XP) +2 dice to Notice and Arcana; ask one true nature question.
 Rite of the Pressure's Toll Standard (8 XP) Transfer inefficiency; reduce DV or impose -1 die.
 Rite of the Sundering Deep High (14 XP) Reality folds inward; enemies act at Desperate Position.

D.8.13 Xhak'Thul (Storm-Sworn)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Thunderous Presence Low (4 XP) Overwhelming presence; NPCs test Resolve or suffer -1 die.
 Rite of the Storm's Step Low (5 XP) +2 dice to Athletics or Stealth; first attack gains +1 Effect.
 Rite of the Shattered Sky Standard (8 XP) Call localized storm; choose lightning, wind, or hail.
 Rite of the Fear-Eater Standard (9 XP) Feed on fear; gain +1 die per Frightened target (max +3).
 Rite of the World's Drum High (14 XP) Become incarnation of storm; +2 dice to strength, speed, intimidation.

D.8.14 Raéyn (Tide-Knight)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Wave-Tide Low (5 XP) Treat slick footing as stable or learn safest route.
 Rite of the Tide's Favor Low (4 XP) Ignore one penalty from moving water; cannot be knocked prone by water.
 Rite of the Changing Tide Standard (8 XP) Bias currents; those moving with tide gain +1 die.
 Rite of the Wave-Road Consecration Standard (7 XP) Consecrate wave-road; allies gain +2 dice to travel.
 Rite of the Storm-Queen's Hand High (13 XP) Shape storm-band; choose two modes (propulsion, concealment, smite).

D.8.15 Ikasha (Shadow Warrior)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Unlit Candle Low (4 XP) +1 die to Stealth or Subterfuge; declare one detail forgotten.
 Rite of the Crossroads Raven Low (5 XP) Raven appears; reroll failed navigation or make enemy hesitate.
 Rite of the Umbral Reservoir Standard (8 XP) Draw on shadow; +2 dice, clear Fatigue, or free escape success.
 Rite of the Unlatched Secret Standard (9 XP) Open threshold or compel truthful answer to one question.

Rite of the Umbral Dream High (14 XP) Become shadow; gain intangible, +2 Stealth, or bypass obstacle.

D.8.16 The Silent Choir (Silent Blade)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Gentle Seal Low (5 XP) Hush space or shield truth from discovery.

Rite of the Quiet Ear Low (4 XP) Hear conversations through walls; cannot be detected.

Rite of the Burden Bearer Standard (8 XP) Name crushed person; they ignore penalties for one scene.

Rite of the Unspoken Vow Standard (7 XP) Swear oath not spoken aloud; breaking causes -1 die for one week.

Rite of the Unburdened Confession High (13 XP) Absorb traumatic memory from willing creature; gain Corruption.

D.8.17 Aveh (Unbound Blade)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Unlatched Step Low (4 XP) Slip free of notice or mark target as outside.

Rite of the Forgotten Road Low (6 XP) Erase trail or grant companion +2 dice to resist capture.

Rite of the Storm's Refuge Standard (12 XP) Group unseen or forgotten for scene; all mark Corruption or forget bond.

Rite of the Unremembered Name Standard (13 XP) Name erased from records for one week; +2 dice to avoid detection.

Rite of the Horizon's Devour High (15 XP) Collapse thresholds; erase something of you.

D.8.18 Inaea (Web-Warrior)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Hearth-Thread Knot Low (4 XP) Bind with target; both gain +1 die to Aid; share Harm.

Rite of the Snaring Filament Low (5 XP) Lay invisible snare; first crossing suffers -2 dice.

Rite of the Strand of Inevitability Standard (8 XP) Link two actors; one action drags other into consequence.

Rite of the Spinner's Debt Standard (9 XP) Offer boon; target accepts Promise Clock [4].

Rite of the Merciful Severing High (13 XP) Sever harmful tie; remove Condition or 1 SB.

D.8.19 Isoka (Serpent-Blade)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Loosening Skin Low (4 XP) Remove Condition or reroll failed escape.
 Rite of the Forked Tongue Low (5 XP) Speak ambiguously without penalty; treat Partial as Clean on Deception.
 Rite of the Shedded Self Standard (8 XP) Shed identity; treated as stranger for scene.
 Rite of Venom's Paradox Standard (9 XP) Inflict poison or cure poison/disease.
 Rite of Unremembered Metamorphosis High (13 XP) Complete metamorphosis; new face, voice, identity.

D.8.20 Malachai (Thorn-Sworn)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Honeyed Binding Low (5 XP) Target gains +2 dice but takes 1 Corruption.
 Rite of the False Dawn Low (6 XP) Bestow gift with hidden curse; target begins Corruption clock.
 Rite of the Cruel Transformation Standard (9 XP) Infect target with supernatural condition for one scene.
 Rite of the Messenger's Burden Standard (13 XP) Channel Malachai; +2 dice per beat, each use marks 1 SB.
 Rite of the Chained Angel's Tribute High (14 XP) Corrupt sacred space; curses gain +1 Effect.

D.8.21 Clockwork Monad (Gear-Warrior)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Iterative Spark Low (5 XP) Enhance creation or analyse improvement.
 Rite of the Quick Infusion Low (4 XP) Create temporary infusion (reinforced blade, striking gear, momentary shield).
 Rite of the Adaptive Mechanism Standard (8 XP) Self-optimising device or progressive workshop.
 Rite of the Optimisation Cascade Standard (7 XP) Establish locus of progressive creation; failures produce insight.
 Rite of the Ultimate Iteration High (14 XP) Achieve perfect optimisation; +3 dice for one session.

D.8.22 Varnek Karn (Cairn-Knight)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Crossing Fee Low (4 XP) Open speech with specific dead individual.
 Rite of the Ancestral Consultation Low (5 XP) Ask one question of ancestral spirit.
 Rite of the Mediated Pact Standard (8 XP) Bind death-bound pact or serve as spirit medium.
 Rite of the Unquiet Host Standard (10 XP) Summon spectral warband as Cap 3 Follower.
 Rite of the Final Testament High (13 XP) Seal dying last request with weight beyond life.

D.8.23 The High Mother (Bloodsworn)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Unspoken Grief Low (4 XP) Absorb grief of dying person; gain Grief Token.
 Rite of the Milk Teeth Low (4 XP) Bind reflection; target acts at Position -1.
 Rite of the Silent Tithe Standard (7 XP) Declare household owes Cord a tithe; gain Influence.
 Rite of the Flesh-Knot Standard (8 XP) Store Fatigue as visible knot in skin.
 Rite of the Hollowed Union High (12 XP) Join bloodlines through debt paid by unborn child.

D.8.24 The Ninth (Fractal Blade)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Ninth Figure Low (4 XP) +1 die to Lore or Investigation with complex systems.
 Rite of the Flooded Scriptorium Low (5 XP) Ask three questions on any topic with written record.
 Rite of the Hypercognitive Lattice Standard (8 XP) Treat Wits as +2 higher for information-processing.
 Rite of the Breaking Glyph Standard (7 XP) Gain perfect grasp of complex system; +3 dice for session.
 Rite of the Ninth Revelation High (14 XP) Glimpse shard of Ninth truth; gain major insight.

D.8.25 Lunara (Moon Knight)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Moonlit Mirror Low (4 XP) +1 die to detect illusions; ask one veiled question.
 Rite of the Crescent Whisper Low (5 XP) Deliver secret thought to target; +1 die to aid them.
 Rite of the Triple Road Standard (8 XP) Reveal hidden path; allies gain +2 dice to traverse.
 Rite of the Lunar Conjunction Standard (7 XP) Commune with veiled knowledge; ask two questions.
 Rite of the Moonbound Ascendant High (14 XP) Enter heightened lunar state; choose two benefits.

D.8.26 Lethai Syncretic (Ghe'hai Operative)

po.25 po.25 po.4

Rite Tier Effect Summary

Rite of the Silk Binding Low (4 XP) Immobilize target with invisible threads.
 Rite of the Mask of Many Faces Standard (7 XP) Assume appearance of any person you have touched.
 Rite of the Unspoken Question Standard (8 XP) Force target to answer one question truthfully.
 Rite of the Spider's Web Standard (9 XP) Create zone of binding threads; enemies suffer -1 die to movement.
 Rite of the Ghe'hai's Escape High (12 XP) Vanish when cornered; reappear in safe location; leave token.

D.8.27 Rite Tier Summary

po.2 po.3 po.4

Tier XP Cost Typical Effect Scale

Low 4-6 XP Scene-limited, single target, minor advantage.
 Standard 7-9 XP Lasting effect, area or multiple targets, significant advantage.
 High 12-15 XP Powerful, costly, often requires witness or threshold.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

D.9 Thiasos by Patron

The following table lists suggested Thiasos forms for each Patron, organized by type. A Thiasos may be living (creature), sentient (object), or spirit. See Chapter: The Thiasos as Ally for full rules.

Patron	Living Thiasos	Sentient Thiasos	Spirit Thiasos
Oath of Flame & Light	Warhorse, Warhound	Dawnblade	Ember-Spirit
Oath of Mercy & Grace	Hospice Bird, Grey Mule	The Grey Bell	Memory of Mercy
Mykkiel	Spirit-Hound, Warhorse	The Speaking Gavel	Precedent-Shade
Inquisitor Prime	Censer-Hound, Lantern-Keeper	The Censer of Unforgiving Flame	Purifier's Witness
The Witness	Raven, Recording Moth	The Silver Mirror	Echo of Truth
The Sealed Gate	Threshold Spirit, Gate-Wolf	The Keystone	Warden-Shade
The Traveler	Spirit-Horse, Road-Dog	The Waystone Compass	Path-Memory
The Pale Shepherd	Grey Bird, Spirit-Sheep	The Grey Bell	Shepherd's Witness
Grimmir	Wolf-Ancestor, Great Stag	The Root-Staff	Grove-Spirit
The Carrion-King	Crow, Fungal Familiar	The Bone-Chime	Rot-Shade
The Savage Heart	Great Cat, Wolf-Ancestor	The Fang	Predator-Spirit
Khemesh	Pressure-Eel, Deep Angler	The Abyssal Glass	Drowned Spirit
Xhak'Thul	Storm-Horse, Thunder-Bird	The Thunder Drum	Storm-Spirit
Raéyn	Selkie, Seabird	The Salt Compass	Tide-Shade
Ikasha	Raven, Shadow-Cat	The Raven's Quill	Whisper-Spirit
The Silent Choir	Hollowed Bird, Grey Moth	The Sealed Lips	Memory-Spirit
Aveh	Trackless Horse, Wind-Hound	The Storm-Banner	Wind-Spirit
Inaea	Spider, Silk-Moth	The Loom-Shuttle	Web-Spirit
Isoka	Serpent, Venomous Familiar	The Shed Fang	Molt-Shade
Malachai	Cursed Hound, Collector	The Silver Coin	Thorn-Spirit
Clockwork Monad	Clockwork Familiar, Gear-Spider	The Iteration Lens	Optimisation-Spirit
Varnek Karn	Cairn-Wight, Grave-Raven	The Grave-Token	Ancestral Shade
The High Mother	Hollowed Child, Heartless Bird	The Scarlet Needle	Cord-Shade
The Ninth	Fractal Moth, Pattern-Spider	The Fractal Slate	Paradox-Echo
Lunara	Shadow-Cat, Moon-Moth	The Moon Disc	Silver-Shade
Lethai (Ghe'hai)	Silk-Spider, Mask-Wasp	The Silk Mask	Veil-Spirit

Thiasos Types by Category

Living Thiasos

Creatures that breathe, eat, and bleed. They can act independently, accept Shared Burden (Fatigue transfer), and have their own Harm tracks. They can be killed.

Sentient Thiasos

Objects that speak, remember, and witness. They cannot act independently, cannot accept Fatigue, but cannot be killed (only damaged or destroyed). They serve as both Thiasos and Codex.

Spirit Thiasos

Incorporeal entities that witness, remember, and sometimes speak. They cannot be harmed by mundane weapons. They can pass through walls and observe without being seen. They have no physical presence but count as witnesses for all Rites.

Choosing a Thiasos

When building a Runic Warrior, choose one Thiasos from your Patron's list, or work with your GM to design a custom Thiasos appropriate to your Patron and culture. A Thiasos should reflect the Runekeeper's covenant and complement their combat style.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

D.10 Codex by Patron

The following table lists suggested Codex forms for each Patron. A Runic Warrior's Codex is not a book—it is a physical object that carries their Rites. See Chapter: The Codex as Object for full rules.

Codex Forms by Category**Worn (Armor, Clothing, Jewelry)**

The Codex is worn on the body. It cannot be stolen without being noticed. It is always visible. Examples: gorget, gauntlet, grey cloak, locket, scar-plate, silk mask.

Carried (Weapons, Tools, Instruments)

The Codex is held or wielded. It can be lost or stolen. It can serve as a weapon or tool. Examples: shield, gavel, staff, axe, waystone, compass, drum, spear.

Marked (Tattoos, Brands, Scars)

The Codex is inscribed on the Runekeeper's skin. It cannot be stolen. It cannot be hidden without clothing. Examples: flesh-tattoos, sealed lips tattoo, scar-plate.

Kept (Tokens, Relics, Trinkets)

The Codex is a small object carried in a pocket or pouch. It is portable and concealable. It can be lost or stolen. Examples: silver coin, thorn, black pearl, bone-chime, shed snakeskin.

Patron	Codex Form	Description
Oath of Flame & Light	Engraved Gorget, Branded Gauntlet	Steel worn over throat or hand, each vow a line of flame
Oath of Mercy & Grace	Grey Cloak, Silver Locket	Woven wool or sealed silver, each fold or tarnish a mercy
Mykkiel	Shield, Oath-Beads, Gavel	Steel or bone, each dent a case won, each bead a covenant
Inquisitor Prime	Censer, Gauntlet, Brand	Brass or iron, never cold, engraved with proscription lists
The Witness	Silver Mirror, Locket, Recording Slate	Polished silver or sealed metal, shows truth or records covenants
The Sealed Gate	Shield, Gate-Key, Bell	Steel or iron, engraved with threshold sigils, marks boundaries
The Traveler	Waystone, Compass, Road-Staff	Carved stone or brass, points to roads or thresholds
The Pale Shepherd	Grey Cloak, Shepherd's Crook, Memory Cord	Woven wool or carved wood, each fold a farewell witness
Grimmir	Carved Staff, Living Bark, Thorn-Cord	Oak or ash, still growing, carved with seasonal runes
The Carrion-King	Bone-Chime, Compost-Stained Trowel, Rot-Cord	Bone or iron, crusted with dark earth, clicks when death is near
The Savage Heart	Predator's Tooth, Pelt Cloak, Claw Necklace	Bone or fur, warm when prey is near, each claw a worth
Khemesh	Abyssal Glass, Diving Bell Valve, Black Pearl	Black glass or brass, cold to the touch, whispers when pressure changes
Xhak'Thul	Storm Drum, Thunder Banner, Lightning-Scarred Spear	Wood and hide, rumbles when storms approach, scarred with lightning
Raéyn	Ship's Wheel, Anchor Charm, Salt-Crusted Compass	Wood or iron, heavy, turns smoothly, points to safe harbors
Ikasha	Shadow-Cloak, Raven's Quill, Silence Bell	Black wool or silk, drinks light, writes in invisible ink
The Silent Choir	Sealed Lips Tattoo, Grey Cord, Silence Bell	Ink or wool, a vow made visible, a knot for each secret kept
Aveh	Storm-Banner, Broken Sword, Erased Map	Torn cloth or snapped steel, twists in unfelt wind, roads shown in scars
Inaea	Spider-Silk Cord, Loom-Shuttle, Threaded Needle	Pale silk or carved wood, stronger than steel, weaves obligations
Isoka	Shed Snakeskin, Fang, Scale	Delicate skin or hollow tooth, warm when change is near
Malachai	Silver Coin, Thorn, Cracked Symbol	Warm metal or black thorn, each use adds a scar
Clockwork Monad	Toolbelt, Schematic-Slate, Brass Lens	Leather and brass, chalked diagrams that change, sees secrets
Varnek Karn	Rune-Carved Axe, Burial Stone, Wergild Bracelet	Steel or stone, carved with ancestors' names, each notch a story
The High Mother	Flesh-Tattoos, Grey Cord, Scar-Plate	Ink or wool, woven into skin, each knot a promise kept
The Ninth	Fractal Slate, Broken Mirror, Equation Rod	Slate or glass, covered in spiraling equations, shows impossible
Lunara	Moon Disc, Silver Needle, Dream-Cord	Polished silver or silk, glows under moonlight, records dreams
Lethai (Ghe'hai)	Silk Mask, Memory Cord, Veil-Clasp	Woven silk or braided cord, shifts patterns, hides the face

Choosing a Codex

When building a Runic Warrior, choose a Codex form appropriate to your Patron and cultural origin. The Codex should reflect your covenant—a Dawn Warrior's engraved gorget, a Bloodsworn's flesh-tattoos, a Shadow Warrior's raven's quill.

A Codex may be damaged or destroyed. Repairing it requires a Craft test (DV 3-5) and appropriate materials. A destroyed Codex loses all Rites engraved on it.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

D.II Sentient Thiasos by Patron

The following table lists suggested sentient Thiasos forms for each Patron. A sentient Thiasos is an object that speaks, remembers, and witnesses. It cannot act independently, but it serves as both Thiasos and Codex. See Chapter: The Thiasos as Ally (Optional Rule: The Sentient Thiasos) for full rules.

Sentient Thiasos Traits

All sentient Thiasos share the following traits:

- **Witness:** Counts as a witness for all Rites. It sees, it remembers, it can testify.

Patron	Sentient Thiasos	Description
Oath of Flame & Light	Dawnblade	A longsword that hums with trapped light. Speaks in proverbs about honor.
Oath of Mercy & Grace	The Grey Bell	A small bronze bell that hums, never rings. Speaks in the voice of the last soul.
Mykkiel	The Speaking Gavel	A judge's gavel carved from ironwood. Speaks in legal citations. Can compel a
Inquisitor Prime	The Censer of Unforgiving Flame	A brass censer that never goes cold. Speaks in harsh, clipped sentences. Its sm
The Witness	The Silver Mirror	A hand mirror that speaks in a flat, neutral tone. Can record a single truth and
The Sealed Gate	The Keystone	A small carved stone that speaks in riddles. Can seal any door for one scene, b
The Traveler	The Waystone Compass	A compass that speaks in the sound of footsteps. Can find a shortcut, but ask
The Pale Shepherd	The Grey Bell	A small bronze bell that hums. Speaks in the voice of the last soul it guided. A
Grimmir	The Root-Staff	A walking staff carved from living wood. Speaks in the rustle of wind through
The Carrion-King	The Bone-Chime	A set of bones that clicks in the voice of the creature they came from. Can sen
The Savage Heart	The Fang	A blade carved from the tooth of a legendary beast. Speaks in growls. Hunger
Khemesh	The Abyssal Glass	A shard of black glass that speaks in the voice of drowned captains. Can exting
Xhak'Thul	The Thunder Drum	A drum that speaks in drumbeats—slow for warning, rapid for danger. Can b
Raéyn	The Salt Compass	A compass that speaks in the rustle of waves. Can find the nearest safe harbor
Ikasha	The Raven's Quill	A black feather that speaks in rustles. Can erase a single written word from a c
The Silent Choir	The Sealed Lips	A clay or porcelain mask with a mouth sewn shut with silver thread. Does not
Aveh	The Storm-Banner	A torn flag on a broken pole that speaks in the howl of wind. Planted, it creat
Inaea	The Loom-Shuttle	A wooden shuttle that speaks in the click of weaving. Can tie a Thread of Me
Isoka	The Shed Fang	A hollow fang that speaks in a sibilant whisper. Can deliver a dose of venom o
Malachai	The Silver Coin	A silver coin that speaks in the voice of the last person who spent it. Can be o
Clockwork Monad	The Iteration Lens	A brass-and-glass lens that speaks in numbers and percentages. Can analyze a
Varnek Karn	The Grave-Token	A polished skull that speaks in the voice of the Runekeeper's own dead. Know
The High Mother	The Scarlet Needle	A silver needle with a red thread already threaded. Speaks in whispers. Can sti
The Ninth	The Fractal Slate	A slate tablet covered in spiraling, unfinished equations. Speaks in overlapping
Lunara	The Moon Disc	A silver disc that speaks in a soft, melancholic voice. Can reveal a hidden thres
Lethai (Ghe'hai)	The Silk Mask	A mask of woven silk that shifts patterns. Speaks in a neutral, androgynous vo

- **Codex:** Rites can be engraved, etched, or woven into its surface. If destroyed, all Rites are lost.
- **Communication:** Speaks aloud (not just in the Runekeeper's mind). It has its own personality, opinions, and occasionally inappropriate commentary.
- **Vulnerability:** Cannot act independently. Cannot accept Shared Burden (Fatigue transfer). Can be damaged or destroyed.

Sentient Thiasos Talents

Characters with a sentient Thiasos may take the following talents:

- **Talking Weapon (2 XP):** Your sentient Thiasos can speak aloud. The GM may use it to deliver hints, warnings, or comic relief.
- **The Blade Remembers (4 XP):** Once per session, your Thiasos can recall a past enemy's fighting style, granting you +1 die to defend against a similar foe.
- **The Hilt Listens (6 XP):** Your Thiasos can hear conversations within Near range even when you are not present (if you leave it in a room). At the end of the scene, it reports what it heard.

- **The Edge Speaks (8 XP):** Once per session, your Thiasos can deliver a single sentence in the voice of anyone whose blood it has tasted. Use this to confuse, frighten, or compel an enemy.

Creating a Sentient Thiasos

When building a sentient Thiasos, work with your GM to determine:

- Its **voice** (cracked, smooth, whispering, booming, multiple)
- Its **personality** (honorable, cynical, mournful, eager, reluctant)
- Its **memory** (what it remembers, what it has forgotten)
- Its **demand** (what it asks for in return for service—a story, a promise, a memory)

A sentient Thiasos is not a pet. It is a partner—and sometimes a critic.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Appendix E

Glossary of Terms

E.1 Glossary of Terms

The following terms are used throughout this expansion. For terms not listed here, consult the *Fate's Edge Comprehensive Resource Guide*.

A

Bloodsworn A Runic Warrior of the High Mother. A warrior who stores Fatigue as knots in their flesh, who pays in blood what others pay in gold.

B

Runic Warrior A Runekeeper whose Codex is a physical object (flesh, stone, or steel) rather than a book. Runic Warriors emphasize physical action, resilience, and close combat.

Bound Vessel A corpse reoccupied by a willing spirit through the Rite of Reoccupied Vessel (Varnek Karn). Serves for a set term or until a specific task is completed.

C

Cairn-Knight A Runic Warrior of Varnek Karn. A death-negotiator who fights alongside ancestral shades and carries the weight of the dead into battle.

Codex The physical record of a Runekeeper's Rites. For a Runic Warrior, the Codex may be a gorget, shield, staff, tattoo, or sentient weapon.

Collector A hollowed child or spirit sent by Malachai to collect debts. Has milk-white eyes sewn shut with silver wire. Does not speak. Watches.

D

Dawn Warrior A Runic Warrior of the Oath of Flame and Light. A crusader who carries vows in steel and fire, who smites foes with radiant strikes.

Death-Warden A Runic Warrior of the Pale Shepherd. A warrior who stands at the threshold between life and death, guiding those who cross.

Deep Warrior A Runic Warrior of Khemesh. An eldritch knight who fights in crushing darkness, who carries the pressure of the abyss in their lungs.

F

Fractal Warrior A Runic Warrior of The Ninth. A warrior who fights with impossible angles and precognition, whose Codex is a broken mirror.

G

Gear-Warrior A Runic Warrior of the Clockwork Monad. An artificer who wears their craft as armor, who improves themselves mid-battle.

Ghe'hai Lethai elite operatives—warriors who are also diplomats, assassins who are also negotiators. A Runic Warrior of the Lethai syncretic tradition.

Grave-Warden A Runic Warrior of the Carrion-King. A warrior who harvests endings and turns them into strength, who fights with rot and renewal.

Grey Gauntlet A knightly tradition within the Oath of Mercy and Grace. Warriors who carry mercy in steel, who protect the helpless and turn violence back on itself.

H

Hollowed A child or animal whose heart has been removed and replaced with a bundle of grey thread and the ash of a forgotten name. Eyes sewn open with silver wire. Witnesses Rites. Cannot be harmed by mundane means. Associated with the High Mother.

Hospitaller A warrior of the Oath of Mercy and Grace. A combat medic who fights not to kill, but to protect. Binds wounds mid-battle. Creates sanctuary.

J

Justicar A Runic Warrior of Mykkiel. A lawbringer who carries the covenant in steel, who enforces oaths with a blade.

P

Purifier A Runic Warrior of the Inquisitor Prime. A witch-hunter who carries judgment in steel and fire, who hunts the corrupt and the tainted.

R

Road-Warden A Runic Warrior of the Traveler. A warrior who carries the road in their feet and their steel, who guides and protects travelers.

Root-Knight A Runic Warrior of Grimmer. A wild warrior who fights with root and thorn, who wears the forest as armor.

S

Serpent-Blade A Runic Warrior of Isoka. A warrior who sheds identity like skin, who transforms in the midst of battle, who uses venom as a weapon.

Shadow Warrior A Runic Warrior of Ikasha. A ninja, a spy, an unseen blade who strikes once and vanishes.

Silent Blade A Runic Warrior of the Silent Choir. A warrior who has sworn an oath of restraint, who protects the vulnerable and keeps the secrets of the dead.

Storm-Sworn A Runic Warrior of Xhak'Thul. A primal warrior who carries the tempest in their blood, who shouts as a weapon.

T

Thiasos A fragment of a Patron's attention made manifest. For a Runic Warrior, the Thiasos may be a warhorse, a spirit-hound, a hollowed bird, or a sentient blade.

Thorn-Sworn A Runic Warrior of Malachai. A cursed warrior who has accepted power at a price, who carries their affliction like a second skin.

Tide-Knight A Runic Warrior of Raéyn. A warrior who fights on rolling decks and slippery shores, who reads the currents of battle as a pilot reads the sea.

Truth-Sworn A Runic Warrior of The Witness. A warrior who carries truth in steel and silence, who cannot lie, who exposes deception.

U

Unbound Blade A Runic Warrior of Aveh. A ronin, a wanderer, a warrior who has cut all ties and answers to no master.

W

Warden A Runic Warrior of the Sealed Gate. A sentinel who stands at the boundary between what belongs and what must be kept out.

Web-Warrior A Runic Warrior of Inaea. A fighter who binds foes in invisible threads, who controls the battle-field through entanglement and restraint.

Credits

This glossary was compiled from the *Fate's Edge Comprehensive Resource Guide*, *The Grey Wanderer's Grimoire*, and *The Runic Warrior: Codices of Flesh, Stone, and Steel*.

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

Appendix F

Faction Relationship Matrix

F.I Faction Relationship Matrix

The following tables outline how major factions across Fate's Edge view Runic Warriors. Use these as guidelines for roleplaying, social navigation, and conflict generation.

Faction Stances

Each faction's stance is rated as:

- **Welcome:** Runic Warriors are accepted, even respected. May receive preferential treatment.
- **Tolerated:** Runic Warriors are accepted conditionally. Must follow local customs or face consequences.
- **Suspicious:** Runic Warriors are watched. May face scrutiny, delayed service, or higher prices.
- **Hostile:** Runic Warriors are hunted or actively opposed. May be arrested, attacked, or driven out.
- **Varies:** Stance depends on specific Patron, culture, or circumstances.

By Patron Family

By Specific Patron (Notable Examples)

Using the Faction Matrix

When a Runic Warrior interacts with a faction, consider:

- **Welcome:** NPCs may offer aid, lower prices, or share information. Social rolls start at Controlled Position.
- **Tolerated:** NPCs are neutral but watchful. Social rolls start at Controlled Position but may shift to Desperate if the Runekeeper draws attention.
- **Suspicious:** NPCs are wary. Social rolls start at Controlled Position but suffer +1 DV. Guards may ask questions.

Faction	Vowed	Threshold	Wild	Deep	Shadow
Chain-Lanterns (Thepyrgos)	Tolerated	Suspicious	Hostile	Hostile	Hostile
Spirit-Shield Correctors (Aeler)	Welcome	Welcome	Tolerated	Suspicious	Suspicious
Sum-Abjurers (Aelinnel)	Tolerated	Welcome	Tolerated	Tolerated	Tolerated
Break-Reins Riders (Ykrul)	Suspicious	Welcome	Welcome	Suspicious	Tolerated
Silk Vigil (Lethai)	Tolerated	Welcome	Welcome	Suspicious	Tolerated
Shed Vigil (Lethai)	Tolerated	Tolerated	Welcome	Suspicious	Tolerated
Wake-Judges (Linn)	Suspicious	Welcome	Welcome	Suspicious	Suspicious
Daughters of the Cord	Suspicious	Tolerated	Tolerated	Suspicious	Tolerated
Everflame Inquisition (Ecktoria)	Hostile	Hostile	Hostile	Hostile	Hostile
Queen's Justicars (Viterra)	Welcome	Tolerated	Suspicious	Suspicious	Suspicious
Admiralty (Kahfagia)	Tolerated	Welcome	Tolerated	Tolerated	Tolerated
Salt Prince's Court (Zakov)	Tolerated	Tolerated	Suspicious	Welcome	Tolerated
Vermilion Corps (Oshiira)	Tolerated	Suspicious	Suspicious	Suspicious	Hostile
Veiled Sisters (Ashaan)	Hostile	Hostile	Hostile	Tolerated	Hostile
Green Council (Sekogo)	Suspicious	Tolerated	Welcome	Suspicious	Tolerated

Faction	Web	Forge	Grave	Fracture
Chain-Lanterns (Thepyrgos)	Hostile	Tolerated	Hostile	Hostile
Spirit-Shield Correctors (Aeler)	Suspicious	Welcome	Tolerated	Suspicious
Sum-Abjurers (Aelinnel)	Tolerated	Welcome	Tolerated	Welcome
Break-Reins Riders (Ykrul)	Tolerated	Tolerated	Welcome	Suspicious
Silk Vigil (Lethai)	Welcome	Tolerated	Tolerated	Tolerated
Shed Vigil (Lethai)	Tolerated	Suspicious	Tolerated	Suspicious
Wake-Judges (Linn)	Suspicious	Suspicious	Welcome	Suspicious
Daughters of the Cord	Welcome	Suspicious	Tolerated	Suspicious
Everflame Inquisition (Ecktoria)	Hostile	Hostile	Hostile	Hostile
Queen's Justicars (Viterra)	Suspicious	Tolerated	Suspicious	Suspicious
Admiralty (Kahfagia)	Tolerated	Tolerated	Tolerated	Suspicious
Salt Prince's Court (Zakov)	Tolerated	Tolerated	Welcome	Suspicious
Vermilion Corps (Oshiira)	Hostile	Tolerated	Suspicious	Hostile
Veiled Sisters (Ashaan)	Hostile	Suspicious	Hostile	Hostile
Green Council (Sekogo)	Welcome	Suspicious	Welcome	Suspicious

- **Hostile:** NPCs are actively opposed. Social rolls start at Desperate Position. The faction may send agents to harass, arrest, or eliminate the Runekeeper.
- **Varies:** The GM determines stance based on specific Patron, cultural context, and recent events.

Changing Stance

A Runic Warrior's standing with a faction can change through:

- **Service:** Completing a mission for the faction improves stance by one step (Hostile → Suspicious → Tolerated → Welcome).
- **Harm:** Attacking faction members or undermining their goals worsens stance by one step.
- **Reputation:** Famous (or infamous) deeds may shift stance region-wide.
- **Patron's Influence:** Some Patrons have standing relationships with factions (e.g., the Everflame Inquisition welcomes Oath of Flame & Light Runekeepers).

Patron	Faction	Stance
Oath of Flame & Light	Everflame Inquisition	Welcome (as censer-knights)
Oath of Flame & Light	Queen's Justicars	Welcome (as dawn-knights)
Oath of Mercy & Grace	Daughters of the Cord	Tolerated (rivals in mercy)
Mykkiel	Queen's Justicars	Welcome (as justicars)
Inquisitor Prime	Chain-Lanterns	Welcome (as witch-hunters)
The Sealed Gate	Spirit-Shield Correctors	Welcome (as wardens)
The Traveler	Break-Reins Riders	Welcome (as road-wardens)
Grimmir	Green Council	Welcome (as root-keepers)
The Savage Heart	Ykrul clans	Welcome (as beast-warriors)
Khemesh	Salt Prince's Court	Welcome (as deep-warriors)
Xhak'Thul	Ykrul clans	Welcome (as storm-sworn)
Ikasha	Daughters of the Cord	Tolerated (shadow-kin)
Aveh	Break-Reins Riders	Tolerated (unbound blades)
Inaea	Silk Vigil	Welcome (as web-warriors)
The High Mother	Daughters of the Cord	Welcome (as bloodsworn)
Clockwork Monad	Spirit-Shield Correctors	Welcome (as artificers)
Varnek Karn	Wake-Judges	Welcome (as cairn-knights)

Faction Clocks

For campaigns involving significant faction interaction, use the following clocks:

- **Faction Attention [6]:** Ticks when the party attracts notice (successful missions, public failures, high-profile conflicts). When full, a faction representative makes contact—ally, employer, or adversary.
- **Faction Wrath [8]:** Ticks when the party harms faction interests. When full, the faction sends agents to eliminate or capture the party.
- **Faction Favor [4]:** Ticks when the party aids faction interests. When full, the party may call in a significant favor (safe passage, resources, intelligence).

The thread held. The water carried. That is not a Rite. That is grace.

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The Runic Warrior: Codices of Flesh, Stone, and Steel

An Expansion for Fate's Edge